Illusions of Control

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by Atterrion

Summary

Horde Officer Cadet Adora was quite happy with how her life was going. She had her Squadron in the Fright Zone, which she had become the unofficial leader of, and had just been promoted to Force Captain. Then she had to go and fall out of a skiff, get a concussion and perhaps loose her sanity talking to the voices in her head.

She had begun to trust one.

Adora I

"Hey Adora."

The blond haired young woman known as Adora, or sometimes Cadet Adora if someone with a higher rank was particularly annoyed, stared at the lithe figure perched atop one of the seemingly identical metal buildings amidst the sea of sheet metal, pipes, cables and wires that so many people called their homes. To the untrained eye, the Fright Zone was a mess of streets, alleys and passage ways with no discernible features, no landmarks bar the towering structures that housed various sensitive facilities and departments, but to its inhabitants, to the children and adults of the Horde, it was a home they could navigate blind.

Not that they had ever had to, Shadow Weaver had only even taken out one eye in a punishment session at absolute worst.

"Catra." The raven haired girl with tan skin and a lithe figure stared back down at the bulkier blonde with the sort of casual interest that Catra devoted to the important things in life. A by-product of their upbringing, the two girls were perfect images of the two ways that the indoctrinating life that they had lived could mould a youth. Adora's dutiful responsibility and adherence to orders and rules, and Catra's rebellious streak that saw her in trouble from their superiors time and time again - even influencing Adora sometimes.

After all, all that they had to their names were the clothes on their back, although even those were marked as Horde property, and each other. And no matter how much their superiors pushed and punished them, they could never take that last one away.

Adora had not missed Catra's absence at dinner - there had been a painfully empty spot next to her at the 303rd Cadet Training Squadron table that had been noticed by everyone. The others - primarily Lonnie and Rogelio - had chosen to ignore the absence of their feline compatriot, at least physically. Their voices were more subdued, less boastful and boisterous as none could bring themselves to really enjoy the company of their friends as one of their group was probably being tortured to within an inch of their life.

The exception, as always, was Kyle, who had not stopped stealing glancing at the empty space between Adora and he, occasionally shooting the blonde sympathetic looks when their eyes met. It was not usually this awkward around the table, even with one of their number missing, yet the anger that Shadow Weaver had directed to Catra openly was enough to make even the usually apathetic Lonnie and Rogelio somewhat concerned for how the feline would be treated behind closed doors. They all wore the same scars as morbid memories of her wrath, and they had come nowhere close to how badly Catra had annoyed the sorceress.

Well.. All bar Adora.

Regardless of the out of place silence that clung to the table, yet one that had become a disturbingly common feature of their evening meals, Adora had gone about her depressingly (and increasingly) common routine of saving a portion of her own (and

a portion "volunteered" by Kyle) ration bar for the feline. The first time she had done this, Catra had resisted for the first night, and had been starving by the morning, and still in a great amount of pain as the wounds from the sorceress failed to heal overnight.

The second time, Adora had managed to get Catra to eat - and the pain in the morning had been so reduced that the feline had stopped complaining, but had never admitted Adora was right. Catra wasn’t like that - and Adora was fine with that.

The building that the feline was perched upon was familiar to Adora - it was the one that they had marked out as the start of the path to their super-secret hide out in the Fright Zone. The climb had been more treacherous when they were younger, clambering along the side of a tall building, along the railings and pipes that ran up the tower and to their perch. The path had long since been hewed by their repeated trips up to the rooftop, whenever one of them was missing, it was usually the first place they checked after their bunk.

The silence hung in the air, both of them asking and answering a silent question respectively, the feline turning her back to Adora as the ravenette lead the blonde towards their rooftop hideaway. The entire climb was done in silence, hands finding familiar perches, feet slotting into the same grooves and onto ledges travelled hundreds of times. A silent tradition, their one unique experience in the Horde.

Their rooftop haven was deserted, as it would always be. Others knew about the location, sure, but they didn't know how to get to it, and that was the key to their privacy.

The duo was silent as Catra ate, and Adora made a point not to look at the feline as she did so, Catra did not need Adora's teasing wearing at her pride whilst she recovered. That would inevitably go poorly, and Catra needed her strength.

Besides, there was other things to do as she waited for the feline to finish what she had managed to save from their dinner. The open stretches of land beyond the walls of the Fright Zone, the sandy dunes and rocky cliffs, the sea to their flanks and then beyond that, the ominous mass of twisting wood and leaves that dominated the horizon inland which was the Whispering Woods.

The woods had always represented danger, it was the home of the Princesses and the brainwashed Etherians who lived under their cruel rule, who the Horde was fighting to give a better life to, free from the yoke of the tyrants. But it was also a place of supreme mystery and mystique. No Horde soldier really knew what went on in there, just that the trees shifted and blocked their path when they tried to enter, either trapping soldiers in there at the mercy of the native wildlife, or sending them turning about and spitting them out in front of the Fright Zone, as if daring them to have another go.

Neither Adora or Catra had gone into the Whispering Woods before - but they had promised each other that they would. One day, when they ran the Fright Zone.

Another promise.

"You ready for tomorrow Adora?" Catra's voice heralded the end of Adora's internal monologue, bring her attention back the feline as the ravenette cast her gaze out over the forest where Adora's had been resting a moment ago, leaving the blond free to briefly inspect Catra. The result was not pretty, an angry red patch of skin marked in a familiar way to just about anyone who had crossed Shadow Weaver, bar Adora.

The blonde hugged herself as she swallowed, her hands resting on the points on her arms that corresponded to Catra's wounds, the ghostly ebbs of pain throbbing there, only in her mind. The lack of pain, of any similar wounds, made her feel.. Inadequate, as if she wasn't good enough for them. Or too good even. That's what Shadow Weaver had said, that Adora was too good for them.

But she didn't want to be too good. She wanted to share the pain, she didn't want to be the one singled out as special - she just wanted to be Adora, to be like Catra, and the rest of the 303rd. She wanted those shared experiences - the bond of comradery. She didn't want to be looked down on by her friends as too good for them, but she didn't dare cross Shadow Weaver, or rather, she couldn't bring herself to.

"Hey - Adora? You alive in there?" The sharp sensation of knuckles rapping on her forehead pulled the blonde from her almost self-loathing, blinking in surprise as her brain spat out the most intelligent reply it could.

"Eh?"

Catra stared at Adora, an eyebrow raised quizzically. "I asked if you were ready for tomorrow? You brain damaged or something?"

"Wha- No! I mean yes. But also no. Yes and no-" Adora's indignant reply swiftly devolved into rambling as the ravenette sighed resting one hand over her own eyes whilst the other covered Adora's mouth, shutting the blonde up quickly. The unimpressed look on Catra's face met Adora's own irked one before both settled into neutral expressions with varying levels of softness.

"Shadow Weaver is going to drive us so hard tomorrow." At the mention of the witch, Catra's expression turned guarded, hands repeatedly curling into fists and then partially opening, only to curl back into fists, as if reminding herself of the full range of muscle motion that she had available to her. A pang of guilt shot through Adora as the blonde tried to forget the reaction she had just caused, failing horribly.

"Yeah. Us." Catra's tone betrayed the felines feelings, a spiteful stab at the witch who Catra had every reason to hate. But it was also a stab at the blonde, and Adora did not miss it.

"Catra.. I try-"

"Yeah you do. Now come on, its nearly curfew and I know you need your beauty sleep Adora." The feline elbowed the blonde cheekily, who responded with her own elbow jab as the feline stood, the sullen emotions momentarily cast aside as, just for a moment, they acted like kids, mirthful and full of life and energy,

having fun. Escaping the confines of their militaristic life, being individuals, rich in character.

But the sharp siren that rang out across the never ending sea of green metal buildings brought a sudden end to that, a brisk and forceful reminder of who they were - what they were a part of. The mirth died, replaced by stoic duty as the two girls briefly clasped each other's hand, before descending from their platform, back to the winding maze of corridors and roads that was their home.

Their lives.

"Adora."

The ethereal voice hung in the air, scything through the nothingness of her sleep, lingering in the void empty of any dream.

Devoid of any sensation, unsure of if she was standing, floating, sitting or even laying down, unable to see anything, to do anything, only listen.

"Adora.. Balance..."

Balance.

Balance what, exactly? What needed balancing.

"Balance"

The voice sounded empty, as absent of emotion as everything in the lingering void. A husk of what a person was.

"Adora."

"Hey! Adora."

A sharp jab to her forehead ripped through the void, a different, clear and more grounded voice drowning out whatever the first one was saying.

She knew this voice, it was.. Different. It carried with it emotion, it had life, was full of life. It brought forth emotions from within the blonde, ones that made her feel warm inside, safe – at home.

Home.

She could feel now – sensation blossomed, pain again, sharp and on her cheek. Her left arm came up, clasping the spot, feeling skin beneath her touch, but not her own.

"Adora..."

The ethereal voice was barely audible, drowned beneath the sensations she could feel, torn away by the slight crick in her back and the cool breeze across her skin.

She was laying down, she could feel that much, her arm felt heavy from defying gravity from this position. So she sat up.

And her eyes opened, dispelling the final whisper of the empty husk of a voice in her mind.

"Good – you're up."

Darkness still crowded her vision, but the faintest glow of turquoise light came from the illuminated path that ran down the middle of the room. Their room, the shared barracks of two squadrons, with enough bunks to sleep 16 people, yet only occupied by the nine remaining cadets who had lasted this long in training.

Not all were suited for combat roles – only those who stayed soldier cadets got to sleep in the barracks.

The darkness, however, could not cover up two glowing eyes staring at her from close range, one yellow, one blue. A familiar weight straddled her legs, covered by the thin blanket adorning every occupied bed in the barracks, the intimacy of the situation passing by completely unnoticed as the haze cleared from Adora's mind.

"Catra... What time.." The feline pulled herself off of Adora, the comforting pressure and warmth dissipating into the cool air of the room as the feline jerked her head, barely visible in the dim light of the room. In a similar motion, Adora pushed herself out of bed, stretching her muscles and feeling the satisfaction of them stretching out, waking from their slumber, a soft groan leaving her mouth in response, affirming her situation.

"Like 5 minutes before lights on. C'mon, you wanted to be up early." Sock covered feet met the metal floor of the room, toes curling slightly at the cold, although the blonde was deeply grateful for the layer of fabric separating her bare skin from the frigid metal. The momentary hesitation was quashed as Adora pushed herself out of bed, slipping her feet into the waiting boots next to her bed, settling her feet into the well-worn groves made through years of use.

Catra was waiting inside the doorway of the locker room that separated the barracks and the main hallways of the Fright Zone, nonchalantly waiting for Adora to get her morning routine in order. The dim lighting of the locker room was enough to see by, but not

enough to disturb those sleeping next door, one of the few luxuries in the modular design.

A spartan shower, lasting a whole two minutes, was more than enough to get clean but not long enough to enjoy, even if they ducked from one shower to another to use all 4 minutes of their combined run time. Yet it was still a brief moment of peace, another fleeting moment of alone time, even if it was whilst they were bathing. It was still, just them, alone, enjoying the silence with each other in the scalding water of the Fright Zone.

The water ran dry a few seconds early – as it always did – and the lights snapped on with an industrial clap, waking those slumbering from their stupor in an unpleasant, yet comfortingly familiar way. By the time the first risers made their way into the locker room, the two girls were gone, the only signs they had been there being the last dribbles of bitter toothpaste in the sink, curling steam sliding into the ventilation system and a few wet footprints on the floor.

Catra I

Chapter Notes

> AN: Catra will perceive Shadow Weaver as someone who relishes in their power over others, and who uses their position sadistically. This is simply her opinion.
>
> Shadow Weaver is a firm disciplinarian, as opposed to an abusive sadist, although there is a very much present sadistic streak to the woman.

Catra was aware that her space on the floor outside the training room was absent.

Not like it mattered anyway – Shadow Weaver was *always* going to find a reason to dish out punishment against her *regardless* of if she acted flawlessly. It'd probably be Kyle getting her in trouble again, because Catra was apparently responsible for *everyone* in the Squadron.

So – if she was going to be punished for anything, let it be on her terms. At least this way she could make Shadow Weaver look incompetent in front of Hordak, it would bring the feline satisfaction she could not attain otherwise. Punishment be damned.

Surprisingly, the training room had *not* been locked before the exercise was set up, giving Catra free reign of the entire room, with *plenty* of time to find a somewhat comfortable perch from which to observe Adora and the rest of them go through the paces.

Ok so *maybe* she wasn't avoiding muster *just* to spite Shadow Weaver.

But c'mon! They were ready for actual combat – their constant training was getting bland and predictable at this point. They were officer cadets – not rank and file Horde Grunts. Shadow Weaver was probably trying to get Catra to mess up one too many times and have to drop out, to wherever drop outs went.

Probably manual labour.

The thought brought a shudder down her spine. She was of a lithe build, a speed fighter, not one who took hits and dealt in kind. She'd last 5 minutes in manual labour.

Although maybe as a *guard..*

A whip can't be THAT hard to use, can it? Her idle musing was cut abruptly short by the sharp blare of the siren in the training room, the heterochomic gaze being cast down upon the group of 4 cadets glancing around them (or trying not to panic in the case of Kyle). *How HE made it this far, I will never understand.*

One of the spider-like training droids passed by her, once again not even pausing for a second to scan or take in the abnormality in the otherwise lifeless training room. They were crudely modified

from combat droids, and their variations were limited to the weapons that had been bolted on to them being non-lethal as opposed to the very much lethal combat lasers.

And whilst she was no technician, she was fairly certain that they were only able to target the target plates that the rest of her Squadron was wearing. This was the third time one of them had passed her in their search patterns, and they hadn't even reacted when she'd pushed one out of the "tree" in idle curiosity.

The trio of humans and their reptilian comrade charged into the "woods," indicating that there was finally a need to get moving from her really quite comfortable perch. Sure, it hadn't been so comfortable to start off with, but once she shaved away a nice seat for herself to relax in...

Languidly pushing herself upright, the feline allowed her claws to sink into the metal pylons meant to imitate the trees of the Whispering Woods, the low quality metal barely putting up any resistance to her claws, the biological quirk proving itself to be advantageous yet again.

Catra *loved* her claws for *many* reasons.

First and foremost, it meant that she was never without a weapon, always possessing a means to defend herself from whomever or whatever tried to stand in her way, be it an irritating superior or Kyle looking like he was about to develop a *backbone*. And everyone really couldn’t have the latter.

Secondly, it allow her to move.

Most Etherians thought of movement as a three dimensional concept, but in reality more exercised it as if it were a two dimension concept. Left and right, in front and behind.

Catra thought of it in three dimensions. Her claws allowed for vertical movement, letting her climb objects, scramble onto things and to introduce a new variable into combat that most beings never had to contend with, and certainly not on the scale Catra was capable of utilising.

Which is what she was doing right now, quite casually hopping from faux tree branch to faux tree branch, following along with her squadron as Adora lead the charge, like she always did.

She was too good for the Horde – little Miss Stupid Hair Poof Perfect. Sure she had her faults, and Catra knew them all, and she *liked* it that way. It was.. Almost comforting to know them. Like it was a secret that would never be shared – a sense of trust that left Catra feeling cosy and *safe*, and otherwise alien concept.

And besides, she could deal with Adora just fine if she had to – even though she never would.

They had promised each other to be there when the other needed it.

Promises were sacred.

Her train of thought came to an end, her attention now brought back to Adora dealing with the large sentry bot that towered over the pit that had deployed it. Truly a monstrous sight, one that would bring fear on the battlefield.

Sure it was also horrifically impractical, a massive target and a probably wasteful use of resources, but Shadow Weaver had never really been a *great* tactician. Most of her plans and strategies relied on striking fear and terror into their opponents, but as Catra knew personally, everyone's fear has a breaking point.

Catra had reached hers long ago, all she felt towards the witch was spite and anger.

The Rebels would reach that point too, or maybe they already had.

Her idle thoughts brought her to the final branch she could reach before entering the clearing. Adora had made fine work of the sentry bot, its battered form barely hanging on to the edges of the pit from which it had emerged, and was now sprawled on the floor, staring up at her handiwork. *Well I have to do SOMETHING this time*.

The sudden sinking feeling in her gut, followed by the rush of adrenaline flooding her system as she went into momentary freefall was exhilarating, albeit short lived as her feet met the cool metal that made up most floors in the Fright Zone. It was a sensation she was acutely familiar with, one she was familiar landing on.

Adora was looking up at her, Catra could practically *feel* her gaze on her as the feline strode over to the precariously perched bot, and ever so casually shoved one of its legs into the pit with her foot. The result was instant and cacophonous, the screeching of metal dragging on metal filling the air as the robot slid over the edge, crashing down into the dark abyss below. *Now its over*.

Turning back to Adora, the feline had to bite her lip to suppress the laugh building inside her chest, raising a hand to cover her mouth, whilst pointing at the befuddled Adora with the index claw of her right hand. Or perhaps more accurately, at the crimson hexagon underneath Adora.

The laugh escaped her at the startled noise Adora made as the floor beneath her suddenly gave way. *Typical Adora*.

Giving a somewhat lazy inspection of her surroundings, Catra casually strode over to the hole, crouching down and leaning her face over the edge, looking down at the unimpressed blonde hanging from her staff some 3 feet below her.

The pun was too good to pass up. "Hey Adora - How's it hanging?"

An unimpressed grumble was her response. "Catra.. Leave us the hard work again? That’s low…"

"Oh Adora… *Nothing* is too low for me." The feline reached her arm down, offering her hand to the hanging blonde, unable to stop the sly smirk spreading across her tanned features, seemingly inspiring a lightly annoyed smile from Adora. "C'mon, you look stupid hanging down there."

Adora took her hand as Catra hauled the blonde out of the pit, onto the now stable floor of the training room. Now standing next to the blonde, Catra returned the small smile that was being offered to her, but it soon was washed away. The harsh industrial lighting overhead had begun to twitch out her eyes, but the shadows slinking in the corner of the room began to put ease to that, yet heralded something worse than a minor irritation. *Shadows… Great..*

"*Adora…*"

The cruel curl of the witches voice sent shivers down Catra's spine, right down to the tip of her long tail. In an unconscious betrayal of her emotions, it curled protectively around her leg, her ears flattening in synchrony to keep them safe from whatever damage could come of them.

The darkness crept closer, surging forth and engulfing the clearing, Adora pulling herself upright and out of Catra's arms and

to attention, whilst the feline stuffed her hands in her pockets, trying to look as nonchalant as she possibly could in the situation, whilst also looking *somewhat* presentable. Not like it mattered anyway - Shadow Weaver would find some excuse to dish out punishment.

"Shadow Weaver." Adora, ever the goodie two shoes, saluted like a good little officer, leaving Catra standing there somewhat awkwardly, torn between staying quiet or making her presence known. In the end, it was no real contest, as the feline kept quiet, listening in to the conversation that was very clearly meant to include her, but one in which two of the parties were happy to keep her out of.

The shadows curled around the trio quite languidly, licking around them in a neat circle like they usually did, a subtle reminder of exactly *who* was in control of the situation. Right now, the witch was focused on Adora, and so the shadows were quite subdued. "I am impressed. You completely the training course in record time, and with only one casualty. No matter, recruit Kyle will simply have to undergo.. Further training."

The shadows picked up a little towards the end, licking around the witches feet. A part of Catra felt sorry for Kyle - empathised with the pain that he would shortly undergo. A larger part of Catra didn't care in the slightest - Kyle was worse than useless, he was an active liability to those around him.

"With respect Shadow Weaver - it wasn't just me who completed the course. Catra and the others did too." Adora's innocent attempt to spread the glory served the exact opposite purpose*. Adora you idiot..*

The shadows curling around them grew agitated in a heartbeat, curling up to thigh height and seeming sharper, more oppressive. Darkness began to engulf the trio, nowhere near blocking out the light completely, but enough for Catra to shift closer to Adora, protectively and self defensively. *Only one thing would have set the witch off..*

"Under *your* direction they did. It makes me wonder what Catra could accomplish if she ever put effort into her duties.." The dismissive tone was evidently meant to get a rise out of Catra, and it certainly worked, with the feline doing absolutely *everything* she could to suppress the urge to swing at the Witch. "Walk with me Adora. You are dismissed *cadet.*"

With a curl of her lip, Catra stood there, letting the Witch take Adora away, whispering manipulative rumours into her ears, giving Adora the praise and glory that Catra so *craved,* all while the feline stood impotently by, trying to ignore the thin trickles of crimson ichor rolling down her fingers.

"Force *Captain*?"

"Yeah! Shadow Weaver said Lord Hordak was impressed with my work. Apparently I'm going to lead a Squadron on active duty!"

The words sounded too good to be true, which, in Catra's experience with the Witch who raised them from their infancy, meant they absolutely were. Yet in the euphoria, she had neglected to remember this.

"This is great! I can finally get out of here before I *die* of boredom…. Adora.. I need to blow something up!" The euphoria drained away in an instant as she looked at the sinking expression on Adora's face. Of course - she should have known.

"Catra… Shadow Weaver said.." Adora's reaction was the final nail in the coffin, the feline sighing and rolling her head back to stare at the sky, exhaling in frustration. *There it was. That's why Shadow Weaver was so light today.*

"Don't say it Adora." Her tone was perhaps unfairly terse. It wasn't Adora's fault that Shadow Weaver thought so little of the rest of the squadron, or perhaps thought so much of the blonde. She had just had the luck to be Shadow Weavers sick project, grooming her with lies and tricks to make her into a perfect leader - a poster child for the Horde.

She was perfect. She followed orders, inspired those under her and had a dorkish charisma that people found *endearing* for some reason.

Catra, with her rebellious nature and her ability to see through the lies spun by the Horde, would never be a good poster child. She was too headstrong, too smart for her own good, whilst Adora… well whilst not dumb, she wasn't the *most* perceptive.

But above all, Catra looked.. Scary. In a way. And she had resorted to her feline instincts to defend herself before, poofed tail, sharp claws and fangs, all of it could be used to make herself bigger - to look more dangerous.

And she had put her focus into it.

The conversation was well and truly over, with Catra breaking away, heading to their spot high upon the roof tops of the Fright Zone. Beyond the walls.. Beyond the sand and rock, and the faint green blur of the Whispering Woods… who knew what was out there.. Maybe possibility, a chance to do something other than be in the Horde.

She wasn't sure how long it was before Adora came back, looking hopeful. All she was focused on was the soft jingling of the set of keys in her hand.

Catra's eyes lit up, a grin creeping onto her lips.

Maybe Adora *wasn't* so perfect after all.

Lonnie

Lonnie didn't like Catra.

Not many people in the Horde actually did. The list could be counted on the fingers of one hand, if the person who had the hand was a three finger amputee.

Adora was the obvious one. She was basically Catra's other half, always ducking in to try and relieve the pressure that was placed on the feline by the duo's misadventures, always getting away with it too because she was the pet project of Shadow Weaver, and no one *dared* cross the Sorceress after the incident with Force Captain Areli. Not that there was much of the man left to remember him by.

As for the other person.. Well Kyle hardly counted. He liked everyone - more out of a survival technique than anything else. That and he was *seriously* terrified of the feline. Lonnie could somewhat understand that - Kyle was honestly a bit pathetic. How he had managed to last this long, she would never really understand.

As far as the girl was concerned, she was fairly confident that Catra didn’t even like *herself*. She probably had some sort of self awakening and realised how bad of a person she was, and in all honesty - that wouldn't be a surprise.

But on the other hand, *Adora*..

Well perhaps it was best to be blunt - Lonnie was no stranger to physical attraction, she had spent a decent amount of time around the older Cadets - those who had gone before and graduated into full blown officers. She knew what it meant to be attracted to someone, and she knew that she was attracted - at the very least - to Adora physically.

But on the other hand, she found Adora to be... Distinctively bland personality wise.

She was nice - perhaps too nice to be a Horde Soldier, let alone an officer, but Lonnie held respect for her regardless. Adora was, by all means, tactically sound in combat, and an inspirational leader to follow, always willing to put those under her command before herself.

Well, unless you were *Kyle*.

Still, Adora had her weaknesses. She was cripplingly naïve, probably believed all the lies they had been fed in training, and that could be very easily used against her. She also had a burgeoning case of "its all my fault" syndrome, something that Lonnie wasn't inclined to help with. Adora might have been her friend, but she also held the power in the Squadron dynamic. Lonnie might need that.

She cared for those under her command. And Lonnie respected that.

She just thought Adora cared for Catra a little too much.

There was definitely some level of affection going on between the two - you'd have to be blind to not notice it. The willingness to take the blame for Catra from Adora, Catra's sacrifice at the hands of Shadow Weaver to keep Adora safe when it came to it, Adora doing everything to rehabilitate the feline after the punishment.

Hell, Catra literally slept at Adora's feet instead of on her own bed.

Lonnie had no idea how they got away with doing that - all she knew was that the one person who had given them shit for it, Cadet Lemuri, had not been the same after reporting them to an officer. The one time bully of the 303rd Training Squadron had begun to flinch away from the two girls whenever they were near, even moving to the opposite end of the room as opposed to sleeping where he had been assigned to.

He'd dropped out of the Squadron a week later.

It didn't take a mastermind to realise that Adora was under a total screen of protection from above. Shadow Weaver had always doted on Adora, as opposed to scarring her skin like everyone else, but it was only once Lemuri vanished from the Squadron that Lonnie, or indeed anyone, realised that Catra was also protected in a way.

Suddenly, the girl had a lot more respect for Catra's tactical mind. She had bound herself to the most powerful cadet in the Horde, and in turn had gained a portion of the protection offered by Adora's status. She had made herself an extension of Adora, and all it cost was sleeping at Adora's feet. Lonnie was impressed.

She hadn't given Catra enough of her attention when it came to strategy it seemed.

Although maybe not - given that the Feline taunted the Witch with such regularity that was almost unheard of before. If it had been literally anyone else in the Horde, Shadow Weaver would have had them killed years ago, but because Catra meant something *MAJOR* to Adora, she was spared, although tortured for it.

Still, everyone could tell that Catra would probably never leave Adora's side, definitely not willingly. Adora was certainly Force Captain materiel, that was almost guaranteed, and Catra would probably end up dragged along as her advisor or something. Bodyguard maybe.

Staring at the empty seat next to Kyle, or perhaps to be more accurate, two empty seats next to Kyle, Lonnie sighed, trying not to pinch the bridge of her nose.

She just hoped Adora knew what she was doing.

And that Catra didn't drag her down with her.

Adora II

The first thing she remembered when her consciousness returned was that it was a REALLY bad idea to fall out of a moving vehicle, especially a skiff. Seriously, those things needed some sort of hand rails to prevent their operators from falling out - She should bring that up to Shadow Weaver-

Oh right I'm not supposed to be out here..

Catra

".. Catra?" The tentative cry of the feline's name alerted the blonde to the dryness in her throat, sore from dehydration, although it was fairly trivial compared to the sharp pain at the back of her head. She must have hit it when she fell from the.. No, she had hit her head on a tree branch, she remembered that much, the sharp, blinding pain that almost knocked her out.

Pushing herself upright from her sprawled position, Adora glanced down at the bush she had landed in, marvelling at her luck. She was extremely lucky to have not broken anything in that fall. Speaking of, she turned her head up, only for a blinding pain to erupt at the base of her skull, one that had her cringing, turning

her gaze back down swiftly to avoid the pain. Perhaps her injuries were worse than she thought.

Tentatively, she raised a shaky hand to the back of her head, gently dabbing at the point of impact and wincing sharply, ripping her hand away as if it was scalding hot. On her hand was a smear of nearly dried blood, matted into her blonde hair. It was sore, yeah, but she was otherwise ok..

"Adora.."

Oooor maybe not, given that she was now hearing voices.

Her head still ached from the fall, but the blonde tried to remember everything that she had been taught about basic self first aid. Blunt force trauma to the back of the head... Closing her eyes briefly to try and remember, the blonde snapped them open after an instant, grunting in pain. Pain behind the eyes.

Great - A concussion.

"Adora."

Auditory hallucinations - this day really just kept getting better and better.

A twinkle of light in her periphery drew her gaze, pulling her attention away from her inspection of her own wounds and subsequent self diagnosis, and towards the glowing object in the woods. It had her uncertain - the Horde always said that Princesses were tricksters who loved nothing more than to torture their captives with cruel tricks and horrible memories, but funnily enough, the memories of those classes failed to manifest in Adora's mind.

Her eyes flirted, instead, to the left, where she could see the other ring of the Whispering Woods, and beyond that the rocky and sandy desert from which Adora and Catra had come. Beyond that lay home - safety and respite. Sure, she would have to get in past Shadow Weaver and into her bed, and then rest all of her injuries of in private, but.. Surely that was better..

"*Adora.. Balance...*"

Her head whipped around, ignoring the burning pain brought about by the sudden motion, staring directly to the right, at the glowing blue light beyond the bushes. The familiarity of the voice clicked. My dream.

Unconsciously, her teeth nibbled at her lower lip, eyes dancing left, towards her life. Towards the Horde, towards her home. Then right. Possibility, opportunity, a chance to discover.. Something, maybe a way to end the war? Some intelligence maybe? And Catra...

What would Catra do..

Lifting her left foot, she went to take a step, pausing. *I can't leave Catra.. No matter what..*

Her left foot swung around, leading the blonde towards the blinding light.

After walking for a not insignificant amount of time, or at least so Adora thought, her head was a little fuzzy from the fall, the blonde began to have doubts about what she was doing. She knew the rumours - that no Horde Squadron who had ever ventured into the Whispering Woods had ever returned from their journey. That the woods shifted about, spitting the lucky ones out near the Fright Zone with warnings, whilst those who didn't flee when they had the chance ended up vanishing forever, their helmets becoming morbid trophies for the savage rebels and Princesses.

Had this fate befallen her? Another number?

The light was still glowing, even brighter now, and it seemed to be getting even closer. *Just a little further..*

There was a sudden force on her back, shoving her through the shrubbery ahead, spitting her out onto the earthen floor of the clearing. The impact knocked the last semblance of control over

her hair away, although it could honestly have been like that since Adora fell from the skiff, she honestly had no clue. She raised her head to look back at-

...

Oh..

A beautifully intricate sword sat in the grasp of mossy vines, deeply embedded in the roots as if it had been there for a thousand years, letting nature consume it. Yet it was in perfect condition, the light blue blade adorned with markings, lines running down the flat of the blade, into a softly glowing, heavily stylised golden hilt.

Adora had never seen anything like it, but her eyes focused on the small blue gemstone inset into the hilt. It was pulsing slightly - and it told Adora what this was.

This has to do with Princesses...

Ignoring the pressure in her head, Adora picked herself up off the ground, approaching the weapon cautiously, glancing too and fro around them as she closed in, just in case it was some elaborate trap set to capture Horde soldiers. But the woods were dead silent, even devoid of the soft noises that some creatures that lived in the forest made as they passed by.

Carefully, her hand reached out, going to touch the hilt, but her arm buckled, hesitation overriding her motor functions. Something about this felt... Really important, like a changing point that she could never go back from.

Do I... Do I do this? Take this back to the Horde..?

It doesn't feel right... But I have to..

Adora touched the sword.

Darkness crowded her vision, just like the nights sky.

A planet hung in the otherwise empty void, orbited by its moons. Despite never seeing it from any other angle than her own eyes from the ground, Adora knew it was Etheria.

Wrong...

Adora blinked, and in an instant, she was staring at Etheria again, through a great bronze coloured window, looking up at the planet from a rocky surface. From a moon of Etheria...

This isn't my memory.. It can't be. Shadow Weaver told me-

"Adora."

The voice was back, unnatural, ethereal, as if it was being played back through some sort of machine. Something in Adora's gut did not like it, it pulled away, curling up and trying to pull away. The voice rang out again.

"Etheria needs a protector Adora."

Each blink of her eyelids brought her to places so alien to Adora, showed her creatures she could never imagine, places that couldn't be possible. A shining building, decorated in gold and marble overlooking a large body of water, from which a magnificent golden tower rose, in its grasp a pearly white gemstone.

Blink

An enormous tree, the likes of which she had never seen before. It sported deep, craggy roots that coiled in and out of the ground like serpents, coated in moss and dotted with little white specks. Its deep bushy branches and leaves sported these same specks, just far larger and in every colour that Adora could possibly

imagine. The word came to her, a word she had never heard before. Flowers..

Nestled in its roots, a light green gemstone.

Blink

A grand cliff, overlooking an ocean that spread further than the eye could see, with all nature of animals around. Sea creatures, large land creatures, a roaring waterfall as a river spewed into the ocean below. No Razorfins... Nothing violent... Just.. Peaceful animals

Blink

A woman now stood on the cliffs edge, holding a sword. Her blonde hair was flowing back behind her, a blood red cape snapping in the breeze that Adora had not felt a second prior. Clad in all white, she turned, staring at Adora with glowing white eyes. Her mouth did not move, but Adora could tell the voice that spoke was not the woman's.. It just didn't.. Seem right for it to be hers..

"Will you bring Balance to Etheria Adora?"

"Don't!"

The blonde blinked, suddenly aware of the sword hovering in front of her in the inky void. There had been a second voice, cutting through, a desperate plea. The second voice sounded so.. Familiar.. So warm.. But desperate... Like it was trying to stop something terrible.. Sensation returned in her limbs, the blonde finding her right arm still out stretched from touching the sword in the forest-

Forest. Skiff. Crash. Promotion. Force Captain.

Catra.

"Adora!"

Adora's eyes opened.

"Hey! Adora!"

Catra was standing over her, shaking her, sounding more and more nervous by the second. "Oh thank stars, you're not dead. Shadow Weaver would have skinned me alive if I got you killed."

"Wha- Whahappened..."Adora sounded drunk as all hell about now, rubbing the base of her skull gently to find-

No matted blood. No torn hair.

Gingerly lowering her hand, she found that some things had stayed the same, her hair was still down, having broken free of the pony tail of its own accord. So the sword...

"Uh - *you* fell out of the skiff." A spark of annoyance, Adora's arms flashing upwards as she pushed Catra over.

"*You* pushed me out!"

"Eh - up for debate, now C'mon we need to get back home." Catra walked past Adora, out of the clearing that Adora had been laying in, and to the waiting skiff just beyond the tree line-
That's... Not possible... Did the Whispering Woods... Make my journey longer? That's DEFINITELY the bush I fell into..

No.. No they couldn't leave without the Sword..

"Where is it?" Catra paused, turning to look back at the disoriented and stationary Adora with a concerned look, but also a cautious one. Adora didn't notice however, she needed to make her point.

"Uh - where's what?"

"The Sword! It was right here! I saw it... There was a flash of light.." In a heartbeat Catra's hands were all over Adora's face, tilting her head and examining her from differing angles.

"Are you brain damaged? *PLEASE* don't be brain damaged.. Shadow Weaver will kill me.." Catra glanced past Adora, looking around them to amplify her point. "I don't see any magic disappearing swords Adora. Now come on, we need to get back before they notice the Skiff is missing."

Adora took a step towards the skiff, sighing slightly and rubbing her head on the wound that she had sustained... Had she even sustained it? She really didn't know anymore.. She just.. Felt kinda aimless, lost without direction, like a piece of her life had just gone missing.

With a regretful look in her eyes, Adora turned, walking back towards the skiff and towards Catra. Home sounded nice about now..

"Adora.. Adora..."

Fumbling from both the exhaustion and the darkness combined, the pillow was finally extracted from under her head and came down over her ears, the blonde with the messy blonde hair trying desperately to cover her ears, to block out the voice that had been harrowing her.

It had been three days since their little adventure, and each night, the calls from the voice got louder and louder, more and more persistent and more demanding. On top of feeling physically exhausted from the injuries, the ghosts of whom still lingers, occasionally sending a jolt of pain through her head, the lack of sleep along with Horde training before the up coming operation against the Fortress of Thaymore meant that Adora was barely functioning, and was more dragging herself through each day.

It would only be a matter of time before someone asked what was going on.

The darkness of the barracks made it easy to get out the door unnoticed, everyone else was still asleep. The only things she had to contend with were the Security bots, and she knew their patrol patterns from the days she and Catra had snuck out as kids. Speaking of, it became abruptly apparent that someone had not been asleep.

"Adora! Where the hell are you going?" Catra's voice was a low hiss, using her body to pin Adora in the alcove running along the wall to avoid the ever patrolling horde of security bots designed to stop people breaking curfew. On the other hand, Adora could barely keep herself awake, rubbing her eyes and trying to fend off the exhaustion.

Catra, quite handily, put an end to her efforts, gently pricking her with a claw. Enough to make Adora give a soft yelp of pain, but not enough to draw blood. "Hey - Stay awake you."

"Catra.. I just... I need to go back to the woods ok. I need to see something." Adora was aware her argument didn't have much weight, given she looked like she was about to pass out. Catra seemed to think so, pushing back her head to stare at Adora from a weird angle.

"Are you sure you're not brain damaged?"

Slapping Catra's hand down, Adora made an irritable noise. "Catra! Be serious. I just need you to cover for me. I'll be back in the morning. I promise, I'm not going to leave you.." It felt dirty, using the phrase 'promise'. It felt like she was manipulating Catra, and it stung her to do so, but she had to figure out what was going on. Sure, Shadow Weaver might help, or she might just incinerate Adora where she stood. It was honestly 50/50.

And so that put Adora in the position of manipulating Catra.

The feline looked conflicted, casting her gaze left and right, tail swishing nervously as her ears flicked as if irritated by something, before she sighed and nodded. "Alright... Please... Be safe Adora.."

Gently clasping the felines hands in her own, Adora gave Catra a reassuring smile. "I will Catra. I'll see you soon."

Letting go, the blondes hands fell to her side as she turned away, darting off down the winding corridors of the Fright Zone, trying to ignore how empty her hands now felt.

Staring at Adora's retreating form impotently, Catra gave a sigh, moving back into the barracks and trying to get some sleep, knowing that she would need all she could to handle Shadow Weaver's wrath in the morning.

As fate would have it - Catra would need a lot more sleep if that were the case.

This was a stupid idea.

The blonde ducked under a branch, ignoring how it seemed that the branches appeared in her path whenever she looked away. She had discovered that the Whispering Woods was still hostile towards her, placing obstructions in her path everywhere she went.

*The stories were true then... The woods **are** alive..*

Adora had found where they'd crashed the skiff - she had decided that it was a group effort as opposed to any one of the two. That way if Shadow Weaver found out, Catra would be absolved of total responsibility. Still, it had been a good place to start, running her fingers along the freshly split bark of the tree, marvelling at the substance that felt as strong as the metal used in the Horde, but was nowhere near as smooth or as cold to the touch.

But now, after what felt like hours of walking, Adora was quite convinced that she was lost, and that if she turned around even for a moment, she would be spat back out at the skiff which she had ridden here on.

So she didn't turn back, and instead pressed on, walking further and further into the Whispering Woods and doubting herself with every step she took. *A glowing magic sword.. Catra was right, maybe I was concussed and hallucinating things..*

But these voices.. They're not leaving me alone...

In a culmination of her frustration she made an annoyed noise, smacking the bushes ahead of her aside. "What is *HAPPENING* to me!"

The woods, quite helpfully, remained silent. Adora subconsciously thanked them for that - her sanity probably would not be able to

handle the trees starting to talk to her too.

Yet the trees seemed to disagree with Adora on a few things, and that was how she found herself suddenly swallowed by a mass of leaves, stumbling about blindly in the sudden darkness as her heart pounded in her chest, her survival instincts kicking in. There was no way for her to flee, not when she was being suffocated by trees, so there was only fight.

Her arms came up, trying to push aside the branches, only to meet no resistance, being once again dumped into the middle of a clearing, albeit this time she managed to stumble to a halt as opposed to falling over like an idiot. Dragging her gaze up, her expression froze, spotting the same gold and light blue sword embedded in the vines like she had seen those three days ago.

She took a step forward and the screaming started.

Glancing down, she hurriedly took a step back. Now the *grass* was screaming at her?

Then her directional hearing kicked in, bringing her head left, staring at a dark skinned boy with some device in his hand, his left arm raised and index finger pointed firmly in her direction. He was screaming aimlessly, although he appeared to be armed with some sort of bow - Adora had been told the Rebels relied primarily on primitive weapons, and the Bow probably qualified as such.

Her concern was more on the short girl next to him, also screaming at her. She might not have looked like much, decently short, definitely not dressed for combat, and with stylised hair for crying out loud, but Adora could tell at a glance that this was one of their dreaded foes. A *princess*. The signs were all there.

Well that and she was *glowing* with balls of... Were those *sparkles* in her hands?

Realisation clicked. They were here for the sword. Adora could not let the Princesses get a magical sword. It could be the end of the Horde!

And so she bolted forwards, taking that step again as she shifted her body mass forwards, closing in on the sword at such a speed that she would easily get there before-

A wink of pink appeared in front of her, far too close to stop as the princess materialised from thin air in her face, Sparkles' own brown eyes widening as she seemed to realise far too late that collision was inevitable. The difference between Sparkles and Adora, was that the latter knew how to make it hurt far more for her opponent than herself, angling her body so that her shoulder would be the thing that made contact.

She felt the initial contact, but then a stomach wrenching sensation yanked her sideways, tossing them both to the ground and sending Adora tumbling to the hard earth of Etheria. It took her a moment to get to her feet, but it was taking Sparkles far longer, clearly having been staggered by the impact and whatever

magic she used. The boy had seemingly abandoned his attack in favour of helping the Princess to her feet, ignoring the strategic threat that Adora posed.

She scoffed internally, letting her mind momentarily wander as she drew the combat staff. No wonder the Horde was winning.

Magic... It felt... Strangely familiar...

Adora glanced up, looking for the sword that was a scant few metres in front-

... *Or* it was halfway across the clearing. Ok..

She looked back at the Princess and what she assumed was her slave? Brainwashed minion? Enforcer? All of them seemed reasonable, but regardless of what they were, they were first and foremost a threat.

And so she charged them, combat staff raised into an offensive stance as she came swinging at the boy, the Princess winking away from him in a heartbeat like the coward she was, leaving him and his steadily more terrified expression to face Adora with his bow and nought else. The first impact of her staff on his bow nearly buckled his hold, and Adora took the chance to try and knee cap him with her leg, kicking him off balance and staggering him back.

It was almost too easy, far easier than the combat simulations that Adora had been partaking in. It seemed to validate everything Catra had been saying, how poorly the boy was prepared to face someone like Adora, who was using her staff to control his central line, forcing him to constantly keep shifting the golden bow to absorb her blows. He was doing a somewhat admirable job of that, but was clearly on the back foot.

Feigning high, she swung low, knocking him to the ground in a fluid motion and bringing her staff up to deal him a heavy blow, only to be thrown off by the wink and sudden weight on her shoulders. The Princess had clearly returned, and the added weight of her entire body on Adora's shoulder not only send her tumbling backwards, but also knocked the staff from her hands, horribly out of reach.

Sparkles hadn't, however, compensated for how Adora would be landing, slamming the combined force of their body weight into her when they hit the ground, Adora tumbling from the pink haired princesses grasp. Legs scrambling, she put some distance between them, taking deep breaths and taking stock of the situation.

The boy was looking haggard from their brief engagement, clearly looking like he had been through a bit of hell. He was on his feet sure, but he had yet to retrieve his bow, which had fallen from his grasp when Adora had thrown him to the ground. He was clearly tired, but was determined, and that made him dangerous. A cornered animal had nothing to loose.

Sparkles on the other hand was looking distinctly worse for wear. Her impractical clothing had smears of mud on it, her skin looked raw in several places and she appeared to be panting heavily, clearly having exerted herself greatly in their brief fight. Seemed like Shadow Weaver was right - a violent instigator who could barely control herself. She looked like she would blow away if the breeze blew too hard.

On the other hand - Adora was more or less unharmed. A little queasy from that whole teleportation thing, and a little sore from the repeated contact with the harsh embrace of Etheria, not to mention drained from a lack of sleep and just general exhaustion, but she had had worse in the past, and would undoubtedly have worse in the future.

Only issue stopping Adora actually fighting was the fact that she was now without a weapon.

A weapon which Sparkles had just taken as some sort of oversized sword.

Sword.

Adora's head whipped right, a grin spreading onto her face as she turned back to face the duo. Taking a single step back, she grasped the hilt of the sword-

---

She blinked.

Whiteness.

Nothing but whiteness.

"Adora.."

She blinked again, the voice returned, this time visualised. Startled, she backpedalled, or at least tried to, her limbs frozen as a transparent woman flickered in front of her, robes adorned with some indecipherable language. Swallowing, she tried to open her mouth, to say something, explain herself, but nothing came out.

"Adora.. Will you be Etheria's defender?"

She blinked again - what magic was this?.. It.. Felt right.. Felt like it completed her. She felt like this was a part of her that she didn't even know was missing.

"Will you fight for the Honour of Greyskull?"

Her lungs drew breath again, blinking once, and the transparent woman was gone, as the white light consumed her.

The beast burst through the trees in front of Adora, a horrible spider-beetle hybrid.

Her attention, however, was not focused on that. Instead, it was focused on why the ground was coming towards her so quickly.

It was coming towards her so quickly, it turns out, because Adora was passing out, toppling to the right, slumped against the sword.

Adora III

It turns out, there is a very good reason why people with concussions are told to rest both physically and mentally after sustaining their injuries.

It also turns out that Adora is the sort of dumbass to ignore that advice.

Her eyes dragged open, taking stock of the situation. She was slumped over, would have been laying down if not for the sword stuck in the vines and roots that she was leant up against, glowing brightly, far more brightly than it had before, enough to send a jab of pain behind her sensitive eyes.

Then her brain clocked the *screaming*.

Irritatingly enough it was back, throbbing in her ears and pressing down on her brain, which in turn was crying out for the noise to stop. She didn't care really, however, more focused on trying to see what the source of the screaming was. There shouldn't be anyone out here-

Sword. Rebels. Fight

Princess.

Huge fucking bug.

Her gaze drifted to the right, looking at the sword she was slumped against, before her head rolled counter-clockwise, taking in the source of the screams.

It was the Princess, of course, utterly failing to do anything to the beetle-spider thing with her balls of sparkly pink light, which seemed to be almost bouncing off the beasts carapace if not for their seeming inability to actually sustain any other motion other than straight flight.

The real damage seemed to be coming from the three or four arrows that had found themselves lodged in the beasts carapace, creating a small cobweb of fracture marks that spanned out from the impact points. Yet the real story was told by the dozen or so arrows that littered the ground, and that followed the beasts tracks. *Clearly, the bow isn't strong enough to reliably land damaging shots*..

Her concern was more on the Princess, however, and how it seemed that she was so completely powerless to stop the beast in front of her, let alone Adora. Had.. Shadow Weaver been wrong..? Sparkles was screaming like a scared child as the beast shrugged off her attacks.

Something inside Adora pulled towards the magic, that small part of her that always cowered from Shadow Weaver. She had *long*

thought it to be her fears, her cowardice that hid away whenever the witch was around, but surely then it would tell Adora to run from this too?

But it wasn't, it was telling her to.. to *help* a *Princess*!

And it felt *RIGHT* too!

"Adora... Sword."

There was the voice in her head again... Not the distorted, fake human voice, the soft one, the gentle and tender one that made Adora feel safe and warm. The one she felt she could trust. Her gaze turned to the vine bound sword next to her, her head at the height where she could read the inscription on the blade.

"She-Ra..." Her lips moved unconsciously, sounding out the word in her mouth, although no words could have prepared for the reaction.

The small part of her, the part she had once called cowardice, burst to life, flooding her limbs with energy, sending tingling sensation through every part of her body, bringing up goose bumps all over her skin as it radiated out in waves. The exhaustion, the pain, all of it went numb, the fogginess in her mind vanishing in a heartbeat as thoughts came freely and thick.

Pushing herself upright, she grasped the handle of the golden sword tentatively, surprised at how *warm* the handle felt, despite no one having touched the thing in what could have very well been centuries. It felt *right* in her hand, like it belonged.. Or almost belonged. Just a little something felt off, although it was probably down to not being used to holding a sword.

But the vines and roots unravelled themselves freely and quickly, as if handing custody of the sword to the blonde in a heartbeat, leaving her suddenly *very* nervous, and not a little anxious. She felt almost stupid, standing there with a large golden sword, which was *glowing* and which weighed a not inconsiderable amount. *What the hell am I supposed to do now...*

But almost on *impulse* she raised the sword, settling into what she *hoped* was a combat stance, hoping that her muscles would find something that felt comfortable. But the small part, which was.. She guessed a big(ger) part now, inside her told her to keep going, to raise the sword high.

Her mind recalled the phrase told to her in the most recent vision, the one that felt so *important*, the one from when she had touched the sword. Even *thinking* it made Adora feel.. Complete, like the part of her she never knew was missing had returned to her in full.

"Will you fight..-" Her lips began to move of their own volition, uttering the phrase that she would come to regard as the most important thing she ever said.

"For the Honour of Greyskull!"

It was hard to describe what happened next.

Her vision vanished into a void of never ending white, her body positively *thrumming* with power, all of it flooding out from her chest, into her suddenly much longer legs, her arms, her chest, all of it felt so... *Full*. As if she was overflowing with energy.. With..

Magic.

That's why it felt so familiar...

Bow was *well* aware that this was a loosing battle.

His arms *ached* with a pain the likes of which he had never felt before, sore from the nearly overwhelming assault from the Horde soldier they had found wandering the Whispering Woods. Hell, he didn't even know *how* she had managed to get this close to Bright Moon without being detected, or the woods simply sending her round and round in circles. But given that she had seemed tired, but otherwise mostly fine, he guessed she hadn't been trying for long.

It had been somewhat sad seeing another soldier alone in the woods - Hordak had apparently not given up on his self-destructive strategy of sending soldiers and patrols into the Woods, like the council of planners had thought after so long without finding traces of one, but it seemed they were wrong. Sure, there was always the chance that this particular soldier had disobeyed orders, but disloyalty was not a trait found in any Horde Soldier.

Not even those threatened with execution.

He probably would never know if General Juliet ever carried through on her threats of executions, but given that Bright Moon apparently *still* lacked a proper prison, it seemed more than likely that the site was either located elsewhere or that the threats were promises.

He didn't like to dwell on that thought.

What he did dwell on was the importance of the blonde haired Horde Soldier that they had run into. He had never seen one out of armour before, but it was only once he laid eyes on the *badge* that she was wearing that he had realised the tactical *value* of their find. She was a Force *Captain*. An *officer.*

And then he learned why Force Captains got promoted.

Bow knew that he wasn't a push over in a fight, he could well and truly stand his ground against multiple Horde grunts and still expect to come out on top a decent 7 or 8 times out of 10. The

generic Horde soldiers arsenal really was not suited to engaging him at any sort of range, not when he had his bow.

And to couple that, he had *Glimmer*. A *Princess* fighting along side him. Sure, whilst her sparkles weren't the *most* effective weapons he had ever seen, they could deal some serious kinetic force, *PLUS* she could teleport, throwing opponents off easily. Sure, she had to recharge every so often, but still, she was more or less on her A game.

But this Force Captain was *REALLY* something else. If Glimmer was on her A game, then this Force Captain went all the way round to the other end of the alphabet in terms of skill.

She had not only beaten the living daylights out of Bow with her staff, but had managed to keep Glimmer at bay with her defensive twirls of her staff that had also served as attack against Bow. He didn't think she even *noticed* that she had foiled two of Glimmers attempted grabs on top of deflecting away her sparkles with her staff.

In the end, he was only saved by Glimmer *finally* landing a grab on the blonde amazon and toppling her, sending both girls sprawling.

Then there was the whole fact that the Force Captain probably would have beaten them to an absolute pulp with her *bare hands* if it hadn't been for her attempt to wield the glowing sword in the middle of the grove, one that had apparently knocked her out,

judging by how she had crumpled like a sack of potatoes immediately upon making contact.

Oh and then there was the giant monster chasing them.

Bow had never seen anything like it, and he was certain his Dads would have *loved* to study it, but personally, as of this very moment, he would rather it not be there. Unfortunately for him, it seemed to be doing just about everything in its power to *remain* there, despite their best efforts.

In his moment of distraction, he failed to notice how close the monster had gotten to Glimmer, and he was forced to watch in impotent horror as Glimmer was smacked sideways by one of its forward legs, sending her careening towards Bow. With just a second to think, he dropped his weapon, bracing himself and stopping Glimmer's impromptu flight in a rough, but considerably softer than it could have been, landing.

Giving the Princess a weak smile, her helped her upright, only to stare up in horror at the beast reared up over them. "Glimm*e*r....." His tone was, he thought, justifiably nervous and rather urgent, and his voice most certainly did not break to add to the embarrassment of the situation. Still, they could get out of this, Glimmer just had to-

The panicked look on Glimmer's face, mixed with the sudden dread in her eyes as she snapped her fingers repeatedly, trying to fall back on her emergency teleportation trigger, the one she had

used when learning how to control her powers, yet only resulting in generating a weak pink fizzle of light.

His stomach did a nose dive, staring up at the gaping maw of the monster as it reared up over them, ready to consume them in an instant. *This is how it ends...?*

"For the Honour of Greyskull!"

In a heartbeat, the creatures attention shifted from preparing to devour the duo to staring at the source of the voice, the voice that could only have come from the Horde Officer who had so thoroughly beaten the stars out of Bow and Glimmer. Her voice sounded nice, inspiring even, and if he didn't know what she was, he might have been inclined to follow her.

A blinding flash of white light, forced his head to look away, shielding the dazed Glimmer with his body to prevent her from getting a face full of the blinding light. It may have lasted a few seconds, and Bow may have given it a couple more before he turned his head back to look at the Horde Officer, but whatever device the Horde soldier had used to blind the beast couldn't have-

Incredibly, the monster's previously upright and agitated spines had flattened and its body had stooped low. It had shifted from being aggressive and attempting to assert its territorial dominance to being *submissive*, as if it had been thoroughly trounced in a battle and was begging for its life. To add even more icing to the cake, it wheeled about and *ran* from the grove, ploughing back

through the trees where it had come from and presumably back to its nest.

Whatever that device or tool or whatever that the Horde soldier had, it was *dangerously* effective. It could enable the Horde to counter the beasts of the Whispering Woods, which would be half the danger mitigated in a heartbeat... But if the *Rebellion* could capture it, Bow could reverse engineer it, put it to use making the Woods safer for the Rebellion!

Sure, he was no Princess *Entrapta*, but he could still reverse engineer whatever Horde device that the Force Captain was probably holding in her hand-

His stomach once again went into freefall as he *stared* in pure, unadulterated *awe* and equal parts *horror* at the seven odd foot tall, glowing warrior *Princess* clad in white, the legends of whom Bow had been *raised* on. His lips moved in unconscious unison with Glimmer's.

"She-Ra"

"*She-Ra."*

Glancing down at his friend, he utter the only thing that he could think of in that moment. "This is *really* bad...."

Thankfully, the tension of the awkward scenario was broken.

Unhelpfully, it was by She-Ra seemingly breaking out of her heroic looking trance, taking one look at herself and *screaming bloody murder*, dropping the glowing golden sword, which ploughed smoothly into the dirt roughly half way to the hilt. In a heartbeat, the majestic warrior Princess winked out of existence, replaced by the terrified looking blonde Force Captain, who started patting herself down, seemingly trying to verify that she was all there.

Her gaze shot to the sword buried in the dirt, swallowing so harshly that it was visible from across the grove where Bow and Glimmer were still clutching each other protectively, before staring up at them. Her gaze... Bow had never seen something like it.

There was a deep fury behind her eyes, an ice cold *rage* directed at everything around them - at the Whispering Woods, at Bow, at Glimmer, even *herself*, but *ESPECIALLY* the Sword in the dirt. But ignoring that, pushing past it rather, there was just fear. Fear as far as the eye could see.

What the hell has she been through?

"***What did you do to me!?"***

Adora had officially lost her cool, and in her moment of rage, had wheeled around and jabbed her finger accusingly at the

disheveled Princess and her lackey standing across the grove. This made no sense whatsoever - there was no logical or scientific explanation for what had just happened.

One second, she was Force Captain Adora, poster child of the Horde, inspirational leader and other half of Catra. *Then poof! I'm a 7 foot tall Amazonian in a tiara! What the fuck.*

She barely paid the rebels any attention, trying desperately to search within herself for some sort of direction, for a gut sensation - for a sign or even one of the voices. They knew what do to usually.

But even they were finally, mercifully, silent... at the *one* time Adora wanted them to talk.

So it had resorted to venting her anger at the two rebels standing across the clearing, both of whom were still armed, although Adora made no attempt to pick up the sword, or to arm herself. Getting her staff back would be easy enough…

The sword… I don't want to touch. Not in a million years…

"ME?! I should be asking ***YOU*** that!" Sparkles had the *nerve* to play coy with Adora, after *everything* that had just happened. "How the *hell* did you turn into ***She-Ra!***"

Adora blinked, fathoming what had just been said. *She-Ra... That's what is written on the sword... So its.. Not the swords name.. Its... Her?*

That.. Woman is She-Ra... Or.. I-

Adora swallowed, her mouth suddenly as dry as the deserts that surrounded the Fright Zone, unable to swallow *that* particular pill just yet. It was too.. Uncomfortable. *Princesses are all violent instigators - this one attacked ME. You can't just* become *a Princess. You're born one or you aren't..*

The boy was staring at Adora, or so she just noticed, and so Adora locked her gaze onto him, watching as he winced under her harsh glare - although in reality the effect was mostly ruined by how *frazzled* Adora looked. Sparkles had been saying something, but both of them had tuned it out in favour of reading each other more closely. Suddenly, the boy broke his silence. "You don't know who She-Ra is."

Sparkles whipped around, giving the boy a look of supreme indignation, one that show off just *how* petty Princesses were. The boy was probably going to be punished for cutting her off later on, so Adora figured the least she could do was satisfy his question, if only in an attempt to get him punished harsher. He looked like he was the sort to start talking and not stop, and this way she could possibly weasel something out of him.

It was certainly not because Adora *wanted* to find out more about this part of herself *desperately*, and certainly not because she

knew that going back to the Fright Zone would result in loosing maybe her one chance at figuring out herself. Plus - that part of her was *pulling* her towards these two rebels, driving her towards them, and Adora didn't want it to leave her - her gut told her that if Shadow Weaver found out about it... It would be bad.. Very bad..

So she took the plunge, taking a breath and committed a crime against the Horde - acting in self interest over the good and betterment of the Horde. "Does it *look* like I know what She-Ra or whatever her name is?"

"No - it really doesn't... How *did* you do that... Or rather - how did you *know* how to do that?" The wording was innocent enough, but it felt like Adora had just been thrown into a penal battalion in the Kingdom of Snows. It felt like he knew more than he should have, but at the same time was doing a *really* good job of hiding it.

It might have been the residual effects of the concussion, or it might have been the drive from that part of her (She-Ra now, she guessed), or maybe even a combination of both, but she opened her mouth and spilled *everything*. "I don't *KNOW*. I just.. Listened.. It felt *right*, like.. Like a part of me had already done this so many times! And the voices... They kept whispering to me... Its been happening for *days*..."

Suddenly, it occurred that A. Adora was terrible at operational security and B. She might very well sound.. Well, *completely* insane. But surprisingly enough, the boy didn't seem *too* phased by her admission of possible schizophrenia, nodding his head as if he was stuck in deep thought. "What sort of whispers...?"

Hesitating, Adora weighed her options *again*. She had given away *more* than she had intended to, and had gleamed absolutely *nothing* in return for it. This was hardly an equitable trade, but... It just felt like she had one chance to do this, and she *needed* to go all in on it. So she swallowed any final semblance of doing things for the Horde and just spoke.

"Calling my name - talking about*.. Balance* whatever that means.. Something about fighting 'For the honour of Greyskull', I don-SEE!" Adora interrupted her own counting off of her symptoms, instead jabbing her finger at the sword stuck in the ground, which was glowing brightly at the annunciation of the phrase she had uttered before transforming. The boy turned his head, eyebrows rising slightly, before looking sidelong at Sparkles, who returned his look with one that seemed to say 'Not me.'

A loud, bellowing roar rung out through the grove, enough to force everyone present to cover their ears least they be momentarily deafened by the noise. Turning her head to the direction of the noise, Adora stared at the dislocated and damaged trees along the path that the spider-beetle monster had retreated. Apparently he was coming back for some more.

Then a second roar rang out in response, amplifying the danger *tenfold*.

Now was a good time to *leave*.

"I need to go." Despite her normally confident tone, Adora couldn't help but feel that she was more asking to leave as opposed to saying she was leaving. Her words sounded unsure, uneasy, but like she was hoping there was an alternative. She couldn't shake the feeling that she was letting opportunity slip through her fingers.

She cast her gaze back to the Rebels, who both seemed fairly nervous about the whole ordeal, glancing between each other and talking in a hushed tone for a few seconds. Sparkles seemed to be a bit annoyed, whilst the boy seemed to be trying to convince her of something, probably to his own detriment. Sparkles looked like she was going to obliterate him in an instant, but she dramatically sighed, rolling her eyes, uttering the only words Adora got from their conversation. "Fine, but its on *you*."

The boy nodded his thanks to the Princess before looking back at Adora. "You should come with us. That thing will return soon... And he doesn't sound alone anymore.."

The whiplash of the situation made Adora reel, indeed she took a physical step back, nearly laughing with incredulity. "What? *Why* would I do that?"

The boy looked sidelong at the path of destruction, clearly wanting some more time to think about his answers, yet pushed by the limit imposed by the inbound threat. Sighing in frustration, he turned back to her, revealing just how frazzled he himself was. "Because if you come with us, we can figure out what is happening between you and She-Ra."

Adora opened her mouth to spit back some retort, some incredulous response at the words he was speaking, but found none coming freely. His words were *so* tempting, they were everything she wanted at that time - almost everything. Working her jaw silently, she struggled to find words. It would be almost *suicidal* to follow them. It would be too dangerous.

Apparently, he picked up on her nerves. Glancing to the right, he looked down at Sparkles. "Glimmer, give her the staff back."

Sparkles, or apparently *Glimmer* as she was called (how he got away with calling her just *Glimmer,* Adora couldn't comprehend. If she had called Lord Hordak just 'Hordak', she'd be dead on the spot), looked up at the boy with about as much shock as Adora felt on her face. "*What!* Are you *insane* Bow!? I'm just *meant* to give her a weapon!? You saw how easily she beat us with it!"

The boy, apparently called Bow, nodded. "I know Glimmer, that's *why* I want you to give it to her. Besides-" He looked over at Adora, as if he was trying to talk down a particularly angry superior. "I don't think you want to touch the sword, do you?"

"No." The response was instant and came easily, but She-Ra inside her wilted a little bit, as if disappointed by the her response. It was, however, easier to ignore now.

Glimmer stared at Bow for a few seconds, then at Adora with a distrustful gaze for a few more. Then her head slumped forward and she sighed. "You're *really* sure about this, Bow?"

"I am Glimmer. Now give it to her."

A few more seconds passed before the pink clad Princess cautiously approached Adora, the blonde taking a few shaky breaths in preparation for this all to be some Princess trick. In an instant, Shadow Weaver's words rung through her head - *All Princesses are cruel tricksters and violent instigators*. Adora bit down on the inside of her lower lip *hard*, trying to not tense up. She-Ra was telling her she needed to get this *right*.

Glimmer picked up the sword from the ground first, nearly stumbling over at the weight of the weapon, but maintaining her footing in the end. Adora had to shift her bite to the inside of her cheek to avoid laughing at how stupid the Princess looked in that moment.

Then came the fateful moment, Glimmer turning to look at Adora, visibly taking a few deep breaths before starting to walk towards the Blonde. No words were expressed, but the deep breaths and the body language the Princess displayed allowed Adora to read the girl like an open book. *She's just as nervous as I am...*

Glimmer offered her the staff from as far away as she could, with a metre and a half or so of empty space between them, bridged by the length of metal. Reaching forward confidently, or with as much confidence as she could muster while as nervous as she was, Adora took the staff, Glimmer letting go and taking a step back, but staying close, holding the sword with both arms.

Adora shifted the staff upright, then let it fall through her hands for a second, before grasping the middle in a practiced manoeuvre and collapsing it up, sliding it back onto her waist where it belonged. Unconsciously, all three parties in the grove let out a sigh of relief as the threat of hostilities died.

Glimmer and Bow stood a few metres from Adora, the two sides staring at each other in an uneasy fashion. Neither was quite sure how to proceed, and Adora had to ignore her instincts to treat them with hostility.

Thankfully, something solved the tension.

Unhelpfully, the ground started to shake under foot.

The distrust turned into panic as both sides glanced around for a way out, Glimmer immediately taking off down the way she and Bow had come from, with Adora figuring her chances of survival were far better going with them than trying to make it to the skiff, through a monster. So she followed suit.

Glancing back as they ran, Bow shot her a smile (How he managed to be upbeat when they were running for their lives, Adora would *never* know.) "I'm Bow, that's Glimmer."

Adora, glancing up for a second as she vaulted a log, decided she was long past the point of committing treason against the Horde.

With an incredulous look, mixed with a soft expression of amusement, Adora replied in kind. "Adora."

Catra II

Chapter Notes

Edit 6/07/2021: Fixed Italics, didn't port over properly

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wasn't back by the morning.

The feline was finding it harder and hard to play off Adora's absence - both to the rest of the 303rd Cadet Training Squadron, to her superiors and to Shadow Weaver *especially*. It was, however, infinitely harder to play off Adora's absence to *herself*.

Normally, someone's absence at breakfast was not usually missed, sure their place was given a few glances and the occasional sympathetic look from the rest of the Officer cadets (their cohort had shrunk to the point that basically everyone knew each others names), but today was different. The awkward silence that hung around in the air as everyone tried to pointedly ignore the absence of their unofficial leader was impossibly tense, and the whole meal was had in near silence as looks were shot between

the other members of the squad, all whilst Catra stared at her meal.

However, it had not been uneventful.

Catra had long since noticed how Lonnie had tried to place herself as the unofficial leader of the Squadron, but she had been thoroughly trounced in terms of charisma and skill by Adora, and that was even before you took into account how she was Shadow Weavers pet project. So Lonnie had settled into place as the firm in terms of social standing. Catra hadn't given a single fuck about that whole social hierarchy, and had mostly subsisted outside it, and given how she was almost always by Adora's side, she hadn't had to worry.

But now with Adora *absent*, Catra was in the uneasy position of having to assert her own position, all whilst Lonnie looked ever closer to making a power play.

There had been a few times when Lonnie had looked like she was going to talk, to ask about Adora, but every time she had either held her tongue or Catra's body language had sent off enough warning signs that even the human could pick up her agitated nature.

It turned out that when push came to shove, Lonnie didn't seem like she was willing to risk a physical injury from Catra, let alone a scene in a public place, not when their leader could be coming back any second to put Lonnie in her place, probably entirely unconsciously.

She sighed, picking at her ration bar. *Adora will be back soon. She promised.*

Noon came - Adora was still not back, and Catra had begun to worry.

Some of their superior officers were eyeing Catra with an air of suspicion, evidently not trusting her with the belief that she knew more than she was letting on about their otherwise star Cadet's sudden absence. It was times like this that Catra wished that Adora had not been such a goody two shoes and turned up for every class and training session that they had.

And whilst the officers couldn't officially do anything against Catra given that she ostensibly didn't know where Adora had vanished off to, the moment that Commander Cobalt had begun to note things down on a data pad immediately after talking to Catra, the feline knew how the dice had rolled. She knew what was coming later in the day.

Rolling her left shoulder, Catra still felt the vicious pain present from the last time Shadow Weaver had delivered punishment to her for her transgressions. She had hurt the joint in a training

exercise a week ago and Shadow Weaver had quickly discovered that the injury was still tender after Catra had chosen to 'get snippy with her'.

The pain had been *unimaginable* at the time, just like it always was, but it had slipped into the sea of her memories as just another one of Shadow Weavers 'discipline sessions'. Mundanity amidst a sea of similar memories.

Regardless, the looming threat of another one of Shadow Weaver's sessions was not really aided by Lonnie deciding to finally question where Adora was.

Catra had done her best to brush Lonnie off. Apparently the deeply tanned girl with dreadlocks did not like being brushed off so easily, and did not take 'dunno' as an adequate answer.

And that's how Catra found herself staring at Lonnie, who was stepping in front of her every time she tried to disengage from the conversation, and really beginning to wonder if the girl with the dreadlocks had a death wish.

"Where is Adora, Catra."

Inhaling one last time through her nose, Catra ground out her response from between her teeth, trying to ignore the painful noise that only she heard as they ground together. "I told you. I don't know."

"Like hell you don't! You're inseparable. Or what, did she abandon you *finally*?" Lonnie's tone took on a lint, taunting and goading Catra into giving up an answer, trying to use her rage against her. Fortunately, it worked.

Unfortunately, it *worked*.

Catra was aware of many things as she stepped right up close to Lonnie, driving a single claw on each foot through the top of Lonnie's shoes and lightly scraping the top of her feet. The position may have been uncomfortable for Catra, but she had the balancing skills that resulted from a lifetime of training, and she could hold the position.

Lonnie, on the other hand..

Well, whilst the strained noise of pain as she tried to maintain her 'tough guy' position, all with the burning pain shooting through her nervous system, certainly wouldn't have been audible to a human... *Catra, on the other hand...*

The cruel curl of her lip as she once again ground out her response would have been a dead give away that she knew. "I. **Do not** know, Lonnie."

Stepping back from her dominant position over the other cadet, Catra made to pass by, knowing that she had only prolonged

Lonnie's retaliation against her for a short while. Still - Catra needed some air.

Lonnie's words had done far more damaged than the girl with dreadlocks could ever be allowed to know.

She wouldn't let anyone see her cry though.

She couldn't.

"*Catra*."

It was amazing how a single word could made Catra's whole body stiffen and her brain abandon all logical thought, but yet here she was, suffering from the paralysing sensation of *fear* that only one person could instil in her. *Shadow Weaver.*

Swallowing, she turned her body stiffly around and repeated the name aloud this time, trying to suppress the undertone of fear that she knew the Witch would *revel* in achieving in the normally defiant feline. "Shadow Weaver."

And yet the subtle tilt of the masked woman's head almost seemed to say that Catra's effort had been pointless, and the feline had the sneaking suspicion that the woman knew exactly what her voice had been trying to hide, and that the whole thing amused her in a sick way. She shoved down the urge to shudder, feeling the sensation dissipate uncomfortably in her stomach, but it was far better than giving the witch any gratification.

"Tell me Catra, have you seen.. *Adora* around today?" The Witch's tone immediately told Catra that she already knew where Adora was, but was simply playing Catra along for the sadistic satisfaction. And yet, her stupid pride didn't let her back down.

"I don't know where she is. Why would I know?" Catra's retort could have been better than just casual passive aggressive back chatter, but the feline was really not in the mood for a full on argument, but more importantly, she could read Shadow Weaver, or more accurately, the curling shadows around her. They were already agitated by something, and Catra was always going to avoid torture at the hands of the Witch if possible.

"Because you two spend an inordinate amount of time together, even if you are *bunkmates*." The subtle emphasis on the final word sent a shiver up Catra's spine far quicker than she would have liked, and she was aware of how her ears unconsciously and unwillingly folded down defensively. Sure, Shadow Weaver would have known about it from the whole Lemuri incident, but it was still against protocol and the fact that she was directly bringing it up meant that the Witch was serious.

Catra could only manage a half-assed shrug, trying to steady herself before replying. "She just said she had something to do. I *don't know* where she is."

The shadows behind the Witch curled angrily, more agitated and Catra could hear the woman inhale annoyedly, before exhaling softly, both actions far quieter than the human ear could manage, but Catra was more than capable on picking up on them. The shadows slowly began to recede from their highly agitated position, into their previous agitated position as Shadow Weaver turned on the spot.

"*Walk*." It wasn't a request or a question. It was an order.

Catra obeyed.

Betrayal stung.

Sitting on the bed that had once been Adora's, Catra just stared at the bedding, the blankness of her emotions corresponding to the emptiness in her heart. *Adora left me.*

She broke her promised.

For the fucking Rebellion.

The bucket of emotion she carried inside her splashed dangerously, looking up from the plain sheets covering the bed, threatening to spill over as she laid eyes on the childish drawings of her and Adora in the small alcove of their bunk. They had been done when they were kids, and they had been so terrified of what would happen if they got caught graffitiing on Horde property. Adora had promised they wouldn't be caught.

Promise.

That single word, those seven innocent letters, kicked the emotional bucket over, mixing the murky emotional waters together, and allowing for the deep crimson rage to dominate.

Before she even registered what was going on, her claws had already torn 4 deep scores through the drawing from their youth, shattering the physical memory of the promise in an instant. It left a small void inside her, staring silently as the ramifications set in, running her fingers down the scarred drawing with a delicate touch.

Why doesn't it HURT.

It needs to hurt... Adora left me.

The hazy memory of two nights before ripped through her head, the soft touch of Adora's hands on her own, the warmth in her chest at the sensation, the usual comfort she felt in Adora's company dashed by the nervous doubt she held. It was a bad idea.. She should have said something, done something!

I fucked up our promises! I shouldn't have let her go!

And then the memory of everything she did to defend Adora's honour in her absence. Aggravating Lonnie, blowing off Horde Officers, even directly lying to Shadow Weaver's face, the paralysing fear and the threat of agonising pain, all of it done in the hopes Adora would return for her.

And then opportunity, a chance to prove herself - to gain the gratification of those around her, a chance to become something more than just Shadow Weavers failure. She got to prove herself and her leadership capabilities.

And she had found Adora, done as told.

And then it had all gone to shit.

Adora *had* actually been that naïve, to believe everything she was told in the Horde. She had imagined the Horde as some sort of

liberation force, as the 'good guys'. And her faith in the Horde had been utterly destroyed by the Horde's actions.

And Catra's.

And despite her revulsion. Despite the horrible things that she had seen Catra do..

She still begged Catra to come with her. *And I turned her down.*

No.. I attacked her whilst her back was turned...

Her fist came down on the thin mattress, sending pain rocketing through her system as the rage simmered away beneath the surface. She knew she had to stop, that Catra could not possible contain herself if her mind didn't stop the self destructive thoughts.

Catra had turned her back on Adora's promises.

For what? The Horde? She hated the Horde. She hated Shadow Weaver, she hated the food, the propaganda, the lies and half truths, the abuse - both physical and mental. She had only stayed because of Adora, and because there was no where to go otherwise.

And now Adora was gone, and Catra had a cold, empty bed to sleep on. *Alone.*

I'm to blame... I drove Adora away.. I drive everyone away....

The second swipe was easier than the first, there was no reflection this time as she gutted the mattress on which she had slept for almost her entire life. It was letting go of the old times in the most violent way she could, the only really way she knew how to without Adora there to help her.

The third swing was just reflexive at that point, as was the fourth, both coming down and tearing more and more out of the mattress, cloth and foam flying. As for the rest of the swings...

She didn't remember the rest.

The next thing she remembered was kneeling over the gutted mattress, hugging the one thing that was spared her rampage.

The pillow.

"*Catra*!"

The Witches voice normally would have made her freeze up, but the modulation this time was entirely wrong to have that effect on her. What it did do was make her ears fold back and her tail stiffen protectively, because Catra had never heard Shadow Weavers voice so full of *fury*.

She barely had time to scramble out of the bunk before the Witch grabbed her arm with her hand, dragging the feline off her feet and dragging her out of the room. "You have failed! You had one mission and you failed *spectacularly*!"

The rage hadn't simmered away, feeding into her blood as adrenaline as she chose to stand her verbal ground and fight. "ME? *YOU* didn't tell me there would be Princesses! Besides, its pointless! Adora betrayed us!" *Betrayed me..*

That got a response from Shadow Weaver, something that would have otherwise given Catra a healthy dose of satisfaction. Unfortunately, that never manifested, as the neurons that would have triggered that dopamine rush were busy panicking as Shadow Weavers free hand grabbed her by the throat and hauled her off her feet, shadows coiling around her arm, making the grip on her neck burn.

"***LIES***! Your insolence will be punished by a higher power! Your failure will not be handled by me. Lord Hordak will ***personally*** deal with you." The cruel lint in Shadow Weavers voice told Catra that the felines face was indeed a mask of pure fear and dread. This had been threatened in the past, but Shadow Weaver had never carried through on her threats to Catra, but the feline knew to dread the name.

Those who were sent to Hordak rarely returned. And those who returned were always people who were sent to deliver good news.

Being dumped bodily on the hard floor, still being hauled by the arm, Catra barely registered that they were already at Lord Hordak's throne room, so overcome by the acceptance that she was about to die, and that Adora had been right, was she. This cycle of panic was shattered by her bodily impact with the ground as Shadow Weaver threw her down, one that knocked the wind from her lungs and left her gasping for breath as she lifted her gaze.

The room was lit by what seemed to be the only window in the entire Fright Zone not tinted, the golden light blazing down upon the throne which dominated the centre of the room. On the arm of the throne, a small creature Catra had never seen before sat, staring back at her with an intelligence that surprised the feline.

Then her gaze turned right, into the shadows of the room.

The shadowy figure lurking in the darkness made her wish she hadn't.

"Lord Hordak." Catra was vaguely aware of even Shadow Weaver bowing in respect, something that had Catra swallowing nervously, ignoring the shivers of fear that she kept barely suppressed. "I gave Catra a simple task and *overwhelming* forces. Instead of returning Force Captain Adora, we have suffered a

humiliating defeat, and she has the audacity to attempt to *lie* to me."

The glowing crimson eyes in the darkness stared into Catra, seemingly boring into her soul as she lay sprawled there, analysing every fibre of her being. It felt incredibly uncomfortable, as if Lord Hordak knew far more about Catra than she had been lead to believe, maybe even more than Shadow Weaver knew.

Maybe more than I know…

"So you mean to say.. You are *still* down a Force Captain, Shadow Weaver?" The unimpressed tone had Catra flinching out of sheer instinct, and it took a few seconds for the words to sink in. Lord Hordak didn't sound too displeased. If anything, he sounded more unimpressed with *Shadow Weaver* as opposed to Catra.

Hang on..

Apparently, the sudden shift in power dynamics caught the witch off guard too, given the pregnant pause before her response, which in and of itself was exceedingly measured. "Yes, Lord Hordak. Rest assured, we will find and return Force Captain Adora-"

"**No**." The sharpness of the simple word caught both women entirely by surprise, Shadow Weaver visibly stiffening, evidently surprised at his response. Hordak hadn't even raised his voice, he

had just abruptly cut the woman off as if she barely mattered to him. "You will elect another and resume normal operations."

Catra stared. *Shadow Weaver brings me here to see me get told off… and Hordak is having a go at HER. For once, I don't mind being dragged off. This was SO worth it.*

"B-But my Lord, *Adora* was the *only*, *viable* candidate!" Shadow Weaver's tone sported an unfamiliar new pattern - incredulity. Catra had never seen the woman anywhere close to how unbalanced she was in this instant, and all from a few words from Hordak.

"You have Catra, was she not too your ward?" Catra had to sink her teeth into the inside of her lips to stop a grin spreading across her face. Shadow Weaver was being torn a metaphorical new one by Hordak and it was positively hilarious. Then the ramifications set in. *I'm… being considered for Force Captain?*

"*Catra*, is *NOTHING* but a *disappointment*." Shadow Weaver's hair was snaking out, the shadows around the rim of her cloak curling in agitation. The witch had almost screeched when Hordak mentioned her name. I can die happy now.

"Then whose fault is it that she was not conditioned correctly?"

Silence hung in the room, Catra having to raise a hand to her mouth to cover the start of a laugh that threatened to escape her

lips. Of all the things she had expected upon entering this room, having to suppress laughter whilst Hordak tore Shadow Weaver apart piece by piece was admittedly not a considered factor.

A surprise, but a welcome one at that.

"My ***Lord***!-" Shadow Weaver sounded exceedingly upset by the whole affair, almost indignantly responding to Hordak. But yet, the man was not having it.

"Enough. I have made my decision." The figure in the darkness approached, stepping forwards towards the duo, halting just inside the light, a closed hand covered in a gauntlet outstretched, holding something in its grasp.

The hand uncurled, revealing the gleaming golden badge of a Force Captain. Realisation. It was being offered to her. "Arise, Force Captain Catra."

Oh- Oh this is happening…

With surprisingly steady hands, Catra took the badge from the man, staring at it in her gasp as she pulled herself upright, ignoring how utterly furious Shadow Weaver looked to her left, in favour of daring to raise her eyes to look at the man before her. Unconsciously, she drew a breath of surprise.

Catra had never laid eyes on Hordak before, not from outside the shadows from where he would occasionally watch Cadets practicing for their final training sessions before graduation, but she had never really pondered what he would look like. After hearing him talk to Shadow Weaver, he looked... Strangely fitting for his voice.

The man mostly wore armour, covering all but his face, yet that face told a story. He had almost bat-like features, sharp pointy ears, a crest of deep blue hair on his head and sleek red eyes. But his skin was as white as a sheet, alabaster almost, with no discernible nose. It may have seemed odd on their own, but together they made his face look strangely complete in a way.

Staring back down at the badge in her hand, Catra came to a sudden realisation.

She had been stunted by Shadow Weaver, who always chose Adora over Catra, who saw potential in Adora whilst Catra had the exact same potential, locked behind the witches sadistic cruelty.

She had never needed Shadow Weaver, the woman was only a stepping stone in the road to achieving Catra's goals. She would run the Fright Zone one day, like she had promised *herself*.

Adora leaving... Was the best thing that ever happened to me..

A cruel grin slid onto her face. *She'll see what I've become.*

Those thoughts would haunt her for the rest of her life.

Chapter End Notes

In this chapter we see the transition of Catra's mindset throughout the three days that have passed since the fateful day that Adora went into the woods and met Bow and Glimmer. Note the changing ways she treats Adora, and especially Hordak, shifting from calling him Lord Hordak to just 'Hordak' in her mind.

Adora IV

Adora had her doubts.

It had not been easy at first, leaving behind everything she had ever known to be consumed into the darkness of her past, and to forge a new, brighter future. It felt.. Hollow at first, but then again, so did *everything* she had done up to that point, all for a cause that had manipulated and used her like a tool, just like the Rebellion would like to. Adora had had enough of being a tool however.

At first she had tried to justify *some* of the Hordes actions, but it had been made quite clear that she was clutching at straws, and she had stopped after a few hours. Even without Glimmer's incessant badgering about what the Horde had done to the people of Etheria, the attack on Thaymore that *Catra*-

In a heartbeat, Adora's train of thought derailed, tumbling into the endless abyss of her mind, leaving her blankly staring at the decorative waterfall on her balcony, the gnawing void inside her eating away at her just a little bit more as she wallowed. Wallowed in a mire of grief, loss and longing.

I failed Catra.. And turned her against me..

The normally breathtaking view, the marvellous white and gold castle, the brilliant and calming light of the Moonstone glowing upon its plinth outside the castle, the dazzling glint of the suns rays dancing off the crystal clear water of the lake surrounding the castle, all of it seemed dull and bland in a heartbeat. They had taken Adora's breath away at first, but now.. They were pretty, she guessed. She didn't really have it in her to say more on the topic.

The mood wasn't there. Like she wasn't deserving of thinking nice thoughts.

Catra was going to be a painful topic. It was better to not mention it.

Sighing, Adora glanced over her shoulder, looking at the inside of the door to her room. Her own room - not a barracks like the Horde. Her own room, own bed, own bath - All of it had been a serious culture shock for the Blonde when she had first come across it - hell the Princesses had never heard of a *shower* before. It felt.. Somewhat comforting that there was learning going on for both sides.

Speaking of learning - her taste buds and stomach were learning to deal with the egregiously rich flavours and textures of the food here. Adora had nearly thrown up the first time she had a full Bright Moon meal, having eaten far too much, resulting in her first night being spent on the balcony, resting her feet in the pool of the decorative waterfall and feeling sorry for herself.

Blink.

The memories vanished in a heartbeat, replaced by the image of the door, bringing back the melancholy mood and making the blonde's shoulders slump slightly. Ostensibly, she was a guest of the Queen and a member of the rebellion. She was She-Ra, Princess of Power.

Unless the power extends to fixing my mistakes.. I don't much want it...

She-Ra pulsed lightly inside, a soft sensation washing through her body, calming her down and washing away the worst of the negative sensations, leaving Adora feeling *balanced*, if not exactly whole of person. In the wake of the pulse, a new memory came up, one that She-Ra chose for a reason.

The ghost of a smile flickered across Adora's lips, the memory of being brought before the Queen of Bright Moon playing again in her head.

Adora had been *terrified* at first

The Queen of Bright Moon was the *ultimate* evil she had been brought up to hate - the embodiment of everything that she had stood against not a mere 24 hours prior. Now that she had her eyes opened, at least partially, to the error of her ways and the

things she had stood against, Adora had been like damp clay on a potters wheel, malleable in her views.

Some things, however, had managed to slip by at first. The topic of the Queen had been one.

So Adora had prepared herself to face some horrible monster, like the holograms she had seen so often in training, unconsciously running the moves she had trained with through her head, just in case. Fortunately for all involved, Queen Angella had been a relatively normal looking woman, when one ignored the giant wings on her back, with a kind expression and a soft smile.

Unfortunately for Adora, that kind expression and soft smile had vanished the millisecond she locked eyes with Adora.

The cold rage and anger that the woman wore on her face was enough to make Adora *wish* for the horrible demonic creature that she had seen projected on the holograms. The silent fury was infinitely more terrifying than what she had seen in the simulations, and she got the sudden feeling that she would be nowhere near as easy to down as her daughter had been.

The court she held was barely any better, all probably planning how they would deal with her whilst she approached the dais, flanked defensively by Bow and Glimmer. Had she tried this alone, she had no doubt that she'd've been torn limb from limb by the villagers *outside* the castle.

Admittedly, it had been *immensely* satisfying to see the hostility in the room vanish in an instant as Glimmer uttered the phrase 'She-Ra', watching the fury turn into stunned disbelief, then hope. It would have given her whiplash if not for her apprehension.

Momentarily pulled from the memory, Adora looked at the golden sword resting on the mantle next to her bed, feeling that same uncertainty and aimless sensation returning, edging into the corners of her mind.

She blinked.

The sword was resting at the same angle, although now in Bow's arms, offered to Adora hilt first. The gaze of the court rested on her, the anticipation and pressure almost drowning her in the oppressive gaze of the court. Taking a few deep breaths, Adora had quelled the panic as she focused on only those who mattered in the situation. Bow, Glimmer, Angella.

She-Ra.

She had avoided touching the sword before then - having only touched it thrice before that moment. When she first found it in the forest, when she passed out in front of Bow and Glimmer, and lastly when she first transformed. She had thought about risking touches, just gentle scrapes or nudges, but she couldn't bring herself to risk it. The panic had been clawing at her throat and even Adora could read that body signal.

So she hadn't. Until the time she *needed* to.

Memory Adora's hand came down on the hilt of the blade, taking the weight from Bow and holding it in a one handed grip in front of her face, staring at the stylised phrase on the blade. *She-Ra.*

Blink.

Adora stared at the same angle, the sword in her hand, the comforting weight partially filling the hole inside her as she stared at the same word written on the blade. *She-Ra.*

What do you want me to do..

Blink.

Instead of the awed face of Queen Angella as She-Ra stared back at the Queen of Bright Moon, the beaming faces of Bow and Glimmer and the reverent expressions of the courtiers and members of the council that Adora expected, a new memory flashed up, one that was not her own.

A small shack, nestled in the woods, covered by leaves and foliage and roots, shrubs growing next to the small curtain that functioned as a door, with a small home garden out front. A hole had been cut out of the grass covered roof, propped open by a

stick to serve as a chimney, with a thin wisp of smoke coiled out from the opening.

The comforting voice uttered a single word, startling Adora from the memory. The voice sounded so.. Fond.. So happy, but also carried a twinge of sadness. *Razz..*

Staring down at the sword in her hands, the diamond, circle and triangle on the blue blade that spelled out 'She-Ra' clearly to none, bar Adora, pulsed softly with golden light, as if agreeing. Adora swallowed gingerly, glancing back out over the marvellous sparkling, crystal clear water of Lake Bright Moon, exhaling.

She wasn't naïve enough to think that she was fully trust by the Rebellion, and vanishing off into the Whispering Woods wouldn't help her credibility, but she just.. Had the feeling she needed to go. Alone.

Glimmer would insist on going with her.. But *Bow*..

Glancing at the desk that sat against one of the walls of the excessively large room, Adora raised the sword over her shoulder, resting it in the holster that had been added to the webbing of her belt, striding over to the desk and pausing for a moment to thing. Choosing her words carefully, she scrawled a note to Bow, sliding it under the door for one of the guards to notice.

This done, she set about the arguably harder objective, walking out onto the balcony and exhaling softly, swallowing carefully. *Getting myself killed helps no one.*

Carefully choosing her footholds, Adora began to climb down the vast mass of Bright Moon Castle.

This was a stupid idea..

Picking her way over a log, Adora ducked under the dangling foliage of some tree that she could have sworn she had walked past five or six times already. Sure, she had expected to get turned around, that was inevitable, but this... It felt wrong - like the Whispering Woods was *actively* trying to stop her from finding whatever it was She-Ra wanted her to find.

Defender of Etheria my ass... That thing with the insect was just a one off then-

Hang on..

Blinking, Adora pulled the sword off her shoulder, staring at the softly glowing inscription on the blade unmoving for a few

seconds, letting her mind kick itself into gear. *So... She-Ra is part of Etheria.. But Etheria doesn't recognise me as She-Ra.. But if I turn into She-Ra...*

Inside her, She-Ra welled and pulsed softly, as if congratulating her on what she had just figured out. Adora paused for a second, turning her attention inwards as she looked down at her sternum, where she could feel She-Ra. Or at least, where she felt that the... consciousness(?) of the Warrior Princess sat, realisation dawning as she spoke. "You're.. Guiding me, but making me figure things out.."

All was silent for a few seconds, and Adora got the feeling that she was talking to herself, and in doing so, going completely insane. But just when she was about to give up, the essence of She-Ra pulsed gently, and that gave Adora the confirmation and satisfaction (not to mention the relief that she wasn't loosing it) that she had been looking for.

Raising the sword aloft, she breathed out, letting her exhale push aside the fears and doubts that she still had about becoming the Warrior Princess, asserting that this was her life now - she was well beyond the point of no return with the Horde. It sounded fragile in her mind, but she focused on grasping the warm glow inside her, clinging to it as she uttered that same phrase again.

"For the Honour of Greyskull!"

The warmth inside Adora's body swelled, expanding and flooding through every part of her body, head to toe, finger tip to finger

tip, her head tipping backwards slightly and looking up to the sky, eyes closed. Energy ran through the sword, the blade glowing with a golden outline that was mimicked on Adora's skin, not that she could see with her eyes closed.

The blinding white void into which she gazed vanished in a heartbeat, her eyes opening.

The way ahead of her was now parted, a corridor for the Princess to travel through. The breeze was cool on her bare legs, but Adora didn't feel anything, although she did wonder why exactly the Warrior Princess had such a.. Young looking outfit. She felt almost dorky.

Catra would think I look like a total dork..

Catra..

A sharp jolt of terror passed through her, the brilliant energy, the strength and will of She-Ra flickering and slipping through her grasp for a second. For a moment, she winked back to Adora, muscles feeling heavy, the stream of power broken by her indecisions and doubts, but the energy pooling in the sword created a feedback loop, jolting her back into the guise of the Warrior Princess in a heartbeat.

Blink.

The path ahead of Adora had shrunk a little, not as wide as it was before, but still very clearly there. Flexing her fingers, just to remind herself that she had total control over herself, a soothing action, Adora took off in a run, along the path cleared for her in the woods. She could hear the trees behind her snapping shut, the panic clawing at her throat as she spurred herself onwards, faster and faster.

Her own stamina was gone quickly, draining in just a minute of running, and the exhaustion began to set in, muscles going stiff, limbs feeling heavier and heavier, her chest tightening. The noise of the trees got louder and louder behind her, the panic beginning to restrict her breathing as she grasped for something, *anything* to help her keep her pace. The sword in her hand pulsed under her grip, guiding her towards the energy of the Warrior Princess inside, something Adora grasped onto-

A burst of energy overcame the exhaustion, spurring her onwards, flooding her body with a newfound strength that saw her dart out of the trees, and into a clearing, stumbling to a halt and falling to her knees, exhausted and out of breath, sucking in great lungful's of delicious oxygen as she tried not to throw up, despite the pressure on her stomach.

The noise of rustling fabric pulled Adora's head up, echoing the image she had seen already in her mind earlier that day. Staring down at her was a bespeckled old woman, wearing a patchy pink/red cloak and sporting wild and long white hair that would have made *Catra* jealous with how long it was.

She-Ra flickered again, once again the sword pulled Adora back into being She-Ra, the jolt of shifting so quickly causing her to wince slightly. It wasn't painful, but it was uncomfortable.

The old woman paused for a minute, then smiled wide and clapped her hands. "*Mara*!"

The name sent shockwaves through Adora, the rest of the old woman's words going in one ear and out the other as the reverberations through her body ripped her consciousness from her violently, memories surging forwards to take its place.

Adora's eyes opened. It was dusk, but somehow she knew that that was wrong - like this wasn't really happening. *Memory..*

Blink.

Her gaze turned up, staring up at the night sky, sparkling with thousands and thousands of *stars*. Goosebumps erupted over her skin, staring up at the nights sky, slack jawed with awe at the marvellous sight before her, sparkling away in the sky without a care in the world.

*When **is** this..?*

Footsteps over grass brought her attention, a tanned woman with a long brown hair in a braid, dressed in a blue leotard emerging from the grass covered shack, a warm smile on her face, turning back to look at the shack. From it came the short old lady, looking exactly the same as how Adora had seen her. "Goodbye Mara dearie! Tomorrow we can make a pie!"

The tanned woman, apparently named Mara, turned, looking back at the older lady, her words pulling Adora's attention. She looked happy, a warm smile on her lips, like she enjoyed spending time with the old woman. "Alright Razz. I'll see you tomorrow."

Adora's eyes, however, were not on Mara's face, or even Razz. They were fixed to Mara's waist, where, on her hip, a very familiar sword sat. It was almost identical to the one Adora had been holding, just with a few changes to it. *Mara... Was She-Ra..*

She was my predecessor..

Just saying the name 'Mara' had She-Ra inside her glowing warmly. Adora's lips parted slightly, taking in a soft breath of air, her brain clocking something as she gazed down at her chest, her brain apparently not being panicked at her mostly transparent body. *So.. You're Mara then..?*

She-Ra *(or was it Mara?)* was quiet inside her.

Concerned by her guides silence, Adora looked up, now standing several metres from where she had been with Mara walking right past her. Reflexively, she reached out, her ghostly fingers passing right through Mara's shoulder, but still grabbing the woman's attention, given how she stopped walking.

But then Adora clocked how the whole memory had stopped, every fraction of the world frozen in time, the birds overhead, Razz turning to head back into the hut in the woods, Mara-

Mara had turned whilst Adora was looking away from her, the blonde turning back to face-

She-Ra.

But not *her* She-Ra. This one had platinum blonde hair, and stood a few inches taller than Adora, with blazing blue eyes that pierced right into Adora's soul. Wearing full length white pants and heeled boots, things that looked much nicer and far more mature than Adora's own youthful She-Ra form, Mara's She-Ra felt commanding, orderly, and had Adora's mouth dry staring at it.

"Adora."

The words that escaped Mara's open mouth came without the woman moving her lips, and it almost felt like it was a whisper

being said in her own head. Then she realised that it was. It was the whisper of the voice she trusted, the one that she had come to view as her guide to being She-Ra. *So it was you...*

Mara's right hand came to rest on Adora's shoulder, and the blonde realised that she too was in her She-Ra form, shorts, boots and all, her own sword resting in her left hand, like Mara's. Mara radiated.. This raw power, the orderly power of She-Ra, but she felt so much stronger, like a beacon, a true connection to Etheria, one that Adora had only just begun to understand. Mara represented the potential that Adora had in her.

"Don't trust Light Hope."

The blonde's mouth opened, trying to ask the pertinent question of her elder counterpart, but found her mouth unwilling to speak. Instead, her mind spun and her vision went blurry, silently toppling over to the side and landing on the soft ground without the force of any impact.

Instead, her vision too spun, and with a blink, she was gone from the memory, the forest clearing vanishing in a heart beat, leaving only the sparkling stars in the black void left behind.

"Mara dearie, you need to take better care of yourself! Can't go round passing out like that. She-Ra needs to take better care of herself.." The warbly voice of Razz rang in Adora's ears as the blondes eyes opened drowsily, a yawn breaking through her lips as she struggled back to consciousness. Despite its odd nature, Razz's voice was full of care and affection, and it made Adora feel *safe* most of all.

First thing she noticed was that her back was *sore*. Even though she had been sleeping on a firm mattress at Bright Moon (Glimmer, Bow and Angella had all gotten incredulous looks when she had asked for something firm), Adora wasn't a fan of sleeping on whatever Razz called a bed. Opening her eyes properly and looking down revealed that Adora was sleeping on a rock, which might explain the old ladies hunched posture.

"Ah goodie! You're awake Mara. Come, come, its berry picking day, remember?" Swinging her feet off the rock and standing up, her back protested, something she silenced with a nice firm stretch, sighing vocally in relief at the sensation. Her waking up was interrupted by something being shoved into her hands, a basket made of wicker, something that Adora looked at somewhat cluelessly.

"Uh.. Razz? I'm.. Adora, not Mara.." The old lady paused, blinking, before turning to look at Adora and raising her glasses to view the blonde with her bare eyes. Shrugging, she lowered the glasses back onto her eyes and set about collecting a few more things, including a broom, a sack of something from under a Horde Soldiers helmet (that had Adora slightly concerned), and a basket for herself.

"You'll have to speak up dearie, I'm not wearing my glasses."

Adora blinked.

She blinked again.

She tried to wrap her head around the statement.

She found, very quickly, that her brain started to hurt when she tried to do that. Adora stopped trying to wrap her brain around the statement, giving a confused laugh and deciding to just.. Go with it. She-Ra.. Or was it Mara... They had brought Adora here for a reason. Razz had to know something.

"Riight... So.. Berry picking? Why?"

"Oh for Madame Razz's Pies of course! You should know better Mara dearie!" *Berry picking.. Is Razz going to lead me somewhere..? Or maybe tell me something important..*

Adora tuned back into reality, blinking. Razz was gone. *Shit shit shit....*

Pushing past the curtain, Adora glanced around outside, spotting the retreating figure of Razz moving into the Whispering Woods.

Hurriedly, Adora glanced around for the sword, finding it next to the door and sliding it into the makeshift sheathe on her back, before taking off after the old lady, wicker basket hanging from her elbow behind her, acting like a sail.

It would almost be amusing if Adora wasn't so stressed out.

Adora V

"Madame Razz?! Hey- Razz wait-..."

Adora found herself trailing off, staring up at the immense monument that lay in front of her, overgrown from the years of neglect. The clearly First Ones made structure sported some wear and tear, clearly having suffered from the abandonment, with mother nature having begun to reclaim some of the structures surrounding the main tower. To the right, what looked like a boundary wall and a small storehouse had been overgrown, wrapped within the crushing roots of the Whispering Woods, the walls tuned into chunks of dull looking crystal.

The left hand side was faring little better, a large tree wrapping its roots around the large building sitting there, seemingly trying to give the building the same treatment as the storehouse on the right, although the more robust design of the larger building proved to be enough to resist them for now.

The real attention puller was the monumental structure that dominated the back of the clearing, standing high above the tops of even the tallest trees, the walls sparkling in the light of the glowing moon of Etheria that hung overhead. At the very top, a glowing crystal sat in almost stasis, suspended above the rest of the building by some invisible force that Adora didn't even *want* to begin and try to understand.

It's... Like a beacon...

Yet even the main beacon was not immune, with vines and other overgrowth wrapped around the structure, but ultimately doing very little to the beacon.

Stepping out of the tree line where she had stood immobile, Adora's foot came down on the same materiel that the rest of the structure was made of, firm hard rock, but decorated with something far beyond her understanding, and impregnated with the technology of the First Ones.

Out from under her boot, a trail of light shot, spreading out in all directions, coursing throughout the whole structure and spelling out words on the ground, more than Adora could ever comprehend. The streams of light, however, all converged on the beacon, racing up to the top of the tower and into the glowing crystal, which *blazed* with brilliant blue light. It was almost blinding, but strangely Adora didn't want to take her eyes off it, like it was something exceptionally important.

That being said, Adora immediately pulled her boot back, staring up at the beacon with surprise plastered over her face, wincing at the ground as if she had done something wrong. When no angry bugs or.. Whatever else came out of the woods to destroy her for her transgressions and trespassing, Adora tentatively stepped back onto the First Ones structure and stood very still for almost a minute, taking in the enormity of the project.

It was definitely smaller than Castle Bright Moon, but it looked *far* more imposing than the majestic structure ever did, something about the building felt.. Foreboding. Or maybe that was just gathered from how She-Ra fluttered nervously inside her,

preemptively building up the energy that she felt Adora would need when inside the foreboding structure.

Cautiously stepping forwards, towards where Razz was staring up at the structure, Adora's eyes flashed left and right, constantly on alert for any threat that could pounce from the shadows. The eerie emptiness of the structure didn't sit right with her, but ultimately nothing came at them aiming to claw either of their faces off.

What Adora did notice, however, was the damage to the buildings was precise. Particular.

Running her fingers along one of the scars in the side of what used to be the storehouse, Adora realised just *why* they were so precise when she raised the sword on her back, and it slid perfectly through the groove.

Re-sheathing her sword far more cautiously, Adora stared down at her sternum, to where She-Ra was feeling a lot less warm - almost standoffish - and paused for a moment, having a staring contest with the swell of her white undershirt. Licking her now dry lips, Adora took a careful breath and lowered her voice so that Razz wouldn't hear her. "What aren't you telling me?"

Silence .

Adora blinked once, keeping silent for almost twenty seconds, but still She-Ra refused to offer any sort of reply. It was foolish of her, she realised on reflection, to trust this so.. Blindly. She had turned her entire life around because of this mysterious princess and now she was a wanted fugitive of the Horde, and only being kept safe because she was a supposedly important part of the Rebellion.

She was being used. Again .

Catra was right.

"Adora dearie? What are you doing?" Razz's warbling voice saved the situation from devolving further as Adora looked up to protest at Razz's misnomer, making a noise before she caught herself with a surprised jolt. Razz had actually called her Adora, *not* Mara. Maybe the old woman wasn't completely loopy.

"You'll need to speak up dearie, I'm still not wearing my glasses."

Ok maybe she still is a bit loopy.

"Nothing- Nothing." Adora took one last forlorn stare at the marks on the storehouse, staring at them to ensure they stayed burnt into her mind, before she turned away and walked towards the old lady, who herself was picking berries from the bushes surrounding the beacon. Adora's footsteps barely made any noise on the overgrown floor, and Razz didn't move her head from the

task of picking berries, but the old woman's timing was impeccable and a little startling.

"You should go in. She'll be waiting for you." The tone was a jarring difference from the warbling voice that Adora had grown accustomed to, and her words gave Adora a strange sensation in her gut. The voice was wizened, impossibly old, and yet it sounded timeless. Razz didn't turn around, instead focusing on a berry in her spindly fingers. "Trust only yourself Dearie."

Struggling to find her words, Adora finally latched onto a statement, managing to croak out a question from her suddenly dry throat. "Wh.. Who will be waiting for me?"

Razz's words had sounded *ominous* , like she was moments away from being attacked by some horrible being, or some ancient evil. Or maybe it would be someone she couldn't face - someone like.. Shadow Weaver or.. Catra.

Despite being attacked by Catra in Thaymore, Adora and the feline had never actually crossed proverbial blades. Neither had been forced to fight the other yet, and although Adora couldn't possibly know, she liked to think that both of them couldn't bring themselves to fight the other in combat. If she *did* have to fight Catra, She-Ra's sword... Wasn't the best tool to use. Her staff would be far better.

But she *didn't have* her staff on her. She just had the sword.

It's going to have to do..

Razz cut through Adora's intense, panic driven battle planning in a heartbeat, back to her old warbling voice that Adora had come to known and (admittedly) vastly prefer to the cryptic voice that had given that ominous premonition. Adora didn't know if Razz was schizophrenic or something, but it seemed like she knew more than she let on. "Hmm? What was that Mara? Alright, Madame Razz will wait here, but don't take too long! The berries will go cold."

And its back to Mara... Great..

Don't have a choice now..

Staring up at the smooth rock wall in front of her, Adora bit her lower lip, taking in the enormity of what the door looked to be. No visible markings, just smooth, layered rock forming part of the base of the beacon. *Don't suppose I knock..*

Feeling somewhat stupid, Adora raised her fist and gently rapped on the rock, waiting for a pregnant pause to pass before accepting that, it had indeed been, a *very* stupid idea. *How would I open my secret lair..?*

"Uh.. Hello? Open?.. Razz, do you know-" Turning to the old lady who had been to her left, Adora found herself staring instead at a bush entirely stripped of berries, blinking slowly before sighing

deeply, her shoulders slumping. *I can do this... Its just a door. Come ON Adora, surely you can figure a DOOR out...*

Inside her, She-Ra began to blossom, rising up to speak, to give her some sort of guidance, but Adora stopped, clenching her fist and taking a deep breath. "I *don't* need you telling me what to do."

The essence of the Warrior Princess slumped, abandoning her efforts to help Adora figure out the structure. She felt disappointed, as if Adora had done something wrong, broken some sort of rule, broken a promise. *Fuck that, I've broken the most important one I've ever made. Can't get worse than that.*

She didn't know how a disembodied essence could feel *sassy* , but if She-Ra was capable of exuding that sensation, she definitely was right now. Almost like she was saying 'You haven't seen *anything* yet'.

Ten minutes of trying would prove Adora wrong.

It's official. I can't figure out a door.

Taking a step back, Adora returned to the position she had stood in so many times before, atop the overgrowth in front of the door to the beacon. It was particularly humiliating. She was supposedly this all powerful Warrior Princess who was the destined saviour of Etheria, and failing that, she was a product of the elite, refined officer cadet program that the Horde ran, and she was totally incapable of figuring out a door.

"Fine. Help me." Glaring, she turned her gaze down to her sternum, waiting silently for She-Ra to speak, to pulse, to blossom to life, to give her any words of wisdom, but the being was frustratingly silent on the matter. Like she was drawing this out to make a point to Adora, except it was one the blonde had totally missed.

Glancing upwards, she observed the glowing moons position, taking a tentative breath as she estimated the time. Her absence had definitely been noticed by now, and Bow would probably be able to buy her a few hours, but night fall was an absolute deadline to be back at Bright Moon by. Any later and she'd be wandering the Whispering Woods blind, and well.. *That's a death sentence, even if you are a 7 foot tall Princess with a sword.*

Plus, she'd make the entire rebellion more suspicious than they already were of her, and it would offset *all* the trust she had been trying to build.

Frustrated, she vented some of her emotions into the ground, swinging her boot into the mossy undergrowth underfoot shift, nearly throwing her off her feet as the slick moss gave no grip against the smooth stone underneath, sliding off and flinging itself several metres through the air. For a second, the sharp panic as

she flailed for purchase, as more of the moss broke away under her feet, stabbed deep into her heart, a lump forming in her throat as she managed to regain a cautious balance.

Staring down at her feet to ensure she was staying upright, she found herself greeted with a circle, glowing softly with the light that still ran through the structure as a whole. There was a line connecting two sides of it, and somehow Adora's brain clocked that it was part of a word, and that the circle was a letter. *E..*

Drawing the sword from her back, she used the point of the blade to scrape clear the next letters in the sequence, swallowing to lubricate her throat as the anticipation built. *T.. E.. RN.. IA.*

"Eternia?" The word sounded familiar, and it sent shivers throughout her entire body, as if the word had a far greater meaning than Adora could possibly ever understand, although the ghostly warmth and happiness that she felt, echoes of a past long escaping her actual memory, lingered and gave her an idea of what it meant. *It sounds like... Like a home..? How..*

"How do I know that..." She glanced down to her sternum, pulling herself out of her reflection to stare at her silent guide, only for the ground under her to shift suddenly *downwards* , tilting as the blonde found herself slid off her feet by the slick surface, sliding down the rapidly appearing ramp, into the dark hallway waiting underground.

Suddenly, her failure to open the door seemed incredibly stupid and understandable regardless. *Because it wasn't a door,*

dumbass.

Also ow.

Standing up and rubbing the rapidly bruising skin on her hip from where she had hit the cold stone floor of the gloomy hallway, Adora found herself struck by the realisation that the corridor was surprisingly illuminated, covered in the strange language of shapes and lines, all glowing softly with blue light. It was an awesome sight, one that had Adora's breath hitch in wonder as she observed each of the words, trying to see just how far her knowledge of this alien language went.

As it turns out.. I'm basically fluent...

Glancing at the nearest wall, she tentatively extended her fingers, running them along a trio of symbols in a triangular formation. This one took a moment to translate in her head, but when it clicked, the breath in her throat died in a strangled squark. *Ad.. or-*

.. Adora..

How the hell did they know I would....

Turning her head right, she looked at the next name along the wall, although something inside her told her that she was actually

looking at the name before hers, that this language was read right to left. It just felt like part of her very *mind* and *soul* was telling her how to read this, and that had started to stress her out a little. *Ma ra..*

Hurriedly taking a few steps forwards, she came to a stop in front of the name before Mara's, reading the inscription. *K ei ra.. Keira.. All these names end with ra..*

Just to satisfy her theory, Adora walked up to the name before Keira, only to come upon a section of wall again scarred by the sword that rested on her back, weighing a thousand tons as she ran her fingers over the damaged wall, the name forever expunged from history. The glowing streams of light still ran into the scarred wall, but they faded out just as they reached the first gap, hiding whatever was used to make them glow.

"What did you do?" Adora's hand on the wall curled into a fist, as did her hand resting at her side, casting her gaze down at her sternum, feeling the anger well up inside her. Whoever she was had given her life to Etheria and the First Ones, and her legacy had been wiped from existence by one of her successors to the title of She-Ra. How was that fair?

The proverbial bucket was rocking dangerously close to toppling over as she felt the Princesses essence begin to rise up inside her, finally giving her *something* to work with. Maybe she would try and explain herself, try to justify her actions by telling Adora what she wanted to hear, something that she could latch that anger onto.

But the response from the voice, the voice Adora trusted, the voice that she now knew was Mara, sounded so.. Weak.. So hopeless and so depressed. It sounded like the woman had done unspeakable things to bring them to where they were today, and her guilt had stuck with her to that point. Her voice was barely a whisper in Adora's mind. *'What had to be done.. I paid for it with my life..'*

The bucket of rage evaporated in a heartbeat, leaving Adora standing there in the hallway, feeling aimless, without any sort of direction, distinctly emotionally *empty* . How was she meant to respond to that? How do you tell someone that their ultimate sacrifice for what they believed in was *wrong?*

I can't.. I just... There's nothing TO say...

Adora pivoted, looking down towards the end of the corridor she was headed, taking a deep breath and exhaling, flexing her fingers as a soothing action to centre herself before she proceeded any further. This journey had *already* thrown her off, and she hadn't even arrived where she needed to be, she was just on the threshold.

A foot moved out, and Adora left the tunnel, stepping out into a chamber with a raised plinth, the entire room made of a variety of glowing crystals, providing the room with enough ambient light that Adora figured that it was brighter in this room than it had been outside. Still, something else had her attention, the hologram of a tall figure in robes who was perched atop the plinth, standing there expectantly.

"Hello Adora. You've come at last. I am Light Hope." The name sent Goosebumps racing over Adora's body in a wave, instilling into her a fight or flight response that the blonde didn't really understand the cause of. Sure, Mara had *warned* her of the being known as Light Hope, but Mara had apparently had a go at this place with She-Ra's sword and had tried to hide it from Adora.

Trust is relevant...

But Adora had to admit, this hologram was.. Uncanny.. Unnatural, and it sported the voice that Adora had come to distrust, that ethereal, fake husk that had first pulled her from the life which she had been perfectly fine and happy living. Standing silently there, almost awkwardly, Adora just waited, letting the hologram speak. *I think I'll make my own mind up.*

"I have been waiting for you since you were an infant, but I could not save you from the Horde. Instead, I watched you from afar, and waited for the right time to send you the Sword of Protection, so that you could fulfil your destiny."

A new hologram winked into existence between the duo, a familiar sword floating mid air, blade pointed upwards, towards the high, vaulted ceiling of the subterranean chamber. Intrigued, Adora strode forward, unslinging the sword from her back, comparing it to the sword floating in front of her. *Identical.. Perfectly identical.*

Holding the blade out in front of her, Adora raised it to rest inside the hologram of the blade, the two merging seamlessly, bar the

slight flickering distortion of the hologram as it came into contact with both her arm and the sword. She couldn't help the slightly pleased grin at the satisfying meld of the two swords as they slotted perfectly into each other.

Still.. She's been watching me my entire life? That's...

"That's... A little creepy Hope..." The holographic woman flickered slightly, her face distorting as if remembering something, something that had put a kink in her otherwise normal programming. Adora stared at the hologram cautiously, unconsciously falling back into the tried and true method of being tentative with her questions, like when she was around a potentially annoyed superior officer. "Light Hope..?"

"I am merely reflecting upon the fact that both you and your predecessor appear to forgo pronouncing half of the name that I was assigned. Is this normal for humans?" Adora pursed her lips as she reflected upon what had been revealed in that short span of time. *Mara knew Light Hope... And she said not to trust her..*

"Uh- Yeah, sorta.." Awkwardly shifting her feet, Adora stared at the ground for a moment as she slung the sword back onto her back. "You knew... Her? My predecessor? What happened to her?" Biting her tongue, Adora hoped that her verbal slip up had not been noticed, having nearly said Mara's name, something she should not know.

Thankfully, Light Hope's programming did not account for apparent verbal slips, instead tilting her head as if recalling

memories, before giving a deliberate nod, something that looked a little off, too stiff. "Yes. Mara was your predecessor. However she lost control, she was compromised and destroyed much of the infrastructure relating to my functions. In doing so, she was destroyed, thus breaking the line of She-Ra's who had come before her. Ora, you are the first She-Ra in a thousand years.."

Adora blinked, screwing up her face in a frown as she struggled to figure out what 'Ora' meant, but thankfully for her, the Hologram was willing to clarify. "Is that not following normality for Humans? To shorten one's name by half?"

Suddenly, it clicked. *Ora.. Ad **Ora** ..* "Oh no.. No no, that's... That's not how that works.. Adora is.. Fine, Light hope.."

The hologram again tilted its head, that robotic nod returning. "I apologise. My Human social interaction protocol is severely outdated. My previous attempts to update it have failed due to a failure to connect to the main servers, resulting from when Mara stranded us in the empty dimension of Despandos."

As the hologram went on, Adora reflected on just how much she had been told in such a short span of time, far more than she could have possibly gleamed from the very particular Princess inside her. *So.. Mara did all this damage... And she presumably disconnected Light Hope from the main servers.. But **you** aren't telling me anything about it... I guess Light Hope is my best bet..*

"So.. Light Hope... What is uh.. Your purpose..?"

Blinking, Light Hope tilted her head, something that she had apparently been programmed to do frequently given how often she seemingly did so. "I am Light Hope. Etheria's Facilitator. I was created to aid She-Ra in her duty to balance Etheria and to save the planet."

"Aid.." The phrase piqued Adora's interest, and so she dug a little deeper. "Aid how?"

The hologram looked at Adora silently for a moment before answering. "I am able to assist She-Ra with any number of queries, questions, possible issues, connection to the primary and secondary servers, communication with the Eternian high council, battle strategy-"

The list had begun to get boring very quickly, Adora's shoulder starting to slump as the hologram began a seemingly endless list of purposes, but the comment about battle strategy woke Adora up. "Battle Strategy! So.. You can help me train..?"

Hope stared at her completely frozen for a few seconds, empty eyes boring holes straight through Adora in an unnerving way, one that had the blonde feeling distinctly uncomfortable. *Is she... Broken?*

"Uh, Light Hope-"

"Yes. I am able to assist She-Ra with training associated with utilisation of the Sword of Protection offensively, utilisation of the Sword of Protection defensively, utilisation of the Sword of Protection as a tool through which to..."

Adora fought the urge to groan as she stood there, silently listening to the hologram listing off the specifics of her function. *I should have stayed with Razz...*

Catra III

Chapter Summary

> A compilation chapter covering the events with Catra during the intervening months around Adora discovering the Crystal Castle.

Chapter Notes

> A/N: Chapter 10 will probably be something similar - as I wanted to write a bit more and cover the events of Entrapta's defection to the Horde, but I was both pressed for time and acutely aware that this chapter is nearly 6000 words. Longer chapters like this will probably continue now that we're getting more into the AU elements and less into the season 1 content.

The Salineas Seagate was an imposing structure by any definition of the word, soaring high above even the tallest mast on any ship Catra had seen.. Well, ever. It probably stood taller than most, if not all, of the buildings in the Fright Zone, and none were nearly as vast or just...

Well, pretty.

The intricate carvings, the clear attention to detail put into this monumental structure, it made it almost a shame to destroy it. *Speaking of..*

"Since when was there a giant gate blocking the way to Seaworthy?" Unable to keep the incredulity from her voice, Catra turned to the mountain of a woman who was standing next to her

at the prow of the vessel they were on. The ashen haired giant, who had the rather fitting name of Scorpia (when one considered she looked like an oversized scorpion), in turn gave her a look of surprise.

"Uh, since always. It was mentioned in Force Captain orientation… Didn't you go?"

The annoying itch in her eyebrow as it did a sudden nose dive betrayed the irritation that she tried to keep off her face, mainly because it was self directed. Of course she missed Force Captain Orientation, there was supposed to be no point to the thing, it was meant to be something that she would already know, but apparently there was a few things that her sheltered upbringing in the Horde did not prepare her for.

"Beginning to think I should have.." Her grumbled reply was unfortunately picked up by the ashen haired woman, who slapped Catra on the back fondly and yet far too roughly, the friendly gesture nearly sending her careening into the sea. Saved only from the horrific experience by her reflexes and genetic advantage that saw the railing of the boat perforated by claws, she glared back at Scorpia, who in turn seemed to be entirely oblivious.

"Ah don't worry Wildcat - I'll give you the cliff notes.. Although they're probably a bit old.. It *has* been a while." There it was, that nick name. *Wildcat*. Catra didn't like it.

But what she did like was what it replaced. *Catra.*

Catra was what *Adora* called her. But that Catra was dead - she died with Adora. Right now, Wildcat was far better than being called Catra by someone of equal rank. If it was an underling like *Lonnie* or Kyle, then it was *Force Captain* Catra, and nothing more or less. She had made that *very* clear.

Regardless, Scorpia's increasingly side-tracked rambling brought about a new line of inquiry, just so that Catra didn't have to deal with Scorpia's incessant *rambling*. "How old even *are* you if you have to worry about those notes being out of date."

Scorpia paused for a moment, doing a stereotypical thinking pose that Catra completely ignored in favour of staring ahead at the Sea Gate through the telescope that she had stolen from Kyle. *There aren't any obvious weak spots to target, but.. Well there's that disc in the middle of it, but that'll be a pain to hit at any sort of range.. And I don't trust these idiots to shoot straight...*

"Y'know- I don't really remember. I guess it's because I've been a Force Captain since the Horde arrived and my family gave Hordak my Kingdom." Scorpia hadn't touched her, but Catra nearly fell off the boat regardless as Scorpia's words hit her brain. Wheeling onto the woman, Catra stared incredulously.

"*YOU'RE* a ***Princess?!***" Scorpia blinked blankly, staring at Catra as the feline practically *screeched* her question.

"Uh.. Yeah? I thought that was common knowledge, given it was covered in Force- Oh right." She at least had the decency to look a little embarrassed, rubbing the back of her head bashfully. Catra didn't care however, turning back to look at the Sea Gate, and the figures now standing on floating rocks in front of the gate.

A sinking feeling settled in her stomach as she prayed that it wouldn't be who she knew it would be, that she wouldn't have to run up against her this soon. Sure, it had been nearly two months since Adora betrayed her, but Catra still hadn't figured out what she wanted to *do* to Adora when she met her.

Unfortunately for her, only one idiot wore their hair in that poof.

Great.. Now I have to rush things..

Grounding herself both mentally and physically, Catra straightened up, eyes flicking between the various rocks that tore their way up through the otherwise calm ocean, plotting what jumps she could and couldn't make. The result was fairly surprising. She could easily make it all the way up to Adora, who had just been momentarily engulfed in a flash of white light that Catra knew would probably be her turning into that Princess who had torn apart her forces at Thaymore.

A cruel smile slid onto her thin lips. *I took all the punishment for Adora.. Maybe its time she returned the favour.*

"Scorpia. Give me a distraction. Keep them occupied.." The corners of her mouth twisted further upwards as she stared at the golden haired figure standing helplessly in front of the Sea Gate. "I've got something important to do."

Without waiting for a response, Catra hurled herself off the boat, pointedly fixing her gaze on the rock that she was about to smack into. Looking down would mean staring at the ocean, and it would only make her twitchy and fearful, and that would be stupid. She had learned from her youth. *3... 2.. 1... Brace..*

Claws sunk into stone as the first shot from the boats weapon rang out, and even from this distance Catra could hear Adora's surprised and pained grunt. *So.. She'll be occupied..*

As she went for her second jump, she made a point of focusing on her movement. And ignoring the fragment of her mind that was still that girl Catra, and the way she ached hearing Adora in pain.

I'm better off without her.

Catra was well aware that there was a battle going on - but Adora *really* needed to work on her situational awareness.

Even as this supposedly all powerful Princess connected to the planet or whatever, She-Ra was apparently as deaf as a snake and as blind as a bat, and Catra reckoned she probably would have had to sprint towards the Princess, screaming her name to get any sort of reaction. Still, the real struggle had been getting past the rest of the rebels and the two princesses, although they were unsurprisingly focused on the distraction that Scorpia was making.

Admittedly, Kyle's only purpose was so that there was *some* sense of victory for the rebels, but pride is the downfall of so many.

Rather lazily striding up behind the Warrior Princess, Catra took in a good long view of She-Ra and her attire, softly whistling her appreciation as a way of announcing her presence, which judging by the startled jump the blonde made as she struggled to keep her concentration on... Whatever she was doing, worked. Indeed, it worked so well that Adora's focus momentarily broke, the stream of energy flowing into the gate faltering and giving the blonde some rather vicious looking feedback energy that elicited another grunt of pain.

Adora had most certainly been muscular for her physique and age. She was a Horde officer Cadet after all, but the blonde had always gone above and beyond to be the best, just because she *needed* to be.

Unwillingly, Catra's fist tightened as she strode closer, making the final few observations and continuing her thoughts.

She-Ra, however, was *extremely* muscular, in a way that made Adora look like Catra had to Adora. That on its own told Catra one thing - She-Ra would be a far different beast to Adora in terms of

head to head combat. She could probably take a few hits from Adora, but She-Ra? *One hit and I'm done for.*

Seemingly haven given up on trying to look behind her, She-Ra called out instead. "H-Hello? Who's there?"

Oh but She-Ra would have looked so intimidating, if it wasn't for those stupid shorts. They made her look so dorky, hard to take seriously really. Perhaps that's what Catra was shoving down inside - the urge to laugh at the blonde, to mock her whilst she stood there, unable to resist or do anything about it.

But still - Catra was a Force Captain. She had responsibilities. And one of them was right in front of her.

She-Ra's immobile and exposed back was almost as good as a training dummy, and Catra was more than happy to oblige the target, rising up to her tippy toes and moving her mouth right against She-Ra's ear, bracing her hands on She-Ra's shoulders in order to set up her strike.

"Hey Adora." The feline registered the Warrior Princesses eyes widening in surprise, her eyebrows skyrocketing as a single glowing blue orb stared back into Catra's own heterochomic eyes, twinkling with... Was that *fear~? Oh that's wonderful.*

Of course, this happened in the space of a second as Catra yanked back on the Princess's shoulders, pulling her backwards as

Catra's knee came up, landing *exactly* where she aimed it, the approximate area of a human's liver.

The Horde had banned using liver and kidney shots in hand to hand sparring practice, yet they still taught how to inflict the damage onto a hostile. The actual impact that such a strike would have on another being had long been confined to Catra's morbid curiosity, and now seemed like as good of a time as any to put that to the test. She-Ra would survive, almost certainly. That didn't mean that she couldn't *hurt* however.

Catra learned *immediately* why it was banned in sparring practice.

She-Ra was tough, Catra could tell that just based off the muscle mass she observed and that which she impacted with her knee, but even still the Warrior Princess *immediately* inhaled sharply, wheezing as her knees buckled and dropped the blonde to her knees, then further spilled her onto her side, propped up only by her right hand as her left still held the sword, discharging a beam of energy into the gate. It was pitiful really, watching She-Ra staving off the pain flooding her nervous system as she still kept on powering that stupid fucking gate.

Fucking Adora. Always having to show off. Oooh look at me, I'm Adora, I can do EVERYTHING. I'm a magical *Princess! All it cost me was my best friend and my entire life!*

A sneer slipped onto her lips for a brief moment as she crossed in front of She-Ra, stepping onto the sword as she crossed it, finding herself unable to suppress the sadistic grin as she watched She-

Ra grit her teeth as she did so, rather casually crouching in front of the blonde's face. "You know.. The more I look at it, the stupider you look. That tiara... Those boots... Ah, and how could we forget the *shorts*. You sure you didn't get younger, Adora?"

The blondes silence as she gulped in air left Catra bored, flirting her eyes over the decidedly less majestic looking Princess laying before her on the rock, chest heaving as she struggled to stave off the effects of the single blow Catra had landed. Eventually, however, the Princess managed a reply, although it took far longer as her words were intercut with deep breaths and pained expressions. "Catra.. H-.. How did you find me.."

Catra almost groaned. She wasn't about to tell Adora that it was a coincidence, that would put her at ease, give her solace, with only the sneaking suspicion otherwise. Instead, some psychological warfare would be far more effective. "Oh Adora.. You of all people should know... Its not that easy to escape the Horde."

Reaching out, Catra gripped She-Ra's chin, forcing her gaze towards the feline's lapel and the winged badge that sat there. In reflection, the move served no purpose, but Catra of the moment felt like she deserved to rub Adora's nose in it a little more. "See.. Without you, *I* got *your* promotion."

The response was... Less than what she wanted, however. A defiant She-Ra managed only a contemptuous "Congratulations" before closing her eyes and trying to focus herself against the pain that was surely *screaming* through her nervous system.

A stab of anger flared, and Catra ripped her hand away from holding She-Ra's face, claws digging into the blonde's tender flesh unintentionally, streaks of blood splashing across the Princess’s face as Catra's hand froze between them.

In fact, both of them froze, staring at the crimson ichor dripping from Catra's claws accusingly.

Catra swallowed, staring at the blood on her hands. Adora's blood. She hadn't had anyone's blood on her hands before, it was a new experience, one that might have done a hell of a lot less damage than the knee she delivered to the Princess's liver, but represented a lot more.

There was no going back. The lines had been drawn in the sand, and were marked by Adora's wounds.

She didn't know what Adora's expression was, as the next heartbeat she was thrown from the rocky platform by a stream of water, and hurled down to the ocean far below.

She didn’t remember much past that, just that Scorpia found her in the water an hour later, staring at her hand.

The nightmares only got worse afterwards.

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*Of all the self centred things that the Princesses of Etheria could do - they have a friggin All-Princess **Prom** .*

The sheer insanity of the event spoke leagues about the self entitled brats who ruled over Etheria's various fragmented kingdoms. Still - Scorpia's invitation had been a blessing in disguise Catra reckoned. Not only would it allow her to come into close contact with some of the other Princesses on Etheria, but it would also prove itself useful for sowing discontent within their ranks.

Plus she could use it to try and mess with Adora and her plans. If she knew the blonde (which she liked to think she did), she would be too busy chasing after Catra all night to really be bothered by forging alliances if the feline turned up.

So distracting Adora was her first order of business. Showing discontent was second - and could in all honesty probably be accomplished through step one, and finally preventing Adora from making contacts went hand in hand with the other two steps.

The whole plan was made far easier by the strict rules and etiquette required by the Prom, one that strictly dictated that there was to be no violence or fighting of any sort. That meant Adora would be disarmed and unable to become She-Ra, and Catra would be at a far greater advantage than she normally was.

Plus, whoever she came with - probably no one, given that Sparkles would bring Arrow boy with her, who himself would also be disarmed, leaving the main threat as Sparkles. But still, there was a possibility that Adora had a new sidekick to replace her, something that had brought her left hand into a tight fist, and that would mean yet another threat. But there was probably no one.

The only obstacle left was... Well, what would the goal be. Catra couldn't just run off to the Prom with Scorpia, Hordak would never allow it, there had to be an overarching purpose that the man could be convinced was worth the investment and the risk...

"Sooo.. What're you pacing about for?" The sudden vocalisation pulled Catra from her strategic mindset in a heartbeat, the ashen haired woman sitting on her bed, still holding that absurdly long scroll that had sparked this whole conversation. Irritation flared, and the ire that blazed to life was turned onto Scorpia in an instant.

"*Trying* to figure out how we'll get approval for this mission." Her words were sharp, barked out and full of the anger that impulsively rose to the surface at having her scheming interrupted, although the fellow Force Captain seemed totally oblivious of the tone. "Hordak wouldn't understand the subtle intricacies. He needs a bigger target. Something strategic."

"Like... Bright Moon?" The reply was unsure, completely tentative and said more as a question than a suggestion, but it got the gears turning in her head just as her irritation moved to bark out another barb at Scorpia. Straightening, she raised a hand to her lips, cupping her own chin as she thought, running through the possibilities.

Bright Moon was *certainly* too big of a target. Even trying to get through the Whispering Woods to attack it was pointless, there was little logic behind the action. However, they could indirectly launch a crippling blow against Bright Moon by attacking their Queen..

"Scorpia.. Does the Queen usually attend the... Uhg, *prom*?" The undertone carried a bit of hope to it, something that Catra wasn't overly impressed with her inability to suppress. Still, Scorpia's face contorted into a frown as she raised an oversized pincer to her lips.

"Y'know - I'm not really sure. I know my Moms went together but that was considered pretty rare. It'd probably be the Princess who went, not the Queen. Why'd you ask?" Each passing second pulled Catra's lips further upwards. *Perfect...*

"Because I know how we can defeat the Queen of Bright Moon in a single night..." Unable to suppress the sadistic grin on her lips, Catra hopped up deftly onto the edge of the bed, looking down at Scorpia sitting on the side. "*You* are going to the Prom. *I'm* coming as your Plus One and *we* are going to catch ourselves a Princess."

Scorpia seemed more and more sold on the idea with each passing word, and Catra had to admit to herself that it was a pretty good plan-

.. Although she didn't think it warranted being crushed to death by an oversized bug.

It was stupid. She was being stupid.

Adora should not be making Catra feel nervous, she should have easily grounded herself. Adora was the enemy, they had shed blood on the battlefield facing each other, and Catra was far more in control of herself and her emotions than Adora was. She also had a plan, she knew what Adora's plan would be, and Adora didn't know that she was coming, thus leaving all the cards in Catra's hand.

*No... **We** haven't shed blood, **I** shed **Adora's** . She hasn't so much as flicked me.*

Admittedly, the whole plan had actually required a bit more planning, so she had regrettably been forced to drag along the rest of the human 303rd Alumni for the mission (she still have *zero* clue how Kyle was viewed as an officer, yet alas, he was). They would be lurking around somewhere, hopefully making themselves *useful* with their collective 30 iq, they just needed to buy Scorpia time once Catra began to distract Adora.

She had felt *disturbingly* embarrassed in the weird scorpion shaped ship that had been placed at their disposal, but regardless, they had both managed to insert their infiltration team and make

it past the guards at the entrance without any sort of security response, so all seemed good. Of *particular* note was the gleaming golden sword sitting in the coat room, something that she would need to direct one of their infiltrators to try and retrieve...

Once they report in... If they remember... Kyle wont.

Surprisingly, her Force Captain badge, secreted away in the breast pocket of her blazer, vibrated slightly three times, her eyebrows rising in surprised amazement. That was the signal that their infiltration team had managed to not only enter the main castle safely, but had also managed to procure some form of disguise without raising an alarm. *Impressive... Especially for* them.

Walking down the hallway of sparkling ice, adorned with amazing looking sculptures and decorations that baffled the mind to even consider possible, without the involvement of magic, Catra leant against Scorpia, bringing their heads close in a gesture that could be mistaken as intimate. Her words, however, carried nothing of the sort, a simple and short explanation of what was going on. "They're in."

Scorpia made no comment, only a nod as she seemingly psyched herself up for the evening, Catra pulling her head away lazily and staring at the magnificent door that lay ahead of them, glittering with crystalline decoration that was supplemented by the glinting ice. Taking one last breath of her own, she continued her pace and passed through the doors, letting them silently swing open ahead of her, revealing the room beyond.

This place is... Enormous..

Room was indeed a very ill fitting description, the monumental cavern styled into an immense ball room in which a full blown *party* was going on, with more people than Catra had ever seen gathered in one place, and she had been to Horde rallies. *If there are this many Princesses, how the hell have they not beaten the Horde? Are they really that disunited?*

Rolling her eyes, she sighed slightly irritably at herself. *Of course they are, they're selfish. They don't care about the bigger picture. I don't even need to* ***try*** *and sow discontent.*

Speaking of bigger pictures, Catra could practically *feel* Adora's gaze on her immediately, a presence gazing down on her and scrutinizing her every move. Still, she couldn't move onto the next phase of her plan until the formalities of the evening were done, and that meant greeting the Hostess of the Prom, Princess Frosta.

Still, even as they crossed the open room, Catra's eyes wandered, flirting about and trying to pin down the location of her watcher, whilst simultaneously drawing on her wealth of knowledge about the blonde. *Knowing Adora... She'll probably be high up, trying to get the drop on me.. Heh, predictable as always.*

True to her assumption, Catra found Adora staring at her from the second elevated platform, gazing over the railing down at her. Next to her stood a far shorter figure with purple hair, someone who was probably the Princess of Bright Moon, but who Catra knew more as 'Sparkles'. *Target sighted...*

Her next step, however faltered slightly as she focused in on Adora's face.

Or rather, what was wrong with it.

Three neat scores, or rather, scars under her right eye.

Her follow up step managed to correct the stutter in her otherwise regular stride, bringing her back into sync with Scorpia, but she knew for certain that her mistake had just been spotted by Adora. To compound that issue, she found her right hand rising to brush against her own right cheek where the ghostly ebb of the injury rang out in Catra's nervous system. *I scarred her...*

It should have meant nothing - it really should have. Catra didn't care about Adora, she was the enemy, she betrayed Catra and her family, all for a light show, dress up games and muscles the size of the pipes that dotted the walls of the Fright Zone. Adora was worthless - she was pointless and she would be crushed. *I don't need Adora. I never did.*

This was the mantra she repeated to herself as she bowed to Frosta, as she blew off Adora's floundering outrage with cool and level headed logic that would appeal to the Princess, and as she ditched Scorpia and dominated the attention of Sparkles and Adora.

She just couldn't help that small part of the stupid girl Catra, who kept yelling that it meant something.

She had to admit, messing with Adora had *never* been so fun.

She'd watched Adora bumping into pretty much half the people in attendance, making a complete fool of herself in front of Frosta, and everyone else in attendance too for that matter. Going rooting through the trash was not a *great* look for anyone, let alone someone ostensibly trying to forge alliances that evening.

Then there was the whole thing with that tinkerer Princess. Given by how Adora had looked like she was about to burst a blood vessel, and by the hushed conversation that she had tried to have with the purple haired weirdo (who was apparently named Entrapta) that Catra heard *every* word of, apparently Entrapta was a member of the rebellion, although a very pliable one.

Still - even without the stated mission completed, Sparkles seemed to have been entirely neutralised. Catra hadn't seen her for nearly 30 minutes after she first grabbed the duo's attention, but when she had finally reacquired her the Princess had been arguing with Arrow Boy and then running off in a crying fit, which could only mean that Scorpia was *completely* unmolested in her mission.

So then it was time to make the final move. The checkmate.

Again, Adora's situational awareness had not improved, which allowed Catra to slide right into the spot that Adora's dance partner would take, offering her left hand to the blonde and pulling her lips into a smug grin. Regardless, she could not help the nerves that chipped away at her composure, the butterflies in her stomach fluttering as her neurons fired. This was risky, and the move might not work properly. If the Rebellion caught even a whiff of what the actual plan of the night was, it would be over in a heart beat, and they would keep their prize assets close to their chest.

That in and of itself would still be useful, but Hordak would not be impressed in the slightest...

Still - Catra had to begrudgingly admit that the evening had been enjoyable, or at least it would have been if she knew anyone other than her conspirators planning a false flag attack and a kidnapping. Yet even without knowing anyone, much of her enjoyment had come from completely out foxing Adora at every turn, although even she had to admit the atmosphere was unique here. It was almost a shame to ruin it.

Almost.

Adora wheeled back around, nearly bumping into the feline, her face shifting from a worried expression to one of momentary relief, then hardening resolve and anger, but still she took Catra’s hand in a familiar gesture, the impact of which was not lost on either of them. This was a final chance to fix things, and yet

neither was going to bow out, ultimately meaning that this was going to be the end of the last of their friendship.

The first chord of the music rang out and Catra's feet began to move in the briefly practiced motions that she had engrained in her mind during the trip to the Kingdom of Snows. A simple series of movements whilst her mind and body was free to taunt and probe Adora for weaknesses. "I don't know about you, but I am having a *blast.*"

The importance of the pun was unfortunately (and yet expectedly) lost on the blonde, whose response was so stereotypical that Catra almost *groaned* at it. "Whatever you're planning Catra, it won't work. I wont let it-"

The response she had been working on died on her lips as they changed partners, Catra staring at the dark skinned woman in a two tone blue dress with the mid riff exposed. Recognition screamed in her ears, but Catra couldn't plant a memory to the face of the woman who was looking distinctly unimpressed with the whole evening, which Catra seemed to remember as just her resting expression.

Still, despite an unenthusiastic glare from the woman, which Catra responded to with a sly smirk before their partners shifted again, leaving Catra now standing opposite a man with *excessively* styled hair and a colour palette that matches the one that the Princess she had *just* been dancing with. Suddenly, the memory clicked. Salineas

"You're that guy who sets his boats on fire."

"Ah! You've heard about the legendary *Sea Hawk!*" The moment his eyes lit up at the end of Catra's half blurted statement, the sinking sense of dread burst forth, the feline groaning internally at her inability to control her mouth this evening. Still, from what she remembered, Water Princess didn't like this guy too much. A glint rose to her eyes and her smirk tugged a little wider.

"Oh Water Princess just *can't* stop talking about you." Catra used that final word to ditch boat guy and swapped back to Water Princess, unable to hide the smug look on her face as she stared into the dispassionate face of the Princess across from her. For her part, the Water Princess looked entirely unaware of what had happened, and Catra used the silence to plan what she would say to Adora.

"Oh you're like.. That Horde person. Yeah, whatever. We beat you." Catra ignored the almost ground out dialogue in favour of offering a cocked eyebrow and a widening smirk, before shifting back to Adora for the final part of the dance. Flopping back into Adora's arms, Catra rolled her head back to look over her shoulder, ignoring the unsettled sensation she felt in her stomach as her plan came to a climax.

"Maybe my plan won't work.. But then again..." Catra registered the expression on Adora's face, the smirk shifting into a sadistic grin as she locked eyes with the blonde. Catra could tell that Adora had begun to piece things together since the start of their dance, and that had left her increasingly unbalanced.

With a sharp motion she pushed Adora back, throwing her off balance, then pulled her sharply towards herself, dipping the blonde in her arms, clearly using more force than was strictly necessary for the action. Still, the action worked, pulling the blonde into her arms, clutching her waist and holding her close against herself in such a way that Catra could *feel* Adora's body heat. Her feet moved of their own accord, keeping the both of them carefully balanced like that for a second or two longer than was strictly needed. *Not just yet... A little longer..*

"Maybe it already has..." The end of her barb came almost as an afterthought, pulling Adora out of the dip and swinging her away, joined only by their out stretched arms, Catra's right hand clutching Adora's left wrist as the blonde stared back at her in mounting dread. *Now..*

"Say.. Where's your friend? ***Bow.***" Adora's pupils shrank almost comically quickly, her lips parting as she stared at Catra in pure horror, implications sinking in within a heartbeat. The horror transitioned in a second heartbeat, rage and fury boiling in Adora's eyes. Catra had been expecting this, and had braced herself for Adora to do something violent.

What she *hadn't* expected was for Adora to lash out so quickly *or* so forcefully.

Sure, if she was at the peak of her game, she could have easily avoided the punch that Adora sent for her face, but she needed to sell the whole innocence thing. The animalistic growl that Adora made before swinging told Catra that she had lost her self control to her emotions, something that would be useful and easy to exploit. So bracing herself as much as she could, she let Adora hit

her, or at least she did right up until the punch was going to land, when she realised just *how much* force was behind it.

Fuck....

She was fairly sure that the impact hadn't given her brain damage, but she could have *sworn* Adora had started to glow with a technicolour light the moment before the impact landed. It certainly felt a lot more forceful than what Catra had ever received in sparring practice, and the impact sent Catra sprawling to the ground a metre or so back from where she had been standing.

Her cheek *stung* violently under her left eye, the feline raising a hand there and gently brushing at the raw skin, wincing slightly as she came into contact with the lower layers of skin that had been exposed by Adora's fist tearing away the top few. Pulling herself up to her feet, she momentarily stumbled, eyes widening in alarm as dark spots danced about in her vision. She had *never* been this unbalanced before, and the unfamiliarity of the situation sent a jab of panic through her system, her chest tightening as she struggled to stay upright.

Of course, Adora didn't give her the chance to recover, gripping her collar with the force to raise the feline off the ground, up to face height with Adora. The blonde then shoved her back, sending her back through an ice sculpture, still held in Adora's rough and angry grasp. "What did you do to him!"

Pain flared through her nervous system, pricking behind her eyes and threatening to spill out salty tears. That she couldn't

understand - she had taken far worse pain from Shadow Weaver before, and there had been no tears that fell then, just screams at the worst. Silence and screams. *Why does... This make me want to cry.*

Her head still screamed at her, her vision still danced with dark specks that wouldn't go away no matter how much she blinked or closed her eyes. The lights had become irritatingly bright to her eyes and her attention kept drifting away from Adora, but she forced herself back onto the blonde's face. "Nothing... Permeant."

The anger in Adora's eyes welled larger, but Catra found herself dropped suddenly when a wall of ice rose between them, Adora's grasp letting go of the collar of her blazer and dropping the feline to the ground roughly, as their hostess descended onto the field and began to chastise and shame Adora. Taking her cue to leave, Catra rose half way to her feet, but found the floor under her shift, alarm spiking as she glanced up, staring at where the bombs would be. *Those idiots blew them early-*

But there were no screams - no cries... No explosions.

Then she realised the floor hadn't shifted, her balance was just off. Trying to stand again, she found herself on her feet this time, just a little bit unsure of her footing. The diagnosis was fairly simple in hind sight, one that Catra should have considered in all seriousness. *I've got a concussion... Adora.. Concussed me with a single hit..*

Rubbing her cheek again, Catra stared once more at the Princess trapped pitifully in an ice cage, then turned and made distance as casually as she could, picking her way carefully through the gathering crowd in order to compensate for her reduced mobility and dexterity.

I need to be out of here before the bombs go off..

The tears behind her eyes stung just as much as the raw skin on her cheek.

Catra IV

Chapter Notes

> A/N: Final Catra Chapter for a bit - shifting back to cover the first major cannon divergence from Adora's perspective after one interlude chapter from Lonnie.

The scraping of the sword against the metal of the wall was sending increasingly unpleasant shivers down Catra's spine, those which she forcibly suppressed in order to maintain her presence. Part of her could not believe what she was doing, an act similar to what Adora had done, committing treason against the Horde. Catra was better though. She was doing this in the best interests of the Horde.

That bitch wants to take credit for my success? She can take credit for my failings then, too.

Adora and Sparkles were trapped in front of her, behind a locked door and next to a drop into a yawning abyss, one that the two girls could not possibly hope to survive uninjured, and they knew it. More importantly, Sparkles couldn't seem to teleport, if their continued presence in the corridor was anything to go off.

Her jaw tightened into a sneer as Adora, still weak from when Shadow Weaver had tortured her, stepped in front of Sparkles protectively, raising her fists into a weak stance that Catra could probably land two hits through before-

No. Calm down. Scaring her won't work.

She's still so fucking selfless. Always playing hero.. Yet she is the lesser of two evils.

The sneer faded in the blink of an eye, Catra coming to a stop just out of the sword's reach of Adora, swinging it forwards to point the tip of the blade at the two girls, the uncomfortable weight hanging there for a few seconds whilst both sides stared each other down. *This is going to work. It needs to, Shadow Weaver cannot stay where she is. I need to succeed her. Hordak just needs some prompting.*

Carefully, she rotated the sword in her hand, shifting it so that the hilt was extended towards Adora and Sparkles, watching their eyes narrow in suspicion. More prompting then. Adora is still so dense..

"Take it."

Eyes shifted from narrowing to widening in amazement and surprise, Adora's lips parting in shock as she stared at the extended handle of the sword, then at Catra's face, stunned into silence at the scene playing out before her. Silence reigned, intercut only by the pulsing red lights and the soft whine of the alarms far off in the distance.

"What.." The word that slipped through Adora's lips was overloaded with amazement and surprise, it sounded almost reverently uttered as the blonde stared at Catra with an

unreadable expression, so drowned in emotions was it. But then Adora uttered something that caught the feline flat footed. "Catra.."

Just her name.

That one word. The word that should have sent her anger flaring, her hatred of Adora should have returned, but that tone. That fragile, gentle and tender tone, and that word...

Catra wanted to hear more of it. Hear it again.

No... I won't allow myself to be second fiddle again.

Her gaze shifted, off Adora's face and onto the scars on her cheek. Adora and Catra could never really be friends again, not after what they had done to each other. The raw skin on her cheek, covered by a grey medical patch to prevent infection, throbbed slightly as her mind replayed the phantom impact. Her gaze then shifted further, looking aside and away from Adora to help the delivery of her next words.

"This is not because I like you." *This is because I need to destroy Shadow Weaver.*

She couldn't help but feel like she was trying to convince herself.

Adora swallowed gingerly, taking a step forwards and reaching out towards the sword's hilt, pausing only momentarily to look back at Sparkles, who was holding Adora's arm, sending a silent message. Anger momentarily bubbled, but Catra pushed it down as Adora pulled her arm free of Sparkles' grasp, taking another step and grasping the sword's hilt, their fingers meeting for a second in a tender contact. A painful stab of memories shot through her system - of better times when there wasn't so much murky water between them. A time where life was better for them.

A time where I was nothing but Adora's side kick.

The anger didn't flare this time, smothered by other emotions.
Thats not right.

The contact between their hands had lasted for only a second, but Catra pulled her hand away like it had been burned, letting it fall to her side and allowing Adora to step back and take the full weight of the sword that she had been holding. She watched as Adora stared down at the blade, as if questioning what it was or what it represented, then looking up at Catra. The feline was acutely aware that she had no clue what expression she was wearing, but whatever it was, it seemingly inspired something in Adora.

"Catra I-"

"Just... Get out of here Adora." She was unable to suppress the unenthusiastic tone in her voice, her gaze drifting to the side once more, not bothering to take in Adora's reaction. *She'll become She-Ra and I'll not see her until we're on the battlefield next time, and this will be all over.*

Turning away, Catra began to leave the duo, to provide herself an alibi for what she was doing whilst Adora and Sparkles escaped. Thankfully, Shadow Weavers whole spiel about getting Adora back to take her place would be a wonderful excuse to Hordak as to why the feline had both not failed her duty, and why Shadow Weaver had.

Unfortunately, Adora had another idea.

A sudden warmth engulfed Catra's left hand, a familiar warmth. One she had felt only a few days before on the other side of the world. *Adora.*

Turning her gaze back, anger welling in her gut stomach as she turned to spit out some poisonous bard. Was she *stupid*? Did she think Catra would be so lenient? Did Adora really think that Catra would just suddenly turn like that? Did she think Catra would be fine to going back to playing second fiddle to the blonde?

The anger, the pooling hate and vile thoughts, all of it died in an instant as she looked at Adora, eyes shimmering with tears and.. Something more. Hope.

The barb died in her throat as Adora spoke, the sword hanging limply at the blonde's side as her other hand clutched Catra's own hand tenderly. "Please... Catra... Come with me.."

The shiver that the feline had been suppressing this entire time ran down her spine in full force, bringing goosebumps to blazing life all down her legs. The last time Adora had said that, Catra had betrayed her so completely by attacking her exposed back. The memory brought her so much shame, a mark against what she could have done there. Her ears flattened against her head at the thought.

But this time.. Adora was willing to give her another chance. *Why? Why do I deserve it? What have I done? Does she think I'm just going to roll over, let things go back to how they were?*

Swallowing the lump in her throat, Catra carefully worked her hand free of Adora's grasp, trying to ignore the sinking feeling in her chest at the recognition of what it meant, sacrificing this chance. It wasn't made any easier by the hope on Adora's face draining away either, but the feline managed a reply, sans any of the usual tone. "Just... Go."

It was a pathetic response, but she didn't have it in her to reply any differently.

The glowing light filled the hallway as the girl became the princess, and when it cleared, the feline was gone.

The evening of the raid on the Fright Zone found the feline sitting in the shower of the locker room adjacent to her Force Captains quarters. One of the small luxuries that Force Captains got over regular officers was that their locker room was shared between only two Force Captains, and that the showers ran pretty much forever (although she had been informed via word of mouth that maintenance could and would cut any and all cold water if they noticed showers going on for too long, apparently the burns were horrific).

Yet the worst thing Catra could think of was not receiving telling first degree burns as a result of the ire of a maintenance worker, but instead rested solely inside her mind. Thankfully, the Force Captain she had ended up sharing a locker room with was Scorpia (although that might have been a downside if the ashen haired giant ever got on her nerves), which meant that Catra basically had the sway to keep the other woman out whilst the feline moped about, waiting for the torment that she knew would come.

"You know - You're really not *that* bad of a person, Catra." The familiar voice brought a lump to her throat, one that the feline shoved down as she rather lazily turned her head right, staring at the source of the voice. Despite sitting under the same shower head that Catra was, Adora was both dressed in her normal attire, the one Catra knew as synonymous with the blonde, and was completely bone dry.

"Yeah. And Shadow Weaver has a *heart*." Catra's dry, deadpan tone left little to the imagination as she sat under the warm spray of the shower. Normally, she disliked the process of bathing,

preferring to just wash herself and get out, but as of late, the irritating part of her mind had decided that now was a great time to force Catra to face her decisions.

Adora tilted her head, staring at Catra. "And yet you still seek her approval."

The uncomfortable truth shot through Catra like a bolt from a stun gun, the feline struggling to find the words to rebuke the claim that had just been made. For her part, Adora tilted her head, staring at Catra. "You can't lie to your conscience, Catra."

The feline glared at her conscience, trying to will it out of existence, or at the very least to will it out of existence for this evening - even to take it to a different topic, but ultimately she knew what was coming, and having it interrupt her sleep was most certainly a less favourable option. "You did the right thing, giving the sword back."

The topic brought forth the stab of anger that Catra had not been able to muster earlier, glaring at the faux Adora sitting next to her, now running her hands down the non-existent sword in her non-existent hands. "Oh why - because I *let* them go? I needed to - Shadow Weaver is *useless*. *I'M* the only one who knows how to properly command!"

"You could have taken my offer." Catra scowled at the words.

"You're not her. Don't refer to her in the first."

Sighing, the faux Adora pushed herself upright with the dexterity that only Catra possessed, resulting in the weird visual of Adora doing some very Catra looking movements as the blonde rather lackadaisically waltzed around the small space separated for the two showers in the room adjacent to the locker room. Settling into a position directly mirroring Catra's own, her conscience observed her from across the space. "My question still stands. Why did you refuse her offer?"

"Because she betrayed me. I'm not going back to playing second fiddle." Faux Adora's eyes narrowed and Catra blinked, Adora shifting from sitting on the floor of the shower to standing, dressed in the armour of a Horde Soldier and staring down at Catra. The feline blinked again, and Adora now stood closer, dressed in the white long sleeve shirt that she always wore.

Another blink brought Adora standing over Catra, dressed in only a sports bra and shorts - the same clothes that Catra had waiting for her outside the shower, the ones she had taken to wearing most days. Thankfully for Catra's blood pressure, nothing else changed as Adora stood over her, slowly tilting her head to the left as if seeing something exceedingly interesting that Catra had totally missed.

"Is that what you think? Or is that what *she* wants you to think?" There was no clarification as to who 'She' was, but Catra already knew who was being referenced. Opening her mouth to spit a barb, Catra blinked just once, and her conscience was gone, leaving Catra alone in the shower, feeling just a little insane and rather irritated.

I think for myself.

..Don't I?

Of all the things to be doing after being promoted to equal standing with the woman who had abused her for the entire life that she could remember, going off to some frigid fucking wasteland in the company of a Princess who was ostensibly her prisoner turned colleague in search of ancient artefacts was not it. And yet, here they were, in a temporary base set up so that Entrapta could go digging for ancient artefacts.

Honestly, Catra had no clue, and had been absolutely bored out of her skull for the entire time that they had been stationed up in the far northern reaches of Etheria. The feline had initially tried reflecting on the chaotic eight or so months since she was promoted to Force Captain, an incident that marked the most significant turning point in her life. But then she had started asking herself if the path she had chosen was for the better or for the worse...

She had decided promptly to do *literally* anything else.

Scorpia had jumped in then with the offer to play some sort of juvenile game, and Catra had seriously considered going back to

her self reflection, but then Entrapta had made some comment about needing to find things, and so Catra had jumped on that offer. The magnitude of her mistake had only just sunk in once she had seen the absolute mountain of storage boxes that the purple haired weirdo had managed to bring with them.

Naturally, Catra had spent all of three hours looking for it, including moving between no less than 4 separate buildings out in the blizzard that was steadily whipping up outside, before Entrapta found it in two minutes of searching flat (and in the building Catra had started searching in no less). The feline had nearly torn the Princesses hair from her skull, but had settled for just going for a nap instead. Now well rested and feeling substantially less prone to murder or grievous bodily harm (whichever it could be described as), Catra strode into the main building and watched as Entrapta busied herself spinning on a chair wildly.

"Uhm, what are you doing?"

"Oh, Hi Catra! Did you have a good nap?"

One of Catra's eyebrow did a nosedive as yet another shiver rocked her body, the feline hugging herself and rubbing her arms to induce friction in the hope that it gave her more warmth. Yes, she did have a good nap, and yes, she would rather go back to the warmth under the blankets that she had thought to bring. The main room was positively frigid compared to the accommodation that Catra had been staying in.

The irritation brought on by her discomfort made her short tempered, she was acutely aware, but even regardless, their stay up here in the north was far longer than it needed to be. This was supposed to be a short mission, not a long one. Groaning, she leant forwards against a table, sighing. "Why is this taking so long."

For her part, Entrapta's indifference rubbed Catra in the wrong way. "Its buried really deep in the ice, and yet it still gave off a really strong signal. I could pick it up from the Fright Zone! Judging by how strong it is, I think its part of the First Ones supercomputer."

A computer... Greaaaat.. Here I was thinking we could find something useful.

"Riiiight... Anyway, hurry up. Hordak isn't going to be happy if we just waste time up here-" Noticing Entrapta about to interject, Catra cut her off, remembering the five minute long rant that she had got from Entrapta about wasting time. "-And I'm *not* freezing my tail off for 'Data.' Find whatever this is, or I'm calling it quits and we're going back somewhere that isn't below freezing on the hottest day of the year."

Going to leave, something caught Catra's eyes, a sparkling three pronged red crystal in an open tub. Something about it seemed... Odd. Off, even. Like it wasn't right, a gut reaction that told Catra that what she had just found was incredibly dangerous and incredibly wrong, like its intended purpose had been warped by something.

"Hey - what's this thing." Plucking the offending item up, Catra tapped it with her nail out of curiosity, but regardless, Entrapta went ballistic, struggling to take it back from Catra as the feline held her at bay. Pressing her hand to Entrapta's face, Catra really lamented the fact that she could not use her claws to scare Entrapta off, straining against both the weight of the Princess and to continue holding the disc away from Entrapta's prehensile hair.

"Ah! Careful with that! Its a First Ones data disc. I haven't had a chance to study it yet." A noise from the computer pulled the purple haired weirdo's attention, prompting her to shift away from Catra and to look back at the screen as some big red alert commanded their attention briefly. Almost offhandedly, Entrapta finished speaking whilst she worked. "Last time I deployed it, it infected all my robots and She-Ra. They got *really* murdery, but it stopped when Glimmer destroyed it. I think its some sort of corrupted virus that infects technology."

As Entrapta worked, Catra stared at the object in her hand, pondering the words that Entrapta had spoken to her. A virus that infected technology, and one that made all of Entrapta's loyal servant robots and She-Ra murdery maniacs. And Sparkles had *destroyed* it, and Entrapta had *deliberately* rebuilt it.

And now Entrapta wants to study the thing. Which means interfacing it with *Horde Tech..*

"Ah! Ok, we may have hit a small bump." Entrapta's slightly concerned tone pulled Catra from her thoughts as she examined the screen which was still flagging alerts. Moving over whilst still gingerly holding the data disc that suddenly seemed a lot heavier

than it had a minute ago, Catra stared at the screen, blinking. She blinked again.

I don't understand this...

"Entrapta - how did you get Horde systems to run this language-"

"Our drilling bots are offline. Like.. All of them. At once. And there's no responses..." Totally ignoring Catra's indignant questioning, the Princess shoved herself away from the desk, spinning wildly on her chair for a bit before launching herself off it and onto the floor, hands raised in a pose that seemed triumphant. "But, I'm sure its nothing! Lets go investigate!"

The Princess raced off out of the room, disappearing down a corridor and towards the exit of the main structure, her departure marked by the tell-tale mechanical noise of the doors sliding open and closed. Even from inside a whole other building, Catra could still hear Entrapta yelling Scorpia's name. *I swear she will never calm down..*

Moving to follow, a heavy weight in her palm brought her back to the topic that they had been discussing before, prompting Catra to stare down at the disc in her hands. It was a simple device, one that looked innocent if not for the red colouration that almost screamed corruption, that Entrapta had said turned She-Ra into a murdering machine, and also turned technology against them.

In all honesty, Catra preferred She-Ra when she wasn't trying to kill the feline. She liked Adora when she was normal. This disc took that away, it made her behaviours and her patterns an unknown factor, something new to comprehend and something new to fight and deal with. She would be dealing with a whole new Adora and a murderous maniac She-Ra.

Plus it was also a virus that infected seemingly *every* computer system on the planet and turned those connected to it into a murderous hive mind. On its own, if it got out, it could be a complete disaster. But when one considered the amount of bots that the Horde used, that could mean the end of *all* life on Etheria. It would mean the end of the world as she knew it, and she had known it, and as she could come to know it.

All of her work would be for *nothing*.

All of her struggle would be for *nothing*.

She would be *nothing*.

I think for myself.

Clutching the disc in her palm, Catra raised her claws on her free hand and set them against the disc, pressing down hard on the weak points and succeeding in shattering the red crystalline disc into fragments in her palm. Hurriedly stuffing it into her pockets,

Catra followed Entrapta outside, sure for the first time in a while that she had most certainly made the right choice.

The figure laying sprawled on the soft grass of the village used to be a man.

He had probably had a family, and he had left his family to fight against the Horde as a rebel soldier. He had a life and his life had run out when he had entered the battle field to try and stop the conquest of this insignificant village. Catra wondered what sort of official notice of death the Rebellion had.

The Horde didn't need one. If you died in combat, everyone knew. You fell side by side with your brother and sisters in arms.

The blow she had delivered had done far too much damage to be survivable as a whole being. The way he had awkwardly crumpled told Catra that her blow to his back had probably snapped his spine like a twig, and her claws had probably dealt a fatal blow. Still, at least he had been blacked out by the impact.

She hadn't taken any pleasure in the action of ending his suffering there and then, but her claws had once again tasted blood, far more than they had when she had unintentionally scarred Adora's cheek. But then again, she had not felt any disgust at the action, just a distinct...

Emptiness.

Part of her wondered if Adora had ever taken a life before, ever had to put someone out of their misery. To kill instead of being killed.

She probably hadn't. She was too good for that.

She looked back down at the husk of what used to be a man.

He was *nothing*.

He had meant *nothing*, and he had amounted to *nothing*.

The most significant thing in his life was his death.

Catra had claimed her first kill.

It would not be her last.

Her claws would do worse, that she knew.

I'll survive.

Lonnie II

Lonnie... Still didn't like Catra.

The feline had worsened their already strained relationship with that stunt around the time that Adora betrayed the Horde, and Lonnie still hadn't fully recovered the trust she once had in Catra (or what little she had at least). At the very least, Lonnie had to admit that the betrayal of the blonde had come as a surprise to all of them, and Lonnie hadn't known *who* she could trust outside of Kyle and Rogelio. Catra having been so close to the blonde didn't help either.

However, Catra's sudden ascension in the wake of Adora's defection meant that Lonnie had found what *should* have been the perfect opportunity to take command of the group, spoiled by Catra's very tangible superiority over her, something that the feline had immediately taken to lording over the dark skinned girl's head. It had not been a very nice experience for Lonnie, and the feline had made it known that they were to respect her rank, regardless of what they had used to be.

The feline was burning her bridges, and Lonnie knew that if she wanted *any* of the work she had done to one day get herself in any sort of command position to be worth it, she would have to turn her bridge from wood to stone *real* quick.

For all of her failings, Lonnie had to admit (*very* begrudgingly) that Catra was a vastly superior commander to Shadow Weaver, and the progress the Horde had been making in the past few weeks was all one had to look at to validate the claims. The years of stagnation and bungled advances under Shadow Weaver had been replaced by the rapid expansion of Horde territory along the coast lines and through the valleys and forests to the north and west. Whilst their territory could be defined as thin lines along the coasts to the East, the Whispering Woods sat in the way of more stable lines.

Still, Lonnie could see the strategy behind the move. If the Rebellion was content to just sit behind the Whispering Woods, then the Horde would simply encircle the Whispering Woods.

Lonnie didn't know the full story behind the move, that is to say, the restructuring of the command chain that placed Catra in near total control of all strategic operations, whilst Shadow Weaver was delegate to the more logistical and training posts, but Lonnie could tell that the move probably had something to do with the recent raid on the Fright Zone by the Rebellion. It had probably shown Hordak that Shadow Weaver was an incapable commander, and the move had cost the Horde not only the key to ending the Rebellion, but also the Rebellion's key asset - Adora.

Lonnie still refused to call Adora whatever that stupid Princess name she had.

Regardless, all they had to show for it was some wacko with purple hair who was apparently some genius tinkerer Princess that Lonnie had never even heard of.

Still, she had to be of some use, given that she was sticking around and the Horde had some new gadgets to play with. It meant less casualties on the front lines, and Lonnie was quite happy with that.

Shadow Weaver, however, looked positively apoplectic regarding the whole affair. Lonnie was aware that the woman still held authority over punishment in the ranks, and those had been stepped up, yet it was more manual labour as opposed to torture until someone's voice gave out, and she knew that the sudden change had most certainly been the result of Catra's meddling.

As for the final member of the Triumvirate running the Horde, Lord Hordak was.. Well, actually seen outside his sanctum for the first time in years. He had been inspecting troops, production facilities and just about everything that Lonnie had expected a leader to do, and he had even apparently begun to hold strategy council with Catra every few days.

Speaking of the feline, Catra had changed up her look a little. Gone were the lighter tones of the reddish orange leotard, replaced instead by a darker one, with dark coverings over one arm and her legs. The feline had also seemingly made an attempt to control her hair, with a bit of length reduced in favour of a more controlled style. The shift made her look more formal, more in command.

But what had changed most was the Horde itself. Catra had done a purge of the ranks of officers, and had pulled in a bunch of officer cadets that had previously been sidelined. The whole system of squads had been reworked, meaning that soldiers fought with the same squad like before, but the squads were now formed out of the groups that they had trained with. It hadn't seemed like much, but the results had spoken for themselves, with vast swathes of territory under Horde control now.

Unfortunately... That is why we're stuck out here in.. Whatever the hell this shit is.

From her seat behind the controls of the transport truck racing along the edges of the Whispering Woods, Lonnie stared at the glowing orange balls lazily floating down towards the ground. Whatever the hell the stuff was, it seemed to be seeping through the ground, making small little craters where they touched down. More concerningly, the stuff was sticking all over the front of the transport they were driving.

Naturally, the stressful task of avoiding encroaching on the Whispering Woods, whilst also keeping clear of the those spore things, was made no easier by the utter cacophony going on behind the drivers cab. *Swear to god Kyle..*

"Kyle, what the *hell* are you doing back there." Lonnie didn't bother looking back, wincing as another loud crash rang through the truck as she swerved around a tree that was leaning precariously out over the path that they were driving along.

"Woah-" Kyle's cry of alarm was cut off by another crash, and Lonnie groaned, looking up at the road ahead just in time to swerve violently around a falling tree, the trunk almost half eaten away by those spore clouds. Next to her, Rogelio made some alarmed noise that sounded almost like a hiss, but the raven haired girl with dreadlocks had little issue pulling the truck around the tree.

Unfortunately, that put them firmly *inside* the Whispering Woods, with no way back out.

And then the engine died.

Lonnie stared at the dashboard of the truck, the mounting dread of the scenario eliciting a loud groan as the machine dutifully reported that all systems were functioning as intended, bar the engine. "I swear, Catra better have a good fucking reason for needing this armour plate."

Picking up her helmet from the seat of the truck, Lonnie gazed out the drivers side door at the spores getting denser by the minute outside. They were starting to melt through the armour of the truck, and Lonnie didn't wager there would be much protection offered by their Horde armour. That was another issue - the fact that they were in the Horde going near the Whispering Woods. No one would be coming for them, they had to do this themselves.

Still.. Better sooner than later.

"C'mon you two.. Lets fix this quickly, before Catra kills us for staying alive.."

Adora VI

"You are not taking your training seriously."

The emotionless voice nearly brought a groan out of Adora as she quite casually cleaved her way through the swarms of robots surrounding her. The originally stressful training that she had undergone at the hands of Light Hope had devolved quite quickly into a regular monotony of trashing a bunch of holographic robots whilst the Ai simply watched on and made the occasional comment after the whole exercise was concluded.

However, the monotony had been made worse by the fact that Light Hope seemingly utilised similar, if not identical battle patterns and parameters every time, which meant that Adora quite literally felt like she was running the same obstacle course every time. Even Hope's attempt at replicating Catra hadn't done the trick, and Adora had been quite easily able to counter the feline, something that she reckoned was more detrimental than useful.

Even Hope's programming regarding the sword was fairly exploitable, given that it almost *always* seemed to return to Adora's grasp when she had need of it, something that she had fallen into the bad habit of regularly abusing after the simulations ended. Speaking of such, the simulation faded away, revealing the main room of the Crystal Castle, the Sword of Protection quite lazily falling into her outstretched grasp, where upon she slid it onto the sheathe on her back.

A flash of light brought her from the Warrior Princess to Adora, staring up at the tall hologram standing in front of her. "Hope - I'm not learning anything new. We've done this for *weeks* . If anything.. I'm getting *too* used to this."

"I sense.. Resistance.."

"Because this is *useless* . I don't need *more* training, I need *answers* ." Frustration burst through her demeanour, Adora turning away from the holographic administrator, venting her frustration in deep breaths as she tried to calm herself down, to save herself from revealing information that Hope might be able to use.

Adora's original opinion of Etheria's Facilitator had switched from the initial blind trust and faith that she knew better than Adora, to the current distrust that Adora had firmly cemented in her mind. As much as she had initially distrusted her internal companion, the Warrior Princess had been *totally* correct in the judgement that Adora should not trust the ai.

Hope had been hiding things from Adora. She had been hiding parts of Mara's past, she had been hiding *all* of Adora's past, she had been evasive when asked question and she *STILL* refused to say what she meant by 'Bring balance to Etheria.'

Like come on! How do not explain more. "Hey you know how there's a race of super mysterious aliens who are all extinct? You're one of them! No questions!"

"When you balance the planet, all will be clear.. It is your duty as She- She- She- She-"

Hope froze, glitching violently between the last two movements she made, and Adora groaned as she rested a hand on her hip, shifting her weight to it in a sassy motion. "Oh, *wOw.* What a way to avoid the question.."

Hope flickered back to normal, looking slightly concerned. "This is strange - my logs detect a spore storm in the Whispering Woods, but such an event would have been forecast.."

Adora stared at Hope, mouth slightly agape. *She can forecast the* ***weather*** . *How?! Is it something to do with being the Facilitator of Etheria? If she isn't telling me stuff like this...*

For her part, Hope turned back to Adora, then resumed violently glitching on the spot before fading completely out of existence in the blink of an eye. A noise like an engine running out of energy filled the air as light drained from the entire structure, leaving Adora trapped in the dim room, the oppressive darkness broken only by the soft light given off by the Sword of Protection glowing softly.

The constrictive darkness pulled the muscles in her chest taunt as Adora held the Sword in her grp tightly, looking around herself nervously and slowly backing herself up into a corner, somewhere

that her back could meet a solid wall. *What the hell is going on... Where did Light Hope go..*

"Light Hope?"

She-Ra pulsed inside, stronger than Adora had ever felt her pulse before, as if she had been saving up energy for this very moment. It would certainly explain why the Princess's guidance had been so minimal of late, although Adora had thought it was probably down to her making the right choices...

Have I been making the wrong choices?

Mara's voice broke through her head. In contrast to the only other time she had heard the Princess offer full words in her mind whilst she was conscious, this voice sounded rushed, almost panicked or nervous. But this time something else came through, more than just words *. Emotions. ' Adora.. You have to be ready.. I'm sorry I can't explain... Please Adora. For me. For everyone... At the end.. Disobey Hope!'*

Stunned silence reigned in Adora's mind as the lights slowly came back on, the blonde limply holding the sword at her side and blinking slowly, breaths coming in a steady rhythm, albeit drawn shakily. That emotional wave that had slammed into her, the blazing sensations of loss, sorrow, anger, love.. But most of all *hope* ...

It hit her like nothing had before.

It was clear then, the path ahead - for the first time in a long while. This was a choice ahead of her, a cross road. To one side, Light Hope, deceit and yet, blissful ignorance.

On the other - Mara, opportunity and a hard truth.

How the fuck am I meant to deal with this..

The soft noise of a Hologram winking to life pulled Adora out of her self reflection, bringing her eyes up sharply to look at the hologram before her. Smiling slightly, and with wider than normal eyes, it was still definitely Light Hope, albeit looking far more welcoming and friendly than the usual, severe looking hologram that was almost completely emotionless.

"Hello! I a-am Light Hope." The hologram tilted its head, still wearing that very out of place smile. Glitching far more now than Adora had ever seen her, Light Hope continued as if nothing had ever gone wrong. "How-How may I as-assist you?"

Cautiously, Adora took a few steps towards the hologram, a sceptical expression spreading across her face. "Uh.. What's going on Hope..?"

The hologram flickered, blinking a few times, before answering. "My systems are rebooting after experiencing an unexpected and unscheduled shutdown. I would like to answer your query, but the answer to 'what is going on' has not yet loaded..."

The hologram seemed to actually focus its gaze on Adora now, cocking its head slightly further before asking its own question. "Who are you?"

Adora took a sharp breath as she stared at the hologram. *Hope's systems are rebooting.. She doesn't know who I am..*

"What do you mean, 'Who are you'? I'm Adora..."

The hologram blinked, and Adora got the distinct impression that her words had gone in one ear and out the other, metaphorically speaking of course. Light Hope didn't have ears... *I think.. I don't uh.. Think I've ever looked..*

"The Light Hope operating system is attempting to reboot. My functionality is at 22%." Floating screens appeared in front of the hologram, flickering violently and full of text streams, so many words that Adora strained herself trying to read each of them, catching only snippets of phrases, a word here and there, maybe a phrase if she was lucky.

Etheria... Heart.... Light Hope... Eternia… She-Ra...

The screens flickered away, an indignant noise dying in Adora's throat as she realised that the holographic facilitator was no longer standing where she had been a moment ago. Taking a frustrated breath, Adora turned her head left and nearly had a heart attack.

Standing no less than a foot away from her face was Light Hope's face.

Except it just so happened to be *horizontal* , as the hologram was standing on the wall behind Adora. Cheerfully, the hologram passed on her information. "I have just recovered the ability to move around the Castle."

Ignoring the unnerving hologram, Adora looked around the chamber a bit lost for both words and mentally. *What the hell even is this..*

"Who are you?" Turning back to the hologram, Adora tilted her own head, something that the hologram matched after a few seconds. A bit taken aback, the blonde straightened her head, something that the hologram mimicked again.

"Uh.. I'm Adora...? I already told you." The hologram paused at this, looking off into space before bringing up another violently glitching screen that Adora only got the inverse of.

"It would appear that I have yet to recover my short term memory function." Light Hope smiled again, something that Adora averted her gaze from, in favour of looking around the room, searching for any sort of change. Alas, nothing else had changed, simply a normal room. "What is your purpose for being in the Crystal Castle, Adora?"

"Uhm.. I'm She-Ra..? You *were* training me before you went all.. Reboot-y." Waving her hand in a lame gesture, Adora turned her attention back to Light Hope, who was now standing upside down on one of the pillars above Adora's head. Craning her neck, Adora looked up at Light Hope and tried not to wince at the angle her neck was making.

"My primary goal is to assist She-Ra. How may I help you?" The hologram seemed elated, genuinely happy and smiling *still* , Adora trying to ignore how pleased the ai looked to help. It made the knowledge that Mara wanted to do.. Something to her all the worse. But still, this was not what Light Hope was usually like.

"Uh... *Well..* Before you rebooted, you were going to tell me.. Like.. Everything I wanted to know. Where I come from.."

Light Hope clapped her hands together silently, a smile spreading across her face. "I will gladly tell you this information." A sudden rush of hope shot through her as she turned her attention back towards the hologram, whose smile did not waver as she continued. "But this information has not yet loaded."

Her hopes came crashing down like a lead balloon, the blonde deflating with a dejected sigh as she turned her attention off into space, retreating inwards into the peace of her own mind. She knew it was a bit of a forlorn hope to expect Hope to just tell her these things when she was rebooting, but the AI had *gotten her hopes up* so high, then brought them down.

"Intriguing. I have just learned to make spiders." The words almost made it past Adora, but her eyes opened on the last word, blue orbs wide with alarm as she stared up at the holographic woman standing next to a horde of giant, mechanical spiders, crimson eyes all locked on Adora.

The blonde swallowed the lump in her throat as she stared at the swarm in front of her. "U-Uh Hope... Get rid of them please..."

The ai had the nerve to look innocent. "I am so sorry - but that information has not yet loaded."

Half expecting the response at that point, Adora raised the sword in her hand, staring at the approaching robotic bugs as she once again uttered the phrase that was probably her most frequently uttered phrase for the past year or so. "For the Honour of Greyskull!"

Unfortunately for her - it appeared that robots aren't affected by the normal stunning effect that the transformation into She-Ra brought with it.

The clattering mass of limbs and metal surged forwards in a wave, Adora barely managing to shriek and bring the Sword around in an arc before the first spider closed to within striking range. Like most things, the sword carved through the metal of the robots, those bots struck crumpling into sparking piles.

Yet whilst on their own not much of a threat, the sheer number was a quality of its own, forcing Adora out of her position and towards the centre of the room, constantly backpedalling in order to prevent them encircling her. Like many of Hope's previous combat trials, the bots had a sort of hive mind connection, that much was evident by how two or three came at her at once, but these attack algorithms were different.

It appeared that Hope had unintentionally *improved* the difficulty of her training by forgetting her programming.

Great timing..

"Hoope... Have you learned how to un-make spiders...?" It was wistful thinking as Adora planted the sword into a spider's head, then swung the corpse of the beast sideways, into another one while drawing the sword clear, only to spin around and parry a strike from an oversized foreleg. "Sooner rather than later please..."

The hologram appeared nearby, seemingly curious regarding the whole affair, and completely unbothered by the spider walking through her still quite glitchy body. "I regret to inform you that

the information has still not loaded. My reboot appears to have encountered an unexpected system blockage at 36%."

"Great! How do we fix it." Adora lurched back violently to avoid an attempt to swallow her whole, swinging the sword down onto the spider's head as another one blindsided her, bashing her away and into a wall. The impact caused her She-Ra form to flicker momentarily, shifting her back to Adora, before the familiar feedback loop from the sword shoved her back into the form of the Warrior Princess.

Stumbling to her feet, Adora hurled the sword at the approaching spider, dashing after it and retrieving it from the crumpled machine's head as she turned to face the next attacker, only to be met with Light Hope standing in the middle of the antechamber, looking intrigued. Panting softly and scanning the room for threats, Adora was more than a little relieved to see nothing worthy of noting, other than unstable ai holding some crystal in her hand.

"You must connect this data crystal to the core processing unit... I made a crystal!" Light Hope sounded rather pleased with herself Adora had to admit, the blonde allowing the energy of the Warrior Princess to fade away, leaving just the blonde girl standing there with her sword on her back.

"Right.. So, like I could do that all day.. But uh.. Where, exactly, is the core processing unit?" Resting her hand on her hip, Adora tried to look like the experience hadn't been as tiring as it really was, although she did have to wonder to herself why exactly she thought the AI who probably wouldn't remember this needed to

know. *Eh.. It's just nice to have Hope impressed with me for once..*

"It is over this way." Hope waved her hand towards an open doorway, yet appeared to inadvertently activate something else, a dozen more of the large, mechanical spiders appearing in the room with them. The hologram's expression took a nosedive, shifting into a frown. "Oh dear. I appear to have made more spiders."

Staring at the sudden re-emergence of the threat, Adora groaned through closed lips, drawing her sword again and holding it aloft.

"For the Honour of Greyskull!"

This time, I'm staying as She-Ra..

"Do not worry She-Ra, I believe I can help." The words on their own were enough cause for alarm, but coming from a Light Hope who was totally unsure of her powers was practically a recipe for disaster. But it could very possibly mean that Hope had figured out how to *stop* the spiders.

"Hope - can you get rid of them?" There was a sudden noise, a roaring of something coming down one of the open corridors, and Adora wheeled around to look at it.

Thankfully, it was not some horrific beast.

Unfortunately, it was the *ocean* .

"HooOOPE!" The wall of water slammed into the Warrior Princess and her vision went black.

Adora...

Adora!

The blonde opened her eyes, sucking in great lungful's of-

Nothing.

Glancing to her left, then her right, Adora was greeted with a plane of total darkness. There was a great, black *nothing* surrounding her, no light, no darkness, no ground, no sky, just *nothing* . A total absence of being.

Adora!

The cry of her name brought her head around to look at-

There was suddenly a grassy hilltop, overlooking a clear, sparkling river through a forest, leading into an ocean whose surface bounced the rays of the brightly glowing moon as it sank beyond the horizon, over the water.

"What the-"

This is your mind, Adora. Sorry about intruding..

Mara's voice responded to the question that Adora had been about to ask, the response coming from her left as the blonde overlooked the gorgeous view below. Glancing to the source of the voice, on her left, Adora nearly had a heart attack.

There was a woman sitting next to her, on a blanket that Adora was now aware she was sitting on too. Wearing a familiar blue leotard and deep blue pants, Mara tilted her head, looking at Adora with an expression that Adora could perhaps only describe as complacent.

Struggling to find words, Adora simply stared at the woman who she knew as her predecessor as the tanned woman stared over the view that they shared, a soft smile growing on her lips. Giving a sigh of satisfaction, she began to speak to the blonde casually.

"I'm sorry for.. Hijacking this part of your subconscious, it's easier when your conscious isn't awake and filling the space... I thought you would appreciate something somewhat tangible. This is all in your head, just.. So you know.."

Pausing for a moment to choose her next words, Mara continued. "I.. Loved Etheria.. When I was alive. The planet was.. so strange.. So *different* to all the others that I had been to. Not like the sprawling metropolises of Earth and Acadia, or the capital, Eternia.. It was so *raw* . So untouched..."

Adora swallowed, reeling at the sudden influx of information. *The First Ones had a whole empire in the stars... And Mara had taken Etheria away from it... And Eternia. It was their capital planet... And it was their home.. My home..*

Sighing as she forlornly set her hand down on the grass, only for the ground to shimmer and part around her hand, the brunette only looking more dejected by the sight. Her tone had shifted when she next spoke, moving to a more sombre expression of her emotions. "Razz showed me how.. Crazy the magic here was.. I loved it... Adora.. I know you didn't trust me, and you still have doubts.. But please, you can save the planet *we* love.. You... Just need to put that crystal in the other slot.."

The vision began to wobble, to shimmer and distort, and Mara seemed to realise it. Adora forced herself to focus on what would surely be important words, forcibly stabilising the wavering vision just for a moment longer, just to hear what Mara had to say.

The brunette stared her in the eyes, holding one hand over her own heart. "Trust yourself."

The vision collapsed back into darkness.

The darkness was then abruptly engulfed in light.

"Apologies - She-Ra, I was unaware that Humans are unable to swim."

Adora's eyes burst open and the blonde sat bolt upright, gulping in deep breaths of air as she felt her stomach churning. No different to the time she had eaten so much that she made herself sick, Adora hugged her gut tenderly, trying to calm the sensations down. Different, however, was the fact that this time it made no difference.

The noise of the blonde purging the contents of her stomach into the yawning abyss next to the platform she was sat on filled the room, making for an *exceedingly* unpleasant combination. *Apparently my body does not know the difference between simulated water and real water..*

"I... Uhck.. Can swim.. I just can't *breathe* underwater." Adora spat the foul tasting saliva in her mouth into the abyss too,

groaning as she carefully picked herself up off the ground, avoiding smacking her head on some crystalline spire above her head. *I must be the first She-Ra to ever puke my guts up in the Crystal Castle* .

She resisted the urge to snort in amusement as her own commentary.

For her part, Light Hope looked intrigued. " *Interesting...* I shall make a note of this.."

Looking forwards, Adora stared at the obscure maze of crystal shapes, each of them looking totally random in and of themselves, but together forming some strangely beautiful and distinctly chaotic *mess* that seemed perfectly in line with the whole idea of the Castle.

"Well.. Do I just... Go through?" Turning to Hope, Adora noticed the sudden absence of the hologram, blinking in indignant surprise. Opening her mouth to make some remark, she closed it again just as quickly, choosing to silently fume to herself as she carefully began to pick her way through the tight gaps of the maze.

For a few, heart stopping seconds, Adora found herself stuck in the shapes, frozen in silent panic as she struggled to find a way through with her eyes. Wriggling left and right brought her no freedom but shifting upwards left her staring at a path through. Pulling herself back and pushing herself up, Adora clambered

higher up, before squeezing out the other end and gracefully landing on the ground.

Face first.

"... Ow.."

Light Hope was staring down at Adora when the blonde picked herself up off the floor after a solid 3 minutes of simply laying there, questioning how her life had gone to place her in such a predicament. The ai seemed curious, cocking her head as one hand remained held out, holding the crystal in its grasp. "Are you alright Adora? You took quite a lot of time getting up."

"I'm.. Fine, Light Hope.. Is this it..?" Adora stared across at the structure rising from the abyss beneath them, sporting what looked like two sockets for a crystal to be placed in. Between the two platforms floated two platforms, seemingly held up by nothing.

"Yes - It is. You must place the crystal into the left slot." Adora carefully made her way to the edge, preparing herself and forcing her gaze forwards. Looking down at the abyss would start making her feel uncertain of herself, unsure. She'd have doubts and that would distract her.

Catra told me that..

Taking a single, long and deep breath, Adora took three quick, and yet carefully planned, leaps, coming to a stop in front of the console with the two slots. *Hope wants left... Mara wants right...*

With a moment's hesitation, Adora raised the crystal and slipped it into the right slot.

Light Hope vanished.

The lights snapped off in a heartbeat.

Adora's breath hitched.

Silence...

Total darkness.

The world around her glitched for a second, and the lights returned.

A pink hologram stood in front of Adora.

It was not Light Hope.

Adora stared at the figure

Mara stared back at Adora.

Adora's jaw dropped.

Mara swallowed as she looked at Adora, startled.

A hollow sounding voice rang out, a slightly digitised version of Mara's voice. "Oh... Hello.. You must be Adora."

Adora's jaw dropped even further, if that was even possible.

Adora VII

“…”

“.. Adora?”

“. . .”

“Uhm… hello? Adora?”

“. . .”

“You are Adora, right?..” The pink hologram shifted its gaze slightly, looking over the blonde's shoulder, staring at the golden hilt of the sword that the girl wore in the sheathe on her back. A strained look flashed across the holographic woman's face. “Of course you are - you have that accursed thing.”

That statement finally pulled Adora out of her stunned silence, blinking in stunned indignation at the woman who had left her so flummoxed with just a few words. Her spluttered, indignant response was cut off when she first got an actual *look* at Mara, as opposed to just staring aimlessly at the holographic woman.

Mara looked, for the lack of a better descriptor, *exhausted.*

There was a nasty looking gash on her cheek and her leotard looked like it had taken a not insignificant amount of abuse in the previous short while, torn and frayed fabric present all over. Her knees looked particularly scuffed, with the pants that Adora knew to be deep blue, torn and with only a few threads bridging the gap over what was likely raw skin. Her shins were stained with what was probably mud, and the boots that the brunette wore on her feet were probably the most intact part of her outfit.

But her eyes just looked so *tired* . It looked like Mara hadn't slept in days, the bags under her eyes visible beneath the frayed and disorderly fringe that hung down over her eyes.

".. Mara..." The lump in Adora's throat refused to die down as the blonde swallowed, staring at the woman in front of her and fighting her vocal cords to keep her voice level and calm. ".. What *happened* to you.."

The brunette herself swallowed, looking down at herself for a second, before turning her gaze to the roof, resting her gaze firmly up and closing her eyes. After a few seconds, Adora went to comment, but Mara held her hand up to silence the blonde, and so Adora waited there awkwardly, feeling just a little bit irritated and *very* fucking confused by the whole series of events that had just occurred.

The brunette's form shimmered for a second, and all evidence of the injuries and damage done to her person vanished, replaced by Mara as Adora knew her, the hologram shifting colour, ditching the bright pink in favour of the light blue that Adora had so long

associated with the First Ones. The brunette opened her eyes, letting out a breath and turning to the anxiously waiting girl standing right in front of her.

As the two generations of She-Ra locked eyes with each other, Adora found herself somewhat lost for words, staring at the figure standing in front of her. *How the **fuck** am I meant to react?!*

"You.. Probably have questions.."

Adora baulked. *Probably? Make that definitely.* ".. You think?"

The brunette shrugged, a soft smile on her lips. "Fair point... I.. Have been talking to you, right?" Upon seeing Adora's confused expression, Mara clarified, tapping the side of her head with an index finger. "In here."

"Oh! Uh- Yeah you have.." Adora paused for a moment, glancing down at her sternum, tapping it distractedly. "Although.. It's more here.."

The brunette's lips twisted into an interested expression. "Hmm.. That's interesting.. Maybe it's different for everyone. I... Never really got to ask Keira.."

The tone shifted to sombre in a heartbeat, but Mara's expression forced itself back to a balanced look. "Right. So.. I imagine that

I... She... Whatever, I'll just call her 'She-Ra', promised you answers.."

Before Adora even had her mouth open, She-Ra inside her pulsed and Mara - the one in her head - spoke. *Yes, I did.*

Holographic Mara visibly cringed, recoiling slightly. "My voice sounds like *that?* "

Adora reckoned it was a testament to her genetics that her jaw was remaining *on* with how regularly she lost control over the muscles controlling it. Raising her right hand, Adora shook her head in a vain attempt to clear the thoughts fogging up her mind. "Wowowowow.. *You* can hear her?"

Mara blinked. "... Yeah.. I can.. Hmm... Did She-Ra ever speak around Hope?"

Adora paused, pursing her lips. ".. No, she didn't.. I guess that's why. Hope could pick up on her."

".. There's a lot of things I didn't know about Hope.. I suppose I was happy not knowing some things.. But now I'm going to *learn* all of them... What she hid from *me* ." Mara's tone sounded... Almost *heartbroken* . Like some big part of her life had just been torn down. *How much did Hope mean to Mara..?*

"... Not to... Sound insensitive.. But uh, what *happened* back there..?" Adora's words seemingly jumpstarted Mara, the brunette pulling herself out of her stupor and glancing up at Adora. Even as a hologram, Adora could see that there was some emotion brewing behind Mara's grey orbs.

".. I had you complete a protocol that I stashed away inside the Watchtower after I severed it from Light Hope's operating system.. When you reconnected the Watchtower, my protocol infiltrated Light Hope's systems and essentially disabled much of her functionality. Firing random things, pretty much trying to force her to reboot herself.." Mara paused, glancing at the two sockets next to them, the crystal still firmly lodged in the right slot. The sight seemed to sober the woman slightly, and she continued after slumping a little with a sigh.

"My hope was that when you came to fix Hope, I would have been able to convince you to.. Well, make my plan work... And it seems that I did.." Mara sighed, glancing out into the abyss that surrounded the duo. Adora interjected however, a thought nagging at her mind.

"So where's Hope now?"

A strained look flashed across Mara's features as she glanced back at Adora. "I'm... Working on purging her from the interface.. Taking her place, without the grooming to turn you into a weapon of horrific proportions."

Adora choked at the last part. "Say *what* ?"

Surprise flashed across Mara's face for a second, before realisation dawned and swiftly shifted to the beginnings of a deep rage. "Of course - Hope wouldn't have told you. Duh."

Adora glanced back towards the way that she had come from, watching the room flicker in response to its new mistresses commands and emotions. Whatever had Mara worked up was clearly enough to affect her control over the reality in which Adora resided as of the current moment. "Uhm.. Can we have this conversation... Somewhere more... Solid?"

The hologram's eyes shifted right, eyes widening at the flickering room that very quickly stabilised itself once the brunette figured out what was going on, cringing as she did so. "Sorry, Sorry.. Not used to uh... I guess controlling my emotions... After all, us Eternians are *so* emotional..." Mara's eyes seemed to dance with amusement just a little after saying that, glancing aside as a memory flashed unreadably across her face.

Somehow, Adora left the strange room feeling far *more* confused than she ever had before.

“So.. What's this about turning me into a weapon?”

They had relocated to the antechamber of the Crystal Castle, the high ceiling replaced by a holographic image of the outside sky, a deep black void that Adora had correlated with relaxation in Bright Moon, and a sight that Mara had projected onto the ceiling without a word. Indeed, the duo had been in complete silence for most of their walk back, and Adora had only broken it after a few minutes of laying on the faux grass floor, staring into the deep abyss.

Beside her, the holographic woman sighed, almost as if Adora had pulled her out of a particularly relaxing moment, into one that she really did not wish to cover. Regardless, Mara pushed herself into a position where she was leaning back, still looking up. Adora blinked, and the night sky was suddenly dotted with a thousand twinkling specks of light - *stars.*

"There used to be so many other planets out there, Adora. When I did.. What I had to do, I did it not just for Etheria, but for every single living being in the universe…" Mara paused for a while, staring at the stars on the roof, her holographic body flickering slightly. She was silent too, choosing her words before eventually interjecting.

"There's.. No easy way to put this, so I'll just be blunt.. Adora, Etheria is like a bomb – the biggest, most terrible and most destructive bomb in the galaxy – enough to wipe all life in the universe, every planet, every creature, every microscopic fleck of gunk under your fingernails, all of it, out of existence.. and She-Ra is the *key* to that bomb. The only question is – will the key be used to detonate the bomb, or defuse it."

Mara leant back again, staring at the stars. “Hope’s directive was changed by my superiors. She was to utilise She-Ra as the key to detonate that bomb, to use it against… a being, one that my people were losing a war against… Hope changed, overnight almost. In a heartbeat, I lost her... I had heard whispers of what was going on - I tried to figure out what was happening, but I didn’t learn enough, and not nearly fast enough.”

The hologram’s voice became choked by emotion, Mara taking a few seconds to regain control of herself before she eventually continued her commentary. “When we figured it out - Squadron Greyskull and I - we had almost no time to act. I tried to damage Hope in an attempt to stop her from activating the.. The Heart of Etheria Protocol.. But that didn’t do enough.”

The phrase flashed through Adora’s mind. *Heart of Etheria Protocol… that was on Hope’s screens. Heart.. Etheria… She-Ra… and she was going to use it?*

The thoughts made Adora’s stomach churn, but choosing not to puke in the Crystal Castle for a *second* time that evening, Adora fought the sensation down. *I was.. Being groomed into a weapon… to fight this enemy..*

Seemingly oblivious of what Adora was going through, Mara continued her tale. “Our delay meant that Hope had safeguarded the failsafe, the only way to disarm the.. Well, *planet* . So we had to go to the extreme back up… I uploaded my consciousness to the Watchtower, with the help of Serenia… in the end.. I had to strand us in Despondos..”

Mara turned her head to stare at the blonde, a complex web of emotions glowing behind her holographic eyes, each one almost completely unreadable, drowned out in the metaphorical radio static. "I'm not a hero, Adora.. I never wanted to be remembered as one… I won't be remembered as one... It's been a thousand years, Adora. A part of me.. Just wants to forget all of this… but my memory, my consciousness, was *just* there.. For me, these events happened *hours* ago."

Mara stood, the projections fading away, leaving them both standing in the crystalline room, the elder She-Ra seeming distinctly unsettled by the whole affair. "I remember watching as Serenia was turned into *atoms* by the planet ***ripping itself apart*** , I remember being betrayed by the only person I ever loved, and I remember her trying to destroy *billions* with ***my*** hands. Most of all, I remember her using **that** cursed sword to try and make me do it."

The end of the emotional rant had Mara standing right in front of Adora, finger pointed accusingly at the sword over the blonde's shoulder, chest heaving from the effort and eyes streaming tears that made Adora's heart ache in sorrow whilst her brain melted with the horrific tale being told to her. Mara pulled back, concluding in the softest voice that Adora had ever heard, straining to hear it as the woman murmured to herself.

"I remember swearing that there would never be another She-Ra if I could help it. And yet I knew there would be. I just hoped my sacrifice would be worth it…" Pushing her head into her hands, Mara was still for a few moments as her chest heaved, taking in deep breaths to try and control herself. When she spoke again, her voice was choked by grief. ".. Fuck, Adora.. I just want to cry myself to sleep, wake up and have this all be just a bad dream..

But I know that I can't.. That I will never be able to sleep again, that I'm dead in my ship out in some remote part of Etheria, and that all I am is just a ghost of who I was."

....

How does one respond to that?

"Mara..." Adora swallowed, blinking slowly as she chose the words to respond, trying to push through the failing composure to give an adequate response. How does one respond to something like that.

How could she respond to Mara bearing the scars and the grief of a few days cut from the fabric of hell. How could Adora even *begin* to relate to the pain and suffering and turmoil that Mara had been parley to - and most of all, how could she relate to the fact that Mara knew herself to be dead.

"Mara." Shifting a bit, Adora drew the cursed blade from her back, trying to ignore how Mara had been controlled and manipulated by Light Hope through the weapon, instead holding it aloft over her head. "Your sacrifice saved billions. Your memory will not be forgotten, and neither will your Squadron. For the Honour Of Greyskull!"

The brief flash of light momentarily blinded Adora, but when her vision returned, she found Mara staring up at her unmoving,

almost anxious for the blonde's next words. Adora swallowed and pushed the nerves down. "You've done.. So much to save this planet. I need your help to complete what you started. Without you.. I'd be following Hope blindly."

"Please Mara. For Etheria."

The hologram stared at the blade in Adora's hands, then at her face. It was weird standing taller than the woman who was most certainly taller than Adora usually was, but even so, Mara carried an air of authority around her that Adora would not dare question. Mara sighed softly, bowing her head slightly.

".. I suppose you are right - I *do* still have a job to do. I never was the best at training people, but it was always the duty of a predecessor to help train a successor. I can't promise it will be pleasant Adora, but I'll do my best..." Something sparkled behind Mara's eyes, as if a flame had just been lit behind them, a new spark or drive given to the holographic woman. Then it shifted into something more amused, light hearted.

"First things first, I need to teach you something I almost forgot how to do."

Adora cocked her eyebrow curiously. "What's that?"

"Turning into She-Ra-" *well that doesn't sound too hard...* "-Without that abomination."

Say what.

"Wait- You can do that? But isn't this-"

"The Sword of ***Protection*** -" Mara practically *spat* the word, as if it was the most heinous insult she could sling. "-was something that Keira, my.. Predecessor, had a hand in designing, although I suspect not with her knowledge.. I first learned how to become She-Ra without the sword, but when it was given to me, I discovered it was far easier to utilise the Sword to transform."

A bitter laugh left the woman's lips as she stared at the blade. "That Sword is like... A safety harness. It makes it easier to transform and allows you to do it far easier than without. But it's a limited exchange - ultimately in the long run it gimps your power, gives a hard cap. It's far easier to use, but its not congruent with becoming a true She-Ra."

Mara gestured at Adora to emphasise, and the blonde suddenly felt very self conscious about the shorts. "Your form is a reflection of that. You look young because the sword is placing a hard cap on how much energy you can channel. You're not channelling the full power."

Blinking, Adora suddenly felt very relieved by the revelation being given to her, but a thousand questions crashed around in her head, eventually a few slipping out. "So.. Wait, hang on - How do

I channel She-Ra properly? And isn't this thing dangerous? You said it was used to control you.."

The strained look on Mara's face told Adora that any more questions around the whole fiasco probably wouldn't be appreciated too much - although she was fairly sure that she would inevitably end up breaking her own rule. Regardless, Mara broke eye contact and held her left bicep with her right hand. "Channelling She-Ra is a challenging task - It took me months to first succeed. Sometimes it comes easily, life or death scenarios, y'know? Like she realises there is no time to be fickle. But other times she just refuses, like she.."

".. Wants you to figure out the issue yourself..." Adora finished Mara's words almost automatically, and the momentary look of surprise that Mara shot Adora told the blonde that she had absolutely hit the nail on the metaphorical head. The quiet 'Yeah' offered in agreement was followed by Mara clearing her throat and continuing.

"As for the control... Well.. The best way is to show you... But I would... Really rather not.." The dejection and clearly uncomfortable tone in Mara's voice raised Adora's eyebrows in alarm, a hot stab of panic shooting through her. *Fuck, how could I be so insensitive.*

"Oh - no no.. Stars, I'm so sorry.. I shouldn't have asked you to-" Adora's panicked rambling was swiftly shut up by Mara raising a hand and bowing her head slightly. The brunette looked more tired than anything else, Adora sighing as she began to internalise the negative emotions, only for a glowing blue finger to flick her on the nose, startling her out of the rambling.

Well - to say flick her *on* the nose was a bit of a long shot, when Mara's finger actually went *through* Adora's nose, ending up resting on the bridge of Adora's nose, between her eyes. "Stop that. Internalising your rambling. I've been there before. It doesn't help."

"I.... Ok..?" Adora blinked, looking at Mara curiously. The brunette seemed to be occupied thinking to herself, drumming her holographic fingers on her chin in a weirdly human manner that Adora had never really seen on any sort of hologram before, although admittedly it was a little unfair. *Hope doesn't really qualify as human..*

".. Alright. We might as well start.." Mara cleared her throat and straightened up slightly, Adora doing the same unconsciously, in a subtle attempt to do as her predecessor and potentially learn something. "As a wise woman once told me a *very* long time ago.. She-Ra is not the Sword. She-Ra is you.."

As Adora drilled that phrase into her head - she could not help but feel that she had made the first definitively correct choice in a long while.

Thank you, Mara..

Catra V

Today *should* have been a day like any other.

Catra dragged herself out of bed like usual, lamenting the poor quality of the mattress that she had been issued by the supply officer who she had insulted for his incompetence when it came to getting her room ready. She did her usual morning stretches, far beyond what even the most flexible human could manage, dragged herself into the shower for yet another argument with her conscience.

Adora was waiting for Catra in the showers, just like she always was when it came to the morning routine that they had started all those years ago as Cadets. Silently undressing, the duo stood under the two showers, Catra just waiting for the figment of her imagination to start talking to her, and to start berating her for some inconceivable thing that she hadn't even thought of.

But the commentary never started, the only noise in the room being the pressurised whine of the water flowing through the shower head. She knew what the difference was spurred by, but apparently her mind wanted her to start talking first, something that she did with an irate groan as she sat down under the spray.

"Why are you being so quiet?" Adora turned to look at Catra, and suddenly the blonde looked a bit younger. Had it been any other day, Catra would have been unable to guess exactly how much younger, but today was different. Catra knew that she was staring at Adora from exactly a year ago.

"You know why." The voice was a little jarring. It was different to current Adora's voice, which had deepened a little bit compared to that of the girl who sat next to her under the shower's spray. Also different was her body - a lot more lithe than the Adora that she regularly went up against on the battlefield, not to mention her hair was also a little longer here than it was now.

"I *really* don't." Catra didn't know why she still tried to lie to her conscience, she was fairly sure that there was no point in the exercise. Her beliefs were verified by the unimpressed eyebrow that was raised at her in turn, one that she could feel her own guilty reaction towards, although this time she didn't try to hide it.

"One year since she left." Catra sighed to herself, pushing herself upright and stepping out of the spray of water, her ears flicking uncomfortably in order to dry themselves off, a trait picked up from her feline side. Sometimes she lamented how much of her physiology was related to her feline side, but now was not really the time to be complaining as she dressed herself.

Unfortunately, her conscience didn't let up, breaking the rule that she had agreed on with it (herself?).

"One year of going at each other's throats every time you see each other..." Catra slammed the locker door shut as she pulled on the grey sports bra and shorts, half forgetting that they had not originally been hers. Unfortunately again, the part of her mind she really would have rather forgotten, failed to forget. "And yet here you are a year on, wearing her clothes, arguing with yourself that you don't need her, and that you made the right choice."

Catra scowled as she pulled the top over her head, adjusting the sleeve covering her right shoulder to sit more comfortably. The leggings were easy, per usual, and the long glove on her left arm slid on with only a little frustration. She was stressed by this rambling from her mind, and she could tell it, but unfortunately, there was no way to shut up her head without doing some not insignificant damage to herself, and that was completely off the table. Scorpia would have a field day, and Shadow Weaver wouldn't waste a second trying to claw back her old authority.

Staring at the headpiece in her hands for a moment, Catra silently reflected on what her conscience had said to her as she stared at the piece of metal that was the longest serving piece of her appearance. It had been with her since she was a kid, and it was still with her today, through thick and thin. Through her time with the 303rd, with Adora, and finally now to her life beyond the shadow of the blonde.

But she had gotten out of the shadow, she wasn't the sidekick anymore, she was the villain. The big bad for the hero to fight, and yet Adora had done little other than constantly lose to Catra over and over, achieving only minimal victories by the skin of her teeth. The Horde just wasn't doing enough. *More.. We need to do more - More land, more people, more of everything. More sacrifices.*

The noise of the other door opening pulled her out of her inflection, her gaze travelling over to look at Scorpia emerging from her room, looking as if she had just woken up. Noticing her roommate realising her presence, Catra scowled slightly deeper and turned away from the scorpion princess as she raised a

friendly hand in greeting, the feline simply donning her headpiece and walking out the door, not caring about how the princess slumped slightly as she left.

Everyone needs to make sacrifices ...

"Get up. Do it *again* ."

Catra had to resist the urge to drag her nails down her face - that would be more relaxing and less painful than trying to get what was left of the sorry excuse of her former training squad mates back through the advanced training. It was utterly pathetic watching the sparring that Catra had put them through.

Kyle was totally pathetic when it came to any sort of combat - be that hand to hand or even utilising the ranged lasers that some soldiers were issued in lieu of their electro prods. Sure, he could aim just fine, but his major issue seemed to be that he was either facing a target that would fight back, or that he was facing a living target. *Honestly - I should just send him to maintenance or something. But then Shadow Weaver would point to the drop outs, not to mention Lonnie and Rogelio would drop out and they're somewhat competent.... Uuuuhg.*

For his part, Rogelio was usually a fairly handy fighter, but his major issue came with the fact that he was paired up with *Kyle* , and Catra knew *exactly* how gay the both of them were (seriously,

just LOOK at how they stare at each other), so there was absolutely no chance in hell that either of them would even raise a finger against each other. This was absolutely apparent when Catra even looked in their general direction - she could probably read the broadcasted attacks from the Kingdom of *Snows* .

*And yet, **KYLE** is still on the floor.*

For her part, Lonnie had just beaten the ever living daylights out of Force Captain Octavia, something that the feline felt just a modicum of pleasure out of seeing. After all, that was rather the reason that she called the octopoid Force Captain to the training today - Catra knew that she would not be able to resist the idea of potentially beating up a bunch of effectively cadets.

The fact that Catra had deliberately described them as 'failures' to lower the woman's expectations was hardly *her* fault.

From her position on the gantry overlooking the sparring room, Catra's forehead came to a rest in her left hand, her eyes peering out from under her hand to stare at the data pad clutched in her right hand. Whilst not exactly on topic, the pad displayed the rest of her days business, (2 meetings with the rest of the Force captains, then an extra with Shadow Weaver and not to mention the nearly endless list of complaints she had to deal with), and at the top of the screen sat the most depressing part of it all.

And for *once* that accursed day, it was *not* the date.

It was the timer that showed how long the last fight had lasted.

Not even thirty seconds.

What it meant was that the rest of the Force Captains were utterly pathetic in a fight, given that Octavia had been beaten up by *Lonnie* , or that they were simple minded and unable to read their opponents, given that Octavia had failed to pick up on *any* of the warning signs (for the record, Catra had seen at least half a dozen indicators that Lonnie knew what she was doing). *Do I have to purge the Force Captains too?*

"Cobalt. What the hell is this." Her brusque demand caught the man off guard from where he was watching the sparring playing out below them, but to his credit, he barely showed it. Instead, he just looked a little unimpressed by the whole thing, dryly replying to her.

"Some of the worst fighting I've seen in the last few years."

She tried to suppress the snort that slipped through her self control, but that *really* didn't work, breaking through her lips despite her efforts. Catra had to admit, she *liked* Cobalt. He knew what he was doing, and he wasn't afraid to call people out on their bullshit. He had done it to her when she was a cadet, and she in turn had kept him around because he wasn't afraid to give frank advice.

The begrudging grin on her lips parted for her reply. "Too right."

Setting the data pad back on her belt, Catra gauged the drop to the floor below, tilted her head from side to side as she weighed the variables. Sure, she could walk down the stairs like a *normal* person, but where was the fun in doing something so mundane, when she could..

Resting a hand on the railing, the feline vaulted the ledge and dropped the twenty odd feet to the ground, landing in a neat roll and straightening up, gently cracking the crick in her back. Turning her attention to the quad of people who had just started staring at her, Catra rolled her eyes and levelled her finger at Octavia. " *YOU* need to get better at reading your opponents-"

Her finger moved to point at Kyle and Rogelio. "-You two need to start *fighting* and not fucking about-" The two in question looked equal parts irritated (Rogelio) and entirely embarrassed and ashamed (Kyle was doing *all* the lifting in that category.) She turned her finger finally to the dreadlocked girl, inhaling and pausing. *Do I really have to say this..*

Sighing in irritation, she rolled her head back and brought it round to her right, tilted at about 30 degrees. Grumbling at the start of her response, she begrudgingly spoke. " *I can't believe I'm saying this* ... You did well - not like there was much opposition, but still."

Lonnie's eyes narrowed at the praise, Catra taking that as her cue to pivot around and make for the exit whilst she still had the brain cells to deal with Shadow Weaver and the vast majority of the

moronic Force Captains who she had put together to flounder the invasion of the Kingdoms of Etheria. *It's almost like she was TRYING to have the Horde lose. I mean seriously, Scorpia I can understand, but Octavia, really?*

"Oh yeah - I reckon I did fine against a real opponent. I'd like to see you do better." Lonnie's challenge brought Catra's exit to a screaming halt, the twitch of her left eye shifting into a smug grin as she looked back over her shoulder at the four of them standing there, staring her down.

Well - three stared her down, Kyle tried very hard to stare *away* .

"Sorry - Did I just hear you *challenge* me? You know what Lonnie - I'll give you a chance to back out. Save you the bruises." Catra's smirk was intended to unnerve the dark skinned girl, yet it failed to achieve its goal, only eliciting an almost identical response from the dreadlocked girl. The smirk on her own lips tugged down into a sneer as she turned herself around.

"One v Four isn't very fair.." The downwards curl on her lips was replaced by a smirk as settled herself into a stance a little more suited for fighting. "Are you *sure* you don't need a fifth? Maybe a sixth, to make up for Kyle?"

Her taunts brought a sneer to Lonnie's lips and appeared to make Rogelio *fairly* unhappy, but that was what she was *counting* on. She had seen it time and time again with Adora - emotions cloud a fighter's judgement, inhibits their ability to retaliate smartly, leaves them open to counter attacks and mind games.

Silence reigned as the two sides stared down the other, waiting for someone to act. *Probably going to be Rogelio or Octavia.. Strength based fighters are SO predictable-*

Rogelio moved forwards, charging her as she waited for her moment to act. When he was almost on top of her, Catra feigned right, then sprung upwards, over the reptile's head as he impotently snatched at the air where she had been a moment before. Her feet landed on his shoulders and she sprung off them forcefully, sending the lizard onto his face with a roar of rage.

Kyle charged next, screaming a pathetic battle cry and moving in with his eyes firmly shut, seemingly spurred on by the charge of Rogelio, but acting far too late to even hope to exploit it. This movement brought her attention quickly back to the reptile, who was just beginning to stand up when Catra sidestepped Kyle's blind charge, planting her foot on the small of his back and shoving him into the reptile, sending them away in a mass of limbs.

Lonnie and Octavia were far more cautious - one as she eyed up her opponent, the other as she tried to *distance* herself from the human sporting an electro prod that had been, admittedly, turned down for training. It would still hurt like a complete bitch though. All the more incentive to avoid getting hit.

Lonnie came in quick and smart, keeping the prod close and keeping her attacks with it more of a stabbing motion as opposed to the overhead charge that Kyle so favoured using. Darting back, Catra kept her eyes peeled for opening in the human’s guard,

waiting for her to commit to something she couldn't manage, all whilst keeping an eye on the boys who were only just getting back onto their feet.

Lonnie's movements became a bit more open, more obvious strikes meant to bait Catra into overextending. Lonnie was utilising battlefield tactics, something that she had picked up from Catra. Lonnie was clearly trying to buy time for the rest of the squad to get back up and close in, knowing that she couldn't beat Catra on her own. Yet her *pride* was her downfall. She was still trying to bait Catra into overextending, to do everything herself.

Lonnie wanted to prove her worth - her pride was hurt. She wanted to show she could do the same as Catra, work alone.

Catra, however, was *far* better than the dreadlocked girl.

It came quick - in fairness, it had *probably* been a bait, but the dreadlocked girl had either overestimated how quick her own movements were, or had underestimated Catra's speed and reflexes. A jab forwards had overextended the girl's guard, and Catra's knee had come up into the bottom of her wrist, flexing the muscles and leading to her dropping the prod.

Now inside Lonnie's guard, Catra's hands came forwards, delivering a sharp blow to Lonnie's gut and a follow up high kick to the chest, sending her over just as Rogelio and Kyle re-entered the battlefield and almost caught her off guard. Rogelio's punch missed by a scant few inches, and Kyle nearly bowled himself over with his own overzealous blow that Catra managed to avoid only

by delivering a kick to the side of Rogelio's knee and springing herself away off the reptile.

Good news - she was out of immediate strike range and upright, ready to keep going.

Bad news - Kyle had the electro prod that had been in Lonnie's grasp and now all three of them were ready to tussle again.

Although, in all fairness, it was probably in the best possible hands for Catra, given that Kyle was completely crap.

The trio came in all at once, and Catra sized up her chances. Lonnie would arrive first, so preferably some move that threw the dreadlocked girl off balance would be best, then she could deal with Rogelio and Kyle at the same time.

True to her prediction, Lonnie arrived first, and Catra feigned right, then feigned the same move she used on Rogelio, starting to spring high, only to dive for the ground and knock the dreadlocked girl's feet out from under her as her arms impotently flailed above her head from where she had been trying to strike the feline. Just for good measure, Catra planted her foot on Lonnie's back and shoved, making the fall more awkward and forceful, to keep her down for a little longer.

Then the boys arrived, Rogelio's strike coming dangerously close to smacking a second concussion into Catra as her head jerked to

the right to avoid the blow. Swinging a second kick into the side of Rogelio's right knee, Catra used it as a springboard to clamber up the Lizard's body, getting a good purchase on his outstretched arm and using it as a leave from which to shove him backwards and off balance.

But then the violent *CRACK* filled the air and *ALL* of her fur stood immediately on end as the jolt of electricity passed through her body.

Kyle stood behind her, eyes closed and electro prod outstretched, where her tail had been a millisecond ago.

Of all people, *KYLE* was the first one to land a hit on her since ***She-Ra*** .

The surprise and panic that had shot through her boiled over into a truly *apoplectic* level of rage in a heartbeat as she used both arms to sharply strike on Kyle's outstretched arm, knocking the weapon from his grasp and nearly breaking his arm in the process, bringing forth a whimper from the boy. Slamming her knee up into his gut, his entire posture buckled as he let out a sharp and pathetic cry of pain as Catra bodily picked him up and swung him around..

Right into the path of the punch swung by the returning Rogelio.

Kyle immediately crumpled like a sack of potatoes as Rogelio stared at his arm in momentary horror, all that Catra needed to send a third and final kick into his right knee, buckling his guard as she landed a rage filled punch on the reptile's jaw, then a second and third into his ribs. Almost as an afterthought, she slammed her body weight into him, sending him to the ground as she sprung off of his chest, out of the way of any potential movement from Lonnie.

Lonnie looked worse for wear, but was definitely still ready to have a go, arms raised in a boxers stance. She couldn't have cared *less* about how Lonnie's stance was probably dodgy, or how Catra could have effortlessly knocked the dreadlocked girl to the ground.

Instead Catra, fuelled by adrenaline and rage, decided to indulge her.

Moving in sharply, Catra darted out of the way of the first strike, the blow harmlessly passing by her side as she surged in, angling herself to mostly deflect the second blow and once more slip inside Lonnie's guard. From there, all it took was a single, sharp jab to the kidneys to buckle Lonnie's stance, before springing over the dreadlocked girl and landing on her shoulders briefly, springing off them to send the girl face down onto the floor, a pair of red scores blossoming to life on her shoulders, visible through the tears that Catra had just gouged into her shirt.

Turning to inspect the three bodies on the floor, Catra, chest heaving and lungs sucking in great deep breaths of air, claws extended and looking like some sort of demonic entity driven solely by rage, turned to face the final opponent, Octavia, who

had simply watched on as Catra dismantled her former squad mates in a bout of pure fury. Trying to look as unexhausted as possible, the feline growled out a response to the octopoid.

"You want a try?"

Octavia, given by how quickly she turned and *fled* from the sparring room, apparently did *not* want a try.

From the gantry, the noise of someone clapping drifted down to the floor of the sparring room, the blue form of Cobalt peering over the banister and applauding softly. For the first time in a while, he actually emoted, looking mildly impressed by the whole thing.

“Very well done.”

Baring her fangs, Catra gave him a grin and turned away whilst pulling the data pad off her belt. It took a few seconds for the adrenaline to die down, but eventually she opened the device and glanced at the time.

Well overdue for that meeting with Shadow Weaver.

Fuuuck.

Adora VIII

Chapter Notes

> One month since the start!
>
> This also marks the one year anniversary of the fateful day - same as the last chapter, but just from Adora's view. She's not taking it nearly as well as Catra.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The date did not help Adora’s mental state.

Waking up in Bright Moon’s luxurious bed had become a second nature for Adora after more than a year of-

No. *Exactly* a year of experiencing the jarring culture shock of switching sides in the war that she had been raised in, the war that she had been raised *for,* and ultimately the war that she had been intended to end, and the war that she was *going* to end.

As it was, the war had been raging for too long already. It had done far too much damage to far too many innocent lives, it had taken too much. All Adora had to do was be a better She-Ra, be a better tactician than the enemy, be a better role model for the common soldier.

That was easy, right?

Of course it was..

Except that she didn't have a *CLUE* how to be a better She-Ra - Mara was still trying to help her to tap into the true energy of the Warrior Princess, and the Princess just kept darting away, like it wasn't the right time for it. And Adora knew - she knew that it could take time, lots of time and an immense amount of effort, but she didn't *have* time. Every day, more people died, more innocents lost their homes. More sacrifices were made by those without anything to give, all because *she* wasn't strong enough.

Except that the Rebellion was horrifically outnumbered and poorly supplied, and if the Horde managed to navigate the Whispering Woods, the whole war would be lost in a heartbeat, Bright Moon would fall and the Rebellion would collapse without leadership. The common Horde Soldier was far better equipped, far better trained and possessed a fanatical fervour in battle that the Rebellion's militia just simply could not handle or hope to match. Even worse, they simply had to let the Horde roll into towns unmolested, lest the weak forces of the region be crushed in open battle, because Adora didn't expect the strike, or spent too much time doing other things.

Except, that Adora wasn't even close to being able to compete with the Horde's tacticians. She had had the obligatory officer cadet training course, but she was expected to become a Force Captain, moving forces around on a tactical level and taking advice from dedicated strategists - and suddenly Adora had been thrust unto the post of War Master of the Rebellion, without a staff of experts. The closest thing she had to an expert was General Juliette, and she was the previous War Master - and her performance had been.. acceptable. Even Mara wasn't much help in that department - the woman had always been delegated to

rear line duties by her superiors. All of this left Adora in the unenviable position of pitting her mediocre skills against perhaps the greatest tactician on Etheria.

Catra…

The name had re-opened old wounds after the fiasco regarding the raid on the Fright Zone following the Princess Prom, the hasty rescue mission, the threat of mind wiping, the desperate flight from the Black Garnet chamber…

The hallway.

Rolling over in bed, the blonde buried her face into the top of a body pillow - one that she had originally been given after several nearly sleepless nights a year ago, one that Angella had actually gone out of her way to procure for Adora. Having long since forgotten the exact words, the phrase 'Separation Anxiety' still stuck with her, etched into her mind by her exhausted brain. She had no clue why she felt more secure and safe hugging it, she just knew that it helped with the stress, with the aches in her muscles from days of hand to hand combat, both in training and in the field.

More importantly, it helped with the other aches.

The aches in her head, the mounting mental pressure that, every day, threatened to cave in her mind, to collapse the metaphorical

ceiling and bring her sanity and her composure crashing down into the depths of a mental breakdown. Every day it was only made worse, by the knowledge that she was still failing as War Master, by the knowledge that she was still not living up to Mara's expectations, that every day people died on her orders… and all of it was multiplied by the knowledge that it would only get worse if she failed to keep herself together. It was her silent witness to her meltdowns, her silent pillar of stability that she clung to when she needed to cry about the horrors she had borne witness to, and her closest confidant - the one she could rant and rage and rave to, the one she could trust with anything and everything, without fear that she would be either viewed as insane or the knowledge passed to someone with loose lips.

But most of all, it helped the *emotional* aches.

The bleeding heartache that Adora had come to feel regarding the whole affair with Catra. The longing to feel her, to be beside her through the rough patches - the good times and the bad, to do what they had always promised they would do eventually - running things their way, doing what they wanted, looking out for each other. But most of all, Adora just.. Wanted Catra back.

She had been *so* close in the hallway - she had just.. Almost had Catra back. For a heartbeat, she saw that girl that did everything with her, the Catra of old. But then she slipped through Adora's fingers, just as Catra's hand had, leaving her hand and her heart cold, craving the warmth that it had just been grasping. It had been the eyes that hurt most, however. Catra had always emoted primarily through her eyes and her feline appendages, and the hallway had been no different. Her eyes had been so.. Dull..

Adora had almost sobbed in the hallway when Catra had vanished as she turned into She-Ra. But again, she had to be strong for Glimmer. She needed it, then more than ever, and Adora's own issues could wait.

She had barely slept that night, clutching the pillow close and crying herself until her heart ached so much that she passed out from either the pain or just sheer exhaustion.

Above all, Adora just wanted Catra back. She wanted to hold her, to clutch her close to her body and just be next to her, to *feel* the feline and for her to feel Adora. She had *tried* to initially repress that urge, to find reasons that she simply could not do that, and that she had to put the safety and well being of the people of Etheria before herself and her own wants. She was She-Ra, after all. It was her duty.

Catra was the enemy, of that Adora was acutely aware, far more than she had ever wanted to be aware of. Her actions had done inexplicable amounts of damage to the Rebellion - and had pushed back any scenario of them winning the war by years. She had handed Adora countless defeats, she had razed towns, slaughtered populations, enslaved countless citizens, led the Horde on a spree of conquest all across the planet.

But the needy, selfish part of her mind kept crying out otherwise, finding the cracks and flaws in Adora's reasoning. Catra had, in reality, done perhaps the most out of anyone to *help* the Rebellion, some things intentionally, some things unintentionally.

Catra had made the Horde a threat, had gained it so many towns and villages - but that had catalysed the reformation of the Princess Alliance behind Adora.

She had kidnapped Bow and Glimmer, but in turn had enabled Adora's escape from the Fright Zone, had given her the sword back and had *almost* been convinced to come with Adora to the Rebellion. If only Adora had done something more...

Her grip on the pillow tightened and she buried her head deeper, her mind parroting Mara's words that had stuck with her through her more recent breakdowns. *Stop that - Internalising. It doesn't help.*

The woman had been an immense help to Adora, and her impact had definitely lessened the impact of her recent breakdowns, but Mara had not fully understood Adora when the blonde had tried to confide in the hologram. Again, Adora barely remembered - she had been in a truly sorry state when she had first broken down on Mara’s metaphorical shoulder - but what snippets stayed with her let her put two and two together. Her separation anxiety was intrinsically linked to Catra.

The scars on her right cheek had begun to act as an early warning system for Adora’s mental collapses, the sharp pain cascading through her cheek in ghostly echoes of that fateful day next to the Salineas Seagate every time the pressure began to overwhelm her. So far, she had been able to hide herself away whenever it flared up, but she was acutely aware that eventually someone would catch on, and the whole façade would come crashing down - but that was a problem for future Adora.

Part of her mind had started spouting radical theories to Adora, theories which she had discounted at first as just that, the radical part of her mind screaming out for attention. Things like Catra being secretly on the Rebellion's side, that Catra had always been a rebel agent, things that made no logical sense when she gave them even an ounce of her attention.

All but one.

It had been giving Adora an unreasonable amount of grief, especially since she had paid it attention. It just wasn't right - wasn't possible. Catra was her *enemy* .

But, eventually, she had to admit that there might be something behind it.

Adora *liked* Catra.

The realisation had come during a very brief encounter a few days prior. A passing glance during a recon mission with Glimmer (who Angella had forced Adora to go with after something about 'fooling about' with Bow whilst on a mission, Adora didn't understand), had revealed that the Horde was stepping up their logging operations on the edges of the Whispering Woods, but had made no real progress into the densely packed forest. What it *had* revealed was that Catra was personally overseeing the project.

Or at least, that is what *Glimmer* gathered, Adora was too busy staring at Catra for *strictly* tactical reasons.

*.. That outfit... That's not fair... Why does Catra get to look so... So **good** ... I'm stuck as a dorky looking Princess in a Tiara and she gets to wear **that** ..*

The mortification had set in once Adora played the words back in her head, her carefully constructed reasoning coming crashing down in a heartbeat, leaving her struggling for any sort of mental flotsam to cling onto, to keep herself above the water for the time being. Getting home had been as easy as asking Glimmer to take them back, and Adora had retreated to her room almost immediately, locking the door and letting the floodgates open.

Her pillow had other uses.

"For the Honour of Greyskull!"

The room was filled by a deafening silence, a brief twinkle of light dancing at the blondes fingertips, but ultimately resulting in a whopping total of no physical difference to the room or its occupants. The two women, one tangible and standing with her arm stretched skywards, vainly clutching at the air to search for

something inside her, the other a flickering hologram standing beside the blonde, a strained expression on her face.

Yet that was to say it made no difference, indeed it had already made perhaps the greatest impact on the blonde that it possibly could. The flame of hope burning inside her - a hope that kept driving her forwards, kept fighting in the face of ever increasing, insurmountable odds, the hope that held together a fractured and frayed alliance of self serving Princesses and the hope that was supposed to lead Etheria to balance and order - the dim flame, that had been waning for weeks and months, was quashed in an instant.

Dejection sank in, the arm that was once proudly held skywards instead falling limply to the blonde's side along with her expression. *This is hopeless - this will never work. I've wasted months trying to do this. I've failed Mara, Etheria.. The rebellion.. I even failed Catra.*

"Adora.." Mara's voice was cautious and tender, the woman hovering in Adora's peripheral vision as the blonde stared emptily ahead, the hollow feeling in her chest coming back as she felt the energy of the Warrior Princess slink away from her, leaving a gaping cavity inside her. Doubt and insecurity rushed to fill the gap, leaving the blonde feeling utterly miserable and drained of any and all drive or energy.

The blonde's knees gave way and she sank to the ground, the scars on her cheek throbbing as the forewarning for another bout of anxiety and panic, but at this point the blonde didn't even had the *drive* to push herself back to her feet, let alone get away from Mara to the point that she could conceal her weakness. What was

the point, Mara could see her regardless - Hope had been watching her for her entire life. Mara probably just expected her to push through it.

"Adora!" Very real hands enveloped the blonde, catching her and preventing her from tipping over. Mara's voice was full of surprise and panic and carried with it a tenderness that scythed through the well of insecurities brimming inside the blonde, a metaphorical light in the dark. Through the haze fogging her mind, a single thought broke through.

*Mara is **holding** me...*

Slowly, the blonde's vision refocused itself, turning her head slightly to look to her right, at the tanned woman who was holding the blonde tenderly, with concern plastering her visage. Her body was warm to the touch and she appeared *almost* human, but there were a few little tip offs, things that didn't seem proper, like the brunette's long braid not being affected by her movement. Not that the blonde's focus was on that, her focus was instead on the simple fact that Mara was *physically* holding her.

That seemed... Almost impossible - Mara was confined to the system which she lived in, she was a hologram and the memories of a dead woman, not a physical being. Adora had no clue as to how Mara actually managed to do what she had done, but...

In all honesty, she didn't *care.*

The tanned woman closed her eyes for a moment, a pregnant pause hanging in the air before the brunette inhaled sharply, eyes changing from concern to sorrow in a heartbeat. Adora's mind clocked on in a heartbeat. Mara had just done something - seen something that Adora had been hiding. She knew how *weak* the blonde was. How she had failed Mara, failed Etheria-

Adora's self loathing was silenced in a heartbeat as Mara pulled Adora *closer* to herself, burying Adora's face into the brunette's shoulder in a motion that brought the blonde an inexplicable amount of *comfort* . The warmth, the sensation of *love* and *affection* , the embrace of a matronly figure in her life - who would be there no matter what had happened, and would continue to care for her no matter what.

Shadow Weaver may have been her mother figure, but she had been an abusive, cruel and manipulative witch, someone who had provided none of the things that Adora had *craved* her entire life. She had only given the ghostly appearance of caring, pretending to give whilst putting as little energy into helping Adora develop as possible. Her abuse had *stunted* Adora's emotional development.

Adora had a problem with someone? They were *removed* from her life. Adora was at fault for something? No, it was the other person's fault. This is what happens to those who act out of line Adora, take note.

And so she stayed in silence, letting her own troubles internalise for fear of getting someone else hurt.

"Don't suffer in silence Adora.. Let it out. It's so much easier to let it out." Mara's soft voice brought stinging tears to Adora's eyes and a lump to Adora's throat, something that she could not swallow down no matter what she tried. A strangled sob clung in her throat, dying in an uncomfortable noise that the blonde could not care less about how it sounded.

And now Mara was giving *everything* that Adora had ever craved. A person that didn't care if she was weak, if she had problems that needed dealing with. She was the matronly figure that Adora never had, the older sister that Adora had secretly craved all her life, a woman to understand her troubles with, to share her secrets with and to go to with her woes for advice.

She was the antithesis of Shadow Weaver. Mara would never hurt her friends for Adora's mistakes.

The first tear fell and the next one came *so* much easier as years of pent up anxiety and fear came forth in a deluge. A wail of grief and loss and fear and love and hate filled the air as the blonde entered a total emotional breakdown.

Chapter End Notes

> Worry not - the appearance of Mara in physical form will be explained later on, but for those who want an explanation now - its similar to what Light Hope was capable by creating spiders.

Catra VI

Chapter Notes

> AN: I probably enjoyed writing the bulk of this chapter the least out of any part since the opening chapters where I conformed to the general plot of the show. I guess it might be just that I feel my creativity is being stifled? The final scene was far more enjoyable and it was purely my work, so I guess it might be.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Some things were not truly natural.

Some things in the universe were constants, things that must always happen and things that would never change.

One such constant was Shadow Weaver and her lack of a heart. Well, that was not strictly true to be fair, she had a heart but it just.. Didn't originally belong to her - Catra had spent many a recovery session thinking about that morbid trophy preserved on the walls of the room adjacent to the Black Garnet Chamber.

It'd be more amusing if she wasn't such a horrible person.

Catra had long since thought that Hordak was another one of those constants - the man was always in some kind of foul mood, always lurking in the shadows and brooding about in his 'Sanctum' as he called it. If he had been searching for the most pretentious word to call his lab and whatever else was in there, Catra

reckoned there were few words in the language that screamed 'I want people to think I am important' than friggin *sanctum.*

Regardless, Hordak was protective of his *sanctum* to the extreme and would regularly take out his rage on the trespassers with various forms of punishment - usually in through the vicious medium of Shadow Weaver's sadistic side - that is unless, of course, they had a *very* good reason for being there. Usually, the people Hordak sent *specifically* to Shadow Weaver didn't come back alive *if they were lucky.*

The unlucky ones *survived.*

Catra had read the medical examinations once she became Force Commander - out of morbid curiosity at first, then shifting to morbid intrigue and finally morbid reluctance as she consumed each file she could get her hands on. She was acutely aware that this sort of punishment could befall her if she didn't do a good enough job, and so reading the extent of the torture that the Witch had inflicted on those unlucky enough served as a motivation. Plus it gave Catra more knowledge of Shadow Weavers capabilities, and when your opponent is capable of magic like the Witch, you have to be ready for everything.

Naturally, Catra had taken every care to make sure that none of these things occurred to her, although reading some of the survivor accounts made it fairly clear that Catra's nightmares, that usually brought her back to the various torture sessions she had endured throughout her life, would only be getting *more* fuel.

Still, Catra was aware that no one - with perhaps the absolute, sole expectation of Shadow Weaver herself - really deserved a fate like that.

Which is why she nearly had a fucking *heart attack* watching Entrapta quite casually *waltzing into Hordak's Sanctum.*

Her mind raced at the sight and the implications it carried, rooting her to the spot and locking up her body. If Entrapta got caught, she would certainly get herself killed, it would probably get Catra admonished harshly at the very fucking least, and at most she would suffer the same fate as those who had become the reports she had trawled out of morbid curiosity. And she had a feeling Shadow Weaver would be extra careful to make sure she endured the absolute worst scarring possible, both mental and physical.

And she'd ensure Catra survived and *felt* ***all*** of it.

The paralysing *fear* that shot through her body was a sensation that she had only felt in a few, distinct circumstances in her life and all linked to the one figure who loomed over this situation too. *Shadow Weaver* .

A deep inhale through her nose was interrupted with shivers running down her spine, turning her inhale ragged and choppy as the sensations rushed through her body as she tried to control the damage, exacerbated by the mental scars of her youth. Her hands curled into tight fists, the tips of her claws pressing into her palms almost painfully as she exhaled forcefully, controlling her

breathing through sheer force of will, flexing her hands open, then closed again, only to open them once more.

Breathe in..

Breathe out.

In.

Out.

Go in. Get Entrapta out before Hordak notices .

A tentative step forwards was accompanied by a deep exhale as the inhibitions and nerves were shoved down, in their place a single thought rising up. *Why the fuck am I risking so much for a* ***Princess..***

Her mind spat the response a second later, one that sat comfortably, if not... Completely. *Because I'll get the blame.*

She hesitated on the threshold to the open room, her foot raised, poised to step into the forbidden chamber in an instant. The air on her back was cool, it tasted fresh in comparison to the stuffy, stagnant air of the Sanctum in front of her, the room engulfed in

darkness, bar the single beam of weak sunlight blazing in through the large window, catching dust in its rays. For that single instant, the easy way out lay behind her. To simply turn around, to run away from danger.

It was *so* tempting, and she could feel her willpower draining away into her feet, with terror creeping into her chest and tightening its decrepit hands around her throat, slowly constricting and snatching away her breath. She could tell she had made a mistake the moment she hesitated, and now her composure was compromised by the mistake.

I am better than this. We all make sacrifices, I can't afford to sacrifice Entrapta. She is still useful..

No.. That didn't sit right either, a frown tugging its way onto Catra's lips as her mind shifted focus to pondering what *would* sit right. That was all she needed - a mental distraction to keep her mind occupied as her feet shifted forwards, over the threshold and into the room.

She was inside.

Entrapta wasn't hard to find - she was standing, if you could call being suspended mid air by your own *hair* acting as a giant set of extra legs *standing* , nearby, peering at.. Whatever the hell it was that was suspended inside one of the foul looking tanks of green fluid. All that Catra could tell was that the tanks were evidently not completely airtight, and there was a truly *foul* odour seeping from at least one of them.

" *Entrapta!"* Catra's voice was a low hiss as her eyes and ears darted about, scanning absolutely every inch of the room for any sort of sign of the man who would probably turn the feline into a set of *mittens* if he found her here. Quite handily for her part, Entrapta was paying... Absolutely *zero* attention to Catra, instead staring quite intently at the object floating in the tank.

I'm already in here, no harm in going deeper..

Glancing left, then right, the feline inched further into the room, warily approaching the Princess as she continued to observe the object in the tank without a care in the world. The feline sharply inhaled - this was taking far too long, and the Princess still was not hearing her repeated calls of her name.

A trio of long and quick strides brought Catra up to the Princess's side, the feline grabbing her shoulder as a rage built inside her - this was going to get them both killed. Hissing, Catra glared at the Princess now looking at her. " *Entrapta* ! What the *hell* are you doing in here!"

This finally got the Princess's attention. Unhelpfully, she responded *as loud as she seemed to be capable of* . "Oh! Hi Catra-"

Catra's hand slammed down over the Princess's mouth with a clap, muffling the rest of her words as Catra hurriedly glanced around, praying to whatever god may or may not exist that

Hordak or someone else had *not* heard Entrapta practically *scream* her name. Whatever confidence she had drained in a *heartbeat* as her body was flooded with terror that sunk deep into her chest, forcing her back, pulling Entrapta away from whatever she was looking at and dragging her with her, backpedalling into the shadows and into concealment.

Silence hung heavy in the air, the stagnant air feeling oppressively heavy upon her shoulders as she waited those few, dreadful seconds in pure silence, ragged breaths rocking her chest as she nervously glanced at every moving shadow in the room. Each second dragged by, each eye movement becoming slower and slower as the terror continued to mount inside, piling up deeper and deeper as she and Entrapta huddled in the shadows of the Sanctum, waiting for the worst to happen, and for them to be discovered.

Time became impossible to keep track of, Entrapta eventually breaking Catra out of her stupor by pulling the feline's hand away from her mouth with a strand of hair, looking up at Catra curiously. "What're you so worried about? Ooh! Is Shadow Weaver trying to kill you for something again?"

The mention of the Witches name twitched Catra's head to stare at Entrapta, whose expression shifted when she met Catra's gaze. To be fair, Catra's snapped response to Entrapta was perhaps not all that deserved. " *What?* No! You're not meant to be in here!"

"Oh! I know, but I saw this!" Entrapta's previously normal volume shifted to one that was horribly loud and Catra winced, her ears flattening to her head in a reflexive motion that unhelpfully killed most of her acoustic awareness. The Princess's hand rose,

pointing at the tank that she had been staring at before Catra had pulled her away, and the feline's eyes could not help but follow, only to abruptly stop on the tank, or rather, its contents.

There was something floating in the tank.

".. Curious, isn't it?" Entrapta's voice cut through the fixation that Catra had with the tank. The object floating in the tank looked small, almost bat like, with a bulbous head and *wings* . It looked like that thing that always was following Hordak around in his throne room, the imp that sat on his shoulder, just more deformed and almost like a.. Mutation.

But Hordak already had an Imp... And this one looked so similar. Was this a.. Copy? A *clone?*

What the hell is this?

".. Yeah.." For the first time in a while, Catra found herself somewhat lost for words, staring at the odd creature suspended in animation in front of her. Glancing to the side, she noted the dozen or so other tanks, each seemingly containing the exact same thing in suspended animation. *Seriously, what the fuck is this..*

Something I shouldn't be gawking at like Adora, we need to get out before Hordak finds us here..

Turning to the Princess, Catra vocalised this opinion. "Entrapta, we need to go before-"

Silence cut through the air as Catra's words died on her lips, staring at the space next to her where Entrapta *should* have been, instead only finding a void occupied by the stagnant air of the Sanctum. The initial panic began to creep back in, but the Princess had not gone far.

Unfortunately, she had walked up to the device sitting in the middle of the room and had begun to *tinker with it* .

Catra nearly *whined* , although she would never admit it.

Whatever the device was, the podium sitting in the middle of the room that it sat perched upon certainly made it seem exceptionally important, yet on its own it looked rather incomplete, like a part of it was missing, or had yet to be added to the project. Whatever it was, Catra had decided that she couldn't care less - that their lives were more important than whatever Entrapta was doing.

Unfortunately that was when a gravelly voice broke the silence. " *What* are ***you*** doing in **here** ."

Catra's blood turned to ice as she wheeled about, placing herself in front of Entrapta and staring at the man with glowing red highlights standing in the doorway to one of the many side rooms. Although his body was wreathed in shadow, Lord Hordak's mouth was visibly curled into a crimson sneer as he stared at the duo of idiots standing in front of whatever he had just been working on.

Catra swallowed, the uncomfortable lump in her throat hanging there irritatingly despite her best efforts to force it down.

Lord Hordak was a completely unknown factor. Catra had always planned for fights with the Force Captains, or at worst, Shadow Weaver herself, and she knew what each of them was capable of, but Lord Hordak.. Catra had never seen him doing much of *anything* , and she had no clue how he would do as a fighter, but that was not to say she was just going to roll over and let him sentence her to a horrific fate.

She was half way through the process of shifting into a combat stance when Entrapta quite merrily jumped between them, half stunning Catra with her action, then completing the work with her words. "Hi Hordak! Catra was just trying to get me out - I don't think she knew that I'm your lab partner."

Catra's claws slid back into their sheathes as Lord Hordak's anger seemingly fizzled out in a heartbeat - something that Catra barely noted, more caught up on the fact that Entrapta had referred to him as just 'Hordak,' and he *hadn't* obliterated her. Past that trip up, Catra was then caught on the second part of the statement that Entrapta had just spat out, unable to suppress the confusion. "Lab Partner?"

This seemingly kicked the man back into metaphorical gear, clearing his throat and in turn, bringing back the confident and cool voice of the man that Catra had become so familiar with respecting/being scared to death of. "Yes. I am working, Force Commander Catra - With Entrapa's assistance."

The feline blinked as the information ran through the mental gears, eventually processing in her head. Unhelpfully, Hordak then continued and clogged the gears with an influx of uncharacteristic information.

"Whilst your interruption was well intentioned, Force Commander, Entrapta is to be allowed unlimited access to this room unless I specifically state otherwise, do I make myself *exceedingly* clear?" The cruel lint at the end of his words told Catra that the man had not, in fact, hit his head and woken up with a totally new personality that the feline would have to learn, indeed the old Lord Hordak was certainly lurking under the façade that he was probably putting on for Entrapta's sake, and Catra would have to navigate that.

It was easiest to just nod and to bow her head to show she understood. The man seemed fairly satisfied by the whole ordeal, and made one last comment. "Be prepared for a new assignment, Force Commander. You may go."

With a flick of his hand, Lord Hordak dismissed her, and Catra got the *fuck* out of that room before he changed his mind, leaving Entrapta behind with the man who she had sparked a colossal (if not rather terrifying and unreadable) change in.

"So... Hordak just.. Let you go? Like that?"

Catra groaned, resisting the urge to drag her claws down her face. The feline had retreated to *her* spot for a reason, and somehow the ashen haired scorpion had managed to find out where exactly that was, and was now speaking up at her from a balcony some half a dozen metres below her.

For the fifth time since the conversation started, Catra stared down at the woman and snapped out her increasingly annoyed response. "Yes. I told you this already. He just.. Let me go."

"But *why?* That's not like Hordak.. Or, what we know of him. Don't see him much, do we?" With an oversized pincer resting on her chin (Catra didn't look, she just *knew* that Scorpia would be doing that right now), Scorpia pondered the revelation that had been revealed to her for the fifth time.

"I dunno - all I know is that Entrapta is a lot closer to him than we are." The words leaving Catra's mouth were familiar, themselves a repeat of similar phrases uttered recently, but as she gazed into the softly glowing light of the day moon as it sunk beyond the horizon, her thoughts shifted. Moving without direction, without her usual level of self control (as that was frayed by the harrowing experience of the day), her mind wandered to the girl who she had once been close to.

Of course I'm thinking about her now..

Her arms unconsciously came up to hug herself, trapping the warmth of the moonset on her skin and her uniform, the feline basking in the last of the moon's glow as it slowly sank beyond the horizon. Her body was craving contact - a hug, a gentle bump, something, anything.

She recognised what it was - it was like the aftermath of the torture sessions, where Catra was mentally and physically spent, and Adora would always nurse her back to health. This had never happened since Adora left because Catra was promoted *out* of Shadow Weaver's jurisdiction relatively swiftly, but now here she was, falling back on old habits that made her weak.

But she couldn't shake the feeling - the desire to experience physical contact.

And so she descended from her perch, landing next to the ashen haired woman and, completely and utterly mortified, opened her arms and closed her eyes. Thankfully Scorpia, the angel that she was, asked no questions and simply gave what Catra wanted. Sure, the hug left her feeling warm, secure - but this was more.. Friendly, almost a sort of older sibling sort of hug.

Catra's stomach shifted and her chest tightened as she pulled away. It just *wasn't* the same - It didn't carry the same level of.. Affection.

Glancing back out at the moon slowly slipping beyond the horizon, a single thought crashed through, one that never would have made it past her mental blocks if they were fully intact.

I want Adora back..

The feline was unable to suppress the feeling that it was a turning point in her life.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra is seriously shaken up by the encounter with Hordak and - as such - is acting out of normal character, with thoughts that she would never have otherwise considered coming to the forefront of her mind. We saw in the last chapter that Adora has begun to realise that she is feeling some sort of tug towards Catra when she was suffering a breakdown, and now it has taken an event that rocked Catra for her to start realising that she wants Adora back.
>
> As for the naming conventions with Hordak, Catra starts off referring to him when he isn't present as Hordak - but the moment he appears, she shifts back to calling him 'Lord Hordak' perhaps out of respect or a desire to keep him from killing her. This shifts again back to Hordak when he mellows out, with the exception of when he dismisses her.

Adora IX

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Another day dawned, the thin streams of light breaking through the curtains and planting themselves on the blonde's face in just the right way to irritate the absolute *fuck* out of her eyes, pulling her from her slumber and forcing her to roll over onto her side, face buried in the soft pillow she was currently draped around.

Regrettably, the slight disturbance from the light had done more than enough to kickstart conscious brain function, no matter how lethargic or slumbering it may have been, and this in and of itself gave way to a whole new issue, one that kicked in the walls of Adora's mind and threw her plans of having a decent rest out the window.

The violent, stabbing headache that tore through her mind like a bomb brought forth a groan from the blonde as sudden movement to shield herself from the light inadvertently poured fuel onto the fire that was her migraine, the blonde taking careful and tender movements to find a more comfortable position, whilst not compromising her head. It took time - Adora didn't know how much time it took, but it took more than too long for her tastes - for her to settle her body into a comfortable position, whilst also setting her head comfortably.

But then a whole slew of other, tiny problems flared up.

Her pillow was uncomfortably warm - so the blonde carefully and tenderly raised her head off the pillow, turning it over in fumbled movements that each threatened to disturb her head's carefully poised position. Ultimately, despite hitting the pillow a few times as it hovered, her head came down on the cool side of the pillow's fabric, an unconscious sigh of relief escaping her as she began to relax.

Warmth then flooded her body - an uncomfortable warmth that left her short on breath and restless, filling her with the urge to toss and turn and break free of the heat's grasp. Frustrated limbs moved carefully, working in circles to kick the oppressive blanket off her body, leaving her legs exposed to the crisp morning air that snatched away her breath in a heartbeat, leaving her feeling cold and, unfortunately, wide awake.

Eyes snapped open, the sharp motion causing a small and echoing pain behind her eyes that ultimately was drowned out by the larger, more oppressive pain that wrapped around her head and the back of her neck, suffocating any intelligent thought. Mercifully, the fact that her face was buried in a pillow meant that only a thin strip of light slipped into her eyes, dulled by the fact that Adora's body lay between her and the glowing moon rising over the waters of Castle Bright Moon. Still, it was daylight, and if she wasn't up soon, Glimmer would probably teleport into the room and start screaming about something, and that would be even *worse* .

Legs reluctantly curled up as she vainly tried to suppress the few thoughts that she had crashing around in her head, just hoping for once that she could go back to sleep and rest, but alas it was not to be as even her few thoughts all sang with the same tune - people needed her and her needs could wait.

The same legs swung out with similar reluctance as the girl hauled herself upright, a chorus of agony rising within the confines of her mind, each voice crying to escape the oppressive confines of her head, screaming out its own noise that melded with the symphony of other voices to create an indecipherable cacophony. A moment of hesitation was marked as Adora wobbled backwards and forth, rocking on the balls of her feet as the last of her uncertainty and selfish desire drained away, pushing her forwards onto a steady footing.

The cacophony inside her head began to ebb, draining slowly away as the blonde gingerly went about her normal morning routine, sans the usual exercise she did between waking up and heading outside for breakfast with Bow and Glimmer. One of the voices in her head probably cried out for her to not shirk her exercise like that - it could be the difference between life and death - but for once, Adora let herself be a little selfish. After all, having a worse headache would mean she wouldn't be able to strategise as easily after breakfast at the meeting.

Oh, yeah the strategy meeting... Uhg... Another thing I have to do instead of resting.. Protector of Etheria never sleeps...

*I mean she does. A.. Well, not a **bad** amount of sleep.. Six hours or so is enough.. Right?*

By the time she had dressed herself - an action that took a surprising amount of time when one considered that moving more gently to avoid aggravating the headache meant that the blonde was moving almost comically slow - the screaming cacophony had

retreated into a throb at the back of her head that refused to abate or break no matter how tenderly she moved, or more accurately, no matter how much time she wasted on the usual things.

Resting her hand on the door, Adora slowly drew a breath in through her nose, holding it for a few seconds to balance herself out, then expelled it through her mouth and deflating a little, utilising the momentum to push the door to her room open, stepping through and letting it swing shut behind her slowly. Movement in the corner of her eye alerted her to the presence of the two guards standing outside her door, the blonde only managing to cringe and raise her hands over her ears as their spears raised, then *slammed* down on the polished floors as a sign of respect, but with the force of a *cannon* .

The dull *thud* rang in her ears, the pain in her head flaring as her teeth ground against each other as she cringed through the sharp resurgence of pain in her head, eyes screwed firmly shut as to prevent the sensory overload that would likely have come otherwise. The gesture was meant in respect - but Adora really couldn't care how it was meant, she just wanted to get through this day, preferably without suffering an aneurysm.

Unfortunately, Adora had evidently missed something. And that something was Glimmer.

The familiar wink of Glimmers teleportation in front of Adora pulled her gaze up sharply, a motion that tore whatever expression she was going for off her face, replacing it with a sharp wince that - *mercifully* - shut the Princess up before she shouted anything, her expression shifting from irritation to concern in a

heartbeat. A gentle hand came down on Adora's shoulder, the equal parts disconcerting and familiar sensation of her stomach lurching as they dematerialised washing through Adora as the surroundings shifted from the hallway outside Adora's room to the dining room in a heartbeat.

Adora found herself sinking back into one of the many chairs around the dining table, resting her right hand gently on her forehead and screwing her eyes shut, breathing slowly as if to try and let the jabbing pain in her head wind down into the subtle, dull throb that it had been before. The momentary pain had been nearly blinding, certainly disorienting, and the blonde had felt her feet becoming unsteady beneath her the moment they teleported away.

Movement came on her right, footsteps followed by the noise of someone pouring something into a cup. Opening her eyes a crack, the identity of the person was revealed, rather predictably being Bow, offering her a glass of water with a concerned look plastered on his visage, one that turned into a small, friendly smile. "Try having a drink. You might be dehydrated again."

Taking the cool glass, the outside already starting to condense in the warm atmosphere, Adora raised it to her lips and took a long sip, the cold water sending a shock through her system that did indeed numb the pain of the headache, if only a little bit. Blinking as the pain began to ebb just a little further, Adora's gaze flirted up, then scanned the otherwise empty dining hall, with two adjacent chairs pulled out aside from the one that Bow was sitting on next to her. *Where did Glimmer go?*

"Another headache? This is the third one in two weeks Adora, this isn't normal. Y'know, as much as you say you don't need to, you should really see the court physician." Bow's words were quiet, soft and gentle - three things that the trio had become depressingly familiar with in the past six or so months. These headaches - migraines as the physician had originally told her some few months back - had originally started off happening once every month or so, but as time had gone on, had quickly become more and more prevalent in Adora's life.

Bow's idea was one Adora had heard before, and had become depressingly familiar with just about every single intricacy of how he pronounced those series of words. It was good advice - most of what Bow suggested was fairly sound advice - but Adora just simply could not take him up on his suggestion. Physician Myrtle had made it quite clear three months ago that if the headaches persisted or increased, that Adora was to come back and see her. It was innocent enough, until Adora realised what it could entail.

If Myrtle decided that Adora needed to take some time off to rest, then Adora would be stuck doing nothing. There would be no one to take over the position of War Master for the Rebellion, there would be no one keeping track of all the Horde's movements - the Horde could launch a feint that no one else could see through, meaning the Rebellion could be trapped, or worse, would sit immobile - bunker down and hold the lines whilst the Horde walked in through the gaps and did untold damage.

On top of that, Adora would end up in the position of having to re-learn anything that the Horde did in her absence - and the sheer *stress* of doing that for the first time was an absolute nightmare, one that Adora had no real desire to repeat ever again.

But the real danger lay in if the Horde *figured out* that Adora was out of commission. If *Catra* figured out Adora was out of commission.

It would be all over - Catra would bait whoever replaced Adora into a trap, crush them, then land a decisive blow whilst Adora scrambled to pick up the pieces of the Rebellion. Then the Princesses would once again desert the alliance, the whole thing would crumble, Bright Moon would fall, the rebellion would collapse, the Horde would win and Etheria would be under Catra's thumb, and it would be *all* Adora's fault.

The pain in her head *throbbed* sharply, jabbing directly behind her eyes and drawing the ghost of a wince across her face as agony flashed across her vision in white dots that faded slowly from her view. Momentarily, her body seized up, and she was vaguely aware of the terrifying sensation of being fully conscious, but unable to move herself. Thankfully, this was a fleeting sensation, as Bow's hand came to rest on Adora's shoulder, jolting her back to reality as he moved his head into her downcast vision.

"Hey - Are you doing ok?... Glimmer's gone to call the strategy meeting off - you need to rest." In retrospect, it was truly amazing how just fifteen letters could turn Adora's eyes into orbs the size of dinner plates, but the phrase 'Strategy Meeting' was somewhat more important than it first seemed. This was big - it was the monthly meeting where they figured out what the strategic objectives were for the coming month, and disseminated information to the Rebel cells that operated behind Horde Lines.

PLUS this one was really, really *, really* important - A member of one of the more isolated cells had turned up in Bright Moon specifically for this meeting, and was due to head back tonight. If Adora didn't get her point across regarding her intentions for the cell, it would be *months* before they came asking for orders again, *plus* it would present Bright Moon leadership as either inept, overloaded or just snobbish, and Adora could not afford to be throwing away allies that Queen Angella herself had kept around since the earliest days of the Rebellion.

"No!" The blonde winced at her own outcry, her eyes sliding shut again briefly to conceal the specks of light that danced about her vision irritatingly. Her head throbbed again, but Adora batted the sensations aside and stood up sharply, taking another sip of the water as she did so, to chase off the pain that she could, intent on muscling through the rest. It was her responsibility, her duty - to both the Rebellion, and to Etheria as a whole.

Of course, her confidence was rather marred when she stumbled at the sudden light-headedness, although her footwork was more than enough to keep her on an even and steady footing afterwards - a depressing skill that she had picked up in order to contend with Catra in their many fights. Waving her hand in Bow's general direction, her unconscious grasp of his shoulder to support herself granted her a welcome anchor to the real world as her own world stopped spinning, whilst also having the added benefit of keeping Bow quiet.

"No." Adora repeated herself for the sake of preventing Bow from speaking, and to make sure her point was quite clearly understood. Pulling her gaze up to his, she exhaled and shoved the pain down as deep as it could go, then met his eyes and continued. "We can't afford to skip this one - not with the

representative from the Children of the Woods here. If we skip this, they’re never going to listen to us again.”

Bow's expression was a pained wince - torn between the truth behind Adora's words that appealed to his logical side and his unwavering commitment to duty, but also feeling the pull of his less rational, more emotional side and his concern for his friend's wellbeing. His expression shifted to being visibly torn between his two choices, the high chance that Bow would attempt a halfway-house decision was what Adora was counting on, a bet that paid off almost immediately. ".. Are you *absolutely sure* you're feeling up for this Adora? I don't want you hurting yourself."

I'm used to it by now ..

Of course, she didn't *say* that. That would probably have gotten her sent straight to Physician Myrtle to get her head looked at, and Adora had neither any idea what that would entail doing to her, or how long Myrtle would send her into forced leave for. Summoning the most relaxed expression she could, Adora nodded and put on a faux smile that *probably* didn't convince Bow. "I'll be fine. C'mon, lets go stop Glimmer before she-"

The familiar wink of magic that signified Glimmer's arrival resonated around the room as the Princess appeared, standing next to the duo with her mouth already open to speak before she appeared to catch herself and visibly restarted what she was about to say, likely at a lower volume. "Ok. I've told everyone that we're going to skip today's meeting - Adora, you need to rest."

Bow shot Adora a sidelong look, wearing an expression that told Adora that she was entirely alone in having to plead her case to Glimmer, something that was to be (depressingly) expected of the duo. Moving her own gaze back onto Glimmer's, Adora could already see the gears turning in the Princesses head as she clocked onto what exactly was going on. Judging by the beginnings of her facial movements, she did *not* look impressed. "Adora-"

"Gimmer." Adora's own voice cut through the Princesses before she could start her rambling, Adora (perhaps a little bit rudely) continuing through with the momentum that more or less forced Glimmer to be silent - although that was not to say it forced her to *look* silent. Her face, eyes and body language more than compensated when it came to conveying her *distinctly unimpressed* mood. "I can't afford to miss this. Not with the Children of the Woods waiting for orders. The headache is already waning" - *lie* - "and I'll just need something to eat. It should die down fully afterwards." *Another lie..*

For a few seconds, Glimmer stood there, staring at Adora in an attempt to force her way through the blonde’s façade that she had put up, squinting in an attempt to throw off Adora by morphing her face into an unexpected expression, although to no avail. Adora *knew* what would be coming, there were only so many poses you could pull your face into before it started to get expected.

But then Glimmer's gaze softened to one of reluctant acceptance - almost disappointment - as she broke her stare off and gave a soft sigh, shaking her head slightly and murmuring something. Too late the realisation clocked - Glimmer had been staring at her eyes. Eyes that - when Adora turned her head just a little to gaze

at the mirror on the wall, to avoid both giving away what she was doing and to avoid spilling any more fuel onto the smouldering throb of pain in her head - looked distinctly *tired* , almost bloodshot and wearing dark rings around their edges, with just a flicker of pain hidden behind the surface.

... Glimmer saw right through me..

The other girl set her hand on Adora's shoulder gently, giving a soft squeeze and a softly spoken reply. "You're too selfless, Adora. You don't have to do everything."

There was a slight curl to the last word. A light beat of irritation permeating the request, one that somewhat ruined the otherwise wholesome plea and that sat distinctly uncomfortably within Adora's mind. *I'm She-Ra.. It's my* ***job*** *to* ***protect*** *Etheria. It's only because I wasn't doing my job that the Horde got as far as they did. Not going to happen again..*

Adora swallowed uncomfortably as she nodded her reply to Glimmer's comment, the Princess stepping back and pausing for a moment, ruining the wholesome scene by groaning loudly and rolling her head back. "Guuuhg. *Great!* Now I have to go find everyone *again* ."

With a familiar wink, the Princess of Bright Moon was gone, yet the impact of her brief time lingered. Bow's expression, barely visible out of the corner of her eyes, was a reluctant mask of concern, with a slightly hurt expression lurking beneath the

surface as he looked in her direction, driving her own focus onto inflection. Clearly, he didn't approve.

*.. Should I keep lying to them? I don't **need** to share my troubles.. I shouldn't. It just weighs them down.*

Her gaze flicked to Bow, who broke their eye contact after a moment in favour of paying attention to the breakfast that was coming up from the kitchens as Adora thought, the tempting smells of freshly cooked food scrambling much of her conscious thought as the scents assaulted her senses. One final thought lingered as the blonde selected a particular piece of toast to adorn with just about any topping she could find.

They don't like me hiding my issues... Why do I then?..

The Bright Moon War Council was a critically important Rebellion asset, and dealt with critical information of vital importance and sensitivity to the Rebellion, and so it was held in rooms under high security. Usually, it was held in the War Room that dated back to the First Princess Alliance, guarded by dozens of Bright Moon's Elite Royal Lunar Guards, led by General Juliette.

So naturally it was only made up of the elite. On one hand, you had the Princesses of the most powerful Kingdoms across Etheria, each of whom were some of the most powerful combatants on the planet and who possessed potent magic. On another, you had

the Queen of Bright Moon, who held authority over vast stretches of land, and who was a powerful rallying point. Then there were the non elemental Princesses, Netossa and Spinnerella, whose allegiances lay with the Queen of Bright Moon, along with the head of the Sorcerers guild, Castaspella. And on yet another, you had the non magical experts, the head of the Royal Guard and the Rebellion's tech master.

Then there was the Rebellion's army, an elite militia of soldiers from across Etheria who harassed Horde outposts and attacked isolated Horde elements, forcing them to devote more and more resources to the pacification of the countryside. This ultimately resulted in brutal crackdowns that drove more and more people to the Rebellion's ranks as a result. These forces themselves were trained by officers in the professional army defending Bright Moon, raised from the citizens of the area.

And finally, you had Adora - She-Ra, Princess of Power, War Master of the Rebellion, Former Horde Officer and prophesied hero who would 'Balance' Etheria.

Look any closer, and the cracks began to *rapidly* show.

Half the people on the War Council were under the age of 20, including Adora herself, which made the decision making *questionable* given their relative immaturity, not to mention the *ethical* issues regarding the use of child soldiers in their war against the Horde. On top of that, half of the adults were avowed pacifists, who would rather solve their issues with their words as opposed to their fists, something all well and good - if it were not for the fact that they were fighting a *war* .

Of the final five, three were directly subordinate to the Queen of Bright Moon and could not actually do much in the practical sense of the world, and one was a moody twenty-something who spent most of her time complaining about something or rather, and couldn't summon the enthusiasm to entertain anything that didn't directly benefit herself, and the final one was a Sorcerer whose allegiances lay mainly with the Sorcerers guild and Mystacore.

Not to mention that, whilst the entire War Council was close to each other in terms of friendship, they were all limited by the fact that they were directly tied to their own runestones and their own Kingdoms, meaning that their ultimate loyalties lay with their land. Whilst Adora did not doubt for a second that anyone would betray the Rebellion for the Horde, it did mean that there were always ulterior motives driving the Princesses.

That, and they *constantly* bickered. Turns out, placing three Princesses with *extremely dominant* personalities and telling them to work together as equals under Adora did *not* go well most of the time, and there were usually at least half a dozen arguments regarding movements of troops and strategic objectives for the upcoming month. There were usually more arguments, but only about half a dozen were actually on the *topic* of the war.

Then there was the Army.

Oh *stars,* the Army.

To begin, the professional Army was small, enough to defend the Castle should it come under siege by the Horde, but nowhere near enough to match the Horde on the frontlines that spanned across the whole of Etheria. As a result, its other major flaw had developed.

It hadn't seen combat in nearly a decade, since the death of King Micah, when the Rebellion had made a near total withdrawal from the frontlines and offensive operations.

As a result, what had once been an elite fighting force had fallen out of shape, being practically demobilised and with the citizens living with their families on nearly a week's readiness alert. Not to mention, the force was still trained in tactics nearly a decade old, which would leave them critically vulnerable to the Horde of the modern day.

The only consolation was that the Horde was *similarly* lacking in tactics after a decade of minimal fighting.

And then there were the militias.

On paper, the sheer numbers involved would be enough to cripple the Horde and force them back on all fronts, overrun the Fright Zone and kick the Horde off into the Great Ocean.

In reality, these were poorly trained and disjointed groups of partisans who made opportunistic attacks out of their own,

somewhat selfish, desires to capture Horde equipment or provisions for personal gain, or to liberate certain things or places - often demobilising afterwards. Coupled with their relatively minimal contact with the wider Rebellion as a whole, these small groups began to seem more and more like a liability as every second passed.

Indeed, a number of these cells had been so cruel and vicious in their attacks that they had invited the Horde's direct attention, and had resulted in brutal reprisals against the civilian populaces that they had ostensibly liberated - just to send a very clear message that force would be met with force.

Adora still had nightmares about the sights occasionally returning to disturb her slumber.

But even so, these cells were part of the Rebellion, and as a result they ultimately bowed the knee to the Queen of Bright Moon - Adora suspected that they only obeyed her because they saw her as a conduit for the Queen's will. As part of the Rebellion, they would occasionally have to report in to Bright Moon for further orders, and Adora had begun to take the chance to give these isolated cells as much to do as possible before they reported in next - these were some of the best of the Rebellion after all, and if they could be essentially strong armed into being part of Adora's strategy, she'd do it.

But it was significantly harder to encourage the small cells to cooperate when Mermista and Frosta were arguing over the middle of the war table, voices rising steadily in volume with every passing second whilst Bow practically held Glimmer back from getting involved, all whilst Angella stared serenely forward,

although this mask of calm was disrupted by her left eyebrow repeatedly twitching downwards, threatening to dive as she fought to keep it level. The rest of the table was little better.

Perfuma was busy messing about with some plant that looked like it could bite someone's hand off and would be quite content to do so, the envoy from the Children of the Woods was looking increasingly unimpressed with the response to the intel that he had brought with him, and more and more like he was simply going to walk out on them. Normally, Adora would have just tried to explain otherwise, but today, with the lingering effects of the headache reverberating in her mind, she felt like she was about to burst a blood vessel.

The argument raging had become incoherent - tuned out into a dull noise that rung in her ears aimlessly whilst she stared down at the war table, currently looking at a map of the terrain that was to soon play host to a convoy of Horde transports bringing the raw resources that they used to make armour from the Orelonia mines. Frequent attacks from the militia had forced the Horde to resort to larger convoys of supplies and resources in favour of a constant stream, so attacking this would throw a wrench into the Horde's logistics, and would begin to strangle the supplies that they needed to expand their army and continue their conquest of Etheria.

The pressure in her head built, bringing her teeth together and grinding them slowly against each other as she stared at the map, trying to piece together a plan of attack in what little space in her head she felt she had *left* . But the never ending shitstorm just *continued.* Mermista and Frosta *kept yelling* . Her head kept *throbbing* . The room got uncomfortably warm as the internal pressure kept *building* . Her head throbbed *harder* .

The stress broke *something.*

The pink, 3d holographic map of the forest pass flickered violently, momentarily fading out of existence as Adora's clenched fist *slammed* into the table, denting the surface with a loud *thump* that reverberated around the room. The argument and other conversations going on around the table stopped in an instant, and the blonde was acutely aware that everyone was looking at her as she bored hole into the slightly less stable flickering of the hologram, rubbing her eyes with the hand that was not on the table, trying to beat back the sharp resurgence of pressure behind her eyes.

Deep breath in... And out.. In. Out.

".. Adora-" Bow was talking, his words working their way into her head and dispersing through her building plan, like trying to build a house of cards whilst someone opened a window on a windy day. Her head throbbed just a little bit more, her eyebrow twitching in irritation.

"Bow." Her terse snap of his name silenced the boy, an affronted look rising across his visage - something she noted out of the corner of her eye. She'd now offended *both* of her closest friends in the span of one morning, although Bow was unlikely to hold it against her. *This fucking headache...*

Silence hung for a few seconds, before Adora raised her head, taking in the cautious gazes of the rest of the table. Some lent more towards concern, visibly worried about Adora's sudden shift in character such as Angella or Perfuma, whereas others tended to lean towards more annoyed or even fearful - the latter category was occupied solely by Frosta, who looked irritated on the surface, but under that there was a flicker of fear.

"... This is happening when?" Adora broke the silence, her voice as quiet and level as she could manage whilst not giving away her actual condition - Angella would stop her from going if she knew how bad her headache was. The envoy looked up from his stunned silence, glancing upwards at the skylight through which the glowing moon was visible hanging near its zenith in the sky above them. His gaze came back down, pausing for a second before he spoke.

"A few hours." His accent was different, unique and something that Adora reckoned she would have trouble understanding if it was not for the shortness of the statement. Internally, she groaned. Even now she was still coming across new things that she had to deal with. On the outside, she simply nodded sagely and turned her attention back down, muscling through the pain and staring at the gulley that the transports were due to drive through.

More silence.

Glimmer could only take two other people with her at any one time, so it would just be Adora, Glimmer and Bow going on this particular raid, just like normal. A normal raid. It would be easy.

Simple, even. Force the Horde to divert more resources to protecting these convoys.

"We'll stop the convoy, block its path. Bow, can you handle that?" Adora looked at the dark skinned boy and the concerned expression plastered on his face, but despite that, he managed a slow nod, maintaining eye contact with her all the while. Satisfied, she glanced back down at the flickering map, biting her lip as she struggled to think. *How long is this convoy going to be.. Glimmer might have to go after the drivers instead.*

"Glimmer - can you deal with the drivers of the rearmost vehicles?" The phrasing left a lot to be interpreted - it could be entirely innocent, simply getting them out of the way, and that was what Adora was shooting for. They didn't stoop to the Horde's level.

But the brief dark flash on some peoples faces, missed by Adora, left a bit to be considered.

"I'll hit them from the middle - sow chaos and start breaking through their cohesion. Don't let them form up - there's going to be a lot of them.." Adora began to tune herself out as the coil of stress inside her slowly began to unwind whilst she spoke. At this point, all that was left was to simply read off an internal script and she could manage that with her eyes shut.

They don't appreciate it when I share my stress..

In hindsight, resting would have been a *far* better idea.

The high octane stress of fighting on a battlefield was not doing her still present headache any sort of favours, the sharp and violent manoeuvres required to dodge both attacks and various projectiles that went flying about the confined battlefield of the gulley leaving her head feeling like a maraca with her brain bouncing about inside like a punching bag.

She was simply thankful that there was no sort of lieutenant or any real ranking officer present in this convoy. There ought to have been, but she had seen nought but Horde grunts, and Catra had been reported at the village of Thaymor which had fallen to the Horde. Again. For about the fifth time.

Her scatterbrained thought nearly got her shot, the instinctive violent jerk backwards, pulling her head away from the beam of energy that would have otherwise blasted her head off. A sideways twist hurled the Sword of Protection from her grasp, into the front of the tank, curls of green electricity sparking from the point of impact.

The clanking of metal roused her from her focus on the sword, Adora sidestepping backwards to avoid the blast from a bot, then darting forwards, wincing slightly as she moved up against the leg of the bot, picking it up and swinging it like a demented hammer-throw, casting it off into a pair of other machine and watching the ball of flame blossoming out from the pile of machinery.

"Adora!" The cry of her name twisted her head to glance at the source, only to be met with the sight of a Horde grunt leaping at her, arms outstretched and far too close to keep him back. Instinctively, she braced for the impact and her right foot shot back as the grunt hit her side, swinging around onto her back as other grunts began to close in all around her. The tactic was simple: dog pile onto the stronger opponent so that they would be pinned by sheer numbers.

Unfortunately for them, Adora *knew* their tactics.

Grabbing the arm of the grunt on her, Adora hurled him over her shoulder into one of the other grunts, twisting herself about to slam an elbow into another's helmet and keeping herself *moving* to make their grapples harder to achieve. Momentum still going, she swung her fist into another grunt and kicked another aside, stumbling as her head throbbed in an uncomfortable manner, the dull roar of an explosion the culprit as the tank with her sword in it finally detonated in a spectacular fireball.

"You *NEED* to pay more attention Adora!" Gimmer's brief appearance next to her was accompanied by the noise of a grunt being bodily beaten by the staff that had once belonged to King Micah, the soldiers unconscious form collapsing to the road hewn from rock unceremoniously as Glimmer pushed the Sword of Protection into Adora's hands then vanished in a wink of magic.

A new wave of Horde grunts appeared - almost in a comical fashion as they spilled forth from one of the transports, turning and spotting her almost instantly. It was *rather difficult* to go

incognito as a 7 foot tall, glowing lady with a sword dressed in white and gold. Surging forwards, the wave of people and armour came at her at once in a nearly solid wall, weapons in hand.

Another Horde tactic. Numerical superiority wears an opponent down.

Twirling the blade in her hand experimentally, she pointed the blade down and slammed the tip of her sword into the ground, distinctly aware of the surge energy flowing out from her into the ground, raising part of Etheria beneath her and creating a wall of rock that the Horde soldiers had no chance of evading. The noise of rock hitting armour filled the air as Adora twisted back around, although not fast enough.

The jolt of high voltage electricity surged through her body, stiffening her muscles and firing most of her pain receptors in a heartbeat. Her headache *screamed out* in pure agony as she momentarily lost control of her body, eyesight going nearly pitch black as her muscles snapped back into action, the blonde wildly flailing with her sword in an attempt to make the pain stop.

Miraculously it did, vision slowly creeping back as Adora's blade impacted one of the transports she had been standing near. Her hands were slick with something thicker than water, and Adora reckoned she had punctured one of the transport fuel tanks, blinking tenderly as her vision *finally* cleared of the haze that had been clogging it.

Her stomach churned violently and her grip on the Sword of Protection failed as she spotted the corpse of the Horde soldier she had just impaled against the transport, and whose life blood now stained the blade, and the blonde's hands.

Chapter End Notes

A/N:

This is a stress headache - something that Adora would likely suffer from given that she is under an insane amount of pressure from others and herself. Coupled with her Martyr complex, its not surprising that this would occur repeatedly - you just have to watch Season 2's episode 'Roll with it' to see how central she is to the day to day operations of the Rebellion and how everyone else constantly bickers over things.

The delay on getting this out was due to Uni kicking my ass, and also my own experiences with migraines allowing me to provide some personal input on the issue of headaches and the irrational movements that we do to try and alleviate the pain.

Adora X

It was dark outside when her vision came back into focus, the lunar moon hanging in the sky above her balcony quite lazily, almost serenely so, although the blonde felt absolutely none of that serenity as she sat where she had been for.. However long she had been there.

It had been a weird sensation - the complete lack of any sort of memory or coherent thought from the intervening time between the morning and now, nor any indication of how she had returned to her room. Yet she was sitting on the balcony, pants rolled up to her knees and her feet in the basin of the decorative waterfall, staring listlessly ahead.

Her head was a chaotic blur, a complete and utter mess of half thoughts and excuses to herself that wouldn't hold up under any sort of close scrutiny, but which all hung in the void of her mind like ripe fruit on a tree, waiting to be plucked and joined together with some other line to make a convincing whole. And that was without mentioning the phantom ebb of the headache that had slowly eaten itself up, leaving only a fraction of the initial pain behind as a ghostly reminder of the pains of the morning

Her eyes felt dry, and so she closed and opened them. The absurdity of the scenario shot through her - here she was manually ordering body functions.

Normally, Adora would have found that fact amusing in some way.

But she wasn't Adora anymore - the girl who had once slept next to Catra on the bed was dead, she had died with that poor man-

The numbness of the moment returned in force as her limbs lost all sensation as her mind scrambled to keep her nervous system from fully collapsing, instead relinquishing control of her arms and allowing her hands fall into the water basin of the ostensibly decorative waterfall, the water logged hand towel in her grasp floating free of her limp fingers and bobbing gently on the surface of the water. Her eyes had closed, trying to focus on *any* other memory.

Her mind refused to provide another, focusing instead on her hands. Her hands were slick, she could feel them covered in something that made them slide against each other easily. It felt warm, uncomfortable - ***dirty.*** It needed to be cleaned.

The paralysing sensation vanished, and with a newfound vigour the blonde snatched up the hand towel and once again began to scrub her hands clean of the stain that would not budge.

Her hands were raw - coarse cloth had worn down the skin on them. She could still feel the slickness on her hands, the stain that penetrated far beyond the skin that she had already rubbed off. She hadn't done nearly enough to clean it. Her head ached slightly still. It didn't matter - it didn't stop her.

"Hey - Adora." The muted call of her name brought her head around, unseeing eyes focused far beyond the blurry outline of

the person who was sitting there next to her, their own feet in the pool of water that Adora was still scrubbing her hands in.

"Adora." The voice was more terse now, more demanding of attention and had a physical impact now, jabbing her in the cheek with a finger. The hollow jolt of pain that came trickling through her nervous system proved to be enough to pull her eyes into focus, her dull blue orbs locking onto the brilliantly vibrant, by comparison, hazel orbs of the woman with chocolate coloured skin.

"That bad, is it?" The voice was more musing now, the woman with silver-blue hair turning her gaze out over the water below them, the shimmering reflection of the lunar moon glinting off the stagnant surface of Lake Bright Moon, almost entirely undisturbed by the rest of the world. For one fleeting moment, everything was quiet, silent, peaceful.

The noise of the water reminded her that this was not a peaceful or serene moment.

With a frustrated sigh, Netossa grabbed one of Adora's hands, the hand not clutching the hand towel, flipping it over in her grasp and holding it by the wrist, palm facing up. The sharp bolt of pain that momentarily shot through her system brought forth an unconscious twitch in her elbow that bought her momentarily back to lucidity, glancing to the elder woman with recognition, if little else.

“Look at your hands Adora.” The request was more a demand, carrying with it little to no politeness or any pleasantries, just a brusque order to do as the woman said, one that the blonde saw no harm in contradicting-

The paralysing numbness returned in full force as her gaze began to tilt downwards, her slick hands just out of sight, hanging there as her body began to seize - muscles disobeying her mind. Or perhaps they were obeying her mind, and her conscience was being cast adrift from the rest of her body. *What's the point? They're stained - She's going to shame me for that.*

“I said look Adora. Your hands are clean - you're only taking off your own skin.” The words were wrong - Adora could feel the slick warmth on her hands, the stain she needed to clean off if the older woman would *just let her.*

Netossa was surprisingly strong, or perhaps Adora was just so out of focus that the elder woman had caught her completely off guard, but suddenly, Adora was staring at the raw, red skin of the palm of her left hand, her body as stiff as a board.

The blood in her ears pounded, her mouth went dry and her body seemingly forgot how to utilise its motor functions as her eyes bored into her hand. It was still slick - but she could see that it was the water now, not the blood.. *Where... Where did it go?*

A blink brought her back to the battlefield, the muted noise of combat echoing around her as if it was being heard through a wall of pillows. Her own heartbeat hammered in her ears as she

stared, eyes focused on the man as his life slipped through his fingers like grains of sand. He didn't make an attempt to clutch at his chest or out at her for help like so many stereotypes she had read, he just hung there, staring aimlessly down before he sagged a little and stopped breathing.

The sharp impact of something striking her cheek ripped Adora violently back to the real world, pulling her to lucidity once again with a startled cry, only to have Netossa grab both sides of her head and pull Adora's close against hers, their foreheads meeting as the chocolate skinned woman took *all* of her attention. Her cheek *stung* with the other woman's handprint, the slightly heavier impact from where her ring had hit Adora being the epicentre of the pain. But it was good - it gave her something to ground herself on.

"Focus Blondie. You need to focus. You're not the first person whose taken a life, you're not going to be the last." Adora swallowed, the feeling of panic bubbling away inside her gut surging upwards as Netossa spoke, although the blonde didn't actually focus on that. Instead her focus was still on Netossa's words, and the pain on her cheek. *Words. Pain. Focus.*

"You may think that you're doing the right thing, scrubbing off your 'dirty' hands here, trying to hide everything. Im here to tell you the news - there is no cleaning that stain. It sticks with you for the rest of your life. You live with it."

The woman sighed softly and continued in a more reserved tone, a bit softer and less harsh. She pulled away too, but Adora kept looking at her, not wanting to incur the wrath of the elder Princess again. *Words. Pain.*

“I was in your situation once. Looking at him, I thought; well, that’s it, I’ve killed someone.. you're not you anymore. You’ll never be you again.. But then you wake up the next morning, and you're still you. You’re always you..." A pregnant pause as the other woman thought for a moment, before she continued. "Its not easy - living with it. I tried to hide it. Spinny tried to hide it. Angella never tried to hide it. She had it far easier than us. She wore the shame openly. I do to, now. As does Spinnerella. Embrace it Adora. Its easier.”

Adora swallowed, staring at the palm of her hand, gaze sweeping every portion of the raw skin of her palm with a critical eye, looking for even the slightest hint of blood on her hand. *Is she right?… she sounds like knows better.. But.. The others.*

“.. What about the others?”

Netossa frowned at Adora’s question, clearly not expecting it. Regardless, the woman seemingly delved into her mind, if her eyes breaking focus and her teeth gently sinking into her lower lip was anything to go by. Frowning, she paused for a second, mouth open, then responded.

“You mean the rest of the Princess Alliance?-" A barely perceptible nod, answered in kind by another pregnant pause before Netossa continued.

"Mermista has never had a problem with it - Perfuma is a pacifist, Frosta is too young.. But Juliette is a soldier, so its safe to say she has. Bow and Glimmer..." The dark skinned woman's face twisted into a frown, clearly torn between saying something or not. For a heartbeat, Adora felt she was pushing too far, making the other woman say something that she wasn't meant to for the sake of the blonde. Just as she went to push aside the questioning, Netossa continued, forcing the blonde into silence.

"Glimmer has - she didn't take it very well. We had a similar conversation to the one I'm having with you. Difference is, she was...." Netossa went quiet, searching for the words that apparently fell from her mind, but were caught by Adora's, who promptly spat them out.

"Glimmer about it?"

Netossa blinked, before nodding softly. "That's about right. She refused to listen at first, got all self-destructive. Managed to get to Bow's place somehow - an absolute mess apparently, started babbling to him about what she had done. He couldn't make sense of it at first, but eventually managed to calm her down somehow. All I know after that is that Queen Angella brought Glimmer back asleep."

"As for Bow - he was raised as a pacifist in the house of a soldier. I reckon he has killed before, but doesn't take any pleasure in the act, and only does it as necessary."

Adora paused, reflecting on the knowledge that had just been given to her by the elder Princess. It was not the easiest pill to swallow, that was for sure, but the blonde was reasonably... Sated? With the knowledge that she had just been given by Netossa. However, it was the fact that she had just been given the knowledge that had levelled her mind that itself was now her next question.

"How do *you* know all of this stuff?"

The moment she asked, the panic returned as the silver-blue haired woman's calm expression shifted to one that looked affronted. "Uh, because you *always* need a plan, **and** *I'm* the Rebellion's Spy Master?"

The expression of logical acceptance that rapidly shifted to a look of naked surprise on Adora's face only made the other woman's reaction even *more* offended, an exasperated noise leaving her throat. "How does *no one* know this?! I've been the Spy Master for *years* ! ***YEARS!*** "

Gingerly swallowing, Adora's teeth found their way onto her lower lip. She *really* should have known that Netossa did more than just sit there with her wife, but the guilt of the fact that she had never actually *asked* the other woman what she did was.. Definitely present.

Still - she had to give some sort of reply to the silver-blue haired woman, and so adopting the tenderest and most cautious tone she could, Adora carefully gave a suggestion that was unlikely to

cause an *awful* reaction. "Uh.. Maybe its because you just sit quietly and look pretty unless called on?"

A grumbled reply was shot back, the Princess evidently in a huff about the whole situation. "Spinny does the looking pretty.."

The blonde made a light noise of amusement as she stood up, stepping out of the pool of water and wiping down her legs with a waiting towel, leaving the soaked hand towel laid out to dry. Something felt different - like she had to do something today, something pulling her to visit the first woman in her life who dispensed wisdom. She felt.. Not off, more.. Balanced. On an even and blank playing field.

Now would be *perfect* to try summoning She-Ra *without* the sword.

Ignoring the strange look from Netossa, Adora held out her hand and closed her eyes, reaching within herself and clutching the warm energy that pooled in her chest with a practiced ease, that Adora found herself honestly surprised by. She could almost *feel* the sword in her grasp…

But then, of all things, the Warrior Princess inside her pulled away, sliding out through the cracks with an urgency that surprised the blonde, momentarily stripping her sense of balance from her even as her clutch on the energy immediately gave way. Mara’s voice echoed in her head, the same as it always had, but with a profound softness.

'Later. Talk to Mara.'

Adora barely registered Netossa's repeated questions about what the rush was about, rushing through her usual routine and bolting out of the door and to the Bright Moon stables. Sure - she could run to the Crystal Castle, but taking the horse that she had accidentally turned into a rainbow themed unicorn would be far quicker than simply legging it.

Staring at the door slowly swinging shut behind the blonde on a mission, Netossa ran her fingers through her hair, feet still in the basin of the decorative waterfall, sighing in exhausted exasperation. *Kids these days.. I'm getting too old..*

"Mara?"

The sight of the holographic woman waiting for Adora in the confines of the Crystal Castle's antechamber was one that Adora had become surprisingly familiar with during her year or so with her predecessor. And if one was to add the extra six or so months that she had spent with Light Hope, it had become disturbingly common for the blonde to run into holographic women in her day to day life.

Mara was no longer holographic this time however. Instead the almost human, very solid looking Mara was present, standing in the middle of the antechamber on the raised plinth and looking towards the door frame from which Adora had entered the Crystal Castle.

The warm, yet soft smile offered to her failed to conceal a flicker of excitement behind her brown eyes, Mara doing a slow twirl for Adora as she entered, arms held out to allow the blonde a better view of the new body that the woman had constructed for herself. “I think I did a better job this time around, don’t you, Adora?”

The effect was almost flawless this time around, even down to how the long hair braid was affected by the twirl that the brunette had just done for Adora. It was almost impossible to tell that the brunette was not just another person, so effective was the, well, effect. But there were some giveaways - her movements were just a little stiff, especially with the lack of idle motion that humans usually possessed, replaced instead by a unnatural immobility as whatever body she had evidently did not need to maintain normal functions.

More importantly, Mara looked.. Happy. Alive even - although not *actually* alive, more mentally. She was smiling, evidently in a good mood and pleased with herself regarding her work. It wouldn't be good for anyone if Mara slipped into a self loathing depression from which she could not be pulled from, especially considering Adora could not *force* Mara to listen to her.

Perhaps even *more* importantly, or rather to be more accurate, selfishly, Adora was *craving* the information that she had been.. promised? by the Warrior Princess, nervous impatience building

inside her and trickling out of her in the form of her fidgeting hands. Her nerves were already frayed by the conversation she had with Netossa, although to be fair they were completely *shot* beforehand so it was a marked improvement over her previous state. Still, they had the unhealthy habit of spitting out thoughts that rattled Adora's self confidence in ways that made her visibly betray her mental state

Mara.. Wouldn't think less of me for what I've done.. Would she?

Thanks to her self sabotaging train of thought, the Adora could only manage a slightly unenthusiastic response to the woman as her fingers distractedly drummed out a tuneless beat on her thigh. "Yeah - It looks... Almost perfect."

"I've been trying, but its not.. Quite right. These systems are old and learning to make something as natural as a human body with them..." Evidently, her internal darkness had been too prevalent in her voice, as Mara's excited expression shifted to one of concern after a few seconds as her mind registered what the blonde had said, her voice trailing off as she registered Adora's expression and demeanour, stepping down off the plinth and moving down the blondes level.

Cautiously, the brunette rested a hand on Adora's shoulder, something that the blonde almost *leant* into in the wake of the comforting squeeze that she received as Mara's concerned brown orbs stared into Adora's own baby blue eyes. Hazel stared into ocean blue, asking a silent question that received an equally silent, yet clear and distinct response to its questioning.

The hand left Adora's shoulder, the shame of the simple revocation of the action coming crashing down on her shoulders as self doubt sat poised to pour into the newly opened cavity within the blonde. Eyes squeezed shut as emotions preceded the rush, only to find them cut off by Mara fully embracing Adora in a warm and comforting hug - eliciting a half sob from Adora as emotion choked all other forms of communication.

"It's ok - Adora. It will always be ok. Breathe."

Unconsciously, Adora's own hands found Mara's sides, brushing forearms behind the brunette's back and holding the older woman against her like her life depended on it, as if she would pull away otherwise and be lost forever. That limited love that Catra had always believed in. Had been *made* to believe in.

Suddenly, Adora could see where she was coming from.

The realisation did *not* help her emotional stability.

Gently stroking the back of Adora's head, Mara simply held the blonde close to her, allowing her to vent all of the emotions that she needed to in a deeply maternal action that made Adora feel safe and *secure* , more than she ever had before. It was probably a win-win for the woman, but Adora really was *not* in a position to complain, nor did she feel the desire to.

She didn't know how long she stood there, nor did she have even a remote idea - yet she was pulled out of her mindless embrace by Mara's voice softly ringing in her ears.

"Everyone is born of Etheria, and ultimately everyone will return to it. She-Ra is Etheria, and Etheria is She-Ra. You are She-Ra. You are Etheria. You don't fail being She-Ra if you kill someone, Adora." The words brought Mara just a little further into Adora's clutches, eliciting a soft chuckle of fond amusement from the brunette as she let Adora find solace in hugging her. "Now.. Why else are you here?"

The simple act of just hearing the words from Mara's mouth brought Adora far more comfort than they had any right to do, knocking out most of the supports that were holding up the bastion of dark thoughts regarding the events of that day and removing a far greater load from Adora's mind. The blonde sagged a little, apparently sighing in relief loud enough for Mara to hear if the soft chuckle was anything to go by.

".. I need to talk.. Uh.. *She* told me to come talk to you.."

Stepping back from the brunette, Adora reluctantly let go of the comfortingly maternal embrace she had been in, trying to resist the urge to hug herself to trap the warmth and sense of security that she felt now. Holding her hand out, Adora paused, glancing down at it for a moment before looking up towards Mara, seeking the gratification and confirmation, or perhaps was it the *permission* , that she felt she needed.

"About what? Summoning her?" A soft nod was the brunette's answer, the woman in question exhaling audibly as she thought to herself, casting her gaze off into the unseen distance, evidently curious about what the blonde was telling her. Ultimately, she shrugged, looking back at Adora. "I don't know what she's talking about.. Try it, summoning her."

Taking a deep breath, Adora turned herself and held out her hand, slowing her breathing until the point that she could find a centre on herself, a place of internal calm and balance. Then it was her mind, closing her eyes and wiping away what few thoughts that were still in her head, instead finding that calm, quiet place and then, and only then, once all else was done, Adora reached out and grasped the energy within her.

"For the Honour of Greyskull!"

For a moment, Adora felt it. That familiar surge of energy that came with becoming the Warrior Princess, the limitless power that spilled out from within, filling her body with that raw *power* . She could *feel* the handle of the sword in hand, clutching it tightly and... Faltered momentarily.

"Through the Sword Adora!" Mara's elated cry cut through her faltering panic, the blonde instinctively doing as told, realisation crashing into her like a wave. The sword normally did this, so why would it be any different now.

Flooding the sword with the power of the Princess felt natural. Proper even.

But then it all went wrong.

A voice echoed from her memory, sounding like it was a scant few centimetres from her right ear, the ghostly, tender touch of another person on her shoulders. That voice, a gentle, tender and *beautiful* voice so packed full of love and affection that it filled Adora's stomach with butterflies, was one that Adora would know anywhere. One that she desperately *craved* to hear again. Just once. " *Hey, Adora~"*

Her clasp on the power inside her crumbled like a dam giving way, the power surging through her weakened hold and cascading throughout her body unchecked. She could feel the Warrior Princess telling her off with characteristic sass, almost saying 'I told you so.'

She knew what had given way immediately, it was rather hard not to know because it *hurt so much.* It was the one part of her that she had chosen not to face, to not accept because lying to herself was so much easier. If she could not be true to herself, then how could she be true to the people of Etheria?

The sword winked from existence, fingers that were firmly clutching the hilt a half second prior instead curled into a fist as the energy receded rapidly, leaving Adora feeling completely exhausted and totally unable to support herself. Adora’s legs crumpled, dropping her into an awkward pile that saw the blonde's chest heaving, sucking in great lungfuls of air to steady her racing pulse.

Mara was beside her almost instantly, arms wrapped around Adora in a sudden, tight and maternal hug. A chest wracking sob cut through the air, and it was only then that Adora became aware that she was *bawling* , fat tears streaming down her cheeks as her heartstrings were played like an instrument.

'You can't lie to your heart Adora.. '

A wail of despair cut through the air as the blonde began to curl up in Mara's grasp, her primordial brain seeking the familiar safety of the foetal position, letting Mara hold her tighter as the blonde clutched her own legs to her chest. The maternal safety that her brain also sought brought the blonde no small amount of comfort as she clutched for the few guideposts in the dark.

Life was hard. *I just want to go back to the simpler times..*

"I miss her... So much.." Adora was barely aware of what she was saying, the guilty secret that she had been repressing for months on end spilling out in an emotion fuelled moment. Mortified, Adora moved herself closer to Mara, burying her face in the valley of the woman’s shoulder to hide the embarrassment so naked upon her features.

Swallowing down her own tears, her own experiences that harkened back disturbingly close to Adora's own, Mara simply stroked the back of Adora's head and let the blonde vent the

emotions in a way that the brunette never had the chance to. She'd deal with her own pains later.

"I know you do, Adora... More than you could ever know... I know.."

Catra VII

Catra was 100% *screwed* .

There wasn’t exactly an easy way to tell Hordak that the expansion of the Horde’s control over Etheria had to *halt* when there was no quantifiable force standing between them and occupying even more land and towns. Sure, there were the militias, one of whom had launched an especially irritating raid on a convoy of raw materials coming from the mines in Orelonia (something that she would have *liked advanced notice about* , **Shadow Weaver**), and that absolutely reeked of Adora’s interference, given that it had set production back about 6 months, forcing Catra to begin stripping tanks from battalions being trained in order to supply the frontlines.

Of course, when Catra mentioned this to Shadow Weaver, suddenly it's *her* fault that the convoy didn’t have enough of an escort, despite Catra stripping all but the absolute minimum amount of soldiers from the mine to protect it, and not having enough notice to do anything more than that.

Still - what gave away most that this was an attack that Adora was involved with was the casualties.

Or rather, the relative *lack* thereof.

Sure, the company had been rotated back to the Fright Zone and 84% of their number were either in the infirmary or healing off

their wounds in the barracks, but if it was a militia attack, that number would be the *mortality* rate as opposed to the casualty rate. No, this was absolutely an attack from Adora and the rest of her little group, although the fact that there were more casualties than there usually was indicated.. Some sort of change in the Rebellions modus operandi.

She'd been to the site of the battle, arriving far too late to do anything other than stare at the burning and battle damaged husks of the transports with a low rage, directed not at those involved, not even Adora, but at the witch who had caused all this needless death and waste of resources. It was fucking infuriating, seeing such a blatant disregard for both manpower and equipment that was otherwise vital to the war effort being thrown away through stupidity.

Briefly, Catra entertained the idea that it was Adora responsible for the upturn in mortality rates, holding it in the front of her mind for only a few seconds, the silence broken by a snort that managed to escape her mouth despite her best efforts. The idea was *ludicrous* . Adora was too much of a goody two-shoes for that, and if she had, the situation would have been… scarring.

A sudden, uncharacteristic jolt of sympathy ripped through her, her eyes flaring in surprise as she rebalanced herself. *That's new.*

Of course, there was always the other option, that Adora had become a bloodthirsty maniac who would reave her way through hordes of men to get to her goal. Now *that* would be a surprise, one that even Catra would begrudgingly admit she didn't conceive as a possibility at first. But then again, Adora wasn't really prone to random and massive character swings before, and Catra had

significant reason (a decade and a half of growing up together) to doubt that, during the time between their last two encounters, anything significant had changed at *all* .

Still - it would turn the Rebellion's glorious hero into a bloodthirsty monster and that would be..

Good, I guess.

Apathy aside, Catra glanced over towards the resting place of the data pad that she had been taking inventory of the storehouse on, in a not so subtle attempt to do *literally* anything else other than talking to Hordak. Unfortunately - her own meritocratic promotion hierarchy ended up being her downfall, and only gave her a confirmation that, yes, there were in fact an identical amount of spare parts for Horde Transports in this storehouse when compared to the projections, and with the only other missing ones being noted down as taken for use.

A mildly annoyed groan once again broke through her composure, ringing out in the storehouse as she once more came to an abrupt stop and turned her attention inwards, sporting a frown that was becoming more and more at home on her face. *Where the hell did this sudden lack of self control come from?*

"You really should know."

Catra's head snapped up, sharply darting about and searching deeper into the storehouse with her eyes, sharp and jerky movement seeking out the visual manifestation of what she was hearing. That was *Adora's* voice - although given that she had spoken in response to Catra's own *thoughts* , it took her just a few seconds too long to realise that this was her conscience hijacking Adora's voice for its own use.

Traitor.

A flicker of movement in her peripheral vision, a brief flash of a familiar red colour that brought her head whipping around, staring into the darker parts of the room that she had turned her back to not a minute prior with an unbalanced desperation. It flicked from spare armour plating, already cut to size and collecting dust and cobwebs thanks to the irritating habit of the transports to *explode catastrophically* beyond repair, onto spare engine blocks, also collecting dust, although far less, and then to the burnt and jagged husks of destroyed vehicles.

Finally, the traitorous part of Catra's mind made her appearance, standing posed in the wreck of one of the transports that Catra had been looking at. It cocked Adora's head to the side, staring at Catra with an expression of almost.. Indifference. The expression, whatever it was, ground Catra's molars together and thinned her gaze, warily looking at her perceived opponent.

"Know what?" The sharp barb spat at her conscience elicited an eye roll from her conscience, who threw a hand up in an exaggeratedly sassy motion.

"Oh I could go *on* and *on.* Where should I start?"

"Get to the fucking poi-"

"You're barely sleeping. Barely eating. You're running halfway across Etheria on a *whim* chasing after Adora, knowing that she's not going to be there, under the guise of 'escorting the convoy' that Shadow Weaver didn't tell us about." Her conscience cut her off, drowning out the rest of her words, punctuating each phrase with a step, crossing several dozen steps when Catra blinked and ultimately ending her rant up in Catra's face, the feline taking a step backwards involuntarily at the end and finding her back pressed up against the desk that she had been standing at, the figure using Adora's appearance standing intimately close, but not touching her.

"So what-"

"So *what* ?" Her conscience echoed, now using Catra's own voice in an incredibly disconcerting image that her mind failed to comprehend fully, more focused on.. Other issues. Like the fact that "Adora" was this close to her. It should have activated her flight or fight adrenaline responses, but her traitorous body apparently decided that it was high time to dish out *dopamine* instead of adrenaline.

After a few moments of silence, when Catra didn't offer an extra response for her conscience to interrupt, refusing to entertain its antics any further, faux Adora made an exasperated noise and continued - now once again stealing Adora's voice. "You can' t

keep doing this Catra. You're going to make a mistake at some point, and do you really think Hordak will excuse that?"

Incredulity fuelled her next response, a noise of such escaping her as she responded. "Uh- Yeah? I'm the best strategist he *has* . He can't *afford* to get rid of me-"

"Can't he? He nearly got rid of Shadow Weaver on a *whim* ." The abrupt bluntness brought Catra to a stumbling halt, using the very cheap shot of mentioning the Witch against her. Momentary realisation set in, the feline pausing to take stock of the situation, suddenly realising exactly how precarious the situation that she had put herself in was.

If she shirked her duties to recuperate, she would be reprimanded for dereliction of her duties - if not, then she would make a mistake and end up like Shadow Weaver, disgraced and demoted. Unhelpfully, her conscience appeared to have realised this far, *far* before her. "If you keep going like this, you might as well just slit your wrist open."

Now staring down at her forearm, Catra became acutely aware, just for a single, *morbid* moment, how easy it would be to slit open her veins running up the inside of her forearms and to end it all there and then. By the time anyone found her it would be far too late, and the world could go back to how it was without the girl.

But that would be tantamount to failure. She didn't *do* failure.

It would give Shadow Weaver satisfaction. That was bad. It would give the Rebellion an immense advantage over the Horde. That was bad. It would also hinder the day to day functions of the Horde and result in the total decapitation of the command structure. This was very bad. It would break Adora's heart.

Catra paused in the midst of her self destructive thoughts, finding a lump in her throat that would not go down when she swallowed. *Would it? Does she even still care about me?*

Hell, Is that even a bad thing?

She was torn - on one hand her strategic mind told her that it could be a way to drive Adora into a deep depression, if not give her some serious mental trauma if she played her cards correctly. On the other hand, the rest of her *mind* screamed that it was perhaps the dumbest plan she had ever come up with, and that it might very well be the *last* plan she came up with.

A flash of red appeared in her peripheral vision, the (irritatingly) familiar voice of the Scorpion Princess ringing out through the green tinted walls of the gloomy storehouse. "Hey- Uh, Wildcat, you in here?"

Glancing back to where her conscience was a split second before, Catra was greeted with the sight of row upon row of burnt out husks of vehicles, slowly rusting away in the gloom. It felt like a

metaphor, something that made her unnaturally angry, her reply to Scorpia coming out harsh and sharp. "What."

"Oh! You are. Right, so, Hordak's looking for you - something about a convoy?" Scorpia ignored the poisonous barb spat in her direction by Catra, in favour of delivering a veritable death sentence, all wrapped up in a nice, neat bow. With a sharp inhale, Catra voiced her opinion in yet *another* bout of lack of self control.

"... *Fuck* ."

The doors to Hordak's Sanctum were always imposing - now more so than the past few times Catra had been summoned to this room. Probably had something to do with the fact that this time, Scorpia had come bearing a notice of execution to be carried out on her upon arriving at the Sanctum.

And this wasn't the first time, she had nearly died when Entrapta had broken into Hordak's Sanctum.

And before that, when Catra had been hauled before Hordak by Shadow Weaver initially.

In hindsight, this room was an apparent *death trap* . Probably why Entrapta loved coming here so much.

Pausing in her approach to take a breath, Catra ran through the plan in her head, gently stroking her scalp with her claws and straightening her hair. *Give the facts - there is no point trying to lie to Hordak.* She would just tell him the truth, and he'd see the reasoning behind it. Besides, Shadow Weaver had probably started spinning lies. Even just telling him *her* truth would probably win him over.

She resumed, taking a single step forwards and allowing the automatic door to pick up her presence, the massive steel doors slowly looming open, revealing the green tinted steel of the throne room. Once more, it was wreathed in darkness, with only the thin beam of golden light illuminating the path above the yawning abyss below, the stale air immediately playing havoc on her lungs, the musty smell irritating her nose.

The occupants within all turned to look at her, which in and of itself was surprising. Not the fact that they turned to the presence of a new person, but the simple fact that there were three people present in the room, not the two whom she was expecting. And yet, there Entrapta was, standing on her own two feet for once, tinkering with some object next to the throne, upon which Hordak was seated, conversing with Shadow Weaver who was standing at the bottom of the steps.

Speaking of the Witch, Catra could practically *feel* the sneer that she got from the woman as she entered the room, the blatant distaste obvious in how random shadows around the room flickered sporadically as she approached the trio, even with Catra's eyes fixed firmly ahead, not even giving the woman the effort it

took to turn her eyes to look at her. She didn't deserve the satisfaction of pulling Catra's gaze.

"Lord Hordak." The slight bow forwards seemingly sated Hordak's ego, the man lowering his right arm from the vertical position it had been in once Entrapta gave him two thumbs up and a grin, whereupon Catra realised that Entrapta had actually been tinkering with Hordak's *suit* , not something entirely different. Unfortunately, this meant that his attention was now on her, and Hordak did not look too happy.

"Tell me, Force Commander Catra, why exactly such a heavy toll has been taken on our supply lines. Shadow Weaver was just telling me how six months of production from the Orelonia mines was lost in a single day." Make that *very* unhappy. She could practically hear the sneer in his voice as he stared down at her, acutely aware that her life was now being held in her palms.

"I would like to know too, Lord Hordak, but all I was told was that there was six months of production to be defended. Sure, a heavier escort could have been arranged.. If I had more than a few hours notice." Catra levelled her pointed glare at the Witch, who glared right back at her from behind that mask. She couldn't read the woman's face due to the aforementioned mask, but the shadows flirting around were agitated.

Hordak's ire was now directed towards the Witch. "Is this true?"

"No, Lord Hordak. I told Catra several times that we would be resorting to large scale convoys to circumvent militia strikes, and

yet there were *pitifully* few troops present to defend the convoy." Shadow Weaver's voice had the characteristic cruel and manipulative leer to it, one that Catra herself cut through by jumping the gun on Hordak's next question, directly addressing the witch.

"Yeah - you did. In passing. Several times over a span of months, without giving me a date. If I had *known* when, I could have set resources aside to escort it. But *because* we waited this long, we didn't have enough spare armour to set aside because we were reinforcing the frontlines, and I could ill afford to pull any units off the frontlines for months on end. The units in basic training don't have *any* tanks now. It's hardly my fault that you can't understand basic supply and demand." This brought the Witch round onto Catra, shadows spiking in an extremely agitated way as darkness began to creep further and further into the room, something that *did* fire her fight or flight response.

"I gave you *more* than enough information! I should have known a worthless creature like you would be so incapable of handling even the *simplest* of tasks. This would hardly be an issue if *Adora* -" Catra hissed through her teeth, taking a step towards the Witch, claws extended and fangs bared.

"Don't you *dare* bring her up. She betrayed us all. *You* were so *proud* of her, maybe we should be wondering how competent *you* are at handling the *simplest tasks* ." Shadows *swamped* the room, the Witch seeming to flare up several times her height as Catra went into battle mode, taking a step back into a combat stance and preparing for a revenge that she had dreamed of for *years* .

"Enough." Hordak broke the tension, the shadows lingering for a few tense seconds as Catra wondered if the Witch had finally had enough and would try and kill Catra in defiance of Hordaks whims. Yet it was not to be, the darkness slowly and tensely slipping back, still poised to attack as Hordak rose from his throne, casting a withering glare down at both women, a sneer caught on his lips as his red eyes and mouth blazed down at them. "Shadow Weaver, you will work on a more orderly schedule for moving supplies to and from the Fright Zone, and you will inform Catra of any future convoys well in *advance* , and of any changes to them. For now, have the transports make high speed transits."

Hordak turned to look at Catra, and his expression didn't go soft, it just went less openly angry. "Force Commander Catra, you will provide future convoys with adequate protection to deter most attackers in future, and you will *cooperate* with Shadow Weavers planned schedule, and let her know when it cannot be met. Do I make myself exceedingly clear?"

"Yes my Lord."

"Yes, Lord Hordak."

"Then you will leave us. Force Commander Catra, I have an assignment for you." Hordak's tone, along with the distinctly smug sensation that she got from Shadow Weaver, coupled together to give Catra a sense of distinct unease as she remained behind whilst the Witch left the room, her exit signalled by the opening and shutting of the door at the end of the bridge that Catra used as a signal to relax from her combat ready state.

“You and Entrapta will take Force Captain Scorpia to examine a signal from a fragment of technology that will be potentially useful to our future work.” Catra narrowed her eyes as the man spoke. He was being vague - deliberately so, and that in and of itself was enough of a red flag to tell Catra that she was not going to like the answer to the question she asked next.

“Where exactly are we going?”

Catra discovered that she hated somewhere more than the Fright Zone.

She had made this assertion after a grand total of 5 seconds in the blistering heat of the Crimson Wastes, having been awoken from the nap that she had taken enroute to the wasteland. It had been pleasant inside the climate controlled cabin of the transport they had taken, but that carefully adjusted cool had been stripped away immediately the moment Entrapta had yanked open the back door to get at the crates of equipment that she had brought with them for some unholy reason.

She was under no illusion that this mission was anything *but* a punishment for her acting out earlier today in her brief verbal sparring match with Shadow Weaver. The Witch was proud and Hordak had administered her punishment by giving her a verbal dressing down and ordering her to treat Catra as a relative equal, something that was practically a reward to the feline. The same, however, would not work on Catra - and so Hordak had placed her

at Entrapta's disposal, which apparently meant sentencing her to near certain death in the Crimson Wastes.

Well to be entirely fair, it wasn't like she was exiled for her gross misconduct like, say, allowing perhaps the most valuable prisoner that the Fright Zone had ever held escape out of fucking sentiment. That *would* be a death sentence.

No, this was more torture - she'd be finding sand absolutely *everywhere* for *weeks* .

Laying there, basking in the cool steel underneath her back as she felt the air grow hotter and hotter around her, Catra stared at the ceiling of the cargo hold and absently counted the rivets in the steel as she waited for the heat to become too unbearable in what now amounted to a steel coffin designed to cook anyone inside. She was still dreary from her nap, but she had operated on less sleep before, although in nothing like the conditions she was in now.

Hours upon hours of walking through an unforgiving, inhospitable, daymoon-baked wasteland to find some measly scrap of technology that ***could*** *work towards whatever this "project" those two geeks have been working on. Actually fucking end me.*

The effects of the heat had well and truly sunk in at this point and Catra could feel her organs beginning to bake in the cargo bay of the transport, and so she reluctantly peeled herself off the cool steel and stood, stepping outside into the sweltering heat of the daymoon's glare. It was bright, far brighter than any environment

that she had been in before, bar perhaps only the harsh glare of the spotlights that adorned parts of the Fright Zone's perimeter, both had the effect of irritating the ever living shit out of her eyes as her pupils slowly adjusted into narrow slits to compensate for the abundance of light.

About the *only* mercy was the rear cargo door of the transport, one that swung open upwards for ease of loading and unloading, was blocking the actual daymoon from her vision, leaving the feline standing in *just* the dry, blistering heat of the Crimson Wastes. The sand under her feet was hot - almost painfully so, but the alternative was getting back into the transport and having to endure the same experience a few minutes later, so she chose to begin the acclimatisation process, feeling the searing heat fade away into a comfortingly warm sensation.

Resting her hands on her hips, Catra stretched herself over backwards, feeling the cricks in her back that resulted from napping on what was quite literally a flat steel floor, fade away in a *wonderfully* satisfying way as she slowly and carefully straightened herself up, taking in the view. It wasn't much really, just kilometre upon kilometre of dry, barren wasteland baking in the wrath of the daymoon, the futile attempts of life to flourish here marked by the dead bushes and shrubs that broke up the otherwise barren landscape.

Entrapta rounded the corner - on her feet this time, as opposed to her hair, which was very firmly staying *above* even her waist height. Clearly, there were some base things that even Catra and Entrapta could agree on - fuck sand. With her face buried in a data pad, Catra wasn't even sure Entrapta knew she was there.

"What are we doing here - Why are we stopped?" Entrapta's hair responded by pointing back around the corner of the truck that she had come around as the purple haired Princess responded to the feline almost absentmindedly, all whilst rummaging through a storage crate for something, only to come out with what looked like a toolkit.

"Ah good, you're up. I think we've found it."

Drowsy irritation swamped her system at the vague response, prompting Catra to go towards the corner that Entrapta had come around, groaning in exasperation as she went to look at what would probably be a small cave or some sort of sand dune that they would have to exca.. vate...

Catra's mouth dried in a heartbeat as she stared at the view in unmolested awe.

Scorpia was standing a few metres ahead of her, at the edge of a cliff that they had parked on, the solid rock under Catra's feet a nice change from the sand that she had only been standing in for a few seconds, and yet the same sand that she could *swear* she already felt rubbing between her uniform and her back. Below them was a drop of about 15 metres onto a sandy slope that fed into a small gulley between two dunes, the natural path trailing up towards a large hill.

But it was what was sticking *out* of the hill that was perhaps the most impressive part of the landscape.

It *looked* like some form of temple, with two nearly identical towers straddling one larger one in the centre. It was clearly *not* part of the landscape, the grey metal caked in generations of sand and other debris which had worn away the original paint work. It had also tilted over about fifteen degrees to the right, clearly the foundation having either given way underneath the structure, or it wasn't a building in the first place.

Catra's mind came to an utterly ludicrous conclusion, but one that made far, *far* too much sense when she looked closer at the actual structure with a more careful and observant eye. There were holes in the side towers near their points, an opening in the central face of the structure, with a ramp of some sort that was extended at an angle that required a person to be above the actual opening to utilise. So either there was a structure there before, or it was meant to be deployed if the structure was rotated ninety degrees. *So that means..*

"It's a *ship* ..."

"I know!" Caught in her moment of awe, Catra had forgotten Entrapta was there, and nearly jumped out of her *skin* when the Princess basically screamed her jubilation, instead only wincing, her ears flattening themselves against her head protectively. "Ohoho this is going to be so *exciting* ! It's a nearly intact *First Ones* ship! Maybe even a *spaceship!* This has the potential to be my greatest discovery ever!"

Catra, begrudgingly, had to admit that the find in and of itself had the potential to be *exceptionally* useful to the Horde if it was

indeed a spaceship as Entrapta suggested. The ability to transport troops over *vast* distances with craft like these would grant the Horde an unrivalled advantage over the Rebellion. Hell, they could fly *over* the Whispering Woods and deposit the entire Horde in the middle of Bright Moon and win the war in one fell swoop.

But that was entirely dependent on whether or not Entrapta could get the craft to work *without* causing a catastrophic explosion that either incinerated them or hell, half of Etheria along with them. Who *knows* what sort of fuel that thing had to use.

"So if it's *there* , why are *we* so far away from it? Why didn't you just drive up to it?" Entrapta paused, actually looking up this time and meeting Catra's eyes.

"Our transport truck is unable to handle that steep of a gradient.." Entrapta glanced down at her tablet nervously - something that in and of itself was worrying to Catra as the tinkerer princess displaying *unease* was distinctly concerning to her. "... And there's something under the sand."

Catra blinked. "Under the sand?" She echoed, somewhat incredulously.

"Yes." Entrapta practically shoved the tablet in Catra's face, the feline having to physically push it back and take it from the Princess to even be able to comprehend what was on the screen she was ostensibly being shown. When she finally *was* able to read it, the topographical map of the area showed little that caught Catra's eyes, bar a few ominous red dots in what seemed

like a path. Tapping the dots with a claw, Catra asked the question of the hour.

"So what is it then?"

"Vibrations under the sand - and by the looks of things, made by something *really* big. It's fascinating what sort of life lives out here. I'd love to study it one day.." Entrapta took back the tablet and peered at it for a moment, before clapping her hands and shoving it into a satchel bag that she had procured from somewhere, and had subsequently slung over her shoulder. "Right- Now is the best time to go."

"Wait- what?" Catra wheeled around, noticing Scorpia nod and lower the binoculars from her eyes.

"Oh - ok. Ready Wildcat?" Stuffing the binoculars in the protective bag that they had come from, Scorpia gave Catra a friendly smile, one that the feline couldn't answer with anything but a confused look and half noises as her brain struggled to comprehend what was going on.

"What the hell do you mean 'Ready'?" The incredulity was answered with regular apathy by Entrapta, who was once again entirely occupied by staring at the tracker pad as she spoke, holding it in her hair as her hands rummaged through the satchel bag.

"We're going to make a run for the First Ones wreck. Alright - no better time." And with that metaphorical bomb, Entrapta quite casually jumped off the cliff, sliding down the sand dune on her hair, all the while staring down at her tablet, now clutched in her hands. Scorpia followed suit immediately after, leaving Catra momentarily alone on the cliff top, seriously debating sitting this one out.

But Entrapta would *absolutely* blab to Hordak regardless on whether or not she meant to, and it would be so much worse if Catra returned without the other two, and after a moment's hesitation, she too jumped the cliff, onto the warm sand that felt a lot less annoying and a lot more terrifying.

They were silent as they walked, sometimes coming to a halt behind Entrapta as she stared at the tablet as some unseen horror slipped through the sand nearby them, the only sign of its presence being a blip on a pad, the very muffled noise of shifting sand and stone, and the nerves in Catra's head *fraying* . This little game of cat and mouse had resulted in a new discovery for Catra.

Her ears were *just* sensitive enough to pick up the rumbling of whatever it was tunnelling about underground. To hear the creature stalking them, searching for what it could hear and what it could probably sense, waiting for the right moment for it to strike.

All of a sudden, Entrapta paused in her movement in the middle of the gulley, most of the way to the ship, *just* as the rumbling underground grew noticeably louder and gained a direction.

Directly behind them.

"Uh.. Entrapta... Don't mean to alarm you but.." Catra found her urgent whispering cut off by Entrapta's obnoxiously loud voice.

"Oh I know - it's right behind us and approaching rapidly. Hmm.. Where did I put it..." The Princess was digging through her satchel with one hand as Catra turned around to face whatever it was that was approaching them, preparing herself for a fight. Hopefully, she could do some sort of damage to either kill it or drive it off, providing it wasn't too big.

Fortunately, her question was answered.

Unfortunately, it was answered by the sand some hundred metres behind them rising up as some massive creature rose up to just below the surface of the sand - close enough that the spines that dotted its body broke through the wave of sand that was running back along its body. Catra wondered what it was thinking, seeing the three very out of place women, one standing by her hair, one with scorpion features and a very miffed cat, all about to die.

Fight or flight was kicking in, and it was STRONGLY weighing on flight, but Catra couldn't leave the others, and so she foolishly remained, staring at the thing approaching them under the sand as it surged forwards. Fifty metres, forty, thirty.

At perhaps the last second, Entrapta pulled a small ball out of her satchel with an 'Ah-ha!', hurling it at the sand in front of them, landing between them and whatever it was under the sand. For a moment, it did nothing.

Then Catra went *deaf* .

The ear piercing *SKREEEEEE* that the ball made dropped the feline to her knees in a heartbeat as she flattened her ears and covered them with her hands, clenching her teeth so hard that she feared they might shatter from the sheer pressure of her jaw. She was vaguely aware of both the thing in the sand turning 180 immediately and fucking off to whatever hell hole it had come from, and Scorpia picking her up and carrying her as their trio made a charge towards the ship.

They were there before the next conscious thought came, and unfortunately it was anger. Rounding on Entrapta as they stood, panting and out of breath (Although really that was Scorpia, Catra was just pissed off and Entrapta was busy looking at her pad), Catra hissed through her teeth, conscious that they didn't want to alert whatever they were again.

"Could you at least have fucking *warned* me!?"

"Oh - I didn’t mean to hurt you.. I wasn’t aware that your ears were that sensitive. Sorry Catra.." Entrapta sounded somewhat remorseful, more like Adora getting in trouble from Shadow Weaver in their youth than someone actually receiving punishment. The rage bubbled up inside, but for once,

spontaneously, she shoved it down, sighing to relieve the internal pressure, tersely responding.

"For your information - its *very* sensitive." Speaking of sensitive hearing, Catra's ears fully returned to normality, dancing to the left like radar dishes as she wheeled about to look at the source of the noise of shifting sand, a sudden irritation crashing about in her head.

"Used to be a lot more sensitive if my memory serves me correctly." That familiar fucking voice that spawned the transformation from irritation to anger inside her, the smug, but yet still somehow soft grin of the blonde girl, glowing slightly in the form of the Princess who had taken from Catra the one thing in her life that she fucking cared about. Flanking her were Sparkles and Arrow Boy, two people who she still could not care about to save her life, if her refusal to remember their names was anything to go off. "Hey, Catra."

A small part of her brain complained. *That's meant to be my line...*

Catra VIII

Chapter Notes

> This chapter features a decent number of lines inspired by/adlibbed from Doctor Who, with a few lines stolen from the shows Buffy the Vampire Slayer and Sherlock. They're primarily contained in the dialogue between Catra and Adora after dinner, props to you if you can spot them and bigger props if you can identify where they're from.

That ugly stab of anger coiled up inside Catra, firmly planting its metaphorical heels in as she shifted her stance to place herself both into a combat pose and between the Rebels and her two wards. Sure, Scorpia was a capable fighter, but Catra was by far the best fighter present out of the five combatants present, and she was fairly sure that she could handle the Bright Moon Rebels present. Through gritted teeth, Catra practically *growled* her response.

"Hey Adora."

The logical part of her brain tried to raise an objection, but Catra ignored it in favour of diverting her attention to the more primal side, the side that could tell her the important things and the side that kept her alive if Adora came swinging at her with that massive sword. Still, her wards were of vital importance, and so she turned her head slightly and made eye contact with Scorpia, whilst keeping Adora in her peripheral vision. "Scorpia, keep Entrapta away from the fighting."

She was vaguely aware of a determined nod being her response as white movement flickered in the corners of her eyes, signalling

the opening of hostilities, and reflexively bringing her gaze back towards Adora. Caught mid twirl, Adora was bringing the sword down at her in a swing that, had it hit, would probably have cleaved Catra in two from shoulder to hip. It was easy enough to take a step back, to bounce out of the swings range and to prepare for her counter attack.

Adora's strike fell predictably short, but Catra found herself cancelling whatever attack she was advancing for, sharply leaning back and away from the roundhouse kick that Adora nearly landed on her in a fluid continuation of the momentum she had from the strike. Dancing back a few extra steps, Catra now cautiously analysed the Warrior Princess' stance and found a few things that she cursed herself over. The stance itself was far more confident and more suited to battle than the pose that Adora had been striking before, which looked great as a propaganda tool, but was decidedly mediocre in combat.

Now the Princess was far more balanced and more easily able to do complex manoeuvres with her new stance, something she had just demonstrated nearly to Catra's detriment. Adora was *definitely* more of a threat now than she had been before, and Catra had to be a hell of a lot more careful about both her and the companions she brought with her.

She could hear the sounds of combat from her right, between her and the ship, and the tell-tale noise of magic from Sparkles teleporting, the *twang* of the bow string all accompanied by the noise of Scorpia grunting told Catra that her flanks were relatively clear for the meantime, leaving just her and Adora to face off. That was fine - it would give her a better chance of feeling out Adora's new skills.

Cautiously circling Adora, watching as the blonde did the same to her, both denying each other the tactical advantage of positioning whilst trying to work out their opponents flaws. Adora's guard was a lot better than it was before - almost to a flaw. Her guard was so strong at the probably expense of speed or energy, it would take a lot of effort to move herself quickly out of that pose, something that she could use to her advantage..

Silently, Catra cursed herself. *What the hell am I thinking - She-Ra is all about stamina..*

Waiting until the Princess stood between her and the ship, all so Catra could see exactly where Sparkles and Arrow boy were, the feline lowered her stance and darted in close, watching as Adora raised her guard in order to repel any attack that she might endure. Again, to her (*begrudging*) credit, Adora's guard was true and would be a pain to get through without enduring any injury or harm herself, so Catra would have to play dirty.

Just before she reached Adora, Catra swung her left hand down to scoop up a handful of sand, hurling it at Adora's face as the blonde frowned at her from behind the guard, confusion turning to surprise and ultimately realisation as Adora's eyes shut just before the sand reached her, but that still suited Catra fine. The feline sprang at the blonde, kicking at her vambraces in order to keep the sword from blindly flailing, then with her momentum from the jump, slamming a kick into the back of Adora's head and throwing the Princess wildly off balance, all whilst Catra landed in a neat half turn that ended in a crouch, taking in the sight.

Adora had been staggered by the blow and was clearly reeling and off balance, all the while trying to brush sand from around her eyes with her free hand. There would be a great satisfaction from beating Adora on equal terms, but the opportunity to strike the blonde whilst she was totally unable to respond was a chance too good to miss, and so Catra leapt back in, only to watch as Adora's eyes snapped open and she swung the sword towards Catra in a confident motion that told the feline that she had not been capitalising on a disabled Adora, but had instead fallen for the blondes own trap.

Still, that didn't mean she'd just *let* Adora hit her.

Twisting violently to avoid the strike, the chance to strike Adora's unguarded back was far too appealing, the feline again twisting her body, this time back into the path of the blade in order to line her strike up. The attack was almost perfect, Catra coming in at Adora's hip and slowing her momentum by ripping her claws along and up Adora's back, tearing skin and fabric as she dragged to a stop with her feet planted on Adora's shoulders, facing upwards, then springing off the blonde's shoulders in a backflip that shoved her over as the cry of pain began to leave the blonde's mouth.

But then Catra's own cry of pain escaped her lips as a *burning* line of agony sliced across her back, just under her shoulder blades, making every movement of her arms momentarily agonising as the adrenaline rushed to douse the pain to enable her to keep fighting. Her landing was awkward, Catra stumbling away from the blonde and risking a glance over her shoulder to examine the damage. There was a thin, horizontal line on her back, split by the gap of her spine, the blade having thankfully avoided hitting her spine or any muscles, but having torn bloody gashes through the skin and flesh either side of it.

And her *hair* .

Catra wasn't obsessed with her hair, but she liked it. It represented that she was untameable, wasn't one to conform to any sort of regulations that Shadow Weaver had imposed on every other Cadet. It was a memory of her rebelliousness, a sign of her dedication to duty to piss off the witch at every turn.

Now, it had been cut short by the sword, extending down to about shoulder length before ending in an abrupt sheer line, the cedar brown keratin laying between the duo on the ground in a messy line, the sand around it dotted with crimson droplets of blood from both girls. *Speaking of..*

Catra glanced over at Adora, whose back was looking a lot worse for wear. The majestic white cloth was stained an angry crimson by the wounds, and Catra's eyes could see that there was sand in the gashes, likely aggravating the pain to an extent far above what would normally have been a fairly debilitating pain. She was still on the ground, hair hanging down around her face, and the feline could hear her panting for breath.

Speaking of hearing...

The rumbling underground returned, louder, yet definitely further away. That was bad - That could only mean one thing.

We scared off a smaller one, now the Alpha is coming out to play .. Why...

She cursed herself under her breath. *The fighting - vibrations underground.. Shit.*

The beast broke the surface briefly, surging up from underground and breeching high into the sky up near the transport, thankfully not damaging it. As soon as Catra locked her eyes on it, she knew what it was as she stared into the teeth, the never ending maw of teeth on the end of that worm-like body adorned with hooks and claws and spines pointing every which direction.

She could remember the definition that she had been given during one of their classes on the Crimson Wastes - if only for the fact that it was one of the few times that Shadow Weaver wasn't dishing out punishments to her during their interactions.

The Sand Crawler is a ravenous creature covered head to tail in a solid, chitinous carapace. In spite of its time spent underground, myriad eyes adorn its head, observing every possible angle for prey to devour. Most dangerous of all is the gnashing maw jutting out from its front, an abyss of teeth and fangs seemingly without end, capable of effortlessly tearing through flesh and crushing bone. Their arrival is always heralded by that daunting sound of sifting and beneath the dunes. If you can hear that noise? It can hear you trying to run away.

Unhelpfully, however, the transport being spared was also a curse - because that meant the Sand Crawler was firmly fixed on *them* .

"Scorpia!" Catra's cry of the ashen haired woman's name pulled not only the attention of the woman in question, but also Sparkles and Arrow Boy, not to mention Entrapta who poked her head out over the edge of the ramp, and judging by how the Scorpion Princess blanched at the sight, Catra wasn't actually going crazy. A silent consensus was reached in a heartbeat, as the trio helpfully turned away from Catra and began to *leg it* towards the ship, with Catra wasting little time following them.

"Catra.." The weak call of her name caused her footing to fumble, hissing in pain as sand was kicked into her open wound, rounding on Adora, who had slipped back into her normal form, and yet was still on the ground, struggling to stand up. Hesitation slammed into Catra, the feline's legs refusing to continue on as she stared back at Adora, who managed to make eye contact.

"Please."

Her body acted on its own, legs moving and bringing her down to Adora's side, scooping the blonde onto her shoulders and racing back up towards the ship. The wound on her back screamed in agonising protest, firing pain all throughout her nervous system, all whilst the Sand Crawler behind her grew closer and closer, and her legs grew more and more leaden.

A horrible realisation came to her. *We're not going to make it.*

The Sand Crawler behind her reared up, shadow looming high above the duo as Catra's grip on Adora tightened, turning to place herself between the beast and the blonde, not wanting to die facing away from her opponent. *This is how we go then.. Together.*

The wink of magic to her immediate right and the accompanying stomach wrenching sensation broke her out of the momentary peace, depositing her on the cool metal floor with a bodily impact that knocked Adora from her arms, hissing in pain, although it was rather drowned out by Adora's moan of pain as they both went sprawling on the dark floor of some chamber. The first thing that struck her, other than the pain of her wound, was the delicious cool of the floor under her.

Then realisation hit, her head jerking up as she gazed at Sparkles standing above her, between her and Adora, and looking none too impressed by the situation. Catra nearly snarled, scrambling to her feet only for her body to pull a motion that it really couldn't do with the wound on her back, a sharp hiss of pain escaping as she collapsed back to the floor.

Scorpia was beside her in a heartbeat, helping Catra to her feet as the feline grumbled under her breath, tenderly standing whilst leaning on the ashen haired woman's shoulder to maintain her footing. Sparkles was looking mildly smug under the glare she was shooting Catra, and the feline *really* wanted to wipe that expression from Sparkle's face.

Then, of all people, Entrapta managed to strike a perfect balance between both sides. In her usual monotone, ringing out from underneath some sort of console that she had most of her body

buried under, the Princess voiced her surprisingly apt description of the situation. "It would be a statistically bad idea for us to continue fighting - Allowing for our injured to recuperate would increase our chance of escaping unharmed by a factor of three. I recommend a cessation of hostilities for the time being as we tend to our injured."

Catra blinked in flat surprise, as did almost everyone else in the room, staring at the Princess as she continued to tinker with the ship. The blunt, analytical way of explaining things that Catra was honestly still not completely familiar with, served to bridge the gap between the two sides, Catra meeting Sparkles' equally baffled gaze with a begrudging acceptance. Holding out a hand, Catra shoved down her instinct to scratch Sparkles, instead begrudgingly speaking, not really trying to hide her distaste. "Truce?"

Sparkles stared at Catra's hand for a second, then turned to look at the other two, Catra's gaze following. Arrow Boy stuck up a thumb, whilst Adora lay on the floor on her stomach, breathing slowly, but visibly nodded despite her evident pain. Sparkles grumbled under her breath, but took Catra's wrist, the feline doing the same to her.

"Truce. For now."

"I'll try not to gut you in your sleep then, Princess." Catra's smirk seemed to awaken a sort of determined rivalry within Sparkles, who gave Catra a determined smirk in kind, something that actually softened her firm expression.

"Likewise, Force Commander."

This has got to be the weirdest dinner ever..

The unlikely sextuplet were seated around a small Horde issue portable cooking stove, glowing with an orange flame that was far brighter and larger than any one of these that Catra had ever seen before, owing to the fact that A. Entrapta had been tinkering with it, and B. Catra had abided by the Horde saying regarding these things, ' *Whatever the instruction says, double it.'*

The resulting ball of flame had nearly singed her eyebrows off, but a glare had kept the snickering down to a *tolerable* level.

Sitting at a comfortable 1.4x the base fuel specified, the fire had been more than enough for Arrow boy.. No, *Bow* . His name was apparently *Bow* . She had no clue what sort of monster named their kids like that, but then Bow had pointed out that she was quite literally named ' *Cat* -ra' and she had shut up as the implications had hit her in a *very* uncomfortable way.

Regardless, it had been enough for him to whip up what amounted to a gourmet meal in the Horde, although he had apologised (Catra wagered satirically) for the lack of any sort of flavour or substance to it. He was probably used to lavish feasts, and the simple soup broth that had fed all of them was more than acceptable. He even bothered to go out of his way to make tiny

servings for Entrapta - that on its own told her that they had spent a decent amount of time together before the Tinkerer Princess defected to the Horde.

Still - the display of domesticity was definitely a façade. Catra and Scorpia sat on the direct other side of the cooking stove to the so-called "Best Friends Squad" (she had cringed so hard upon learning the name that words could not even *begin* to describe it), with Entrapta bridging the gap between Scorpia and Bow for the brief few minutes that she had spent away from the consoles. Unfortunately, sitting in a circle meant that there was always going to be another person on each side - and just so unhelpfully, that happened to be Adora.

The blonde had made it quite firmly clear, in tones quiet enough that it was evident that she was trying to keep her voice off the auditory scale of Catra (and failing, mind you), that she would be sitting next to Catra despite Sparkles'... *Glimmer's* protestations. She had no clue what Adora thought would come of it, but she sure as hell wasn't going to waste any effort moving - the medical salve that Scorpia had used (and shared with Adora mind you) required minimal movement from the affected party in order to do its job. She'd be fine by morning, all things considered, and apparently Adora would too, if she kept healing at the accelerated rate that she was.

The room they were in had, judging by the layout of the rather expansive space that was still crammed with dusty boxes of food preserves that Adora had been forced to translate, once been a sort of control room or command centre. In most circumstances, Catra would have assumed that this ship was piloted by a team of people no less than 8 or 9 men strong, but the single chair in the room indicated otherwise.

On the topic of food, it was almost mind boggling that the preserves had not gone off despite their age. Catra had taken a stab in the dark when she mentioned that this ship had to be at least a thousand years old - if only for all the *dust* present inside the ship, only for Adora to surprise her with a rather sombre and confident "Exactly a thousand years old". She'd been thinking about that for a while, running it over in her head.

How on Etheria did she know that..

Maybe it was written down somewhere on the ship, recorded in the language that none of them bar Adora could read, maybe it was told in the stories from the people who lived in the Crimson Wastes, maybe it was recorded down in some archives that Catra couldn't have access to due to being on the wrong side of this conflict or maybe it was written on the damn food packaging. All Catra knew was that it irked her to no end, like something that she should know, something that she *needed* to know.

"So..." The obvious attempt to break the ice came from Bow, and Catra seriously hoped he wasn't trying to start a sing along or some shit like that. Simultaneously, she wondered if a sing along constituted breaking the truce by means of torturing the other party to commit suicide. Thankfully, it wasn't (yet). "How was dinner?"

"Oh yeah, this was some of the best soup I've ever had. I wonder if whoever owned this had more... Uh, what was it?" Scorpia was smiling that infectious smile that Catra was thankfully vaccinated against thanks to prolonged exposure to both Adora and Shadow

Weaver. Honestly, she understood Scorpia was all about making friends - hell she'd managed to break into the Lonnie-Rogelio-Kyle three way thing they had going on - but honestly did it *have* to be with the enemy?

"Oh, it was uh.." Bow paused, staring at the bag that he had emptied into the pot, frowning for a moment before he turned red and looked at Adora, holding the bag up as a silent question. The blonde, however, was paused, staring at her soup with dispassion and a sombre silence, broken only by a reverent intonement.

"They were Mara's."

Catra's eyes darted over to examine the blonde, who said nothing more for a few seconds, staring at her soup whilst breathing softly, although Catra could read her expression regardless. This was an emotion fuelled Adora - a fragile one who honestly looked like she might blow away if the breeze picked up. Eventually, in a dull monotone, Adora answered Bow's question. ".. And its Dehydrated Protein Slaw."

".. Right. Dehydrated protein slaw." All eyes stuck on Adora for a few seconds (bar Entrapta, who was still somewhere inside the ship's consoles, having fully disappeared about half an hour ago and who had not been seen since), all cautiously keeping an eye on the sudden mood shift. Catra would have been more worried, if Entrapta wasn't known for bumping about in the Fright Zone vents. She'd be fine.. Probably.

Catra closed her eyes for a moment, shaking her head as if to clear it of the somewhat off topic thoughts that had come as a by-product of the healing salve, which was also a painkiller and had made her slightly delirious. Unfortunately, this only managed to get her a noseful of the dust that had been hanging in the air, and she only had time to set her bowl down and turn away before she let out a sneeze. " *Haa.. Ha-ptchoo"*

Rubbing her nose, the feline turned back to a sea of faces, all torn between amusement (Sparkles) and fond adoration (to varying levels from the rest of the trio in ascending order, Bow, Adora then Scorpia). She could *swear* that Scorpia even had a sparkle in her eyes that Adora was doing a *disturbingly* good job of mimicking. Her left eye twitched. "What."

" *That's* your sneeze?" Bow was practically *cooing* , and it spiked the irritation inside her, the feline planting her hand on the metal floor and consciously having to *resist* the urge to gouge deep tears in the flooring.

"It's a normal sneeze." The monotonous intonation of her statement was dipped in a little of her irritation as her tail unconsciously swished behind her, betraying her mood despite her otherwise emotionless expression. Bow didn't catch on, however.

"It's.. Just so *cute.* "

"I am not *cute* ." Catra practically *growled* the last word, aware of her tail puffing up behind her stiffly in a way that *finally* got the point across to the rest of the room's occupants, bar Adora, who

seemed to have noticed the warning signs beforehand. All broke eye contact, although she could still see Bow staring at her with a doting expression from time to time.

Sighing, she carefully rose to her feet, all the while ignoring Scorpia's attempted protestations. *I need to get out of here. Even for a minute.*

"Where's the bathroom in this place.." Her question brought about a general swivelling of heads as literally everyone tried to figure out the answer to her question at the same time. Adora looked like she was about to get up and try searching herself, only for Sparkles to pull her back down with a pointed look.

The silence was disturbed by the deafening and startling *crash* of one of the roof panels falling to the floor below that had Catra jumping in surprise, the purple haired walking social disaster poking her head out into the control room from the new hole in the roof, red eyed welding mask still firmly on her face. All eyes stared at her in various degrees of surprise.

"Down the hallway at the end of the right corridor... This really is one of the best finds of the century.. Ooh if I could rewire the power crystals to the main fusion reactor..." Catra tuned out the mad ramblings of the Princess and slipped out the door, pointedly walking straight upright and casually until she escaped the sight of the others.

Once out of the control room, her posture slumped and she leant against the wall, closing her eyes for a moment to muscle her way

through the pain before she continued down the hallway. Thankfully the strange and random thoughts had begun to clear from her mind, although this was unfortunately accompanied by the painkillers wearing off to the point that her back was giving her a not unnoticeable amount of grief.

Also apparent was the air. It was *cool* , almost to the point that Catra could feel the goosebumps on her skin as she finally arrived at the bathroom, although upon entering the room it was evidently far more. It might have once been a spaceship, but this was elegant and extravagant - almost as big as Catra's Force Captain quarters, and with what looked like a shower *and* a bath, not to mention other private amenities.

Catra didn't care about any of that really - more occupied with staring at herself in the vanity mirror and just… thinking to herself in the quiet and peace offered by the distance from the rest of the uneasy alliance. This day had gone from bad, to worse, then to downright bizarre, and now she was meant to sit in the same room as her enemies and be *civil* whilst they healed and rested.

That and there were some things that were beginning to unravel, inside her mind, logic that was not making sense, things that she had learned in the Horde that, although very clearly lies, had absolutely not one grain of truth behind them. Sure, Shadow Weavers whole thing was manipulation, Catra had said as much to Adora on that fateful day, and she had learned much more about Etheria as a whole from ascending through the ranks and being privy to un-doctored information, but there were still some things that surprised her from time to time.

One had been the Sand Crawlers - Catra had seriously thought them a myth until one had nearly fucking *eaten* her a few hours before.

Her hand shifted against the basin, and Catra raised it in front of her face, flexing it outwards to its maximum extent. Despite her attempts, it was clearly shaking, the minor shock clearly setting in now as the adrenaline fully left her body and her mind seared the fear and hopelessness into her memory forever.

I'm in control. I have control.

".. Catra?" The tentative calling of her name pulled Catra from her internal monologue, breaking her gaze from the mirror and bringing it around to look at Adora, who herself was leaning on the doorframe of the bathroom and was clearly in some sort of pain, just as Catra was. The scowl broke through onto her lips for a seconds, before it was shoved down, replaced with a grimace that the feline felt was more appropriate. Adora appeared to appreciate it at least, although why Catra actually *cared* about that was still beyond her. "You.. Uh, doing ok?"

Deciding to avoid giving Adora a negative answer because Catra was *very clearly NOT* doing ok and she felt no need to vocalise it, the feline answered the blonde's question with her own, an exasperated sigh slipping out through her nostrils as she did so. "What're *you* doing up and about?"

"You've been here for nearly 15 minutes - you friend.. Uh, Scorpia? She got worried about you. Said something about 'self

destructive tendencies'?" Her eye twitched as Adora spoke, Catra turning her gaze back to the mirror and the husk of the girl that she once felt she knew completely staring right back at her. Now *Scorpia* was trying to play hero - there was always someone trying to play hero in her life, always someone to stand out whilst Catra played second fiddle.

“They sent one cripple after the other? And to think that our truce was meant to let us heal and to *survive* .” Catra scoffed, looking back down at the hand that had been shaking, only to find it deathly still, hanging there motionlessly as Adora stood in the doorframe watching her. The blonde abruptly looked a little embarrassed, and Catra inhaled sharply in anticipation of what she knew she was about to hear from the blonde.

"Uh well.. I kind of.. Volunteered myself." Adora looked bashful, and the irritation inside Catra flared.

"You're an idiot. You're meant to be resting." Adora blinked, clearly caught off guard by the crass and blunt response that Catra gave, devoid of any other sort of emotion other than just annoyance. " *YOU* don't have to do everything."

".. I wanted to come see you."

"Why."

"I wanted to *talk* to you."

Catra scoffed. "Why here? Why not talk to me out with the rest of them."

"Because I want to talk to *you.* " Catra opened her mouth to shoot back a response, but Adora continued with a forceful tone that caught the feline a little off guard. "I don't want to talk to Force Commander Catra - I want to talk to Catra. The girl I grew up with. The girl who I snuck food from the kitchens for. The girl who I promised to stay with. The girl I-.." A heartbeat of silence. ".. The girl I left behind."

Catra's mouth went dry and her grip on the basin tightened, her emotions running rampant inside her head, a sea of incomprehensible emotions with no definable form or shape that would swallow her whole if she even tried to make any sort of sense of them. Any step into them could be a pothole, a deep point in which she would slip beneath the surface and lose any and all control of herself or her mind.

It was easier just to be annoyed - safer too. Sparkles hated Catra, she could see it. Chances were that Adora hated her too, and she'd use that vulnerability to destroy the feline, or worse, push her achievements aside and make her once again second to Adora.

"Yeah, well." Catra swallowed the bitter lump in her throat, a sneer curling behind her lips. "She died when you left her. I'm all that's left."

She wasn't sure what prompted it, but her hands moved of their own accord, reaching up to grab at what remained of her hair and firmly holding it out in front of her. With a single careful motion, she brought down her claws on it, leaving her with a short, yet messy haircut. It was hardly as well styled as Scorpia's, but it did what Catra wanted it to - it cut her off from that stupid girl that she had been all those years back.

She let the cedar brown keratin fall into the basin, then met Adora's eyes - the baby blue orbs trapping a whole range of emotions that Catra didn't want to begin to try unravelling, yet did anyway. Loss, grief, sadness, yet a determination to keep going through with whatever she was trying to do, despite the fact that it hurt her so much. If it hurt, what was the point - in hindsight it was ironic that Adora mentioned self destructive tendencies when she couldn't identify them in herself.

Catra moved to walk past Adora, finding herself caught and pulled back when Adora grabbed her wrist as she passed, staring at Catra with an expression that was pleading for her to listen. "Catra.. Please. You don't have to be like this. We can fix things. We've always been able to."

Her jaw tightened as she stared into Adora's eyes. Those blue orbs reminded her so much of the sea of emotions within her, light around the outside, yet sinking into inky pupils, just like the pitfalls in the sea of emotions. With a single, sharp tug, Catra pulled her hand free with enough force that Adora stumbled on her uneven footing, finding support on the other side of the door frame than the one she had been leaning on before.

"Maybe." She conceded, ignoring how Adora's eyes lit up in misplaced hope for a heartbeat, before Catra ripped it from her grasp, stomped on it and ground it into the floor. "But that was a long time ago. You killed her."

Catra walked away, footsteps clicking on the metal flooring as she tried to ignore what sounded like muffled sobs from the girl she had just left in the doorframe of the bathroom. Rounding the corner that separated the bathroom to the control room, Catra leant back against one of the walls and took one deep breath to shove her emotions down.

She was done with Adora. No matter how much the tears threatened to fall.

The door to the control room opened and Force Commander Catra stepped through. If anyone noticed that her eyes were a little more red than usual, no one commented.

Sparkles was a genuinely terrible liar. It had started off as "Maybe we should do watches, in case something happens", which Catra had immediately countered by offering to stay awake - ironically for the exact same reasons that Sparkles had been wanting someone to stay awake. The distrust was blatant and yet the Princess refused to openly state her prejudice, something that Catra had a *wonderful* time messing with her over, all whilst 'not understanding' her point.

Then little miss perfect hero jumped in and offered to pull a dual shift with Catra, and the feline realised that her chances of getting *any* sleep at all would be fucking zero, given that the duo would be sharing one of the three blankets that the... *Uhg,* 'Best Friends Squad' had brought with them to deal with the sub zero temperatures in the Crimson Wastes at night time that the 'Super Pal Trio' had planned to counter by sleeping in the transport.

Well, in reality they had brought four with them, but Scorpia was far bigger than anyone else and needed one to herself, and Entrapta had taken away any chance that Catra had at sharing with her when the tinkerer Princess had crawled straight out of an air vent (this time in the floor), taken the blanket reserved for her, then ducked away back into the vents before anyone had managed a word. (It would later transpire that Entrapta spent the night in the starboard engine nacelle working and sleeping amongst a copious [any] amount of sand and grease, and Catra had to admit she'd rather spend the night freezing to death, or hell even under Adora's blanket, than that.)

She was just glad that she wasn't sharing with Sparkles - the only thing to come out of that arrangement would have been a *body* .

By the time that everyone had managed to get themselves tucked into wherever they had chosen to sleep, Catra was still sitting up next to the portable stove, leaning against the side of the command chair, preferring to rely on flickering orange flame for as long as possible as opposed to the company of the blonde who she had done so much ill to. The cold was nipping at her shoulders, but the feline was more concerned with the slowly withering flame and the shortness of fuel that they had on them, having to spare enough for the cooking of breakfast in the morning.

For her part, Adora was continuing the irritating habit of getting annoyingly close to the feline without invading her personal space too much, but more than enough to make her presence known to the feline. Catra suspected that she either wanted the feline's attention, but also didn't want to make it too blatant, which was fine. If Adora wanted to play like that, then Catra would just ignore her until she got blatant.

Which is how Adora ended up practically leaning against Catra, with the feline sorely regretting her decision to give the blonde so much leeway.

The flame flickered in an odd way, accompanied by a soft *crack* of some pocket of air in the fuel being exposed to the heat, and for a brief heartbeat, Catra's mind pulled her from the present with a jolt that swamped her vision with darkness.

Around her, the village burned, the same crackle of flames dancing high into the heavens over what had once been a small town caught in the midst of some unnamed celebration that she couldn't care about in the slightest. The heavy metallic clanking and shifting of gears and machinery so familiar at this point dominated the air, with only the distant undertones of screams breaking the monotony, lasting for only a second before being cut short by the weapons of war.

It was a familiar scene - one that wouldn't leave her no matter how little she cared, one that *couldn't* leave her. She had seen it too often, had it *seared* into her mind by the sheer number of

times that it had been played out in front of her, both physically and mentally.

This town was familiar though, the one that Catra viewed as a Lazarus moment - The death of Senior Cadet Catra and the birth of Force Commander Catra. A birth amidst the fire and horrors of war that the blonde girl had found so addictive that she had betrayed her family to perpetuate, prolonging the suffering of the people of Etheria and adding countless dead to the tolls.

The air was choked with the scents of war - the rancid smell of engine exhaust, the wood smoke of the flames, the thick, metallic taste of blood and the morbid scent of corpses being burned away into ash.

It had been drilled into her head long ago, a phrase that the Horde threw around quite casually, one that served as their *casus belli* for atrocities. "There are no innocents in war", and staring at the bodies, none of whom she knew, nor cared about, Catra knew that phrase would again be used to justify this massacre - the massacre she had perpetrated in the name of the *Horde,* for the woman she loathed.

But the statement that she had applied here had a second part - a treasonous whisper, a betrayal of the Horde and the only family that every soldier knew. There were no innocents in war - just victims.

Victims that Catra had caused.

She had no attachment to them - knew none of them, nor cared about their passing - but they constantly haunted her dreams.

Her fists tightened, the sharp prick of her claws against her palms tearing the tender flesh and sending a jab of pain through her nervous system, tearing her from her mind and brusquely dumping her back into the real world, staring at the licking flames with a blank emptiness that portrayed the inside of her mind. She just felt.. *Empty,* devoid of sensation or feeling.

The acidic smoke burned her nostrils, and Force Commander Catra leant forwards and flicked off the flame, letting the glow die out and smoulder into embers as she forced her mind elsewhere.

A gentle squeeze of her shoulder, one she would have been inclined to allow, had she not been staring at the ashen haired giant - from whom Catra exclusively allowed any sort of emotional contact to come from - sleeping, thus leaving only one culprit for the sudden touch.

Her left hand raised of its own accord as the feline batted Adora's hand from its place on her shoulder, re-establishing her personal space with the sharp motion and driving the blonde back from her immediate vicinity. Primal nature took over as Catra's lips parted slightly, a soft and low growl escaping her throat just loud enough to get the point across, the blonde skirting back to an.. acceptable distance before quite annoyingly stopping and patiently waiting for Catra to stop.

With the last of her breath, Catra picked up the volume and intensity of the growl, but Adora sat there, patiently waiting at a distance. *The* distance - the one that she and Catra had negotiated all those years ago when the feline had first hidden herself away. If Adora expected something so *simple* to win her over, she had another thing coming.

The dying tunes of the growl choked awkwardly in her throat, leaving Catra verbally stumbling over herself as she bit back the awkward noise that lingered, something that Catra silently cursed herself for as she cleared her throat and glared at Adora, daring the other girl to call her out on her mistake.

For her part, Adora simply waited a few extra seconds before fully sitting upright against the command chair and finally speaking, putting an end to the awkward dance that they had been doing around each other. “How are you, Catra?”

“I thought we answered this question.” Short responses - nothing more. There was no need.

“I’m being serious, Catra.” Blondie made a noise of exasperation, folding her arms across her chest and staring at Catra unimpressed.

“We figured this out already, *Princess.* Catra is dead, I’m all that’s left.” Force Commander Catra bit back in response, shoving the frightened and stupid girl inside her down forcefully. She didn’t know what Catra did. She lived in a fantastical world without any

drive or motivation. She was the stupid girl Catra would have been if Adora hadn't left.

"Fine." With a huff, Adora's pleasantries vanished, replaced instead by the girl who faced Force Commander Catra in combat time and time again, who bore the scars of their fights - mental and physical. "How is Force Commander Catra doing?"

"…" *Fuck, she's really not going to let up, is she? Fine.* Groaning exasperatedly and with deliberate exaggeration, Catra sighed. "Fine. I've got a blonde idiot bothering me, but I suppose I'll survive otherwise."

Adora frowned for a second, and Catra could practically *see* the gears turning in her head almost comically slowly. Catra groaned aloud, rolling her eyes and staring sidelong at the blonde. "You, dumbass."

"I knew that!" Adora's grin was infectious - and Catra would blame Scorpia for what happened next. For a brief moment, a similar smile broke through the façade on the feline's features, before it was wiped away in the hollow void of slight contempt on her features.

The look in Adora's eyes told Catra that her mistake had not been missed, and so the feline changed the topic to distract the blonde - something she hoped was as easy as it used to be. "Why do you insist on bothering me?"

"Wha- hey, I thought I was asking questions." Adora's indignant cry was answered by Catra baring her teeth slightly in a grin, although there was very little amusing about the situation.

"A question for a question Blondie." Adora didn't get to do *all* the prying.

The blonde huffed. "Fine. Ask."

Ah shit. I've got to ask ***something*** ..

"What's the deal with Sparkles and Arrow Boy? They're practically *hanging off* each other." Jabbing her thumb over her shoulder in the direction of the sleeping Archer, who was being held around the midriff by a tan arm that was extending from an otherwise unremarkable lump in the blanket, Catra turned back and was met with the flat expression of the blonde, looking completely confused.

"Uh… what do you mean? They're friends. Have been for years." Catra scowled, glaring at Adora. That was the greatest load of shit that Catra had been told in *months* . And by *Adora* of all people - had she suddenly got good at lying?

"Yeah right. You think I'm blind or stupid?"

The blonde looked offended. "What?"

Catra blinked. Then she blinked again. Only on the third blink did realisation slap her across the face, pulling her lips into a pursed ‘o’ shape as she struggled to hide the slightly sadistic amusement. A cackle escaped her, softer at first but quickly building up in scale as the sheer insane predictability of Adora managed to completely subvert her expectations of the blonde. *Sometimes I forget she's still just Adora*

“Stars, you’re still such a dummy. They’re *in love,* Adora. Friends don’t cuddle like that.” Catra jabbed her thumb back at the couple. Sure, she had just exposed herself knowing the answer to her question, thus negating the whole point of it, but the chance to rub it in Adora’s face was so much better.

"What? No, they're not.." Adora's face twisted from the stunned and blank expression into one of intense thought, scrunching up her face and thinking over something in her head as Catra ran the conversation she had just had with the blonde by herself one more time, coming to a screeching halt herself. Her eyes began to widen, something she counter by biting down on her lower lip and raising a claw, staring at it to distract herself from the chaotic internal thought process.

*I just called Adora 'Dummy', what the actual **fuck** is wrong with me.*

"... No." Adora seemed to have come to a conclusion - denial slash lying to herself. "No, they aren't.. They can't be."

"What - Scared that they'll stop caring about you? *Tch* ." Catra waved her hand dismissively. This was Adora's punishment then - to find new people, only for them to abandon her and focus on each other instead of her. Fitting really, to leave Catra behind, only to be ultimately left behind by the people she deserted the feline for.

"They wouldn't, Catra. People don't stop caring for their friends because they have other people closer." Catra cocked an eyebrow and turned her gaze back onto Adora out of the corner of her eye. *This* sounded like an argument in the making, one that Catra really didn't want to have now, so instead the topic was changed.

"What, jealous then?" Something unreadable flashed across the blonde's face, which in and of itself was something that displeased Catra, she liked being able to read the blonde so completely. It was strange that she was unable to. The unreadable emotion became one clearer and more apparent - Adora looked.. Mournful, longing even.

“No. Not jealous.” Adora’s tone was dejected, downtrodden and almost depressive in tone - like she was a child constantly trying to impress a parent, yet only got scorn for her efforts- *I need to come up with new analogies.*

“Oh goodie you care about them. You of all people should know how dangerous that is, Adora.”

“What do you mean dangerous? Caring is good, it keeps you healthy mentally and it's nice to know people care about you.”

Catra scowled. “Uh, yeah no. You should know - all lives end, and in the end, all hearts get broken. Caring *isn’t* an advantage, Adora. Besides - I’m fine, and no one cares about me.” The bitterly spat conclusion hid the fact that, ultimately, she didn’t actually finish her statement, yet the implications were there and Catra felt a pang of victory rocket through her as Adora flinched away from her briefly.

Not anymore .

"I never stopped caring Catra." The revenant whisper placed yet another lump in Catra's throat and doused the spark of victory inside. With just five words, Adora had managed to totally tip the playing field and leave Catra the vulnerable one instead of Adora, who by all right should still have been reeling from Catra's blow.

"Now's as good of a time as any to stop.." *Retaliate* . *Have to retaliate. Keep her talking instead of thinking.* "I don't deserve your compassion… Not after what I've done.”

Despite her goal, the retaliation that left Catra's mouth made her feel even *more* vulnerable than before, and the authoritative and powerful tone that Force Commander Catra had been going for was instead turned into the positively pitiful cry of a girl knowing that she wanted something she couldn't. Mentally moving to try again, Force Commander Catra found herself locked out by the girl she had thought dead, Catra.

"Catra.." Adora interrupted what would have been a truly spectacular battle - had it not been happening inside the head of Catra in such a way that would probably have her taken off any sort of duty that involved responsibility if anyone else learned of it. The careful and gentle tone, Catra realised, was not the blonde patronising her or placing her upon some pedestal, only to be looked at and never touched, but was instead the girl responding to *Catra's* accidental vulnerability in the only way that she knew how - her own. "Why do you think you're beyond forgiveness?"

The surprised laugh left the feline's mouth, just two notes a heartbeat apart. "Eh heh? What? Adora, you *know* what I've done. I've orchestrated the greatest calamity to *ever* befall this planet - I've watched lives end and creations *burn* . I've *made* creations burn, and I've ended more lives than I would care to admit. I have seen things you could not believe, I have done things you would *never* understand.. And when I close my eyes Adora - I hear more screams than you could ever count."

What started as a simple response turned into an emotional tirade, the stream of words shifting quickly into rapids before a waterfall, the roaring crescendo reached as Catra turned back towards Adora, her voice dropping for the final line as the girl of only nineteen years drove home her point. A bitter laugh left her as she again turned away to blink back the tears behind her eyes as she found herself on the precipice of change, dark and misty and without any defined or clear path.

Made my point... Fuck..

"You.." Adora inhaled, holding her breath for a few seconds as Catra tensely waited the revulsion and the rage to come her way -

it was expected... No, perhaps it was more deserved than anything else. She didn't want it, but it was coming regardless. Adora exhaled softly, having evidently composed herself to the point of speaking. "You think you're evil, then? Unable to change? Permanently stuck as this cruel girl who replaced the only good thing in my life? Well here's a news flash. People change. *You* can change. You think you're unforgiveable? Here's the unforeseeable, *I forgive you!"*

A heartbeat of silence, granted by the stunned silence that was currently holding the feline back from forming any sort of cohesive thought. Then it returned in full force - the uncertainty, the nerves and the fear - the fear of being lied to and the fear of having her hopes raised only for them to be crushed again like they had been so many times in her life. ".. *Why!?* "

Adora blinked, caught evidently off guard as Catra wheeled back around, not giving the blonde the chance to respond. The emotional floodgates burst and the dams collapsed as Catra slowly unravelled in the presence of the one person she swore to never unravel in front of again. “What have I done that is deserving of forgiveness!? I’ve done nothing but tear into you for years now! I’ve scarred and abused you. I've killed, maimed and tortured people. I've burned towns and I've razed people's life labours. What have I done to deserve forgiveness?!”

Catra could feel the bitter tears pooling behind her eyes, but didn’t dare to break her gaze from Adora’s face - the scars she had caused on Adora's face, her hard expression the keystone holding together her whole façade that she was unwilling to let crash down - the last thing keeping her expression from falling into the murky emotional floodwaters that roared beneath the surface. Adora was silent for a moment, before speaking in the

tender tone again. “Forgiveness isn’t something earned, Catra. To forgive is an act of compassion. It’s not done because people deserve it, it's done because they *need* it."

The easy response was presented to Catra practically on a golden platter. *I don't need it.* She could say. *I never needed it - I'll never need it.* And yet, there was no desire to do so, no urge to push Adora away now when she was at the most vulnerable she had been around Catra in *years* , when Adora was the easiest to hurt and when Catra held all the cards, there was no drive. Instead there was only a dejected look and a bitter response.

"Yeah.. Well, maybe I'm the exception... Maybe I don't deserve it anyway."

Her tan skin, cold to the touch from exposure to the cool air that now dominated the room in the wake of the fires extinguishing, suddenly blazed as her left shoulder was enveloped in a warm grasp, one that rode nerves of deep rooted stability and safety. It was comfortable, it felt *right* and it had happened so many times before in their lives - Adora's hand resting on Catra's shoulder after a particularly brutal day - a soft encouragement to carry on the struggle until it was their time to do the ruling.

The feline flinched away - her reflexes triumphing over the instinctual urge to sit there and let Adora comfort her. The blonde looked a little disheartened by the gesture, but nowhere near as much as Catra felt she should feel - and if anything seemed more emboldened by the feline's reaction than anything else. Adora pulled her thinking face - staring off into the distance as her eyebrow twitched up in a strange manner. Something about it

made Catra feel uneasy - especially as Adora immediately spoke afterwards.

"Thank you.. Catra. For today."

A cautious and suspicious glance sidelong at the blonde, a careful reply. "Don't mention it."

"Seriously Catra. Thank you."

A noise of irritation slipped past her thin lips, the lack of sleep beginning to pull on her nerves and slowly unravel the uncharacteristic serenity and passivity of the feline, and began to stitch it back into the familiar form of Force Commander Catra's irritation and anger. "I was being serious too. Don't. Mention. It."

The look on Adora's face told Catra that she had shut the line of conversation down quite handily, the blondes pursed lips and far off look again giving away the schemes that were undoubtedly going on inside her head. Catra turned her gaze back to the last softly glowing embers of the hearth and the fuel that had long since been extinguished, if only to stop her irritating habit of staring at Adora. It was then the blonde spoke.

"I'm going to turn in for the night. You should get some sleep."

Another annoyed noise - accompanied by Catra not turning her head as Adora set about making herself ready for bed, a very clear spot left open for the feline in the bedding next to the blonde. A grumbled response came a half minute later. "I'll keep watch until the next shift."

Evidently sleep deprived herself - and as a consequence not thinking about the fact that there were no "shifts", Adora simply nodded and yawned, being tuned out by the feline after a few minutes, once Catra could definitively tell that the Princess had slipped into proper sleep as opposed to feigning it. No way in hell was she actually going to sleep next to Adora - that would be far too much like treason, but sticking her legs under the blanket and keeping watch was.. Acceptable.

As evening turned to morning, Catra stared out the window at the few slivers of moonlight that managed to pierce the inky darkness of the shifting sands that pressed down upon the ship beneath it, held at bay by the glass that had supposedly once held space at bay. She tried to wonder what space was like - could people survive there in the inky void beyond Etheria? Was there life on the moons that surrounded the planet? If so, did they know about Etheria?

Staring into the glowing moon, the feline sighed, expelling the building pressure and stress in one great breath that left her feeling shorter and more deflated than she usually felt after a day of work. *I let myself get too friendly with Adora... This can't happen again.*

Clutching the small sensation of abject *safety* that had been brewing all throughout her conversation - and indeed all through

the evening - Catra reverently locked it away inside herself - swearing that she would get rid of it at some point.

Eventually.

Catra IX

Chapter Notes

> I'm not dead! Just had Uni shit to get through and I took a little bit to ensure that I didn't burn out, apologies for the wait.

Dawn came too quickly.

She could feel the faintest ebb of the wound to her back still present - a slightly stiff muscle on one side and that ghostly echoes of pain on the other, bouncing between the frayed ends of the nerves cut by the blade. It would be weird, not feeling any sensation there ever again - a dull and empty scar upon her body - but it was one that Catra didn't really have a choice in handling. It was with her forever.

She had a lot of those - things that would stay with her forever. Scars that would never heal, knowledge that could never be forgotten, memories that would never fade, no matter how hard she tried. *Guess I'm becoming a creature of absolutes. Carving out my niche in time.*

The blinding beams of daymoon light had burst through the small parts of the bridge canopy not buried under the shifting sands with predictable results, the feline having slowly watched the blazing light creep down the back wall of the room like snipers scanning for targets, and Catra had a damn good feeling where they were going to end up - blinding her. She'd move before then though, if she even could.

Pulling her gaze away from the beams of light, Catra yet again cast her disinterested gaze at the complete idiot who had thrown away everything she had ever learned about sleeping in safe places in the field and had pretty much *snuggled* up against the leg of a person who was about five seconds away from *gutting* her. The feline had really considered shoving Adora away at several points, but the air on her upper torso was *frigid* , and she had ultimately come to the conclusion that she was completely *fucked* the second that she had gotten under that blanket in the first place.

Her disinterested gaze panned over to the massive lump that was Scorpia, wrapped in an almost cocoon of her blanket that looked warm, if not particularly comfortable if the stretched fabric around the barbs on her carapace were anything to go by. Probably a good call to leave the Scorpion by herself.

There had been a number of loud thumps, crashes and what sounded suspiciously like the noise of machinery being worked on for about an hour now, which told Catra that either the Desert Waste had some *extraordinarily* intelligent and capable rodent life, or that the Tinkerer Princess had woken up and was wreaking absolute chaos across the ship. She hoped it was the latter, otherwise Adora would bring up the stupid mouse comment.

Then there was the final sleeping arrangement present, one that Catra practically had to turn her head with her *hands* to muster the energy (or will power) to look at. Unsurprisingly, the duo of Sparkles and Bow were still snuggled (a phrase that she nearly *gagged* at the thought of) under the blanket behind her and Adora, and hadn't moved in hours and in all honesty probably wouldn't for a long while. Just the picture of *fucking* domesticity.

Carefully leaning forward, the feline raised a hand to her back, or more specifically to where the sword had sliced into her shoulder blades the day before - calloused fingers rubbing over the ghostly remains of a scar that should have been a barely healed wound if not for Horde field medicine. Unsurprisingly, the sensation of her fingers on her bare back barely registered in the dead patch, a few ghostly ebbs from where she brushed either side of the scarred tissue, but nought else. It wasn't so much.. Uncomfortable, just strange - unfamiliar.

Speaking of unfamiliar things - Adora.

Catra's hearing was good - not good enough to register the increased heart rate that occurred when leaving REM sleep, but good enough that she registered the blonde's increased rate of breathing - indicative of her stirring at the very least, or waking up. Tactical - yet lethargic and morbid - thoughts rose up, questioning her devotion to duty. What stopped her from just.. Gutting Adora where she slept, or even just going for the clean and quick kill, then moving on to Sparkles and Bow. Absolutely *nothing.*

Just her honour. Or what was *left* of it. You don’t tend to keep a lot around when you've oppressed thousands and killed hundreds with your own hands.

There might have been something else at some point in her life, a childish desire to maintain the friendship that had been so thoroughly annihilated by the stresses and the horrors of the war that they had been perpetuating, the horrors they had been

inflicting on the people of Etheria. But there wasn't a chance any more, not for the rest of time. No way to return to the naïveté of her youth, no way to ignore the years apart.

No way to ignore the fact that her heart sometimes rebelled against her.

It was an infuriating sensation, to feel the one part of her that she could not suppress, constantly flaunting the fact that it rebelled and opposed her - a sensation that made her feel like *Shadow Weaver* did about herself, something she loathed beyond anyone's comprehension. It was a fury that blazed inside her - one that ate her up, that sent aches tearing through her chest, that had ripped sleep away from her, not that she would have tried to next to Adora. Too fucking domestic.

She wasn't going back to that point in her life. She'd rather let the whole damn world burn than to put herself back in that position, sideshow to Adora - practically her sidekick. Catra had done too much - achieved too much in life, known too many successes without Adora, and proved herself superior too often.

Submission was a fate worse than death.

Besides - whatever emotion, whatever pull that she was feeling to Adora would pass. Indeed, it already had in the past, when Adora had left and Catra had gone out of her way to tear every shred of care she had for Adora apart - she was the enemy then and she had been the enemy up until now.

A groan - a familiar one, one that meant that Adora hadn't had a comfortable night's sleep, which was pretty much to be expected when sleeping against a solid metal chair and on an unforgiving metal floor that in all honesty was probably better than the bed that they had shared in the Fright Zone, even with both of their 'mattresses' (if you could call the foam bricks that were mass produced for sleeping on, that) placed upon it.

Leaning back up against the metal chair, gently rolling her shoulder blades to iron out the crick in her neck, Catra forced her eyes open wide, blinking a few times and wiping the sleep from the corners of her eyes. There was a certain tiredness edging on the corners of her mind - an exhaustion that she could feel seeping into the stream of consciousness, but one that skittered away like a frightened animal when she focused upon it.

Adora’s eyes opened, searching the surroundings with a slow and languid sweep that suddenly turned alert - skittish and prepared for something, a motion that Catra relished in inspiring in the blonde's primal brain.

But then the satisfaction morphed itself into an ugly sensation of disgust as Adora *relaxed* upon locking eyes on her, the sensation of familiarity at this scene clawing at her throat in such a way that she could practically feel the urge to be ill - although that could be down to the sleep deprivation from the fact she had been up for going on 30 hours. She could feel the exhaustion, and if she tried to clutch it, the urge to sleep felt like it was within her grasp, although Catra knew it really wasn't. She'd spend at least two more hours awake trying to sleep before any rest graced her.

And of course, Adora was almost positively *chipper* , excitement and energy filling her eyes as she gave the feline a soft smile that made Catra's stomach churn uncomfortably. It could have been answered with a scowl, a barb or any other manner of responses, but Catra could barely bring herself to glare and rise to her feet in the cool air of the cockpit, leaving the warmth of the blanket for the comfortable embrace of the air.

Even as she walked away towards the bathroom, she could feel Adora's eyes boring into her back, and that smile cut yet another scar across her shoulder blades.

Teeth ground on teeth as the door shut behind her, severing their contact.

By the time that Catra came back through the door of the crashed starship's bridge, the rest of the uneasy alliance was awake, sitting around the fire and chatting in hushed, if friendly tones that tapered out and died the moment that the feline stalked her way back into the room. It was a satisfying sensation, to have her mere presence be a factor that commanded such intense attention from those around her, friend and foe alike.

It was enough to bring the self satisfied smirk that often consumed her emotional expressions before fights, back into the equation - hiding the rage and sorrow, hate and love that had battled for control of her in her brief time away.

Catra was dead - Long live Force Commander Catra.

Staring down at the rest of the group, Catra's eyebrow did a slight twitch at the absence of the Tinkerer Princess, but to be brutally honest, she didn't particularly feel like crawling through air vents to find her. Scorpia was still here, although fraternising with the enemy, so the feline took a seat next to her and just stared at the flame of the portable stove, letting the silence that her presence commanded dominate the space in such a way that anyone trying to talk would find it horrifically awkward.

Perfect .

Of course, she had overlooked the fact that it would take an irritating awkward idiot to break the silence, and there was indeed one in attendance. As the start of the pensive question rang out, Catra forced her eye to not twitch in annoyance. Why did Adora *have* to start a conversation?

"So... Catra.. Where's the.. Y'know. Sword."

Pulling her irate gaze to her right at a leisurely pace to show exactly how much she *did not at all* care about the stupid sword, Catra rolled her eyes and drawled out a response. "Why would I know? You're 'She Ra'. Don't you know where it is?"

"No I don't ' *know where it is* '." The annoyed, but not sharp snap from Adora jolted a little surprise into the feline, accompanied by

a spark of interest. That seemed like a sore spot to say the very least, a revelation that drew the corners of Catra's mouth up into curls. "Last I saw it was.. Yesterday."

Catra had no clue as to why Adora was so adverse to stating the obvious - that they were beating the ever living shit out of each other - but it may have been because the feline could see the gears barely turning in Adora's stupid empty head, slowly and surely winding towards producing an intelligent thought. For her part, Catra had perhaps one guess, one that she voiced after watching Adora stumble over her mumbled recounting of the battle under her breath.

"Fucking- ok. I genuinely can derive no more enjoyment from listening to you stumble over yourself. Thing's probably outside where you dropped it..." Catra shrugged, waving a hand dismissively, grumbling under her breath. That outburst should have made her feel better - all she felt was annoyed. Adora fixed her with a hard look.

"Outside."

"... Uh, did I stutter? Yeah, outside."

"With the Sand Crawlers."

"Uh, yeah, where else?"

"Couldn't you have grabbed it?" Sparkles interjected with her shrill fucking voice that Catra had been enjoying the *absence* of, the feline rolling her eyes and staring down the Princess with a deadpan expression that was accompanied by a similar tone in her voice.

"Gee Sparkles, I would have but there was this big heavy blonde dumbass I had to make sure didn't get turned into worm food, and I can't fucking *teleport* like ***some*** people around here." The Princess's expression went from irritated, to embarrassed, to *very* embarrassed and finally settled on a simmering rage that would have probably scared the common Horde soldier, had it not been for the clearly embarrassed dusting of crimson that covered her cheeks. Catra, naturally, still could not find herself satisfied or amused by the situation.

Choosing now, when the two people who were most likely to bash heads with her were off balance, be it mentally or emotionally, Catra clapped her hands together and tried to look just a little bit pleased with herself. Turning to Bow and Scorpia, she forced a slightly pleased tone into her voice and lied right through her teeth. "Right. What's for breakfast? I'm starved."

The barely concealed concern on Scorpia's face told her that she had not been nearly as convincing as she had hoped to be - but Catra ignored that and instead focused on selling it to the sole male. He seemed to buy it.

Catra had a renewed apathy for Adora's plans.

Her latest plan consisted of pretty much making a run for the gold and crystal sword that was buried almost completely up to its hilt in the sand, its polished finishing glinting against the harsh rays of the lunar light that blazed down upon the desert. When asked what the rest of them would do in the plan, the blonde only had a blank expression to offer.

Of course - after all this time she still wants all the glory for herself. How the actual fuck haven't we beaten them.

Well actually that's easy - Shadow Weaver is an incompetent ***bitch*** *who wouldn't know strategy if I tore her eyes out with it.*

"Catra."

"Hmm?" Pressing her eyelids closed and rubbing her left eye, the feline turned her attention back to the other five members of the uneasy alliance against the fuckin nightmare worms - the Tinkerer Princess having rocked up half way through breakfast ranting about someone named 'Keira'. Perhaps if Catra had enough sleep, she'd be more interested, but she really could not conjure forth the energy to appear interested, so it fell by the wayside.

"I asked if you were ready?" Adora's tone was a little annoyed, but it shifted to a mask of concern that had the feline scowling as she stared at the blonde. She didn't need Adora's sympathy and

she did no at all need the blonde caring about how she was - that was tantamount to being on the same side.

Momentary clarity and Catra's expression turned into a scowl. "Oh you're not fucking serious, are you? *REALLY* Adora? A frontal charge?"

"Do you have a *better* idea?"

"Yeah - Sparkles. Teleport out there, grab the thing and come back." A bemused blink, but the feline was on a roll, and she didn't stop. "Or better yet - teleport out there, grab it and get eaten. Might shut you up."

That brought a scowl from Adora and Sparkles, and that was a victory that actually felt remotely like one. Still, Adora shook her head. "It's too dangerous - it could be a trap. Everyone ready?"

Catra blinked incredulously, staring at the idiots utilising some of the dumbest reasoning that she had ever heard. Muttering under her breath, she turned to face the duo she had arrived with. " ' *It could be a trap, so lets charge in and spring it'* fucking *hell* Adora.."

Raising her voice to a normal level, she met Scorpia's gaze with a disinterested look of her own. "Keep Entrapta safe. I'm going to see if I can get one of ‘em killed."

With a disinterested and lazy salute, Catra turned around and followed the trio of idiots out of the crashed ship and into a - fucking *surprise, surprise* , an ambush.

The blonde was just about to grab the sword when the ground under it surged upwards and the long and muscular body of the Sand Crawler sent the glittering weapon, along with about a metric ton of sand, into the sky, raining down upon the ground around them and sending the blonde stumbling away, buried firmly in the creatures shadow. If not for the wink of magic that signified the fact that Adora had just been rescued from her certain death by Sparkles, Catra would have written her off as dead.

Admittedly, two of the 'Best Friends Squad' were in no position to fight these enemies, and Catra herself wasn't well suited either, but Bow *was.* A trio of arrows buried themselves into the thick hide of the Sand Crawler, clicked once and then detonated, blasting the creature sidewards and awkwardly onto the ground, although it scythed through the sand disturbingly quickly, and before anyone could exploit its weakness.

Catra found herself glancing back at the ship with trepidation. Flight was *so* preferable to fight at this point and it took a not insignificant amount of willpower to stay where she was, carefully stepping as to not nullify what audio that she could hear. A sudden rumble to her left sent her stumbling backwards, quickly shifting into a sprint as the worm burst up from the sand behind her and loomed large overhead, arcing up-

And *over* her.

And coming slamming down out of her path.

Riiiight on top of the golden and crystalline sword that they had so desperately been trying to reach, dragging it down into the depths of the Crimson Wastes.

Stunned silence for a heartbeat.

"Fuck."

Adora was caught in a moment of shock, as were Bow and Sparkles, but Catra recognised this for what it was. An ultimate victory. There was no more She Ra, not unless they excavated the entire Crimson Wastes to find that stupid sword. This had been the *best day of her life* in hindsight. A bitter and vicious chuckle escaped her, shifting into laughter that rang out through the sand.

And naturally, that distraction, along with a stupid amount of noise that she was making, leant itself to getting ambushed.

Her vision was momentarily torn away as her reflexes moved faster than her brain, snapping her eyes shut as the ground in front of her erupted in sand and chitin, the click of a leg snapping in two like a toothpick sending a truly agonising pain right through

her nervous system, tearing away all other mental functions. She wanted to scream - to howl and to cry, but none of them came.

Instead all that she was aware of was her canines sinking into her lip hard enough to draw blood, a slick sheen of blood staining her teeth as she hit the ground back first, the otherwise hard impact cushioned by the sand that contained a monster.

Catra was vaguely aware someone was screaming in horror, and the thought had crossed her mind that it might have even been her screaming, but ultimately she was more concerned with the sight above her. The looming maw of the Sand Crawler towering over her, prepared to slam down and swallow her whole, the mass of teeth probably tearing her apart as she passed through its throat.

A figure darted between her and the Sand Crawler, the unkempt mane of Adora's blonde hair, torn free from the ponytail by the fighting - if one could call being thoroughly dominated by a glorified worm fighting - coming into her vision and giving the towering worm a moment's hesitation as it registered the new target in front of it. *Idiot... You're gonna die with me..*

Adora's empty hand flashed skywards as she screamed the phrase Catra had heard so many times before. Even though she was completely unarmed, Catra could barely make out flickering light in the palm of Adora's outstretched hand.

"***FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!***"

The blinding light tore everyone's gaze away, even the enormous Sand Crawlers whose eyes were used to the harsh and cruel glare of the unforgiving lunar light blazing down from above. There was something almost.. Ethereal about the whole affair however, and Catra had never felt so at peace, despite the screaming pain in her... Leg..

The pain in Catra's leg had dulled to the point that she momentarily forgot that she was even wounded, the feline even attempting to use the limb to push herself back, but even then the pain that should have rocketed through her system was barely present, just a dull ache. She *knew* that compound fractures should not go numb that fast, which either meant that she was in shock, or *magic* had something to do with this.

What has she done this tim...e..

The light faded and Catra found herself staring, slack jawed, at the woman towering over her protectively, holding a technicolour sword seemingly hewed from the very light itself. The sword - however, seemed wrong.. Unfamiliar even.

The mix of the dull throb in her head and the sight that befell her when she actually *looked* at the figure killed her train of thought in a heartbeat. *Those legs should be* ***illegal*** .

White boots that melded seamlessly into long white pants, adorned with golden patterning that almost looked like wings, a

half cape from her waist down, leading up into a sleeveless white shirt, adorned with golden accents. A long mane of light blonde hair flowed magnificently in a ponytail, with a tiara perched atop her head in a way that looked eerily familiar to the feline, but the fog of the pain clouded her judgement.

And besides, her eyes were too busy *searing* the sight before her into her long term memory, *permanently* .

The Sand Crawler that had been looming over Catra instead towered over the blonde princess, roaring a vicious challenge that pulled the blonde's attention away from Catra (had she *really* not noticed Adora staring at her?), and towards the beast, her expression hardening as she raised the sword in a basic two handed hold. With a single slash through the air, a scything beam of technicolour light *vaporised* the beast into nothing but a few flecks of ash.

... Adora has become an eight foot tall Princess who shoots rainbow laser beams..

Another pulse of light was all she saw as the pain *finally* overcame her nervous system, and quite mercifully, the disturbingly attractive Adora vanished from her line of sight as her vision collapsed into blackness.

Consciousness briefly flashed back, the lucidity that she would have loved stripped away by what felt like some *serious* painkillers coursing through her veins. She could see Adora's stupid, goofy, adorable and yet oh-so elegant face above her, glowing slightly golden, as if someone was projecting an image of the ocean's waves onto it.

There was something around her - like.. Bindings, but not as tight or harsh. Warmer too, comfortingly so.

Arms. Adora's arms. Adora was holding her.

Her leg didn't hurt - not at all even, although that was probably because she was doped up with enough painkillers to down that giant boar-hog-thing that she had been so focused on driving away from the logging operation on the edge of the Whispering Woods.

She wondered where that thing was - if it had been finally killed in her absence, or if it was just running around like a mindless beast and wrecking things.

That'd be more paperwork.

.. What was Adora doing here..

She pressed her eyelids shut, trying to bush aside the foggy memories and thoughts that assailed her consciousness, fuelled by the painkillers. When she opened her eyes, Scorpia was above her, looking down at her with concern that she really did not deserve. *Scorpia is too good to me* ..

The ashen haired woman's cheeks grew a dusting of crimson, and Catra took a stab in the dark in thinking that she said that aloud when she really, really had not meant to.

A wink of light pulled her attention, her head lolling right to look at Adora as she was momentarily consumed in light, then turned back into herself - not the She Ra that Catra realised that she had indeed been staring at instead of the blonde girl who had just occupied a disturbing amount of her mind, looking tired - exhausted even.

Catra's world began to tip and darkness reclaimed her vision.

Bow I

Chapter Notes

> A/N: Apologies for the hella long delay on this one - I want to try to hit a once monthly post schedule at the slowest, but I will almost certainly pick up the pace from here as we enter the home stretch of the story. On another note - we've surpassed average Novel length so... currently processing that

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He didn't have to be an expert to know that the blow that Catra had taken a scarce half second prior was catastrophic to her combat abilities, even without the deeply unsettling *click* of her leg breaking like a wishbone. A dash of blood sliced through the air as she went over backwards, all while Adora screamed in horror at the sight.

Bow had never heard Adora truly scream, a bloodcurdling cry of dismay and despair, but also a cry that had the weight of promises unfulfilled, of words not spoken. It drilled at his very core - his own insecurities, and he had little doubt that he'd probably scream similarly if it was Glimmer in Catra's position.

Instead, he and Glimmer stood shellshocked, watching as Adora tore past them and towards Catra, the giant rearing Sand Crawler be damned apparently. She looked so utterly minuscule compared to the looming behemoth, but yet she seems so *powerful* , brimming with an unseen energy.

She was confident, bold, and strong. And she seemed determined, as if nothing would ever deter her from that path.

And she was *glowing.*

Not golden like she did as She-Ra. No, instead she was glowing with technicoloured light, every shade of the rainbow washing over her in a thin sheen that was brimming with so much energy that even Bow could *feel* it humming in the air. Glancing sidelong - just about the only action he could manage in that moment, still paralysed with fear and shock, Bow could see the effect it had on Glimmer, who herself was glowing with energy.

Then came that phrase - the familiar battle cry that shook him from his frozen position, this time punctuated by a fiercely protective tone and the roar of a warrior fighting for everything.

" ***FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!*** "

A blinding light consumed the blonde, forcing Bow's gaze away so as to not go blind at the sight that threatened to burn his retinas out. He could barely make out Glimmer next to him, also shielding herself from the immensely bright light, teeth grit firmly against each other.

Stumbling slightly, Bow moved over next to her, pulling the Princess against his body in a consciously cautious and caring,

and also an unconsciously possessive action that Glimmer herself reciprocated.

"What was-"

Glimmer cut off as she turned around once the light stopped blazing past them, her arm lowering as she set eyes on what had to be Adora. As Bow followed her lead, he too came to a sudden stop as he stared in awe at the sight before him.

It was *She-Ra* .

But not Adora's old She-Ra form, not the youthful and almost childlike form that Bow had become so accustomed to. No, this one looked mature, powerful, beautiful even - truly worthy of the 'Warrior Princess' moniker associated with She-Ra.

And he was well aware that Glimmer was not the only other person looking.

Catra, whose leg had to be causing her a serious amount of pain, seemed to be suffering from none of the side effects of the compound fracture to her leg - aside from the fact that she was still immobile. Instead, she was busy staring up at Adora, who was in turn looking back at her.

But the look Catra was giving Adora certainly set off some flags in Bow's mind - it was appreciative, physical and appraising, but under it all was a hunger - a carnal desire.

Catra was checking Adora out.

Well at least it wasn't a one sided attraction like he feared.

Even on day one in Bright Moon, Bow had been able to tell Adora had some connection to Catra that went beyond purely being friends, no matter how close they were. Catra had become a reverent word around Adora - with the exception of combat.

Ironically, however, it had taken both Bow and Glimmer until a.. Certain occasions to realise not only were they both in love with each other, but Adora harboured some seriously repressed feelings for Catra. Regardless of that milestone in their relationship, Adora's feelings for Catra had become an argument point for them.

Glimmer was in favour, naturally, of upending the whole situation by openly confronting Adora about it, and in the process probably annoying Adora, making her doubt herself (which no one wanted more of), and potentially ruining her shot at getting Catra back. Bow couldn't blame her - Glimmer was a creature of action after all and had little patience.

Bow had been more in favour of letting Adora figure it out herself - she had to eventually.

Nearly half a year later - Adora seemed to have figured it out when on a mission with Glimmer, who spent a good long while watching Adora intently staring at Catra.

But since most of their time around Catra was in combat, they didn't have any sort of comparison to go off.

Until now.

Admittedly the situation (which would have otherwise been fairly straight forward) was convoluted by the fact that they were the leaders of both sides of the war, and ostensibly were fighting for the soul of the planet.

It had to be soul - the last time someone made that analogy and used the phrase 'Heart of Etheria' Adora nearly had a panic attack.

But that aside, it did not take a genius to realise that even though the girls had grown up together, the war that they fought against each other had changed them - made them weary and scarred them with its horrors. Everyone was a damaged soul on this planet, and Catra and Adora were the most damaged.

And then he saw it.

The outfit.

Adora had turned to look at them briefly, and Bow recognised one thing in a heartbeat. Adora was wearing Catra's headpiece in the gold and white colour scheme of She-Ra.

And then there was the half cape, like Glimmer.

And the heart on her sternum.

Adora's She-Ra form was a *part* of herself, far more than he thought before.

So.. Had she just accepted it, or..-

Theories later.

Bow managed to find Glimmer's hand whilst staring at Adora, fumbling for a second before locking their fingers together, giving the Princess' hand a tender squeeze as prompting. Normally he'd not have done so - Glimmer was fairly on the ball when it came to teleporting, but Adora was glowing with a dangerous amount of energy blazing through her and along her sword, all radiating off her and leaving a metallic taste in the air, like Glimmer when she teleported too much.

The soft *wink* of magic filled his ears as his stomach churned with a comfortingly familiar sensation as the duo dematerialised as the Warrior Princess went supernova.

When the world came back to the normal level of brightness, Bow and Glimmer found the interesting sight of She-Ra cradling Catra tenderly, the feline clutched protectively in the grasp of the Princess, almost absorbed into her arms. Both were pulsing with the technicolour light that seemed to be the new normal with the Princess, and both had their eyes closed - Adora clearly in concentration and Catra as she had still not regained consciousness.

But the domesticity of the scene could fool anyone who did not know the finer details of the duo, and yet it also betrayed those fine details. It was an intimacy that showed they were familiar with each other, and at the very least that Adora harboured stronger feelings for Catra than was the norm, and yet they were caught in the clutches of a war that pitted them against each other.

It remained to be seen if they complemented each other, or would tear each other new wounds.

In his distraction, he had failed to notice Scorpia and Entrapta finally getting over to them, forming an awkward semicircle around the two girls in a way that felt almost voyeuristic, like they

were watching something intimate that was not at all meant for them. That much was compounded by the fact that Adora was speaking, barely audible words that reached his ears as indistinct whispers, but still maintained the tenderness that gave them a weight far beyond anything that Bow had seen in such an open setting.

No further thoughts down THAT particular alley ..

His momentary derailing of his train of thought meant that he missed the half groan, half comment that Catra gave, which turned Scorpia into a tomato right as Adora's body was once again consumed by the white light, leaving the blonde girl back in her own body, and looking particularly tired to boot. This was only confirmed as the blonde immediately began to tip forwards and close her eyes, saved only from getting a mouthful of sand by Glimmer managing to catch her shoulder and set her down in a slightly more dignified way than would have been otherwise achieved.

The momentary panic passed as quickly as it had come, bringing the entire situation back into context, and Bow found himself staring at the ashen haired Princess right as she turned to look at him, immediately disarming both of them and drawing out an awkward silence as they both waited for one to make a comment. Eventually, it was Scorpia who spoke.

"Soooo.. Uh. If you two don't uh.. Mind. I'm just gonna take Catra and we'll uh. Be off." The Scorpion Princess gingerly and awkwardly extracted Catra from next to the unconscious blonde, eyes never leaving Bow and Glimmer despite the careful manoeuvres, the normally intimidating Force Commander looking

positively tiny in the arms of the mountain of a woman holding her. Bow glanced sidelong at Glimmer, who in turn offered a slightly lost shrug. Made no sense trying to stop them.

"Let's... pretend this never happened.." Glimmer offered an awkward smile to Scorpia, one that Bow found himself echoing in a strained manner. Glimmer was always better at improvising a diplomatic route out when it came to charm - Bow was more a negotiator or a strategist.

"Yeah that would be.. Great. Wonderful even. It's just that Catra and I would probably get in trouble if the Horde knew that we let you guys go and I *really* don't want to have to fight you guys *and* look after Catra. Entrapta is enough of a handful *aaaand* where has she gone.."

Scorpia's monologue concluded with the Princess turning around, noting the absence of the Tinkerer who Bow could have sworn was standing next to them just a second before. A frustrating sense of déjà vu set in as Bow took a step back and looked around them, scanning furiously for the Tinkerer Princess, only to find her standing on her hair, right *behind him* , peering at his tracker pad with a curiosity that felt equal parts satisfying and unnerving.

" ***Gah!*** Stars - Entrapta could *please* not sneak up on me like that.."

"Your tracker pad is fascinating - it's much more advanced since the last time I saw it. How did you manage to get the scanner

working on such a low frequency?” The Princess curiously poked the pad at his hip, tilting her head as she peered closer at the device, a screwdriver in hand and a disturbingly keen glint in her eyes that told Bow his precious pad was seconds away from being dismantled. As such he jerked himself away, bumping into Glimmer and pulling his pad up to his chest to save it from the Princess.

“I reoriented the frequency to the low end and ran it through crystals from Bright Moon, now can you *please* not touch it!” His voice was shrill with worry, but that was one of the last things on his mind, far more concerned for the safety of his masterpiece that was flush against his chest. Entrapta also had repeatedly broadcasted the fact that her experiments had a disturbing habit of going up like a bomb with an even more disturbing regularity that gave him little confidence.

So no - not ever would she get her hands on his precious tracker pad.

The Tinkerer Princess faltered for a moment, but nodded anyway, looking back at Scorpia and toying with the corner of the welding mask resting on her head with a length of her hair. A jab of pity tore through him, able to read Entrapta's body language for what it was - dejection. *Stars, I'm an idiot.. She always spoke about how she never fit in. Fuck.* ..

Still - Bow never got the chance to apologise as Scorpia awkwardly dragged the Princess away, leading them back towards the transport that the Horde trio had arrived in. The moment the engine started and they drove away, the Archer released a breath

that he had no clue that he had been holding the entire time since they had first forged that uneasy truce.

His arms felt heavy - scratch that, his whole body felt heavy, every limb, every finger and every toe. His mind ached, crying out for rest that it had already had, his chest tense from all the momentary conflicts that could have spiralled totally out of control and, regardless of possibility, his soul felt drained of energy.

Glimmer gently wrapped an arm around him, and Bow gratefully took the anchor, leaning to the right and resting his head atop hers, closing his eyes and allowing a soft smile to creep onto his features. He was by no means a coward, but he loathed every time he had to step onto the battlefield, to fight a conflict that had been started by his fathers (fathers'?) generation and one that had been passed on to his own. But he did it gladly - if it would only mean that no more innocents had to suffer.

But this - relaxing in moments of tranquillity with the girl he loved? This was how he endured, and he liked to indulge himself in thinking that it was how she coped too.

I... Haven't actually told Glimmer I love her..

I should soon..

Had he known that the exact same thought had been crashing around the head of the person in question, he almost certainly

would have said so, but hindsight was a far trickier thing to work with.

".. Bow...?" An eye opened, responding to the call of his name, almost checking as if he had heard correctly, before he, very reluctantly, disengaged from the embrace and glanced down at the Princess who had spoken his name. Glimmer, for her part, looked pensive - slightly nervous and skittish, but swallowed and evidently pushed through her reservations, speaking carefully and deliberately, but in a tender manner that made him sit up and take notice. "Bow, I-"

A loud snore broke the Princess's words, drawing both of their attention to the unconscious girl, one with far more ire than the other, but still ire nonetheless. Naturally - Adora had once again managed to unintentionally make herself an awkward third party to the dynamic that Bow and Glimmer had in that moment, and Bow would be lying to himself if he didn't feel just a little bit of irritation towards the blonde for her interruption.

Apparently the feeling was echoed by Glimmer, who looked more than a little irked by the interruption to their surprisingly tender moment that had been interrupted. Regardless - the Princess also looked paradoxically relieved by the same occurrence, which really made Bow question what was originally going to be said.

Still.. It was a long trip back to Bright Moon on foot, something that few people had dared attempt.

Thankfully, as the familiar warmth of Glimmer’s magic encased them and whisked them back home, Bow could step into the second phase of this mission that wouldn’t require nearly as much stress.

Retrieval.

"So... You're sure that you can manage this Perfuma? It's a pretty.. Big ship.." The awkward and forced delivery of the second sentence had Bow cringing, even as he buried his face in the pad that he was cradling to hide the unsuppressable expression across his face. *I don't even know if its big by ship standards. It's huge for Etheria, but it could be positively tiny..*

The peace loving flower Princess gave him a grin that looked half forced, the other half a valiant attempt to maintain a strong façade in the face of some pretty overwhelming evidence to the contrary, like she was trying to convince herself more than anything else. Normally, he would have no qualms accepting Perfuma's words as law. "Of course I can! Nature out here is so hardy and so strong.. It should be easy."

Riiight .

"It's just.." Pausing, he searched for the most polite way for him to address the issue that was currently facing them, and was

currently making itself very known. "Well.. It hasn't moved much..."

A grumbled reply from Glimmer, full of the irritation that was sourced from returning to the blistering heat of the Crimson Wastes, sang out from the shade of the cliff under which she was sheltering from the blazing sun. "Hasn't moved at all.."

Bow's tentative smile grew strained at the words as his attention returned to the starship that had been crashed into the shifting sands of the Crimson Wastes all those years ago. The plan had been fairly simple - get Perfuma to lift Mara's ship onto an even keel at the very least, or in a best case scenario, carry it back into Rebellion Territory.

Except that plan wasn’t getting off the ground, much like the ship itself, which was still firmly buried, nose first, in the endless dunes of the Crimson Wastes.

"I'm... Just taking my time.." The normally peachy and welcoming exterior of the Princess cracked as a there before unseen venom slipped into the pacifist Princess' voice, accompanied by an eyebrow doing a nose dive towards the bridge of her nose. This had the effect of totally annihilating the smile that was otherwise broadcasting a cool, calm and collected, yet openly cheery and happy disposition, and leaving Perfuma visibly torn between her emotions and her disposition.

"... Hey guys..?"

The trio turned their attention to the final member of the party - Adora, who had made it quite apparent that she was capable of resting whilst watching their efforts to recover Mara's ship, and was being guarded by Glimmer, although the job was a misnomer, as all most of the effort behind the job was spent making sure Adora stayed where she was. Evidence of Adora's repeated attempts to help was clearly visible, as Glimmer was standing practically over Adora, and had a hand firmly rested on the blonde's shoulder, holding her down.

For her part, the blonde was looking off into space beyond Perfuma, her head slightly cocked to one side as if she was having another conversation and was about to give them all the cliff notes. Her eyes suddenly refocused and came around to bear on Bow, incredibly calculating in their gaze, before the blonde's head sharply bobbed as she nodded at some unheard question.

"I.. Might have an idea.."

Bow paused, caution rising at the sudden, and quite frankly utterly *bizarre* actions that his friend had just gone through, staring back at her with a mix of intrigue, caution and, perhaps most befittingly, utter confusion. Still - he could not help but feel intrigued, it was a problem that they had no real answer to, and their best bet was currently foundering under the weight of the attempt, so if Adora had a solution that might work...

Well what did they have to lose? ...

".. Alright.. What's the plan?" Glimmer's gaze danced over to Bow, as if questioning the sanity behind letting Adora take command of the situation in her partially exhausted state - and in that she had a fair point, Adora had been unconscious for nearly a day immediately healing Catra, and had only been fully awake and lucid for a few days now. Putting her under pressure again.. Probably wasn't the best idea.

But still - it wasn't like they were spoilt for choice on options.

With a strained expression marring his features and a somewhat lost shrug, Bow passed the metaphorical baton of command to Glimmer, whose shoulder slumped as her upper body tilted forwards in exasperation, a long and drawn out sigh escaping her as she relented. Removing her hand from Adora's shoulder, thus allowing the blonde part-time Princess to her feet, Glimmer presented her hand bluntly to Adora, offering her other hand to Bow. "Fine."

"We'll be a few minutes Perfuma. Don't worry." Glimmer's words may have been meant for the other Princess, but Bow took them for himself, focusing himself around the simple phrase 'Don't Worry'. Truth-be-told, whenever Glimmer allowed another person to influence where they teleported to, it NEVER went well. First there was that time that Queen Angela influenced her daughter and they nearly fell to their deaths.

Then there was the time that Bow influenced Glimmer's teleportation and they nearly fell off a window to their deaths.

Then there was the time Adora influenced their teleportation and they ended up in the *Fright Zone* and almost got captured and killed.

Come to think of it, teleporting under someone else's influence seems to result in a lot of death.

.. Actually most of our life involves lots of death.. George might have had a point about the whole 'danger' thing.

That sickening lurch that had characterised their first attempts at teleportation returned in full force, grabbing the contents of Bow's stomach and lurching them so violently that he nearly retched at the sensation, although he was able to suppress the *very* strong urge to hurl up his guts. Instead, he stumbled, falling over backwards onto a smooth and cool crystalline stone that seemed to be something totally beyond Etheria.

His gaze rose, being greeted with the dual sights of a corridor made of the same substance, running with words and phrases in that same language he had become so accustomed to in the dual lives he led, and the scars of a battle that seemed to have been fought a thousand years ago, deliberate strikes through the wall that left large and deep gashes.

His head spun, a hand rising to clutch at his forehead at the same time that a hand was extended down towards him, which he gratefully took without a second thought, allowing Adora to haul him to his feet as she began to walk towards the end of the corridor, in which a platform was clearly visible. Glancing at

Glimmer with a pensive curiosity, a look that was echoed back at him, Bow watched in amazement as a flicker of light in the centre of the dais shifted into the shape of a woman with long hair and dressed in a leotard, although little else was possible to discern from that distance.

Adora gave them a genuine and warm smile, if not a little nervous. "Come on.. There's someone you should finally meet..."

Chapter End Notes

P.S: As noted by DarthOccultarus in the last chapter (love the name btw), we are getting further and further into uncharted waters here. Just because I would be annoyed if I didn't explain it better - Adora's unlocking of her true She-Ra form came from accepting herself fully and unconditionally, being true to herself and not lying to herself.

She believed she needed the sword, thus her true form didn't manifest.

She believed what was being told to her by Shadow Weaver, thus she didn't trust herself, and couldn't manifest She-Ra

She finally listened to herself in Heart pt.2, and the culmination of the Catradora story was Adora accepting that she did in fact love Catra, and thus that she could balance serving Etheria and her own wants, and She-Ra manifested herself again.

Scorpia I

So... The night.

Scorpia didn't like to remember the night too much. It was bad for her survival to mention it, especially to people of equal rank, who would almost certainly use it against Catra by going to Hordak or Shadow Weaver. Scorpia didn't want to hurt Catra - especially not after hearing what Catra had said.

Or at least.. What she thought she heard Catra say.

Oh yeah - 'The Night' was what she was calling that whole.. Borderline treason night in the Crimson Wastes. Just sounded so much better than saying 'borderline treason'.

Actually in hind sight, it probably wasn't borderline treason, it was just flat out treason.

Funny how hindsight makes these things clearer, eh?

Anyway, Catra.. Yeah she wasn’t doing incredibly well.

Scorpia knew that she wasn’t the sharpest tool in the shed - she was more a brawn over brains person. Hell, if not for her standing as the Princess of the Horror Hall, Queen of the Fright Zone, First

of her name… yada yada yada (and thus someone Hordak was both indebted to and someone he wanted on his side to maintain whatever claim to the kingdom he had), Scorpia would probably be either working some menial task or just outright exiled.

Boy, that would be something, having a cool story about being an exiled Princess driven from her home by an evil usurper.

Hmm…

Anyway, Catra.

Ever since The Night, Catra had seemed more.. Scattered, less cohesive in her thinking, and yet more rational and complete. It was a really weird contradiction of characteristics, but Catra *did* seem to be getting more sleep than she had in the past - which was good, because it meant that she wasn't in a mood the whole day until she turned in around midnight.

(She only kept track of Catra's sleep schedule out of concern, honestly.)

Still - it was better knowing that Catra was getting more sleep. She might now be able to do the paperwork that Scorpia has been trying to do for her, just to ensure that she stayed up to date on absolutely everything whilst taking *some* semblance of care of herself.

But.. Well that meant that Scorpia wouldn't be needed for.. Anything really.

There were people better at fighting than her, there were better planners and strategists, better logisticians and better thinkers, so that just left.. Her. The big bug that scared people and gave hugs that people really rarely actually wanted. The traitorous Princess fighting for the Horde against her kin.

It irked her in a way it shouldn't have, but she just… didn't feel like the Horde was her home anymore - the Fright Zone had become a perversion of what it used to be in the days of her youth, and Scorpia had nothing really tying her down to the place anymore. Entrapta was in Hordak's good books, and thus was essentially immune to all forms of punishment, Catra was taking care of herself and the Horde…

No one really wanted her..

So she had begun to search for something - anything to give herself a purpose that she sought after despite everyone and everything else. She'd managed Catra's reports about the prison becoming overly full after the recent spate of crushing victories against the Forest Brothers that had seen the resistance cell all but totally annihilated. She'd given Catra's assent, after some reluctance, to liquidate the prison's extraneous population, to disperse them so widely into labour corps that they may never regroup without Horde assistance.

It was a.. Surprisingly dark and yet, ruthlessly effective plan. Catra had split up families - and made them cooperate by promising that they would not be reunited unless compliance was absolute.

Now all the prison held was VIP's, people with information and children.

Seeing a bunch of children held behind force fields and in chains was a sight that would wear on even the most cruel Horde soldier's psyche, and yet Scorpia made an effort to try and raise the children's spirits every day.

Tried.

She'd stopped now - it was just too hard.

The children had never tried to accommodate her, despite all her efforts to get them at least somewhat comfortable. They'd been rightfully scared, afraid and honestly, almost completely hopeless.

Scorpia's duties regarding prisoners had continued, although they weren't just limited to the Fright Zone Prison. There were smaller regional outposts with records of prisoners, all of which she had to go through on a monthly basis to determine how the "labourers" were being treated. Some bases clearly kept good care of their workers, some suffered accidents that were logged, and some suffered a few more "accidents" regarding labourers.

Just about the only bright point in going through these records was in pointing out these "accident" prone bases to Catra, who, for all her faults, was a rabid utilitarian who wouldn't simply throw away resources for nothing. More often than not, Catra personally organised a trip out to the bases and gave the entire staff a verbal dressing down or worse.

Scorpia, for her part, simply stood there, looking scary, despite how it pained her to do so.

She wasn't really good at that sort of thing.

Still - going through the records today, looking at another month's list of names slowly growing smaller and smaller, joining families together on paper when she noticed clan names for people in different parts of the Horde's empire, Scorpia had hit upon a single report - one taken from a distance. It was a bi-annual report from Beast Island, regarding the state of prisoners who had been exiled. The report had noted that the population on the island was back down to one, somewhat unsurprising, given that the sole occupant was a "mage of considerable prowess".

Now she might not have had a *clue* who the mage was, but Shadow Weaver had used Beast Island as a threat to a lot of people, although the number that she had actually sent to the Island was highly disputed. Scorpia herself hadn't been threatened - she was special in a way that meant she was avoided, but she knew that Catra had been threatened with it at least once.

So whomever it was, they were probably not too friendly towards the Horde, and they probably had some sort of importance to the Rebellion.

A pause, the sheet of paper in her pincers lowering slightly as her eyes drifted up to look at the green metal that made up the vast majority of the Fright Zone, the walls of her room being no different. It suddenly occurred to her that this single document could be her ticket out of the Horde, her ticket to safety.

But that would mean leaving Entrapta and Catra behind, alone and without her help - and whilst Entrapta was pretty much totally safe with Hordak giving her his personal protection, Catra wasn't. She might make mistakes or need some extra work done...

.. No

No, Catra had said it herself - Scorpia had to start thinking for herself.

But.. Could she just.. Leave her home behind? The relic of what used to be the Kingdom of the Scorpions? The Horror Hall, buried deep beneath the foundations of the endless sea of industrial construction? The memories of her youth - of her grandfather, the last King of the Fright Zone, of her mothers and their tender care of her during her young years. Of the arrival of Hordak, and the ostracising of the Scorpions from the rest of Etheria for their willingness to embrace a foreign ruler.

If she really paid attention - there were the remnant of what this place used to be - the oasis nestled amongst the endless sands of the desert.

But... It wasn't that anymore.

And it wasn't her home.

The decision, whilst so, so incredibly hard, was made in a heartbeat. All she needed was a change of clothes, the document and the photo that had been her only real personal property for her entire life. A reminder of simpler times.

She paused, staring at the paperwork on her desk, all the names and families destroyed by the war that ravaged the entirety of the planet. A heartbeat decision saw them haphazardly shoved into the bag as well. Future good that needed doing by someone.

No one asked what she was doing, walking around the corridors that ultimately led to the skiff bay, nor why she was taking a skiff and no escort or equipment, nor where she was going. They all underestimated her - feared her. Thought her unlikely to do exactly what she was doing right now.

Fixing things.

Many people had found the Whispering Woods uncanny and unsettling - and most of the population of the Horde had found it difficult to navigate, if not totally impossible. In the recent year, however, it had become even *more* of a nightmare to navigate, as if the woods themselves were swallowing Horde soldiers and sending them to a location unknown, as if the spirit in command of the trees had grown more aggressively opposed to the presence of the Horde.

And yet Scorpia's journey was easy - Too easy, which is why she wasn't totally surprised by a figure materialising from thin air in front of her.

She was - however, still surprised, and the skiff veered wildly as the ashen haired woman startled back, saved only from a probably fatal crash into a tree by the incredibly strong grip of the woman in front of her grasping the control lever and steadying it. Briefly, she baulked at the feat - Scorpia was not exactly the lightest person, but this tan woman in a leotard had just negated the effect of Scorpia falling as if it was as easy as catching a twig - and with one hand too.

"Why are you crossing the Whispering Woods, Princess." The woman's gaze was firm, a little harsh and accusatory, but not malicious, like with Shadow Weaver and Hordak. This was more a symbol of authority - a woman who had power and sure as hell knew what it was and how awesome it could be, but didn't laud it over anyone.

"Oh - hey uh.. Sorry, how did you do that? And uh.. I'm not really a Princess..." The bashful claim was one she had made often, the little hole inside her staying stone cold - the point that had once contained just a little spark of magic that her mothers had told her contained her link to the Black Garnet. It had been so long suppressed, so long empty and cold that Scorpia knew that there was no real hope for her to reclaim her heritage.

But the woman across from her, steering the skiff down a path that seemed to birth itself from the trees, the branches almost folding themselves aside to reveal a well worn, yet previously concealed path, barely flinched at the claim, maintaining the expression on her face. Her voice remained firm. "You still have a link to the Black Garnet runestone. You are, like it or not*, Princess* Scorpia of the Scorpioni. This is *the sole* reason you have not suffered the fate of the rest of the Horde soldiers who have trespassed these woods. ***My woods.*** *Why are you here.*"

The trees themselves bent with the woman's words, almost threateningly, and Scorpia realised *exactly* how much trouble she could be in at this point, and also just how bad lying to her could be. With as much confidence as she could muster (and with fear filling up the rest), Scorpia let lose her explanation.

"I.. Can't keep doing this, working for the Horde I mean. I'm not really a fighter - I did that because I had to, because at the time I thought it right. Because I was defending my friends. But.. I'm not cruel, I can't play warden for a bunch of kids and passively stare at reports of people dying and suffering. I can't bring myself to look at any more names of labourers and link family names, separated by hundreds of kilometres. I can't bear to keep them that far apart, to join them only on paper"

With a fumbled action, Scorpia rooted through the small bag she took with her, holding out the folder that contained her bargaining chip, hoping to whatever being existed (maybe this woman?), that it would be just what she needed to get through to Bright Moon. The woman glanced down at it, still steering the skiff at speed despite everything else. "I.. I found a prisoner - Shadow Weaver describes them as 'a mage of considerable prowess'. They're imprisoned on Beast Island, and I just.. I don't know.. I wanted to do something good, to get out of the Horde, to do *good* for Etheria."

The woman's head tilted up, gazing up at the sky, flashing by past the dense tree branches of the canopy of the woods that cast much of the path ahead in light shadow. It seemed almost as if she was thinking, or talking to some unseen and unheard person. Her gaze abruptly returned to Scorpia. "The report is not wrong... What is your plan?"

"Hold up - what do you mean its 'not wrong'. How do you know? And uh, who actually are you?" The simple phrase 'not wrong' had sent gears turning in Scorpia's head - questions flying about that asked some seriously outlandish things. *How the hell does she know that..*

The woman fixed her with a gaze - one that seemed to have softened into a mostly emotionless visage, with the slightest ghost of a smile upon her lips (something that Scorpia let out a breath of relief at), tilting her head slightly. Her tone was still firm, but it was less harsh and accusatory than before. "I am Mara. Etheria's Administrator. What is your plan for getting into Bright Moon."

"Well, uh.. Nice to meet you Mara... I was... Well, I was hoping that the Queen still respected the rite of Hospitality.." The woman, Mara, paused for a moment, which quickly dragged itself out into an uncomfortably pregnant silence, loaded with enough tension to make Scorpia nervous. Just as she was about to speak, Mara's voice cut off Scorpia, catching her a little flat footed.

"Do you have a token?"

"A-.. A token?" Scorpia's heart and stomach began to sink in unison, descending into a pit she wasn't aware was there a moment before. Hopelessness began to edge in at the corners of her mind, whispering cruel nothings that sapped at her resolve and her will.

"A token - part of your life. A guarantee that you will not violate the rite. Almost like a hostage." Mara's words conjured up a thought, and the bag that Scorpia had in her arms became ten times as heavy. There was only one thing that Scorpia could surrender to fulfil that criteria.

"I.. I do." The uncomfortable lump in her throat stuck around even as she swallowed.

"Good. We are here." The bushes in front of Scorpia parted, spitting the duo out in an impossible position, the gates of Bright Moon's palace, having somehow bypassed the entire town of citizens beneath the castle, having apparently moved through trees that ran up the side of the hill. Mara descended the skiff, offering a hand to Scorpia, evidently not knowing just how

pointless it was, or how dangerous, so Scorpia politely declined the aid, hopping off the skiff herself and staring at the duo of guards at the gate, who had now settled into combat stances.

"Any time now Scorpia.." Mara's tone was steady, instructive.

"I-" A momentary verbal trip up, before Scorpia cleared her throat and poke. "I, Princess Scorpia of the Kingdom of the Scorpions, claim the rite of Hospitality of Queen Angella of Bright Moon."

The guards, who had been approaching with weapons drawn, immediately stiffened to attention, pushing open the gate, making it quite clear that Scorpia was to follow them as they set off swiftly towards the castle. Scorpia turned to look at Mara, to search for some advice or guidance in the moment, only for the other woman to have totally vanished just as quickly as she had appeared.

Scorpia swallowed gingerly, and followed the guards.

She was acutely aware of the stares and filthy looks that she got from the citizens of Bright Moon who worked the gardens, and she could not help but feel that she deserved every one of the looks she got, all the hate that she got. She was practically the symbol of the Hordes legitimacy. Her family had allowed this tragedy to befall Etheria.

It was only once they crossed into the hallowed halls of the castle itself that her escort intensified, two sets of footsteps sliding in

behind her as they walked. She dared not look back, but from what she could see in a mirror on a wall, it appeared to be the two unknown factors - Netossa and Spinnerella. Catching her gaze in the mirror, the latter smiled, the former's expression remained firm, a net of blue energy resting in her palms.

Scorpia managed a weak smile at Spinnerella, trying to ignore the lump in her throat.

Ahead of her, twin booms in union rang out, bringing her gaze back to the front, along the open air walk way that they were on, and at an empty doorframe that rose high, arching high and to the ceiling of the room that was isolated from the rest of the palace. They had arrived at the throne room.

The guards in front of her parted, revealing the form of a woman seated upon a throne, floating amidst the clouds in the sky at the other end of the throne room, expression hard and fingers laced together, practically glaring at Scorpia as she approached nervously. Her footsteps rang loudly on the marble floor of the throne room, approaching until the Queen raised an index finger, signalling her to stop.

Queen Angella's voice was cold, harsh and analytical. "You claim the rite of Hospitality of me. By the Ancient Laws, I am obliged to accommodate you. *Why* are you here, *Princess* Scorpia."

The ground out annunciation of 'Princess' reinforced the point that Scorpia had been saying to herself for years - she wasn't one, but she wasn't really going to say that right now. This was her only

chance. "I.. I seek your help, Your Majesty."

"My. Help." Queen Angella rose to her feet, standing at the foot of her throne, fingers interlaced. "House Scorpioni dares ask for my aid after what they have done to our planet - what their actions have allowed? You still host the Horde, yet you have not yet cast them out. Why, tell me, should I be of assistance to them?"

Scorpia wilted slightly, shrinking away from the tirade unleashed by the Queen at her. She was right - it had been a massive mistake coming here and claiming the rite of hospitality. She could be doing so much more than she was doing now, that she was too scared to do. It was a forlorn hope.

The air between the duo flickered, twitched and shifted in a way that looked like a computer screen glitching out. Queen Angella frowned, eyebrows furrowing as she stared down at the seeming error in reality, a casual flick of her fingers sending the guards in the hall into alert. Scorpia backed up from the error, which flickered once more before forming into the shape of a figure - a woman dressed in armour.

Recognition was not immediate, but the outfit was distinctly reminiscent of Adora's She-Ra, the one she had summoned when saving Catra from the Sand Crawler. The cape upon her back came from her shoulder instead of her waist, sporting a deep crimson colour, but the blonde hair was blowing the side, revealing the side profile of a familiar face.

Queen Angella, however, immediately recognised the figure, stumbling backwards onto her throne and fixing the new She Ra with a stare of naked surprise, lips pursed as she stared at

Etheria's Administrator, weight resting on her right leg, right hand upon her right hip in a somewhat sassy pose. Angella's voice was quiet, awestruck and a little unsure. ".. Mara."

"Descendent of Serenia, the rite of Hospitality has been invoked, you are failing to fulfil your part of the deal." Mara's tone was chastising, turning to place Angella and Scorpia on either side of her, gesturing to the Princess with her left hand. "Princess Scorpia has much to tell you Queen Angella. The Rite is safeguarded by She Ra, you would do well not to cross it."

Whoever Serenia was, the simple invocation of her name sent the Queen stiff upon her throne, hands clutching the arms of the golden chair tight enough for bone to show on her knuckles. Things suddenly began to click into place - Mara was a past She Ra, who had evidentially known this Serenia person, from whom the Bright Moon royalty were descended.

"Mara?"

The familiar tone of the current version of She Ra came across the hall, Scorpia turning to face the trio of people whom she had spent a night with nearly a week ago, all seemingly dumbfounded by the sight of Mara in their midst, in her full She Ra form. Adora looked exceptionally confused, even to the point of not noticing Scorpia's out of place presence in their midst. "How.. How on Etheria are you here? And why does Queen Angella know you?"

Mara paused for a moment, before gesturing at the walls for emphasis, hitherto unseen First Ones writing coming to blazing life

upon the floor from her position, racing to the wall and spreading across them. "Etheria is mostly made up of things my people brought with us. We *changed* this planet-" It really didn't sound like that was the word Mara was going to use there, the pronunciation was as if the word was sickening. "- and as for the knowledge, the runestones pass memories from Generation to Generation."

"But.. I don't have a runestone..." Adora sounded lost.

"The sword, Adora. It had She Ra's runestone in it." Mara's tone was bitter - harsh. Anger permeated the surface of her words, the disgust again. Adora's face flashed with realisation.

"You have not told me why Princess Scorpia is here." Queen Angella's voice rang out, attempting to reassert the structure and order in the hall, pulling everyone's attention back to her. She was stood again, and was not nearly as openly hostile, but stared down at Scorpia and Mara with a firm expression.

Mara turned her attention to Angella once more. "It is simple. She seeks asylum from the Horde. In return, she has something of immense interest to you."

"Explain." A demand, directed at Scorpia. The abrasive tone made her fumble with the small bag, eventually withdrawing the folder from the bag and handing it to Mara, who approached the throne and offered it, in turn, to Angella as Scorpia spoke.

"Catra uh.. Put me in charge of handling documentation of prisoners." She winced, shoving down the foul taste in her mouth and the sickening memories that rose up as she spoke. Angella began to read as Scorpia spoke. "I uh.. Came across this. Shadow Weaver-" Angella's free hand tightened on the arm of the throne. "-sent someone to Beast Island 15 years ago. A mage."

The colour in Angella's face drained in a heartbeat, her grip on the arm of the throne of Bright Moon weakening, fingers hanging limply as the document inside the folder gently slipped from her grasp, sliding onto the floor of the throne room in the slight breeze. Tears began to fall from her eyes as she stared beyond Scorpia, momentarily frozen in time.

Mara finished for Scorpia. A single name she was unfamiliar with. "Micah is alive."

Angella rose from the throne, gingerly picking her way down to the floor of the throne room, her pace picking up as a wink of magic sang out from behind Scorpia, Glimmer appearing in her mothers arms as the duo shed tears of joy in a heart warming scene.

"... Thank you, Princess Scorpia." It was a few minutes before Angella spoke, the streaks of tears still staining her face, but now a smile upon her angelic features. "You have made my family whole again."

".. At least I could change one.." Scorpia fished around in her bag, gently offering part of her soul out in her pincers. The photo of

her mothers. "You.. Need my token."

Angella stared at it for a moment, before glancing back up at Scorpia, remorse evident in her eyes. "I am sorry about Erica and Menira's deaths. They were wonderful women. The least I can do for you is keep what memory you have of them intact."

The bubble of emotion inside Scorpia welled sixfold as a tentative inhale made an unsteady noise. "Thank you, your Majesty."

"Angella. Please."

".. Thank you Angella."

"Thank ***you***, Scorpia."

Adora XI

Chapter Notes

Well.. So much for once a month, eh?

All I can say is sorry for the delay - uni restarted. We are, however, in the home stretch of this story, so we're gonna pick up the pace with this. I'll try and strike the balance between being all poetic and shit, and getting these out relatively quickly. Sorry about the delay, time for your (ir)regularly scheduled lesbian disaster.

She hated it.

Being weak - being left out of important things, being barred from attending important meetings and out of the loop of a lot of the operations that she should really, *really* be involved in, no matter how limited the scope of their importance to the overall strategy was. It could create issues in the future, misunderstandings and problems that **would** cost lives in the long run.

She had enough lives on her conscious.

And yet here she was, confined to her room for the foreseeable future, barely able to function without someone else trying to do everything that she was meant to do - except doing it in such a way that meant that she was going to have to do it all again because it wasn't in the right format, or because their handwriting was illegible, or because some tiny thing was wrong and it threw the rest of the work out of whack.

It was just a waste of time, she could do enough of the strategy from her bed - even if she barely spent any time in it.

Exhaling the tightly wound coil of tension in her chest, Adora set the inventory report down, raising her hands to rub at her eyes, feeling the tingling behind her vision intensify in a comforting way as she pressed down upon her eyelids. Rubbing the crusty remains of sleep from the corners of her vision, she stared down at the figures on the paper, finding nothing wrong with the figures that were being presented to her.

Things seemed to actually be going well. This was.. *Unfamiliar - equally as it was concerning.*

Etheria’s civil war had a nasty way of throwing curve balls her way, and she had a feeling that dealing with them would be an unenjoyable experience, just as acting as the planets 'saviour' usually was. Sure - there was the blood pumping, adrenaline shooting sensation of combat, but whilst fighting and training, feeling the hormones smash through her body and sending jolts of dopamine through her with each successful action, may leave her feeling satisfied and content, the actual action of fighting the very people she had grown up with, shared a history with, that was not enjoyable.

Speaking of which...

Catra hadn't been seen in a while, at least, not by and force that had enough people still intact to report back *alive*. In her absence, brutalisation, terror attacks and mass executions had apparently

ramped up, and the Horde's expansion had stalled in favour of totally decimating the civilian population that resisted them. There were reports of mass graves, execution pits, plagues tearing through towns and civilian population centres, and more and more disturbing reports of effective slavery. Some of the reports had even contained images.

Adora really regretted looking at those images after dinner. The stomach cramps after bringing it all up made it nigh impossible to sleep.

Not that she managed to get much. Her sleep schedule had been pushed back further and further, until the point that she was going to bed no earlier than the lunar zenith, and was usually up just after breakfast. She could feel the exhaustion seeping into her, and eventually she would crash totally, probably going down for a day as she slept off the effects of compounding sleep deprivation, but that was a problem for a different Adora-

"That's a problem for a different *Adora and Catra."*

The ghostly echo of a line spoken a little over two years ago brought Adora to a screeching halt, fingers going numb and senseless as her gaze froze on an unremarkable spot upon the desk in front of her. A tiny fragment of her past frozen in a memory that resurfaced from deep within the sea of her mind to torment her right when she really, *really* would rather that it didn't.

Stars, what she would give to go back in time and beat it into their stupid heads that they should never have gone out into the Whispering Woods. It was not worth it.

Not for what it required them to give up.

Stars, would Catra even agree with her? She knew at the very least that the girl found memories of the past somewhat of a sacred and important thing, she had taunted Adora about the abandonment of her promises more than enough for that to be thoroughly proven, but otherwise the feline had shown no desire to return to the days of old. Hell, she had expressed hatred towards the idea before.

But that had been in the heat of the moment - when tensions were running high. She wasn't even sure if there had been a peaceful moment between the two in years, outside the fiasco that had been the excursion to the desert.

Where she had again lost Catra, despite being closer than ever before to getting her back.

She really had fucked things up, hadn't she?

A knock at the door brought her back to jarring reality, staring at her frozen hand hovering just over the discarded sheet of paper, trembling just the tiniest bit as she delved into her past. It was so minute that it was practically a slight twitch, but the tremor in her hand refused to be so easily discarded, instead persisting up until Adora physically forced it down, pressing against the desk as she stood. The application of force and sense of purpose seemed to calm it for the meantime.

A slight pause, stopped just in front of the door, her arm outstretched, hand moving to grasp the handle, frozen as she watched her fingers twitch irregularly, but naturally, organically. *What the hell is this?*

Another knock on the door, this one a touch impatient as the person on the other side clearly had something else to do, and was trying to convey that in the most passive-aggressive way that they could manage without speaking. Regardless of purpose, the action had the desired effect as it spurred Adora into action, her arm jerking back into sudden motion and clutching the door handle, pulling it open to reveal the unimpressed gaze of Netossa standing there, quirking an eyebrow at Adora in a concerned manner that conveyed surprisingly little sympathy.

Netossa still threw her off some times - the woman wore both her emotions and heart on her sleeve, although this time it was almost certainly worn upon her features, as the woman seemed annoyed by the whole situation that she was suddenly placed in. With a bit of force, the woman with the silver-blue hair practically dragged Adora from her room, pulling her down the hallway and towards the War Room, remaining silent despite the blondes confused protestations. "Wha- Netossa, hey! Wait!"

The elder Princess, however, was not waiting, and practically shoved the door open with her shoulder, releasing Adora in the process, much to the blondes momentary relief, before the dismay set in as her senses analysed the room they were in - or rather, the *state* of the room.

The room itself was fine - but the occupants.

There was a veritable screaming match going on as the extended Royal family of Brightmoon (including Castaspella) pitted themselves against perhaps the weirdest alliance that ever existed within the hallowed walls of the Castle of Brightmoon. Mermista, Frost and Perfuma were standing resolutely against Queen Angella, Castaspella and Glimmer, and seemed to be giving as good as they got, although the reverberating noise was thoroughly disorienting, and made any conversation illegible under a wave of syllables that drowned it all out.

Those who happened to be unfortunate enough to be in attendance, namely Bow, Scorpia and Spinnerella, all seemed to be doing their best to try not to break their facades of forced neutrality, especially Bow (whose face was doing a very good impression of someone trying not to crack and failing to hide it) and Scorpia (whom Adora had swiftly learned was a massive softie). Spinnerella gave the blonde a *very* strained smile, Bow couldn't manage that, and Scorpia gave Adora a wave that was somewhat spoiled by the wince upon her features.

But even through this, Adora still had *zero fucking clue* what the shouting match was about.

Thankfully - Netossa "clarified".

"Right. Blondie this is your fault, and that means you're dealing with it. I have just about had it." Netossa's voice was hoarse, and Adora had a decently good idea that she knew what Netossa

meant by 'having just about had it'. Her head was already working itself up for an encore migraine, and she had been in the room for a bare 10 seconds.

"Sorry - uh, whats going on?" Adora tried the most neutral tone she could muster, but neither side acknowledged her, chosing instead to slam a delicately manicured hand down upon the surface of the table (Angella), wave a finger in a manner that was supposedly to hammer a point home (Mermista), and to all but screech something about 'a childhood stolen' - that one was Glimmer.

Netossa's nostrils flared, the woman reaching behind her and grabbing the door handle, swinging the massive door closed with a loud '*thoom'* that immediately killed the conversation, and turned the attention of everyone who had not already noticed Adora, onto the blonde.

Adora swallowed awkwardly, standing still as everyone stared at her for a second too long.

And then Glimmer started yelling again, only for a glowing net to be cast across the room, smacking her on the head and leaving the strangled squawk to die in her throat, the chocolate skinned woman next to Adora giving Glimmer what practically amount to a death glare. With a single gesture, Netossa raised her right index finger to her lips, then cast her arm out to the side, gesturing at Adora and ceding authority in the room to her.

Amazingly, everyone stayed quiet as the soft panic began to creep in and claw at Adora's throat.

"What.. Exactly.. Are we arguing about?" A strained smile was all Adora could muster as both Queen Angella and Mermista stepped forwards to speak, completely ignoring the other and trying to speak over them.

"The guy that Robot lady told us about."

"*My Husband!*"

Adora stumbled mentally for a moment, caught up on trying to process what had just been said, managing only to catch the word 'husband' from Angella, although this gave a decent indication as to what the commotion was about. Holding up a hand weakly and pinching the bridge of her nose, Adora tried to regain the authority she had just lost spectacularly. "Woah, woah, woah. One at a time. This is about King Micah, right?"

Thankfully, it was Spinnerella who got to the punch first, and whose authoritative tone (truly a first from the woman) seemed to momentarily stun the vast majority of the room into silence, Adora nearly included, had it not been for the stern look that the normally jovial woman was fixing her with that kept her rooted in reality. "Yes, Adora, it is. As you can tell, there are divided opinions on this. Her Majesty seeks to be reunited with her husband as soon as possible, however there are those advocating caution."

"Caution?!" Glimmer's shrill voice broke the momentary silence, seemingly triggered by the word. "My dad is *alive*. The time for 'caution' has long passed-"

"Your Highness, if you would please be allow me to *elaborate*." Spinnerella's words were carefully chosen, deliberate and calm - attempting to placate the worked up Princess, all whilst maintaining the somewhat frosty tone that had characterised her previous words. Glimmer looked as if she was about to let loose another outburst, but said nothing, seeming much like some of the expressions Adora had seen Catra pull back in their youth, but just a little chubbier than Catra's sometimes disturbingly thin frame.

The twinge of loss shot through her far too devastatingly for her liking.

"Thank you." Spinnerella's tone softened, but there was still a gentle firmness to her words. "Now - there have been doubts over the situation. Some advise caution-" She nodded in Mermista, Frosta and Perfuma's general directions when she paused, but kept her gaze on Adora regardless. "Others action. Regardless of our actions, we must have a tie breaker vote. It cannot be one of us." The elder Princess gestured at those who had chosen neutrality in the discussion. "It should be you - our war master."

The lump in Adora's throat froze where it was, refusing to move as the girl stared back at the table - at the two sides of an argument who were her closest friends. At the impossible choice to make here. No matter what happened, someone was going to be unhappy.

"Why.." Adora tried - and failed - to swallow the lump in her throat. "Why would we need to be cautious? What's the downsides?" Glimmer had a vicious glint in her eyes, seemingly vindicated by Adora's words, but Mermista seemed utterly unperturbed by the question, and was seemingly characteristically bored, although the sparkle of activity in her eyes and the speed at which she jumped in to reply spoke leagues as to the opposite.

"Well - first off its intel given by a *high ranking Horde officer* who we still don't know if we can fully trust, no offence." Mermista looked back over her shoulder lazily, and Scorpia gave her what probably amounted to a thumbs up, which prompted the water Princess to look back over at Adora. "Not to mention, its backed up by someone who most of us have met or heard of before, but someone who stuns the Queen into silence, and who only you seem to know, and who fucks with the very nature of the planet as we know it."

Adora started forwards, slightly incensed by Mermista's words. "Mara had given us *far* more support than you know. Hell - she's been teaching me how to both be a better strategist, *and* how to get better at being She-Ra."

Mermista froze for a second, before one eyebrow rose towards her hair line. "And.. How have you been cramming this in around running a *war*, blondie?"

"Well.." Adora tilted her head, choosing her approach, before deciding on a general run down of her day. It should hopefully clear things up. "I generally wake up a bit after dawn, have

breakfast, then spend most of the morning doing war work - have a break for lunch and talk with Mara - then get back to war work until dinner, then do paperwork until I sleep."

"Talk.. How? None of us have seen her here before." Mermista was seemingly sceptical about the whole thing, and pressed a little further. "And when do you even sleep?"

"Well shes in here-" Adora tapped her head, completely forgetting how fucking *crazy* that would be to anyone who had no idea of what She-Ra entailed, and continued. "And whenever I finish my paperwork for the day. Usually past the lunar zenith."

".. You're up past *midnight* doing *paperwork*, you wake up at *dawn* and you ***talk*** to the voices ***in your head***?" Mermista held a hand up, blinking furiously and looking *extremely concerned* about the facts that she had just been presented with. Adora turned, searching for support, only to be met with much the same reaction from everyone else.

Maybe that was a mistake.

"*Stars how are we winning this war*." Mermista's low, almost horrified, whisper slipped past Adora's immediate comprehension, the blonde instead focused more on the task of searching for some sort of support from her compatriots. Eventually - mercifully -, she was thrown a line by Perfuma.

"Well.. Adora has led the war for two years now. If she has brought us this far without major fail, then there is that much more credence to her claims. None of us know how She-Ra works, and if it is this random inheritance that we think it is, then there must have been some way to pass on knowledge before the existence of the First Ones. I believe we should trust in Adora's judgement." Perfuma seemed somewhat upbeat - in full support of what Adora was saying, but the subtle undertones were clear as day. She had arranged a raft out of straws that Adora was standing on now - Adora had to be careful.

With that, Perfuma turned and once more ceded the attention of the room to Adora. The blonde did not stutter this time - holding her hand up for momentary silence as she closed her eyes and called upon the Princess within. *Mara?*

'Yes, Adora?'

Where is Micah? Is it dangerous?

A tense pause.

'From what I know, my people used it as a waste disposal site. She could tell you more than I.'

Adora opened her eyes, taking a breath, then exhaling what little stress she could. "Its probably not safe. It *was* once a waste

disposal site. And given that the Horde used the place as a disposal site for prisoners.. It probably still isn't safe."

Mermista looked vindicated - Glimmer angry, incensed by the situation. But Adora kept her momentum. "We need to act soon. If Micah is still alive, we need to save him. I should go-"

In a heartbeat, the room that had been so thoroughly and deeply divided against itself mere moments before, united in unison against Adora in such a startling way that the blonde had almost reckoned that it had been a subliminal trigger - like the ones that she had once heard Shadow Weaver theorising about.

"Absolutely not-"

"No! You need to rest-"

"No way. We can't risk-"

"You're too important-"
"I must go, not you-"

Adora sighed.

At least they agree on something..

It didn't take long.

The trio of Angella, Glimmer and Netossa were gone barely fifteen minutes, but the as the air between Adora and Bow shimmered and glowed pink for a second, the trio - now a quadruplet - seemed to have spent hours or days living in the wilderness. Angella looked utterly worn out by the experience, Glimmer seemed dead upon her feet - and probably was, given she had just teleported three people across the world, and four back - and Netossa's once pristine appearance was sporting scratches and scrapes far in excess of what one could expect.

And then there was the fourth figure.

Adora had no idea of what King Micah had once looked like, but from what she had been able to gather from hearing stories about him from both Glimmer and Angella - along with anyone else who was willing to talk to her in those early days at Brightmoon - he had been a tall man, relatively handsome, with a full beard and a muscular frame. He had apparently been the aggressive force behind the first Princess alliance, and was reportedly one of the greatest sorcerers of his day - although that was after Light Spinner, whose alter-ego Adora had known far too well for her own liking.

He had also been a subject of Shadow Weavers grooming, so perhaps there was some common ground there.

But right now he looked like he had been through a Horde work camp for years. The shoulders might still be broad, but as he was, leaning on his wife and a gnarled staff of wood, King Micah looked resilient, a survivor, but naked in his eyes was clear surprise and

disbelief. It was the look of a man who defied the world for years, and could not simply believe that the world had given up trying to test him.

The quadruplet held their position for a second, almost frozen in time, before they broke stance immediately.

Angella immediately let go of her daughter, turning instead to face her husband and burying her head in his shoulder, arms tight around his frame, although this was soon covered up as the woman's large wings spread out, enveloping the duo. It was such a deep and blatant display of love, and just the sight of it made Adora.. *Jealous*. Not of them - that would be *incredibly weird*, but.. More envious of what they had.

Then things went less well.

Glimmer's knees failed her just as Bow got next to her, leaving the boy to catch her as she fell - giving her a soft landing at the very least. Netossa was not so lucky - her wife was too far away, and the silver haired woman hit the ground awkwardly, giving a grunt of pain as she sucked in needy and deep breaths, her hands glowing as if she was about to cast a net at someone or something.

The noise of the woman hitting the floor broke the paralysis. Practically everyone darted over, doing something or another - be it helping the two exhausted Princesses from the floor, or tackling their brother in a hug for the first time in a decade or so, although there was only one person involved there.

Wearing a concerned look, Spinnerella helped her wife to her feet, trying not to betray her discomfort at Netossa's grunt of exertion and pain as she put weight on a leg that was sporting a thin and shallow cut. With a thin and strained smile, Spinnerella tried to lighten the mood. "And how was your trip, dear?"

The other woman gave a terse and firm reply. "**FUCK going back there.**"

Various noises of amusement broke the silence, and the tension in the room evaporated in a heartbeat, and Adora found herself somewhat awkwardly standing off to the side, watching as everyone else milled about, being useful whilst Adora was sidelined.

Not needed when there's not a war to fight..

It was night time before Adora first spoke to Micah. The day moon had sunk beyond the horizon, but the golden glow still shimmered over the ocean beyond the castle, and her position in the gardens meant that Adora had a spectacular view of the moonset, although she really didn't care about it. Such things were distractions, unimportant in the grand scheme of things - they happened every day.

She barely clocked the person leaning against the wall of the garden next to her, but the voice was so unfamiliar to her that it had to be only one person - unless the palace guards had decided that they would finally speak to her. "Y'know - I always figured that I would never this again. Sure - I could see it whenever I wanted on that island, but its just not the same."

Adora turned, straightening up as she regarded King Micah with a reverent gaze. She had not idea what he was like, so it was safe to treat him like she had once treated Queen Angella, and that meant a proper-

"You have that look. How long?"

Adora stuttered on the spot, practically tipping forwards before steadying herself. Micah seemed unsurprised, offering her a goblet that he had been holding in his grasp, filled with a dark liquid that was probably wine, all whilst holding his own in the other hand. Adora took it silently, swallowed the cringe that she was already pulling, and taking a sip of the liquid, and finding herself surprised by the fruity taste of juice. Micah gave her an amused look.

"Don't drink - not yet, anyway. Used to back in the day, not going to let myself get addicted now." Adora took another sip, finally finding her words.

"How long what, your Majesty?"

"Forget the formalities - its the least I can do. My question was this. How long were you under her 'care'." Micah's tone started

somewhat jovial, friendly even, but the frosty finish to his words told Adora more than enough - the context was there. The witch.

"Oh.. Uh-.. All but the last two years of my life?" Adora tried not to sound guilty over something she had no control over - she didn't want to make Micah suspicious of her right off the bat, that much would be bad, but there wasn't any great way to put the fact. Mercifully, Micah seemed more resigned than anything.

"So I put you in that position. I'm sorry, Adora. I truly am."

"Sorry? Why - you didn't give me to Shadow Weaver... Did you?" The latter half was more Adora's mouth acting on its own accord, and the mortified expression on her face shifted to one of relieved embarrassment as Micah laughed heartily.

"No - no I did not Adora." His almost paternal grin faded into a humourless one as he returned to his topic. "But my leaving drove Shadow Weaver away - to the Horde and to seeking new people, new *children* to groom into her tools. Her followers. I was the one who gave her the means to cast this world into such chaos. I am truly sorry."

Adora paused, nodding distractedly. "How did you know? About Shadow Weaver?"

Micah's expression grew darker, almost depressed. "There's a tell - an invisible scar that doesn't go away. We both wear it Adora, its

just about seeing it. Your scar is deep, defined."

Micah paused, sighing a little. "If you want - I can help you. Try do something to limit the trauma, to help you heal. It won't be completely gone.. It never can be."

Adora nodded, casting her gaze back out to sea, pondering not Micah's offer, but something else.

If my scar is so deep... What has the witch done to Catra?

Catra X

Chapter Notes

> Two chapters in two days after radio silence for two months - god I'm consistent aren't I?
>
> So.. sorry?

Today was *not* a good day.

Normally, the administrative staff that Catra surrounded herself with was ruthlessly effective, and greeted her with salutes, by snapping to attention, or by simple gestures of subservience that conveyed their lower standing. If anyone failed to meet that, it meant that they either had something more important to focus on (which was fair enough and tacitly encouraged), or they were someone deliberately sent by another member of the informal Triumvirate.

She had experienced a *disturbing* amount of pleasure after turning a particularly haughty minion of Shadow Weaver into a blubbering mess when she failed to address Catra with respect. The slight resemblance the blonde girl had shared to Adora had *nothing* to do with it.

But today, even her own, hand selected, administrative staff were cowering away from her. Some were ducking out of the hall when she stalked around the corner, others practically turned into statues, saluting their best salutes and probably praying that her ire wasn't aimed at them.

Hell, Kyle even prostrated himself at her feet and begged forgiveness for giving Lonnie his leftovers.

A darkly amused snort broke through the fog of her memories, eyes focusing on the door that loomed large over her, and the two guards either side who wore armour with some red highlights - Hordak's personal security team. Apparently, the man had felt that he needed something special, and Catra was perfectly ready to offer up some of the less promising (and annoying) members of her latest batch of Special Forces if it meant ingratiating herself with him just a little further.

Catra stared at the door for a second longer, half hoping the guards had some sort of logic and would just let her in, before reluctantly snapping her gaze to the guard on the right, the seething pool of rage within rising just a little further as she ground out; "Let me in."

The guard was silent for a second, before an unsteady voice came out. *Good - he's terrified.* "I.. I cant do that. L-Lord Hordak has a meeting with Shadow-"

She didn't let him finish - the situation was perfect. With a confident and firm step, Catra stepped up uncomfortably close to him, staring up at the nearly opaque visor and at the eyes that failed to find her own. Lowering her voice to a whisper, Catra tilted her head and raised a hand, claws exposed. "You want to go to the Kingdom of Snows? I will make your life more miserable and pathetic than you could even dread to imagine if you do not Let. Me. In right this second."

The fumbled noise of the button being missed, before ultimately being pressed was quickly drowned out by the loud noise of the doors swinging open, and the more muted noise of the guard falling to ground and probably having some sort of emotional and mental breakdown.

Catra didn't give a flying *fuck* about him, more focused on marching forwards, ignoring the noise that Entrapta was making in some depth of the room, focusing instead on turning to enter the throne room and marching right up behind Shadow Weaver, ignoring how Hordak seemed a little taken aback by her presence, rising a little from his throne. "Force Commander Catra - I am currently-"

"***WHAT HAVE YOU DONE?!***" Catra practically growled, jabbing an accusatory finger at the still turned figure of the Witch, who seemed to be having no reaction to the situation, but the rippling darkness in the corners and edges of the room sent a warning signal that Catra completely disregarded. Shadow Weaver's voice was calm, but with the typical cruel lint.

"I have simply done what needed to be done. Pacification of the occupied lands-"

"***YOU CALL THAT PACIFICATION? YOU MURDERED THOUSANDS FOR NO FUCKING REASON!"*** Catra's hands were upon Shadow Weavers collars before anyone realised what was going on - least of all Catra and Shadow Weaver, so clearly taken aback by Catra's aggressive movements was the Witch. Catra could feel her claws on her palms, having ripped right through the cloth of the Witches collar. "***YOU HAVE RUINED EVERYTHING I HAVE WORKED FOR!***"

The Shadows coiled angrily in the corners of her vision, and Shadow Weaver's evil mind seemed to finally find a tooth in the gear, the old woman shoving Catra away, the noise of tearing fabric heralding the ruining of Shadow Weaver's cloak, torn to shreds by Catra's claws. "***I*** have solved the problem of raids from the forest partisans that ***YOU*** have failed to crush! Action had to be taken! We were losing *HUNDREDS* of soldiers!"

"***I SET A PRECEDENT YOU FUCKING MORON!***" Catra practically howled her savage anger - the pot of seething, furious rage boiling well and truly over, the feline gesticulating wildly at the room around them, explaining basic *fucking* ***strategy***. "***A YEAR OF WORK - GONE***. EVERY TIME THEY ATTACKED, we launch reprisals! Casualties are kept to a *minimum* on both sides for fear of a bloodbath."

The room was silent for a moment, Catra turning to Hordak and levelling her right index finger at Shadow Weaver, the rage brimming behind her eyes, her body practically shaking with the rage that threatened to overflow in an even more spectacular way. "**SHADOW WEAVER** broke that pattern. She slaughtered thousands of *INNOCENT CIVILIANS* in retaliation for the deaths of a patrol. She razed villages, slaughtered anyone that we got a hold of. *AND SHE KEPT DOING IT*."

Wheeling back around, Catra very seriously considered ripping the bitches mask off her face and smashing it into a trillion pieces, and making the witch swallow all of it. Instead, she settled for the far more achievable goal of simply continuing her tirade. "*YOU HAVE KILLED THOUSANDS* ***OF OUR OWN MEN. THE PARTISANS WILL SEEK EQUAL RETRIBUTION."***

"Then we can destroy them in battle-"

"THEY WON'T COMMIT. RULE ONE OF IRREGULAR WARFARE - NEVER FIGHT ON TERMS THAT DO NOT FAVOUR YOU." Catra wrenched the headpiece off her head and hurled it at the floor, the metal bouncing with a high pitched *clang* before spiralling towards the Witch, who, startled, stumbled backwards as the object went spiralling into the abyss behind her, bouncing several more times well out of sight. "***This is NOT going to go away. This was MY problem to fix, and right at the FUCKING END, you come in and ruin EVERYTHING."***

There was a momentary silence, be it stunned or horrified, Catra didn't know, but bringing her hands up to her face, the young woman covered her eyes with her palms, inhaling deep, large lungful's of air and trying not to do anything *else* that she would come to completely regret in the coming days. The deep, body shaking, furious rage drained away as quickly as it had taken over, leaving a cold, morbid silence hanging in the room as Catra lowered her hands and levelled her cold, furious gaze upon Shadow Weaver. "This is another mistake of yours I have to clean up - another one caused by your complete *fucking incompetence* when it comes to fighting a war. I will need the next batch of cadets you have in training ready in two weeks. Any later and we risk provoking a total uprising across the Horde's territory."

"I cannot do that - they are not ready!-" Shadow Weaver's indignant cry was silenced by Catra practically barking out an order over her voice, effectively drowning her out.

"*You said **I 'wasn't ready'*** once." Catra mockingly accentuated the quote, fixing the witch with a vicious grin that carried nothing positive with it, other than a vicious sadism that comes with getting revenge after so many years. "You were wrong then - and probably wrong now. Give me the troops within the next two weeks - and scale back the forced labour. You've fucked us with the population, we've got to make concessions to keep them pacified."

"*WHAT!?* **You cannot be serious!**" It was now Shadow Weaver's turn to screech - this time in outraged indignation as Catra levelled such an outrageous demand at her. There was the familiar tone of arrogant egoism in her voice as she turned to Hordak, bringing the silent observer into the conversation. "Lord Hordak, surely you must understand the need to maintain the income of resources. Training troops of a high quality takes *time*."

"Our best troops are the ones that I've had to practically retrain from scratch." Catra drawled, almost boredly, although the sweet taste of revenge was permeating her brain - almost getting her high off the sensation. It was all coming together here, a chance to knock Shadow Weaver out of power and to leave her well and truly out of Hordak's favour. A sweet dream.

But then it all went so *wrong*.

"Mmmh. Shadow Weaver, you are to provide Catra with the extra manpower and to begin releasing some of the less useful labourers. Catra - you believe the damage that has been done to the Horde's standing with the local population is irrevocably damaged?" The infuriated stance that Shadow Weaver had adopted, accompanied by the dangerously dancing shadows

curling around the Witch was more than dopamine to Catra - it was essentially just neuron activation at this point, but the question that was posed to Catra was more concerning than the girl initially perceived it to be, so distracted was she by her victory.

"Probably, yeah." Catra brushed her fringe back over her hairline, exhaling the pent up rage in a momentary calm, trying to center herself within the ball of chaos that had consumed her momentarily.

"Then you will return to full time active service, and continue with Shadow Weaver's policy of repression. Suppress revolts with force, be brutal. The hand that we have been dealt must be played." The victorious sensation vanished in a heartbeat, leaving Catra stood still, blinking.

"***WHAT-***"

"Silence!" Hordak rose from his throne, and both women seemed to simultaneously clock exactly how infuriated he was by the whole situation, his nostrils flared and his eyes burning pits of loathing as he glared down at them with poorly concealed contempt. "My will is dictated. You are both dismissed."

Catra was the first to leave, stalking out in a fit of angsty rage, barely giving Hordak a second more than he needed to quash everything that Catra had worked to accomplish in the past two years of her life - her first long term project, one that would enable the Horde to actually function as a state as opposed to the quasi-feudalistic society that their opponents worked as. And in

just a week, all of it - all the subtle concessions, the unspoken agreements and subtle nuances with regards to retaliations and troop manoeuvres, all of it came crashing down under a ham-fisted ***MORONIC BITCH WHO HAD NO CLUE HOW TO BE A FUCKING PERSON.***

Her fist connected with the wall next to her, the thin metal buckling under the weight of everything behind the blow - the all consuming rage that burned deep and long within her, the bright inferno of fury that flared up whenever someone failed to act like a logical person, the desperation at trying to do the work that had so long evaded people far older and 'more experienced' than herself, and finally - and most well concealed - the burning heartache.

Fuck.

FUCK.

FUCK.

"***FUCK FUCK FUCKITY FUCKING FUCK!"*** Each expletive was coupled with an extra blow to the wall, tan knuckles well versed in punching hard objects starting clean, then coming back bruised, and eventually bloody, staring at the abused, bent wall, bearing jagged tears from which drops of Catra's ichor slowly slipped, carving vibrant streaks onto the green metal.

Chest heaving, Catra stared at the blood stained artwork that so conveyed her very being. Abused - battered and bearing the scars of a woman's rage.

Catra had to resist the urge to collapse in on herself.

Force Commander Catra was feared - revered by some, loathed by others, but above all, she was simply feared by all those in question, bar a very select few.

She was a brilliant strategist who brought the Rebellion to its knees at several points in the war, she was the Horde's weapon to counter the immense power that was the 'Princess of Power', She-Ra. She was the Horde's fireman, able to respond to situations and effectively defuse the situation and repair what damage had been done. She was the Horde’s administrator who selected the gifted personnel to keep everything running as smoothly as possible - she chose officers based on merit, she side-lined those not competent enough for frontline service, and she found roles for those who fell in between.

She was also a façade.

She was still Catra - the 19 year old girl who had spent her birthday alone, sitting in a room by herself, staring at paperwork telling her that a village of old men, women and children had been systematically rounded up, executed or enslaved, all for the actions of a few people operating dozens of kilometres away, all on orders that were issued by the woman who had held her essentially hostage for the entirety of her life.

The 19 year old girl who had been told that she was worth nothing more than her actions, and that she was worthless, had been forced to prove her worth at the expense of so many others.

She had once heard that in war, there were no winners, no losers, just victims.

Everyone was a victim.

Scorpia was a victim, and she had abandoned Catra.

Adora was a victim, and she abandoned Catra.

Catra was a victim, and she abandoned herself.

Catra hated the Horde.

She hated Shadow Weaver for the decades of abuse - for stunting her growth. For driving her and Adora against each other, and for finally torpedoing Catra's once chance in life, taking away the one thing that she had done to keep her safe little bubble of security - where she held the power, the ability to do as she pleased, with very few exceptions.

She hated Hordak for his reluctance to pick a side other than his own - for his stupid fucking strategy that served little purpose other than trying to destroy what little he had for himself. If he had just chosen a *side...*

She hated herself - for not choosing to take one of Adora's offers when she had the chance. For being paralysed by the fear of change. For not seeing the betrayal of Hordak and Shadow Weaver coming, despite knowing for two years now that it was coming - it was always coming. Nothing good ever lasted.

She hated herself for not being honest with herself.

If she could - she'd be gone in a heartbeat, she'd steal a skiff, just like Adora had, drive to Bright Moon and surrender herself. Do some good in the world.

But Catra would be executed as a war criminal - thanks to this final kick between the legs from Shadow Weaver, the final stab that the woman could take at her. Catra would never walk freely, not like this.

The Horde had a year or two left at most. Catra was the one holding things together but this..

Shadow Weaver might very well be a spy for the rebellion, because her actions had shortened the war by a year at the very least - the amount of troops devoted to security duty in the rear-

lines would need to be doubled, or even tripled. The woman had annihilated the compliance that Catra had so desperately tried to cultivate, and had left Catra to pick up the pieces.

She had no help in it - there was no one on her staff that she trusted to continue with how she lead, and even Scorpia was gone, yet for some inexplicable reason, Catra still covered for her, still threw up lies and a façade to keep the other woman free from the crosshairs of the Horde. Traitors were brutalised - Scorpia deserved so much more.

Catra just hoped she was happy.

The showers in the now empty shared barracks ran ceaselessly, and they offered the ghostly echo of a warm and comforting embrace that was totally alien to most people in the Horde. Lonnie even looked at her strangely whenever she mentioned the word 'hug', none of them had really had any sort of knowledge when it came to being tender or soft or even embracing the emotions that ran rampantly out of control in their bodies, and were simply chastised to control themselves.

It kept rapes to a nearly negligible figure at the very least - or that might be the executions that she personally carried out..

The showers also did something else - they hid the tears.

Her eyes were sore, bet it from the tears that spilled from them or the repeated friction of her fingers that sought desperately to control the flow of said tears, Catra was not sure, more concerned with trying to bring her emotions back under control before she ripped herself apart. The shower made for a plausible excuse as to the source of the clear fluid spilling down her cheeks.

She had lost *everything* she had ever worked for.

What more was there to lose.

With an ache in her chest, Catra picked up the shattered remains of her world, carefully storing away what little of herself she wanted to keep, and letting the scraps wash away down the drain, spiralling away with the water that rolled off her body.

Reverently, Catra place the final piece of the puzzle that made her the shattered remnant of the girl that she had once been, carefully securing it within herself and stepping from the shower, each step she took heavier than the next. It was always draining - these meltdowns as she struggled to piece her life back together, or rather to hold together the shattered remains of the life that she had once lived.

She was just.. *So tired*..

With a sigh, Catra clutched the pillow on her bed to her chest and curled up, face buried deep in the object that had once belonged

to the subject of her most precious memories.

Things needed to change.

Adora XII

It was a weird morning routine - that much was true.

Adora was up at dawn, per usual. The unusual part was the fact that she wasn't immediately setting to work on the mountains of paperwork and intelligence piling up high upon her desk, instead, the girl was wrapped up in watching the day moon's light blazing through the trees that dotted the horizon. It was just a momentary pause in a casual jog around the palace gardens that she liked to sneak in whenever she could, but it was a moment in time that would never be truly captured again - and one that felt like it wasn't truly complete.

The Rebellion had been a lot more conscious of Adora's bad habits - she was being made to go to bed earlier, like she was a cadet back in the Horde, with a mandated bedtime. Glimmer didn't have one, but then again, even if she did, the Princess was the least likely to listen to that - she had been spending a lot more time with Bow of late, even later in the night - Adora might have to ask about that as casually as she could.

Probably with the subtlety of a galaxy destroying superweapon being used to kill a fly...

These jogs, however, early in the morning, where the air was fresh, crisp and with the slight cool chill to it that brought with it a sting as her muscles finally cried out for some reprieve from their duty, they were her time - her sanctum in which none could transgress. It was a way to relieve stress that was more socially appropriate to one of her standing than, say, screaming for hours

on end at the vast nothingness that loomed large in vast expanse of the sky.

Although, the few hours a week that she spared to spend with King Micah helped - the man had settled back in to his life with an awkward ease that felt almost endearing to watch as he relearned customs long forgotten, or reunited with someone whom he had thought he would never see again. Queen Angella and Glimmer were practically bursting with joy, in their own separate ways - whereas Glimmer was overtly joyous, Angella had that soft and elegant smile on her lips the entire week, not once fading away - receding momentarily, but never leaving.

Sure - she also saw Micah a lot more than a few hours a week, but when she did, it was for work and business. He had been the Rebellion's War Master before she, and he still knew a few things about running a war and was happy to help her with much of the monotonous work that dragged her sanity well away from her grasp. He was far more charismatic, hell, he was a *living legend* to the people of Bright Moon - far better he rally them than Adora spending more of her time that could be better used.

But when Adora managed to get some time with the King alone, off duty and in their own free time, they reflected on their lives. It wasn't something either of them enjoyed, if the morose tone and hard expressions were anything to go by, but Adora knew it was far better than bottling it up - *stop internalising, it doesn't help*.

So Adora shared her stories, and Micah never once looked surprised - something that Adora found equal parts depressing and surprising, almost as if the man had expected the

manipulative witch Light Spinner to one day step down a far darker path.

But when Micah spoke - told her of what he had experienced, Adora was almost more sorry for the man, more horrified of what she heard, of the manipulation that nearly killed him and the horror that he was unknowingly forced to create, yet simultaneously envious of the softer treatment that Adora would have possibly killed for so that others may have experienced.

But Catra... Catra had once told her that everything she had been taught up to that point was a total lie - that she had been misled and brainwashed into a puppet for Shadow Weaver to wave around and praise herself with. The knowledge that the manipulation could have been deeper and far more subtle was equal parts sickening and concerning.

It could have turned me into a total monster...

Another person’s footsteps pulled her from her reprieve - the blonde turning around and definitely not hitting herself in the face with a messy ponytail that had grown out far too long for it to be truly practical, and was probably a reflection of the stress of the war situation that it had even gotten to this point at all. Blowing and brushing the hair from her face, Adora was met with the scene of the Scorpion Princess looking nervous and guilty at the same time, holding a little metal plate in her hands.

"Oh- hey, uh. She-Ra. Adora, whatever.. Do you uh. Do this often?" Scorpia was nervous, and almost skittish, clearly dressed

for some form of exercise, and whilst her tone was not dismissive, she clearly would rather not be having the conversation and encounter present.

"Whenever I can - I mean, not that I'm shirking my duties, or trying to avoid Glimmer or anything." *Smooth...* "So, uh - what brings you here?"

"Oh- I heard someone running around down here from the window." Scorpia vaguely gestured in the direction of one of the windows and balconies that dotted the side of the Palace, which brought a slight frown to Adora's face - something wasn't quite right about that... *Hang on...*

"Isn't that Perfuma's-"

"*ANYWAY*." Scorpia's volume rose as Adora mentioned the Flower Princess, ignoring how colour seemed to return to the pale woman's features as she spoke. "I uh... Got something you should see.."

With a delicate movement, Scorpia handed Adora the metal plate in her hands, where upon Adora recognised immediately what it was - a Horde data pad that Scorpia had kept with her, open to the messenger window. For a single, heart stopping second, reading *her own name* printed at the top of the most recent message, Adora thought that this had all been a horrible trap, and Scorpia had been waiting for a moment to strike a decisive blow to the Rebellion.

But instead, there was a date gap of nearly a month since the last message, before Scorpia had even turned up at Bright Moon's gates seeking asylum with the Rebellion and offering back a valuable fighter and figurehead who had both lightened Adora's workload, and done much of what Adora simply could not do. The message at the bottom of the screen, however, practically made her heart stop.

'Hey Adora.'

Two words opened the message from one leader to another, and Adora felt her heartstrings being played like a harp as she stewed in complete emotional turmoil over just the *two words* that opened Catra's message to her. She didn't need to read anything else to tell that it was from the feline - that phrase was synonymous enough with her. It took far more willpower than she would care to admit to read on.

'We need to talk. You know where.'

'*C.'*

Adora froze, caught in a myriad of memories, none of them good - but all of them special, delicate and important to what she had become - to who she was and who she would be. To whom Catra was and how she had become what she had at this point. Each had to be treated carefully - as if it would shatter into a billion pieces in a stiff breeze.

If just 10 words did that to her - meeting Catra in person would be far harder.

Catra hadn't specified a time - but Adora was far too distracted to actually give it thought, the previous times they had met in their spot, they had both just known when and where to go. Usually it was near dusk, a good time for Adora to sneak into the Fright Zone and get herself a disguise to let her get back to the spot where she and Catra had last truly spoken.

"So... Uh. What does it say?" Scorpia was still standing just in front of Adora, rocking around on the balls of her feet and looking slightly anxious - her voice startled Adora from her reflection, making the blonde start for a moment, before sighing.

"It’s uh. Nothing much - didn't you read it?" Adora frowned, looking up at the other Princess, who rubbed the back of her head with an oversized pincer.

"Ah - no. I don't like that sort of thing. I saw your name and reckoned it was probably meant for you. Strange though - Catra never bothered sending me anything unless it was important." Scorpia seemed a little disheartened but kept talking. "Entrapta talked to me more - although it was usually some request for a thing she needed for her and Hordak's project."

Adora was unable to hold her right eyebrow down, as it rose slightly above her brow. "Project? What are they working on?"

Scorpia shrugged, clearly uninterested. "Dunno - spoke something about alternate realities and different dimensions and how to reach them. Really advanced stuff - way beyond what I know."

It must have taken a moment for that to sink in to the spirit of the Warrior Princess in her head, because the moment it did, Adora felt what was akin to a gut wrenching sensation that made her retch, stumbling off even footing and flailing with her left arm as her right hugged her gut. Her palm met the bark of the tree roughly, but Adora didn't care, her head throbbing with a sudden pain and her body feeling as if it was having a panic attack, although it was evidently not her.

The Warrior Princess was sending shockwaves of emotions crashing through the blonde.

She was vaguely aware of her surroundings momentarily fading - being replaced by a heartbeat of blackness - before the world around her returned, the sensations fading just as fast as they hit. Scorpia was holding her shoulder, trying to grab her attention, but Adora turned inwards

Mara?

'Go to Catra, Adora. Go to the Fright Zone.'

The sudden wave of sensations hit her as the Warrior Princess responded to Adora, but vanished as quickly as they had come, the moment she finished the final word. Evidently, whatever this thing that had triggered it - the talk of other dimensions and how to access them, She-Ra did not like it at all, and it was triggering a violent response from the Princess that had the potential to have knock on effects upon Adora.

"-ey...- Hey, Adora. You awake? You okay?" Scorpia waved a pincer in front of Adora's face, something Adora answered with a dismissive wave of her hand as she stood upright properly, stretching her back and closing her eyes. "Gave me a bit of a scare - you okay? Any idea what just happened?"

"Fine - fine. Maybe something I ate. Pushed myself too hard?" Adora swallowed and put on a calm and dismissive expression, waving her hand again. She needed to disengage from this conversation now - and although it meant tricking Scorpia, along with the rest of the Rebellion, a sacrifice had to be made. "I need to talk to Mara. Could you let Bow and Glimmer know I'm going to the Crystal Castle?"

Scorpia pursed her lips, biting her lower one judging from how it curled in just a little, her tone cautious and worried. "I dunno - shouldn't you rest? Don't want you going down in the middle of nowhere."

Adora paused for a second - Scorpia was far less pliant than she was wishing for, but all that meant was simply doing things before Scorpia could stop her. "Its fine - just a She-Ra issue. I'll be back tomorrow."

As she spoke, Adora not only disengaged from the conversation, but began to walk away, keeping her strides long and quick, and descending through the tiered garden quickly as to both throw off Scorpia if she decided to follow, but also to keep herself busy, distracted. It didn't sit well with her - none of it did, but her intuition was screaming at her to do something absurdly reckless, and it was rarely wrong.

After a pause for a few seconds, it became apparent that Scorpia had not followed - leaving Adora not only with a hollow feeling of nerves as she ventured deep into the heartland of her foe, but also both a cruel feeling of disgust with herself for abusing Scorpia's trust, and a sense that this trip would be one that she came back from very much a different woman.

Getting a disguise was easy - the Rebellion had downed many, *many* Horde soldiers, and the standard issue armour and kit bag was easy to come by in the arsenal of the castle - none of the guards even battered an eyebrow as she took a set of armour that fit her and stuffed it into the small sack that she had brought with her. Catra would know it was her, but the basic armour that fit her would do good enough to fool anyone who wasn't scrutinising everything about her.

The only downside was the source of the armour, something that didn't sit too well with her at all. The cracked neck plate of the armour betrayed how its original owner had died - clearly some projectile smashing right through the jugular protection of the suit and ending up somewhere very fatal. The neck plate would have to be replaced, but the 303rd Squadron armour that had once

been worn by someone Adora had been raised alongside would do well enough to get access to their special spot.

Getting to the Fright Zone was an all-day journey - walking through the Whispering Woods instead of taking Swift Wind to preserve both the stealth of the situation, and also to not risk another incident when it came to using her connection to the Warrior Princess. Besides - a walk would do her some good and allow her to plan.

Not to mention, as she emerged from the edge of the Whispering Woods - staring at the Day Moon sinking towards the horizon, capturing the ominous fortress that lay ahead of her in golden light, creating a far more beautiful image than the nightmarish citadel deserved - it also had the benefit of dragging away a whole day, allowing her to slip in at dusk.

For a moment - she half considered just walking through the main gate, or even surrendering herself to the guards at the front, but both would cause a scene, and she'd either be captured or face someone like Shadow Weaver in open combat, and that was not something she was looking for. Instead - she'd have to go in quietly.

Quietly, it turned out, was far easier done than said.

It took Adora all of half an hour to find a good spot to cross the wall, where the cliffs and mountainside roads and paths were roughly equal height to the wall. From there, all it took was a slight running start to just about cross the distance, and a slight

drop to plant herself on top of the wall, sprawled out from an awkward landing...

Riiiight in front of a sentry.

The guard stared down at her, clearly stunned by the situation, and Adora's blood ran cold as she realised exactly what was about to happen - she had fucked up spectacularly at the *worst* possible time. Now the entire Fright Zone was going to be on high alert.

But then the person, whomever or whatever they were behind the mask, offered her a hand, pulling her to her feet - and it was only at that time that Adora remembered she was just another faceless Horde grunt, and that this here was a subtle act of defiance, as the sentry tilted their head almost amusedly, then raised their finger to where their lips would be, and waved her along.

Adora practically deflated, expelling the tension and digging into her bag - just to ensure that the guard remained silent - and withdrew a loaf of bread, practically shoving it to the sentry and ducking past them, ignoring the stunned silence as they stared as this object that they surely knew of, but had no experience with enjoying. Hopefully, that was more than enough to convey her thanks.

But beyond that, it was smooth sailing, slipping through checkpoints as just any normal Horde soldier, handing over the stun gun that had to be locked away in an armoury whenever it was not on her person, giving the id number of the deceased soldier and knowing that, given no major battle had occurred, the

soldier being overdue would only warrant a visit from the squad’s senior officer - that being Catra.

For the first time in a long while - Adora's feet navigated the halls they had done so many times before, trying to ignore the Goosebumps that spread along her skin underneath the thin metal that concealed her identity from the veritable horde of enemies whose midst she waded through. There were people going about business, people doing Admin work, typing away on data pads whilst walking down hallways, there were people patrolling and setting about getting ready for the night shift - and there were those headed for the cafeteria.

The ghost of a smile graced her lips as she pondered the thought of walking to get Catra food as she had done so many times before - but that was a grossly unneeded risk, and so Adora made her way out onto the balcony that she had gone to so many times in their youth. The footholds were far less pronounced than she remembered them, but it took her no time at all to scramble most of the way up to the top, only to be forcefully grabbed and hauled the rest of the way up, being bodily deposited on the roof of the building, watching as her helmet slipped off and slid across the ground, and staring across at the woman who sat opposite her.

Catra stared back at her with a mix of surprise, apathy and irritation, but behind that, sparking away in the amber and teal eyes of the girl who Adora had so many mixed emotions for, was a genuine and true happiness - almost tender. It was another sight to preserve in the long-term memory banks. "You're a fucking idiot."

The ghost of a smile crept onto Catra's thin lips as she watched Adora blink and fumble with her thoughts, following it up with a less abrasive greeting.

"*Hey Adora*."

Catra XI

Chapter Notes

I swear I'm consistent...

In all seriousness - I aim to finish this some time in the next two months. Chapter 27 was just a bit of a slog to write. Not to mention, burn out is a bitch.

In other news - officially surpassed the 100, 000 words milestone. Whoo!

"*Hey Adora*."

The uncomfortable mix of relief, nervous apprehension and an ugly curl of rage sat in her gut as Catra stared down at the still slightly sprawled figure of Adora, remaining on the ground and looking up at Catra with thinly veiled surprise and shock. A raised eyebrow was her only response to Adora's eyes not so subtly sweeping up and down her body, eventually resting upon her face, the blonde’s own visage still mired in a mix of surprise and an off-balance expression.

A not insignificant part of Catra relished in the evident power and control that she had over the other girl - her sworn enemy, although it did feel like it was someone else who had done the vowing on her behalf when it came to declaring her as such. The rest of her, however, rather firmly told her that this power and control was a gift to be used carefully, with a very evident leaning towards the word '*gently*'. Be it for fear of losing that control, or fear of possibly *hurting* Adora, Catra didn't know at this point.

Honestly it had been a total fucking surprise when she had actually found Adora hauling her stupid ass up onto the roof.

"Catra.."

The response from Adora was... Almost disappointing. It was a intonation of her name, but it had an air of.. Almost gentle firmness to it that left the feline conflicted in her emotions - was it a firm and resolute stance against her, or a gentle, almost reverent recognition of the situation in which they found themselves, at each other's mercy and cautiously sounding out the other girls stance. It was an uncomfortable position to be in - being unable to read *Adora* of all fucking people, especially with how well Catra knew every mannerism of the girl, right down to her morning routine.

A part of Catra sardonically noted that she had once sworn that she wouldn't end up in a situation like this ever again - good to know that forever meant about two months.

She also wondered if Adora had the same issue of losing sleep like she had.

But this.. Evenness - the level playing field that they were currently perched on, it was not how Catra wanted it to be - it left things open to chance, unpredictability, factors that she was in no position to account for. It was uncomfortable, it made her almost nervous - this was meant to be her time to play Adora to her tune, to use her for what Catra wanted to accomplish, not allow Adora to walk over her like she used to.

So she had to set the playing field in her favour - but not so obviously that Adora wouldn't bite. There was a sure-fire way to do that, but Adora would probably be insanely suspicious about such.

Fuck it. Burn it down - everything. Let Shadow Weaver handle the mess she fucking made.

"I'm leaving the Horde."

Catra could scarcely bring herself to utter the words aloud, as if they were a toxic phrase that physically pained her to utter, because in a way, it was. It was her admission - her first (and hopefully *only*) admission that she had failed. She had failed in her goal to win Etheria, to best Adora, to prove herself to the world, that she was the better strategist, the better soldier - and she was, but she had been given the worst hand she possibly could have been dealt, and that was all that it took to ruin her life. Etheria, clearly, hated her.

".. What?" Adora looked - and sounded - utterly dumbstruck, which Catra supposed was fair enough - her declaration had come totally out of left field, and the blonde had clearly not been expecting it, and Catra had to sympathise to an extent, she hadn't either. Catra had partially tipped her hand to get to this point, and now she had to play the cards she had been holding in reserve, to pull what she could out of Adora in terms of concessions. She had a lot to give away as it stood, better now than when her hand was weak - and with the way the horde was going that could be anywhere from a few months to a few *hours*.

"The Horde is *fucked*. ***Shadow Weaver*** took over in my absence and sent everything to *shit*. Sure - expansion is at its highest, but there is fucking *nothing* holding up the frontline troops." Catra wasn't sure what she was doing at this point - tipping her hand even further, but whatever she was doing, it seemed to work with Adora, whose expression darkened considerably at the mention of the witch's name. Then - almost as if the blonde as attempting to give Catra whiplash, she clung on to the mention *of her* with a desperate glint of *hope* in her eyes.

"Shadow Weaver? She took over operations in the last few weeks?" Adora seemed caught up on that sliver of information, unintentionally revealing that she could pinpoint the timeframe in question, although that momentary slip up briefly got past Catra, who was more focused on Adora's suspicious interest on that tid bit.

".. Yeah, well. Getting nearly killed in the Crimson Wastes tends to leave you incapacitated for a bit. She took over for a week and in doing so she ruined just about everything." Catra cautiously regarded Adora - focused on her reaction, and consequently growing even more confused when Adora seemed just a little disheartened by the fact, but overall seemed buoyed by the revelation.

".. Right. Well... I need.. Your help." Adora seemed a little off balance, but the statement alone - accompanied by a firm pronunciation - was enough to warrant some serious suspicion from Catra, who narrowed her eyes as she stared at the utter moron in front of her.

"My help." Her deadpan was met with a firm nod from Adora.

"I need to talk to Hordak."

.. *What?*

If Adora had been aiming to throw Catra totally off balance, she sure as shit had succeeded in her endeavour, as Catra blinked furiously, staring at the blonde with a mix of incredulity and betrayal, realising that this was probably the reason she had come here - to use Catra as an easy way in to do.. Something. If she was to be honest with herself - a rare thing these days if she was to ironically be honest with herself - Catra had no fucking clue what Adora would do with Hordak, but just the simple idea of being *used* by Adora ***again*** as a steppingstone in her plan was enough to incense the girl.

"Oh - and I should just give you access to Hordak *why* exactly? You plan on killing him, ending this war with a murder? - that wouldn't end the war anyway. Shadow Weaver would just take over and you know how *that* song and dance goes."

Adora scowled - actually genuinely scowled at her, as if she had shed that miss goodie two-shoes persona that she used to run around with, now actually reacting like a normal person. It was strange seeing actual annoyance on Adora's face outside of a fight to the potential death, but the slight flash of hurt in her gaze was indicative of at least some deeper emotion than just annoyance - that was more Adora's style.

Or at least, it used to be.

“You really think so lowly of me?"

"I *know* you think so lowly of me." Classic what-aboutism. Made no sense, but Adora's scowl softened regardless.

"I never thought lowly of you. You're better than me at most things." Catra blinked. Was.. Adora trying to manipulate her or something? Her ego was practically non-existent, despite how much she talked herself up. That sure as hell wouldn't work.

"Stroking my ego isn't going to work *Adora*." Terse annunciation of the blondes name centred Catra's emotions as best that it could - she was meant to be annoyed or angry with Adora, not unsettled or disoriented like she was right now. That would open up far too many weaknesses.

This was, of course, ignoring the many weaknesses that Catra had shown already.

"Why would I-.. You know what, fine. Whatever. I am stroking your ego. Now if you'll excuse me - you've got a valuable prisoner who needs to speak to Hordak." Catra blinked, staring at Adora, utterly dumbfounded. *What*? What was Adora even trying to do? Catra came here with a goal - to get out, escape, spread her wings like the birds above and burn down what she couldn’t take

with her, whilst Adora's goal seemed to be.. Destroying the Rebellion?

Have I made a colossal mistake?

"Wha- Adora, what are you doing?" There was too much firmness - a single-minded determination in Adora's words that caught Catra off guard - spooking her to an extent she was hardly prepared for, somehow going further beyond the disorientation that Catra was already feeling. This *wasn't* Adora - it didn't feel like the girl she knew, that she had grown up with. It was wrong, uncomfortable - she was far too focused, too single-minded - it felt as if she had stopped caring about those around her and was instead laser focused on speaking to fucking *Hordak*.

And she was using Catra to do so.

It was an uncomfortable reversal of the roles that they had become too akin to - Catra's goal driven mentality and Adora being a useful tool to manipulate or control to accomplish said goal. Adora would then inevitably turn the tides back to the previous even footing with a spree of small victories that whittled away at the Horde's unsteady control of their conquered lands, and that would spread chaos behind their lines.

Honestly fucking partisans..

But now.. Now Adora had flipped the table - she had a goal and she had come to achieve it, even at the cost of her relationship with Catra.. Or rather whatever was left of said relationship, given that they had been at war with each other for three or so years now and the number of times they had spoken to each other without trying to kill each other could be counted on the fingers of veteran with enough digits to tell the enemy to go fuck themselves with each hand.

"I'm getting to the point - like you do. I need to speak to Hordak - *please* Catra. So much more depends on this than you could ever understand." Catra's discomfort was replaced by an ugly scowl in a heartbeat - *stupid now, am I?* Adora's expression *should* have flirted off to a realisation, and an apology, but that never came, instead it *hardened*, cementing that quiet determination as she managed to predict Catra's response. "That's *not* what I mean Catra, and you know it."

"Oh, what is it then? Because I understand a fair fucking bit, Adora. You should know - we've been fighting a war over the same things for three years." Adora's expression shifted again, maintaining that firm, quiet determination, but her eyes danced off - losing focus for a second before tightening back on Catra with a mildly cocky glint. *Arrogance, eh?*

"Fine then. So, you'll know Hordak isn't from this dimension, and he and Entrapta are attempting to build a portal to go home. Which, I'm sure you are fully aware of, will inevitably destroy reality and this universe as we know it, mh?" Catra blinked at Adora's somewhat smug expression.

What.

What the actual fuck?

"…" Catra's jaw worked, but no words came out - something she was vaguely aware made her look like a total fucking moron, but there was very little she could do to attempt to stop that. Instead, it was all she could do to close her gaping mouth and stammer out a response that oozed with faux arrogance.

"Yeah - sure, and ***I'm*** She-Ra, not you." The bluster evidently did not fool Adora - nor did it impress her, although one could be fooled into believing such for the thin, utterly humourless smile that spread across Adora's lips. Catra ignored it, focusing instead on Adora's words and realising that there were a concerning number of points that slotted right into place, that answered questions of her own. It was… dare she say, accurate? At least with the information she had herself.

After all - Entrapta and Hordak had been spending an increasingly large amount of time together, and she had heard the word 'portal' chucked around a few times, but there was no way to tell in what way it would be used.

Sure - Catra had been tasked to find a frankly absurd amount of First Ones tech over the past three years, and she had brought a fair bit of it back too, when Adora and her little posse hadn't intervened and managed to barely snag it from under her nose. Each piece Hordak had jumped onto with a fervour not seen outside of the eagerness of cadets to eat after survival training, and every so often he would seem to be in a particularly happy mood.

And then there was the fact that he was constantly trying to generate more power - if the sporadic, yet increasingly frequent power outages were anything to go off of.

The logic worked a little too well for her tastes.

"Catra. Are you going to help me, or are you going to run."

That was uncharacteristic venom in Adora's voice, and Catra could scarcely bring herself to meet the blonde's gaze - to find eyes full of determination and resolve staring right back at her with uncomfortably hostility that left the feline skittish. Such a firm demand - no options, other than to try to bluster her way out, although this ended much the same as before.

"Why would I help you - or run from you."

"Because you're a coward!" Adora's voice was sharp, and the words struck a deep would that Catra physically reeled from - the hurt inside her bursting to the surface as she looked at Adora - really actually looked at her for the first time in a while, all whilst Adora continued her verbal assault. "You're a spiteful coward who has spent years running from everything, because it was easier."

Adora looked tired - haggard by a day of travel and years of constant attritional warfare that worn away at even the toughest soldiers resolve. She had unkempt hair - wiry and frizzy from poor care, and lines around her eyes that spoke a thousand words about how sleep deprived she was, and Catra saw too much of herself in the latter. But her eyes themselves...

They burned - determination and resolve that she had seen earlier, but also an almost rage - uncomfortable and unfamiliar sensations, nerves and uncertainty. Adora looked so.. *Done* with everyone's shit, and she had decided to cut the war off at the head.

And she had a point - it had a not insubstantial chance at actually working.

..

"Just... Go."

Catra broke eye contact, crossing her arms and hugging herself, looking back out over the metal landscape which she practically ruled like a Queen, second only to the King in the castle of his own isolation, leaving her to dictate her will to the beings of the Horde. There were usurpers around every corner, and a Queen could not be seen to be weak.

But now she was - worn out from the duties which she had increasingly piled upon herself, Catra was simply seeking a way out, and dragging Adora back into things would mean only a prolonging of the duties which she so desperately sought to escape from.

"Excuse me?" Adora looked.. Confused, probably. Catra didn't deign to look at her, instead pinching the bridge of her nose and exhaling heavily.

"Go. Leave - fuck off back to where you came from and just let the Horde burn up. It's done for - I don't want any part of this. I've already got a massive fucking target on my back - so big that Kyle could scarcely miss it from 100 paces. I don't want another."

"So you're happy with just.. Letting ***EVERYTHING*** burn? Letting everyone die?" Adora sounded.. Horrified - abhorred by what she was hearing, but Catra rocked her head back, groaning as she ran the fingers pinching her nose down to her neck.

"I'm tired Adora.. I'm so.. So tired of everything." Her weariness flooded out as she spoke, her bones feeling heavy, her muscles weak as she stared at the purple sky above, lit by the receding glow of the setting daymoon. "I just.. I want to just *go* and leave everything behind. I'm sick of everything. The death - the screams. The fighting. Of people I care about abandoning me."

For perhaps the first time in years - Catra actually meant the words she spoke to Adora.

Adora looked right back at her, eyes now brimming with another emotion - adoration. *Ha.*

"I'm not leaving you Catra - Not again. Not after everything."

".. Why? You've got friends - people you care about and people who care about you. I'm a wanted criminal with a bounty on my head. You can't give that up." Weary sighs - forgotten promises.

"I can - and I would, if it means righting my wrongs."

".. Then you're an idiot."

"Maybe I am." There was a slightly unsettled chuckle in her voice, a bluster that kept Adora steady. "But I'm not making the same mistakes again."

".. Then you might well be the smartest idiot I've ever met." Catra inhaled - swallowing down the emotions that had broken out with that stupid girl that she had kept buried within her, forcing her emotions and mind to bend to her will. "And also the dumbest - much like this plan of yours."

Adora almost audibly perked up behind her as Catra turned, a hopeful frown across her features. "You're.. Helping me?"

Running a palm down her face, Catra groaned. "Yes - I suppose I am. Now come on idiot, you said I'm better than you at most things, and I endeavour to hold true to that. If we do this, we do it my way."

"Your way?" Adora frowned, fixing Catra with a stare. "Why not just walk in."

Catra had to resist the urge to roll her eyes so hard that her eyes would roll out of her head, and instead settled for walking two paces over to the blonde's helmet, picking it up casually and examining it as Adora looked at her confused. With a sigh, Catra shifted and lobbed the helmet that the blonde had worn at Adora, the corner of her lip tugging upwards as a satisfying *clonk* echoed

across the roof, and the noise of the blonde crumpling to the metal roof filled the air.

Looking at the blonde's crumped body, thoroughly unconscious, the feline felt somewhat sympathetic for the inevitable headache that she would awaken with, but at the same time, it was punishment, she felt, for having uttered that thoroughly moronic plan. Hordak would never let some random Horde grunt into his '*Sanctum*'. Reaching for the electrified cuffs that rested quite comfortably on her belt, Catra firmly bound the blonde, and set the *revised* plan into motion.

Sorry Adora - my way or not at all.

Catra XII

It was almost too easy to drag the unconscious blonde into Hordak's 'Sanctum' all by her lonesome, but Catra didn't really stop to think about the potential ramifications of her actions until she was practically at the door to the room, pulling Adora's unconscious form into a nearby storage room and propping her upright. Unfortunately, that did nothing to resuscitate her, so the feline resorted to slapping the blonde across the right cheek a few times, and in turn only receiving a few muted groans in response.

Whilst it was *immensely* satisfying to do so, it still had nowhere near the desired effect, other than eliciting aforementioned groans from the blonde girl and a slight tilt of her head to the left. Apparently Adora was as frustrating unconscious as she was when she was fully awake and aware, which meant that Catra had to go to plan C.

Withdrawing her electro prod, Catra deliberately turned the setting right down, more interested in waking the blonde girl up than, say, stopping her heart with fifty thousand volts. With a slight flourish, Catra twirled the prod, double checked the voltage, then jabbed Adora under the ribs with the electrically charged weapon.

The effect was instantaneous and incredibly satisfying, withdrawing a surprised yelp from Adora as the blonde jolted awake, tumbling forwards and practically bowling Catra over, had it not been for the wall behind them that meant Adora only managed to push the feline back a step. Had the wall not been there, Catra would almost certainly have allowed Adora to face-plant onto the floor, but alas all that she managed to do was end up going face first into the feline's chest.

“Oi - steady there dumbass. Surely you didn’t forget how to walk?” The apathetic drawl came off decidedly unimpressed, and was met initially with confusion as Adora clutched her head, though that quickly changed into naked irritation as she evidently remembered the event.

“I dunno, maybe if someone didn’t just *knock me out* without warning I’d be a little less confused!” Adora was too loud, and Catra’s hand came up to cover her mouth, the feline practically hissing her response.

“Fucking stars, quiet down you idiot!” Flapping her hand in a motion that she hoped conveyed the message, Catra released Adora’s mouth before the blonde tried something revolting like licking it - studiously ignoring that she had herself licked Sparkles to great effect before. If anyone caught them where they were, Catra would have to act immediately - and that would probably mean ripping their throat out and hiding them before they alerted anyone else.

And that wouldn't paint the greatest impression of her in Adora's mind.

Why the fuck do I care about that?

"Where even are we?" Adora had managed to get it through her stupid head that they needed to utilise some element of tact when it came to dealing with such a sensitive situation - especially one

that neither of them had fully planned out to any great extent. Catra, for her part, grit her teeth and leant up against the door, pressing an ear against it and drawing a quiet breath, which she subsequently held for a few seconds as she allowed her hearing to pick up on *everything* nearby.

The two guards some twenty metres away from them, around a corner, quietly conversing in hushed tones. Someone with claws striding down a nearby hallway - the clicking was distinct - headed away from them. The distant clanking of Entrapta as she noisily worked away in Hordak's Sanctum - practically screeching as far as Catra's enhanced hearing went.

Adora had said something about that..

And then there was Adora. The blonde's heart was beating just above average for a human, slightly accelerated, and Catra gave a small grimace. There was a reason she hated doing this - she could hear her own heart beat loudest of all, almost matching the rhythm set by Adora's, beating just a little faster than normal. She knew what prompted her own heart's rate, and she could hazard a guess about Adora's. The situation was incredibly stressful.

Sliding her metaphorical hearing blocks back into place and shoving her discomfort aside again, Catra fixed Adora with a firm, yet neutral look. "You said Entrapta and Hordak were working on something. How urgently do you need to talk to him?"

That lit a spark under Adora's ass, the blonde girl immediately going for the door handle, only for Catra to intercept her grasping

hand with a tight grip and a commanding gaze, forcing Adora to look at her as claws pricked at her skin, even through the much loved red jacket she *still* wore. Catra reiterated her demand. "How urgently?"

"Yesterday - Catra what they're working on has the potential to-" Catra barely bothered with the words that followed 'Yesterday', finishing Adora's words for her, accompanied by a roll of her heterochromic eyes.

"Yeah - destroy the Universe as we know it. Got it." At the end of the eyeroll, Catra turned her gaze back to Adora's own eyes, only to find a harsh look behind them, accompanying the look on the rest of Adora's face. It was.. Unnerving intense - unnervingly alien for the blonde, who spoke in a tone that didn't break the trend.

"No - it would destroy *reality*. No time, no matter - *nothing*. We would be plunged into every moment simultaneously, and yet never. Everything would be in the same place, and yet all separate." Catra blinked - trying to wrap her head around the sudden Entrapta-talk coming from perhaps the last person she expected it to be coming from. Everything happening at once, everything in the same place, but yet never happening and never being together.

The feline clutched her head, shaking it slowly. "Stars you're making *no* fucking sense. Who are you, and what have you done with that blonde dumbass?"

"Look - this is why I didn't want to tell you everything, but here we are. Now - are you going to take me to Hordak or what?" Adora's terse tone should have summoned rage, but all it managed was exasperation as Catra ran her hand down her face, careful to ensure her claws were not extended, lest she permanently mark herself.

That *particular* thought drew her eyes to the three scars underneath Adora's eye, but led to her own gaze being caught by the blue orbs of the blonde girl, steeled with a determination not yet seen before, one that threw Catra off entirely, but brought fought a resigned deflation from the feline. "Fine. But you need to be cuffed more believably for the meantime."

Reaching down to grab Adora's still cuffed wrists, Catra amped up the power setting, drawing the blonde's wrists closer together than their previously quite spacious distance, something that Adora merely raised an eyebrow at, cautiously testing the tether distance until she seemed vaguely satisfied with the range of movements that she had been permitted. It almost prompted Catra to drastically tighten the cuffs just to see Adora's reaction, but for perhaps the first time in a while, she allowed the blonde the curtesy.

It wouldn't change anything - Catra could probably still kill Adora regardless.

"Now just - don't run your mouth, alright?" With an inhale to centre herself, Catra gave an exhale, and pushed Adora towards the door. "Just let me do the talking, at least until we get inside Hordak's Sanctum. Then you can go on your whole insane rant

about alternate dimensions and shit. If Hordak decides to kill you, that's on you."

Adora stared at her over her shoulder for a few seconds, before her lips tightened into a thin line. "So you're not helping me then."

Catra paused, holding the blonde by the scruff of her collar whilst regarding her with an unimpressed look. "I said I'd help you, not join the Rebellion. I've got one bounty on my head, I don't want another, Adora."

"So you're still a coward." Adora's voice carried the same conviction as it had before - although there was more disappointment in it this time, like she had just missed a great opportunity. It vaguely flickered through Catra's mind that she could weasel something out of Adora for helping her, but it would be utterly moronic to expect Adora to have the *authority* to negotiate, especially when she was so emotional. If Catra had made an offer like that, Hordak or Shadow Weaver would have countermanded it in a *heartbeat*.

"I've got one goal - stay alive. The Horde can burn for all I care." With a dismissive wave of her hand, Catra regarded Adora with a tilted head, challenging the blonde to say something to the contrary. To her credit, Adora did so.

"I can get you off." Catra blinked twice, as did Adora, before the blonde went blood red in the face, her voice catching in her throat as she hurried to elaborate. "As in a pardon! I- I meant as in.. Getting Angela to reduce your punishment. Or whatever... Listen,

Catra, today could be the *last day* of the war. I just need your help!"

Swallowing the lump in her throat that Adora had put there with her phrasing - seriously, even Catra understood the potential connotations behind Adora's words (words which had brought back thoughts of She-Ra's *legs*, of all things) - Catra levelled an unimpressed expression at Adora, for it was the best that she had in the moment. "Yeah, and your plan could very well end the war in favour of the *Horde*. No promises."

The offer had tempted her - and it still did despite her half refusal. If she kept that line open, it could be her ticket out of the war, out of a life on the run. Out of a life where her face was plastered on wanted posters across the world - as if it wasn't already. To their credit, Catra conceded that the wanted posters that she had seen of her were quite good, and that the Rebellion had some decently skilled artists on their side.

Adora didn't say anything - she didn't even look at Catra as the feline grabbed her by the collar and pushed her forwards, the free hand finding the storage closet door control and thumbing the open button. With a soft hiss, the door slip open, and Catra offered Adora one final remark. "Don't get yourself killed. Just stay quiet."

And then they were out in the hallway, walking around the corner and towards the imposing door that loomed over the two guards standing either side of it, wasting away on sentry duty. They were obviously not paying attention, for they were looking at each other and most likely chatting under their breaths.

That all changed once they saw the duo - both snapped to attention as soon as they heard the footfalls, but Catra watched as the duo practically jumped out of their skins at the sight of Adora. Despite her being cuffed, both of them went for their service weapons, only to freeze mid way as they caught sight of Catra.

And then one of them fumbled for the door button, and Catra's lips pulled into a self-satisfied grin as the guard she had previously reprimanded for not giving her access to Hordak's sanctum opened the door for her without even a second thought.

Without stopping, Catra strode past the duo, pushing Adora in front of her, leaving only a single remark to hang in the air as she passed. "You two are dismissed."

She could hear them practically *sprinting* away.

But then the real challenge came as they entered the room. The looming darkness either side brought a terrifying thought to mind, one Catra hadn't even considered, and one that slowed her pace just a little bit.

What if Shadow Weaver is here?

If Shadow Weaver was in the room, then Hordak might be less inclined to hear Adora out. And, of course, it would create a new issue - one that could apparently see all reality annihilated. Whilst she didn't really understand what Adora was saying, she understood enough to know that any plans she had of survival would be a bit disrupted by every moment happening at the same time.

With a grimace, Catra took a breath, and kept her voice as low as it could possibly be as she leant forwards, against Adora, thin lips brushing against the blonde's ear as a breath slipped from her mouth. The blonde shivered unconsciously, almost jerking away, but Catra's grasp kept her close and her words made the blonde freeze. "If Shadow Weaver is here and doesn't leave, we're going to improvise, alright?"

Adora's reply was barely breathed, her heart thumping against Catra's chest. A single word - "Alright."

And then Catra pulled back, pushing Adora forwards and into the light of the window, and into the vision of the man who sat upon the throne underneath it. His lips parted in surprise, just for a moment, before they pulled into a vicious sneer - one Catra only saw from the red glow of his mouth. "She-Ra... This.. *Exceeds* all expectations, Force Commander Catra."

Pushing Adora to her knees before Hordak, Catra bowed her head in respect to the man, stepping just in front of Adora and twisting her body, keeping the blonde in her peripheral vision, but also the door to the room, just in case. Behind her she could hear the soft clanging of Entrapta working away on this nebulous project, but

she didn't give it any thought at the moment, more concerned on what lay before them. "Lord Hordak."

Adora spoke before Hordak had the chance to, a firm, level tone as she stared up at Hordak with resolve. "Hello, *Little Brother*."

There was the noise of fumbling from the throne, and Catra's gaze *snapped* to the movement in the inky darkness, watching as Hordak half stumbled to his feet, staring down at Adora with a blended mix of shock and dismay. ".. Impossible. Horde Prime would not send a lacky of his *enemy*."

Adora stood, still bound, and stared up at Hordak, who descended the throne to stand before Adora. Despite his height over her, Adora's voice was steady and firm - both her body and voice defiant. "No - I am not a vessel of Prime. But I'm here to stop you trying to bring him to this world. To this reality."

Hordak's expression practically hardened in a heartbeat, lips curling into a sneer. "You will not stop me, She-Ra. Entrapta and I have almost completed our work, and then Prime will come forth unto this world, and see what I have accomplished."

"Accomplished in your own name, *Hordak*."

The man recoiled as if slapped, and Catra blinked in surprise at the response - she didn't understand why a simple utterance of his name would be so jarring. Self discipline kicked in, and she

wiped her surprised expression of her face as fast as it had appeared, but Adora wasn't finished, cutting in before the man could speak.

"He wouldn't approve of that, would he? Everything and everyone is the same in Horde Prime's light. *Everything* is Prime, and *everyone* is Prime. You gave yourself the name, gave yourself an identity. What would he say to that?"

Catra paused for a moment, taking in the words Adora was speaking just as fast as she spoke them. Everything was Prime. That... Raised questions, and answered others. It explained why the grunts all dressed the same, why they all used the same weapons, why everything was so *uniform* in the Horde, especially compared to the rest of Etheria. Hell - the closest thing to uniformity the Rebellion had was the Bright Moon Guard, who hadn't fought on the battlefield for a decade.

But.. What did it mean? Did it mean that everyone considered themselves to be part of Prime, whoever it was?

She didn't have time to dwell on it - for Adora answered the question with perhaps the most horrifying answer she could. "No - he wouldn't. He would toss you aside, would remind you that you're no different to every Little Brother. You would be stripped of your identity, reconditioned and made to serve without any memory of what you accomplished."

"Silence! I am Hordak-"

"You would be no one." Adora snapped, cutting Hordak's furious roar off and leaving the man shell shocked for a brief second. "But that doesn't matter. The portal won't ever open. Not properly."

Hordak stared at her for a moment, growling his next words. "And *why* is that, *child*?"

"Because of what happened here a thousand years ago." Adora's firmness appeared to have faded a little bit, a sombre edge to her tone, just as had been present a handful of months ago in the Crimson Wastes. Adora was talking about this 'Mara' character again, evidently. "My predecessor as She-Ra bound this planet in another dimension, this dimension, known as Despondos."

Hordak sneered again - something he seemed to be doing a lot of in this particular conversation. "The actions of a single woman cannot stop the calculations of science. There exists a way back, of this we are certain."

"I don't doubt there is a way back, but it won't ever happen. By trapping us in Despondos, Mara severed the connections between this dimension and the other, she anchored Etheria in Despondos. Etheria *cannot* go back, it would create a paradox. The world would be in two places at once, in two realities simultaneously, with the same events occurring in both existences."

Suddenly there were hands on her shoulders, shoving her down as a pink blur shot overhead as Catra most definitely did *not*

shriek in alarm as the Tinkerer Princess vaulted over her. Entrapta had managed to sneak up on Catra - *somehow*, and was now standing in front of Adora with what was probably a curious expression on her features. "So you're saying that if we were to activate the portal, it would create a reality paradox that would force the two realties to exist at the same time simultaneously, and yet never.."

Hordak was silent for a moment, before he spoke to Entrapta in a soft tone - softer than anything that Catra had ever heard him speak in to *anyone*. "Is it possible, Entrapta?"

Entrapta was silent for a few seconds, before she flipped her welding mask down and spoke quietly, yet loud enough for everyone present to hear. "It would be almost guaranteed. Even if it didn't happen for a million years, it would force all reality to exist at once infinitesimal second. Even a single differentiation would cause the same effect. It could undo all existence - all time, space and such. Dozens of years ago would be now. Nothing would ever be anywhere, and that's why it would be everywhere."

The room was silent for a second, and Catra drew a baited breath. Sure, she had half believed what Adora had been spouting, and had been somewhat using her to forwards her own goals, but with Entrapta spouting the same bullshit mumbo-jumbo? That was the closest thing she would get to confirmation that such was a for sure scientific fact.

"Why." Hordak's voice was sombre for a second, before it regained its previous low malice. "Why would this *Mara* risk all reality for a *single planet.*"

Adora made a slightly distressed noise, something between a dying keen in her throat that only Catra and Hordak appeared to have picked up on, before the blonde cleared her throat and rasped a comment. "Because Etheria was meant to be a bomb. One that would sterilise all the galaxy of life. It was meant to be used on Horde Prime, but it was one that had no focus. It would have rendered the galaxy dead."

Hordak stared at Adora for a moment, then blinked slowly, pinching the bridge of his nose. He seemed to sag a bit, taking several steps backwards and returning to his place upon his throne. His elbows came to a rest upon the arms of the chair, and his head bowed forwards into his clasped hands, where he remained for several, long seconds. His words were soft when he spoke, harsh, but soft. "I must admit that my goals have diverged from Horde Primes. The destruction of reality is not my aims. But if we cannot have the universe, then we will have this planet. Force Commander Catra, how much would it take for us to conquer Etheria?"

Catra blinked, pulled from her stupor by the question, and one she took a few seconds to actually register. With a heavy sigh and a shake of her head, Catra grimaced and pushed through her reticence to deliver the blunt truth. "We can't. Not now. Shadow Weaver's actions shorted the war by at least a year or two - and not in our favour. The Horde needs to contract its controlled territory, not expand it. Even then, we're probably not going to survive."

Hordak stared at her for a moment, managing only a stunned response. "But we are at the peak of our expansion!"

"And we've exerted ourselves too much to get there. The flame that burns the brightest, burns the shortest." That analogy drew a muted snicker from Adora, and Catra flushed in spite of herself - reminded of that incident in the Crimson wastes with the camp stove. "We're done - we might hold on if we give up decent portions of land, but we cant maintain a frontline with a massive hole in the middle. That's what the Whispering Woods is to us."

She paused for a second, before raising a hand to her chin and adopting a thoughtful pose. "I suppose we could cease conventional operations and act as a police force. But as it stands now, Shadow Weaver has fucked us."

"I have done nothing but bring the Horde to its *peak*!" The cold and cruel lint of the witch's voice rang out in the chamber, and Catra couldn't help but stiffen slightly at the interruption. Out of the corner of her eye, Catra could see Adora's face losing its colour by the second, a flash of fear creeping into her eyes as she met Catra's gaze, futilely thrusting her bound hands towards the feline as discretely as possible.

Catra didn't move.

Shadow Weaver lay a hand upon Adora's shoulder, and the blonde went ram rod straight, but Shadow Weaver didn't even acknowledge Catra or Adora, instead looking up at Hordak as she spoke. "Lord Hordak, surely you do not believe this *defeatist* propaganda? The Horde is at its greatest expanse ever! We control more land, more people, more resources than ever before! We are at the verge of *victory*, not defeat."

Hordak was silent for a moment, before he raised his head and looked at Shadow Weaver. "It matters not. I have other matters to attend to. Force Commander Catra, Shadow Weaver I place you in joint operational command of the Horde in my name. Do what you need to. What you wish."

"Lord Hordak, I protest! I cannot share power with her!" Shadow Weaver's voice was peaked, strained. Catra was stunner - too stunned to say anything, but Hordak didn't let them, speaking his will like he always did, and fucking off to go screw machinery with Entrapta - or her.

A shudder shot down Catra's mind as she felt vaguely ill at the prospect.

"Enough. My will is dictated. Be gone."

"What about She-Ra?" Shadow Weaver's voice was searching, and Catra felt a jolt run down her spine. That had been the fear, and both Catra and Adora dreaded Hordak's answer.

"Do with her as you wish. She is not my concern." The man descended from his throne and stepped off to the side, back into his workshop, with Entrapta bouncing along beside him on her hair. Catra swallowed the lump in her throat for what felt like the dozenth time as Shadow Weaver turned her gaze down to Adora, tilting her head in that manner that suggested cruelty was to come, with her tone conveying nothing but.

"Come now Catra.. Let us deal with She-Ra, once and for all..."

A firm hand grabbed Adora's shoulder and turned her away from the throne, pushing her along the walk way whilst Catra half numbly followed along behind, still processing the ramifications of the situation. She didn't meet Adora's desperate gaze, searching for any kind of help.

Catradora I

Chapter Notes

> And we come to the close. Not how I really wanted to end this work (and a lot later than I ever thought I would) but I've been battling burnout and juggling procrastinating my Uni (or as I put it, writing) and actually doing Uni has sucked up a major part of my time. Whilst this chapter was meant to be pretty basic in its premise - a deep dive into Catra's psyche and her shift from Horde to Rebellion in its totality, I honestly did not have the gusto to push through the final few chapters and to drag them out to 32. So instead I decided to trim down those chapters into this final one, and to finally put an end to Illusions of Control. For those who have put up with me - thank you, and perhaps consider checking out some of my other works.

The screams echoed in her head.

They weren't anything unusual for her - she was *Catra*, Horde Commander and perhaps the most feared individual on the planet of Etheria. She had told Adora once that she had made countless creations burn and brought innumerable lives come to a gruesome end, and that the screams of those people haunted her every night as she closed her eyes. That much was her burden to bear, she had been responsible for quite a few of those deaths herself.

She-Ra had been a victim of hers dozens of times over - Catra had drawn blood on almost every occasion they had fought, and it was a sheer testament to the Princess' durability that She-Ra had managed to soldier through every hit. It was also a testament to Catra's skill that she had faced the lethal monster that She-Ra was and had prevailed nine times out of ten.

A lesser combatant would have fallen at the first hurdle, or would have tripped up at any one of the various occasions where that was a distinct possibility. But Catra had managed to survive with only one major scar - the one she earned in the Crimson Wastes - and in turn she had dealt She-Ra a far more debilitating blow.

The concussion She-Ra had given her at the Prom didn't count.

But it was unusual to hear *Adora* screaming. It was typically She-Ra yelling in pain as Catra stuck somewhere soft in her usually quite penetrable, impenetrable defence.

Yet it was Adora screaming now, and Catra was watching with glassy eyes as the blonde convulsed in agony at the hands of Shadow Weaver's magic. Could she have acted? Yes.

But she was in Command now. She had been given the Horde, with Shadow Weaver admittedly, but she was the highest authority in the Horde. She could pull them back from the brink, so long as Shadow Weaver stayed in her lane.

Yet she didn't feel like she was in command. She still had the same issues hamstringing her command - just because she had the title didn't mean that her authority had actually *changed* that much. If anything, it felt as if she was being handed new problems to deal with, new authority to wield, but also the greater risk of interference.

The screams died down for a moment as Shadow Weaver reared back, panting behind her mask as she wrung her fists. Evidently, her torturing of Adora was becoming tiring, even with them standing in the Black Garnet chamber, the runestone of which Shadow Weaver had placed her hand upon to recharge her magic.

As Adora twitched upon the floor, curled into a half-foetal position, Catra watched as she subtly tested her wrists, as if trying to pull the cuffs apart. Though doubtless, Adora had to have known that the cuffs were much too strong for her in her normal form - she would need She-Ra to break them in two. That, however, wouldn't happen. Shadow Weaver would immediately interrupt any attempt to transform, and as strong as the Warrior Princess was, she was susceptible to *Catra*'s attacks, let alone Shadow Weaver's.

"Catra... Perhaps you would like to... Attend to Adora." Shadow Weaver's words were layered in double meanings - a subtle jab at her loyalties, an open invitation to prove her allegiance. But the words were intercut with deep breaths, betraying another meaning, that being Shadow Weaver's personal exhaustion. Evidently the magic took its toll on her, and the woman was clearly getting on as far as age went.

But now Catra was on the spot. With a blink, her eyes came back into focus, locking on Adora's desperate face cut with pain. Her eyes drifted down to her lips as Adora gave a breathless plea. "Please... End it.."

"Yes, Horde Commander Catra... *End it*." Shadow Weaver crooned.

And it was that which decided it.

Catra's eyes drifted to the trio of scars under Adora's right eye - scars she had slashed across her face. The first blood shed between them. Her mind went to the rank Shadow Weaver had mentioned - her third rank, from Force Captain to Force Commander and now Horde Commander. And all with more misery and pain that she had been shoving down, allowing to fester inside her for as long as it took for her to find somewhere private to scream it all out.

Her hunger for power hadn't brought her satisfaction. It had been how she justified torturing herself.

Deliberately pacing over to centre of the room, Catra stood behind Shadow Weaver and stared down at Adora, raising her right hand and extending her claws. Watching as Shadow Weaver seemed to relax into a smug stance.

And with no ceremony, Catra plunged her left hand straight through Shadow Weaver's back.

The Witch didn't even scream, just seemed utterly bewildered, judging by the tiny pupil staring at her in horror through the eyehole of the mask and the wet gasp that escaped her lips behind the mask. But both Shadow Weaver and Adora both jumped at the sudden violence, Adora seemingly because she had been suddenly covered in a spray of blood.

With equally little ceremony, Catra wrenched the bloody organ that had once been the Witch's rotten heart out from her back and tossed it to the floor. Both the organ and the body splatted against the ground seemingly in unison, and the Black Garnet seemed to glow just a little brighter as Catra stared at her bloodied hand. "Seems she had a heart after all."

Barely had she finished her morbid quip before she retched, stumbling away from Shadow Weaver and over to the wall of the miniscule chamber as she fought the urge to be sick over what she had just done. It made no sense - she should have been celebrating, not revolted and yet here she was being betrayed by her body again.

She had almost forgotten Adora, but it was once she had forced her rebellious body into behaving that she managed to half stumble, half stagger over to Adora, sinking to her knees and grasping the blonde's wrists. Pressing her thumb to the fingerprint scanner, the handcuffs popped free, and Catra practically threw them across the room and grasped Adora's clutching hands.

"A... A-a problem f-for another Catra and Adora?" Adora's tone was almost joking, but her pained twitches and tremors that threw her speech off ruined the effect. Almost, because Catra's heart couldn't help but well just a little bit as the blonde made the remark.

"Shut up dumbass. Can you walk?" Adora looked her in the eyes for a moment, before giving a nod.

"Just.. N-Not to Bright Moon. Might need t-to steal a skiff again.." Catra gave a sigh and pinched her brow as she hauled the blonde to her feet and draped her right arm around Adora shoulders.

"This sounds like a bad joke.."

Whilst Catra had stopped for a brief period to pick what few belongings she valued out of her quarters, and the papers she would need to absolve herself of a lot of the blame, she was acutely aware that she had little that she really cared for. They had taken to the hangar and taken a skiff shortly after almost without incident, whilst Horde grunts may have recognised Adora as the enemy, they were clearly terrified of crossing Catra, whose arm was still covered in blood and gore even as she hauled the blonde towards the exit.

The issue was what was waiting for them in the hangar.

Standing in front of the skiffs were a trio of individuals that both of them recognised - how could they not? The remainder of the 303rd stood between them and the skiff, but for once Catra was loathe to violence - her hand was still stained with the internals of Shadow Weaver.

"Catra, we need to talk." With a sigh at Lonnie's remark, Catra extracted herself from under Adora's left arm, leaving the blonde to stand on shaky feet as Catra placed herself between Adora and Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio. "I've been hearing some worrying things."

Raising her left arm, Catra tilted her head to the left and exhaled some of her frustration as she raised her left arm in demonstration. "Lonnie... I've just dealt with Shadow Weaver; I don't want to do this to you too."

The trio seemed to blanche just a little - evidently Catra's already imposing reputation was only compounded by the absolute state she must have been in the moment. Waving her hands in the negative, Lonnie shook her head. "No - not that. We just want something from you."

"What is it, then?" Pinching her brow again and relaxing just a little, Catra still kept her ears peeled for *any* hint of treachery. It would have been the correct strategic move in the moment, catch her with this distraction and overwhelm her from range.

"Discharge permits." Catra blinked owlishly, staring across at the trio who waited expectantly for her response. "We aren't living our lives on the run. You're the boss now, we want to be discharged from service."

Catra stared at the trio for a moment, before giving a chuckle as she bowed her head. The chuckle turned into a genuine laugh as she pinched her temples with her right hand and laughed at the sheer absurdity of the situation - probably looking a right sight as she did so. Shaking her head, she raised it to gaze at the trio with what must have been the most terrifying thing they could have seen, a genuinely amused smile.

"You know I'm fucking off out of this hell hole too?" At Lonnie's stunned expression, Catra shook her head in amusement. "Tell you what - you're the... Most competent of the Horde's remaining officers ever since Cobalt died six months ago. You're in charge of demobilising everyone - access code to my terminal is 'Promise' with a capital P. Or discharge yourselves and leave, but I trust you to be better than I am."

At the stunned expressions on the faces of the trio opposite, Catra felt relatively safe - safe enough to turn her back on them and help Adora start to close in on the skiff and the remaining trio. As they stood barely an arm’s length apart, Catra cocked her head in what must have been a rather devil-may-care way and gave a grin. "I'll save you all front row seats to my hanging in Bright Moon."

"They won't hang you." Adora's voice was weak but absolute. "I'll guarantee it. The Rebels want an end as much as you do. It'll be peaceful."

".. You're a real prick, Catra." Lonnie's tone was scalding, but the wry grin on her face spoke leagues otherwise. "Guess we have one final job boys. Take care you two."

Helping Adora into the skiff, Catra was about ready to haul herself into it when someone grasped her shoulder before she could do so. Turning to face the person, Catra was surprised to see it was Kyle who had stopped her - his expression nervous but determined. "Catra... Good luck. And thank you."

Catra stared at him for what felt like an age before offering a nod in turn. That was seemingly enough for Kyle, as he released her shoulder, and Catra climbed behind the controls of the skiff, trying not to let her hope drown out her common sense.

Perhaps the most amazing thing about the day was the Whispering Woods, which parted before the skiff like a sea as Catra stood dutifully at the controls as Adora lay against the lip of the bow. Skiffs had come a long way since they had stolen one over two and a half years ago, albeit they were still simple. There was a platform that provided enough room for a half dozen soldiers to stand on, as opposed to the two or three who could have fit on the original skiffs.

What was even more strange was how the forest seemed to guide them along a specific path, the trees visibly closing before Catra's eyes to block off routes that the forest(?) didn't want them to take. She knew the Whispering Woods were blatantly magic and actively working against the Horde (and incidentally that they

were also practically fireproof), but they hadn't visibly moved before the Horde before.

It didn't change the fact that Catra had no clue where they were going, just that they were following the path that the trees themselves were making.

Which sounded utterly fucking insane.

Adora gave a groan from the front of the skiff and pushed herself into a seated position as she watched the trees go by for several seconds, before turning to face Catra with a small smile, but a worried expression. "We're close. But we might have a little problem trying to get you into Bright Moon."

That... Was a good point. Pursing her lips, Catra gave a grimace. "Yeah, I'd rather not be lynched. Or have to get violent."

"Hm... Scorpia managed to get to the castle just fine... We should keep going-" Barely had Adora finished before the skiff burst through the edge of the forest and came to a halt just outside the gates of Bright Moon Castle. Standing at the gates was a trio of individuals - Bow and Sparkles stood flanking a tall woman with dark skin, who was regarding the pair of them with surprise and cautious trepidation. Catra knew her to be Netossa, a scarcely seen member of the Princess Alliance who Catra had pegged at the Rebellions Spy Master.

Giving a grimace, Catra released the tiller and lowered her hand to Adora, pulling the blonde to her shaky feet and helping her down from the skiff. With her nerves pooling in her gut, Catra cautiously helped Adora as they approached the trio at the gate, waiting for any signs of attack.

Silence reigned - an uncomfortable silence as both sides regarded each other from barely two arms lengths. As the silence grew even further, Catra followed Bow's gaze down to her left arm and gave an internal cringe - she still had the remnants of Shadow Weaver on her.

Raising the offending limb, Catra gave a dull look at the elder Princess. "Before you hang me, I'd just like to note that our Witch problem no longer exists."

"I take it you mean Shadow Weaver is dead." Netossa's tone was flat, her lips pressed into a thin line. Pausing internally, Catra made a decision - she liked this woman, or at least how she thought. Adora gently pulled away from Catra, and the feline allowed her to do so, watching carefully as she limped over to Bow and Sparkles and began a quiet conversation that Catra frankly didn't have the chance to care about. Instead, she offered a nod and replied.

"Yes. Perhaps the only person I've killed that unquestionably deserved it." That admission drew a slight cock of one of the dark-skinned woman's eyebrows. Catra wasn't going to let her try and *trap* her however, and continued forwards. Unslinging the satchel bag and handing it to Netossa, she spoke to the somewhat baffled woman. "The Horde is demobilising; I gave the order before I left. Hordak is doing stars knows what, Shadow Weaver is dead, and

the Force Captains are probably taking this time to run. The War is over, I've come to negotiate my surrender in good faith. In that bag are documents regarding the Hordes operations that you may find useful."

"Riiight, and how do you expect that to go?" At the sarcastic remark, Catra gave an amused snort.

"Well, I've already offered three people front row seats to my hanging, so I'd be obliged if you could arrange that much." This time it was Netossa's turn to snort inelegantly, giving a darkly amused chuckle.

"I'll see what I can do on that front. But given you've brought about the end of the war almost singlehandedly and you *seem* to have saved Adora, you might not get that public spectacle you wanted." Catra gave a nod - that was what she had been hoping to achieve. Something in the way of a sentence that *didn't* involve her head being separated from her body. In that sense, Adora was a useful tool to achieve such an outcome but... Catra was aware that she wasn't going to simply leave Adora behind.

Not again.

"Well, if the Spymaster of the Rebellion makes that assessment, it’s better than if it came from that dork." Jabbing her thumb over at Adora, Catra was momentarily alarmed as Netossa seemed to surge for just a moment. But then she slapped her thigh and thrust her open palm at Catra face up and shouted in a rather fed-up tone.

"THANK YOU!" The trio over to her left practically jumped out of their skins, alarmed by the sudden outburst, but at their clear confusion at the scene, Netossa clarified. "Some *RECOGNITION!*"

"Wait. They didn't-?" At Netossa's affronted look, Catra covered her mouth in a deliberately poor attempt to hide her amusement. "They *seriously* didn't peg you as the Spymaster? Stars, how did we end up here?"

"In my defence.. I didn't know we *had* a spymaster." It was Adora who had spoken, and Catra had to bite back her sharp retort - it wouldn't do to start shit *now*.

Turning back to Netossa, Catra tilted her head. "I suppose the reason you haven't hauled me inside is because the court is in total disarray at the events of the day."

Netossa's cringe told her that Catra had hit the nail on the head. Nodding her head at a figure approaching down the path, Catra spoke again. "I'll imagine I need to be cuffed?"

"No point. The firepower in that room is so absurd you'd be turned to ash in a heartbeat." Netossa's remark definitely didn't help the nerves that Catra was feeling, but as she turned over her shoulder to look at the approaching figure, her expression softened a bit. As she glanced back at Catra, she lowered her voice to a barely audible level for a human. "No one would blame

you if you got back on that skiff and ran. I doubt I would be able to stop you."

The offer was tempting - sorely tempting. But ignoring her instincts, Catra stood her ground. "No, I've had enough of running. Besides, I made a Promise."

"Your funeral." *It quite well could be.* Raising her voice, Netossa gave a shout over her shoulder. "Open the gate."

And just like that Catra found herself being escorted up through the gardens of Bright Moon, not really pausing to appreciate the sights that were so nakedly alien to her. This level of luxury was beyond absurd for anyone - Catra had made do with a small room that had a desk in it. The Queen of Bright Moon probably had a desk the size of Catra's room if these gardens were anything to go off of.

The castle itself wasn't much better on that front - the halls were so *needlessly* tall, and wide. Made for a terrible defensive position - it wasn't so much a castle as it was a palace, designed for comfort and pleasure as opposed to defence. She must have been staring, because Netossa's voice drifted back from where she led the small party with the Princess who was likely her wife. "Adora was much the same - but I imagine you'll adapt just as she did."

Pushing open the doors in front of them, Catra was greeted with the sight of an imposing woman sat upon a throne, and a man stood beside her looking somewhat bedraggled. Around them stood the court, each of them whispering questions to each other

- Catra could tell they hadn't seen her yet, just going off the words she could make out. The woman on the throne had, judging by her glare cast firmly on Catra.

Adora's hand found her left shoulder, and Catra gave it a gentle squeeze with her right hand, before pushing it off and steeling her nerves as she strode into the room confidently. *Then* the stunned and horrified whispers began to rise as Catra approached the throne, Netossa and her wife following as Adora's trio picked up the rear. The Queen, however, was eerily silent as Catra came to a stop a health distance back, as she would with Hordak.

After all, that's all she was, another Hordak.

"Netossa, explain." The Queen's demand was met with a moment of pause, before the woman over her shoulder began to speak.

"After Mara informed us that Adora was returning from the Fright Zone with someone, I waited at the gate. Sure enough, just as Scorpia had, Adora appeared at the gate with Catra." Not-so-quiet murmurs spread around the room as Netossa finished speaking, but the Queen only barely turned her gaze over the court before they all fell silent in a heartbeat. Hanging for just a moment, her eyes drifted to rest on her, and Catra had to resist the urge to swallow.

"Anything to say for yourself, Catra?"

And here it was. Just had to not fuck this up. "The War is over. Hordak has surrendered his command authority to me, and I have ordered a demobilisation of the Horde. On behalf of myself and the whole of the Horde, I wish to negotiate our surrender."

The man next to the Queen, more than likely King Micah, who had disappeared years ago yet had reappeared barely a few months prior, stepped forwards. "I understand that Shadow Weaver is a high-ranking officer in the Horde. Would she not be able to interfere with this demobilisation?"

Raising her left hand, Catra twisted it above her head, displaying the dried blood still staining her gloved hand as she bit out her response through grit teeth. "Shadow Weaver will *never* torment another person."

Micah was silent for several seconds, staring at her hand, before nodding once, signal enough for Catra to lower her hand as the man bowed down to the Queen's ear and whispered something. Whilst she could have listened in, Catra resisted the urge - she didn't exactly wish to learn her fate early.

Even though she knew what it would be.

"Adora has already spoken on your behalf - quite insistently I might add." A blink of momentary surprise was followed by Catra casting her gaze back over her shoulder at Adora, who gave her an encouraging smile and a nod. Of *course* she had, it was Adora after all. Turning back to look at the Queen, the woman still

looked incredibly displeased, but continued. "Is there anything else you would like to say in your defence?"

"I've shortened the war by at least two years by ordering the demobilisation. Horde atrocities were mostly under Shadow Weaver's orders, the affairs during my tenure of command can be clearly noted by the documents in that bag Netossa has." Racking her head for anything else that she could think of to immediately absolve herself of, Catra rattled off the list in her brain as bluntly as she could. These trials were hopefully not emotional decisions, but instead purely factual ones. "Whilst I've killed people, so has everyone in this room... I think that's about everything, although I would like to inform you that the Horde is made up of children who were kidnapped from their families. We were raised by Shadow Weaver and not all of us had as strong of a moral compass as Adora."

"I see..." The Queen was silent for several seconds, as if considering what had been said in her head- oh god this *was* a trial by one. That meant that this was an emotional event, and that Catra's appeal to the cold hard facts of the situation were only likely to sway the Queen against her. Grimacing, Catra spoke before a final decision could be made.

"If I might ask, I have promised three of my subordinates seats at my hanging. If that could be arranged, it would be appreciated." The Queen, ironically enough, seemed utterly thrown by the remark, almost as if she hadn't been considering executing Catra for the quite justifiable crimes that she had committed in the name of the enemy.

"Do you mean to say that you came to Bright Moon expecting to be executed?" At the Queen's almost astounded question, Catra gave a single nod.

"I did. Frankly it makes the second most sense out of all the outcomes; It makes your citizens happy; it makes most of your council happy, it demonstrates a punitive action against the Horde and it neutralises one of the greatest threats to your Kingdom. Makes the most sense cost-benefit wise." The Queen stared down at her for several seconds, remaining silent as Catra stood there, slowly becoming more and more uncomfortable. A glance to her left and right revealed that there was indeed quite a lot of firepower in the room, as Netossa had suggested. Any two of these Princesses might have caused her some serious trouble, let alone the twenty or so who must have been in this room.

Clearing her throat, the Queen offered a short reply in lieu of a proper response. "There will be no hanging. Here, we behead our traitors."

Oh *goodie*. That meant it might not be so quick.

The silence reigned for a minute, broken only by the chirping of birds outside - a sound that set Catra's fur on end with primal instincts she barely understood - and the occasional soft whisper as Micah spoke into the Queen's ear. Eventually the woman on the throne cleared her throat and looked down at Catra. "I cannot deny Adora's request for a pardon for you, she is perhaps the individual present who has contributed and lost the most to the War outside of my Husband. However, as you stated I cannot allow you to walk free with your actions standing. My Husband,

however, reminded me that you mentioned an option that made more sense?"

Oh, stars this was happening*.*

Trying not to seem too eager or too callous, Catra gave a nod and played the card that the Queen had handed to her. This could *work*, and without requiring her head sitting on a spike.

"I hold immense authority in the Horde. That authority could be utilised to both demobilise holdouts who do not receive the order, and to direct them to aid in the rebuilding efforts. Furthermore, I essentially ran the entire war by myself for almost two years, I have a mind that outmatches your combined war council. To discard of me for any reason would require a serious reward to offset the cost." The Queen did *not* look very pleased at the assertion, but nodded just past Catra. A moment later, Netossa behind her began to speak.

"Your Highness, whilst... Perhaps direct about her words, Catra is correct in both assertions. Whilst our War Council spent two years chasing her strategy around, our recent spate of successes has all been the result of the Horde's sudden retreat after a re-emergence of the violence." Adora cleared her throat and interjected.

"Your Majesty, I can confirm that the swathe of violence and pogroms were the result of Shadow Weaver temporarily regaining her command after the incident in the Crimson Wastes." Catra grimaced and tried to hide her embarrassment at the mention of the situation. That *really* had not reflected well upon her image.

Silence reigned for several seconds as the Queen again considered her options as Catra felt the pressure mount. When she spoke, it came as almost a surprise.

"How long will it take to rebuild, Catra?" Hesitating, Catra ran the mental numbers in her head, before shaking it and turning to Netossa.

"Can you give me the black file labelled [OCCUPATION]?" Catra watched as the Princess hesitated for a moment, before digging through the bag Catra had handed her at the gate and eventually withdrawing the file that Catra flicked through with practiced ease. Blissfully unaware of the room around her, Catra found the page and spoke. "The Horde razed two hundred and eighty settlements, two hundred and four of which were in Shadow Weaver's tenure of command. There were one thousand, seven hundred and forty-eight settlements which were under some form of occupation at any point, with current occupation numbering nine hundred and eighty-four."

Silence. Dead fucking silence, and that was the indicator that Catra got that she had *perhaps* tipped her hand too far. Continuing on if only to break the silence, Catra ran the numbers in her head. "At current manpower, the job could be accomplished in six months, but guessing at the number of desertions, I would suggest we could accomplish the rebuilding of settlements sometime in the next two to three years."

"You razed *seventy-six* towns." A voice from the court drew a sneer onto Catra's face.

"The Children of the Forest took my captured men and women, executed them after they had surrendered, and stuck their heads on spikes outside seventy-six towns. Your side is hardly innocent. Perhaps you'd like to see the photos?" The court fell silent after that, and Catra handed the folder back to Netossa over her shoulder. Giving a sigh, Catra looked back at the Queen. "I will warn you that I keep meticulous notes. What is in that bag will likely make apparent some ugly truths about the Rebellion."

"Quite. But we cannot allow ourselves to dispel the truth because it is uncomfortable." The Queen stood from her throne and stared down at Catra. "I have come to my decision. Catra of the Horde - I sentence you and the wider Horde to three years of service in the employ of Bright Moon. You will work the land this war has destroyed. Thereafter you will be free to go. Your fellow Force Commanders and Hordak will be tried independently."

A chorus of furious whispers broke out, but the Queen swept her gaze across the crowd. "My decision stands. Should anyone wish to contest, make your voice heard."

None spoke, and the Queen turned her gaze back to Catra. "You may go in the company of Adora."

Adora practically snatched her wrist from her side and dragged her from the Throne room, and Catra found herself following along lest her entire arm be dislocated. Through the winding corridors they went, until Adora threw open a door to a room and pulled Catra inside, shutting the door swiftly behind them. A

heartbeat later, Adora's lips were on her own and Catra had no further complaints.

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